Chapter One: That Changes Everything

The scenes take place when Bell is ten years old.

Narrator:
The first thing Bell Cranel noticed was the silence.

Not the peaceful kind.

It was the kind of silence that made even the smallest sound feel wrong.

Bell stood alone in the middle of an ancient stone corridor, his small body tense as he stared into the darkness ahead.

He didn't remember coming here.

He didn't remember walking through a door.

He didn't even remember leaving wherever he had been before.

He slowly looked down at himself.

His hands were there.

His legs were there.

Everything looked normal.

But somehow...

Something felt wrong.

Bell raised one hand and waved it in front of his face.

Nothing unusual happened.

"...Am I dreaming?"

His voice echoed through the corridor.

"Dreaming...? Then why does this feel so real?"

He took a cautious step forward.

Tap.

The sound traveled through the ancient hallway.

Bell immediately froze.

His heart pounded.

"Who's there?"

Nothing answered.

He swallowed.

"...Okay."

"Nobody's here."

He looked behind himself.

Only darkness.

Bell turned back around.

"Then... I guess I have to find a way out."

He began walking.

The walls were covered in strange symbols.

Some resembled eyes.

Others looked like creatures Bell had never seen before.

There were also figures of people kneeling before enormous shapes that seemed to stretch toward the ceiling.

Bell stared at one of them.

"What are these?"

"I've never seen writing like this before."

He reached toward one of the symbols.

His finger stopped just before touching it.

For some reason, he felt that touching it would be a bad idea.

So he pulled his hand back.

"...Let's not do that."

He continued.

At first, every step made him more nervous.

Every shadow looked like it might move.

Every distant sound made him stop.

But as time passed...

Something changed.

His fear slowly faded.

Not because the place became less frightening.

It didn't.

Rather, Bell simply became accustomed to it.

"I've been walking for a long time..."

He glanced back.

The corridor behind him seemed endless.

"How long have I been here?"

He couldn't tell.

There was no sunlight.

No clock.

No indication of time passing.

Only the faint blue glow coming from the symbols carved into the walls.

Bell's shoulders relaxed.

"...Maybe I'm supposed to be here."

The moment he said it, he frowned.

"No. That's stupid."

"Why would I be supposed to be here?"

He continued walking anyway.

The corridor gradually widened.

The symbols became more elaborate.

Some appeared to depict enormous battles.

Others showed people standing beneath a strange celestial body.

Bell stopped in front of one particular carving.

It showed a tiny human figure standing before something impossibly large.

Bell tilted his head.

"...Is that a god?"

He stared at it.

"It doesn't look like any god I've ever heard about."

He stepped closer.

Then something caught his attention.

The human figure wasn't kneeling.

It was standing.

Facing the enormous being.

Almost as though...

It was challenging it.

Bell's expression became serious.

"...What happened here?"

No answer.

He walked onward.

Eventually, the corridor disappeared.

Bell stepped into a massive chamber.

His eyes widened.

The room was enormous.

Pillars rose into darkness, each covered with the same mysterious hieroglyphs.

The floor beneath his feet was perfectly smooth.

And at the very center...

There was something.

Bell couldn't quite see it.

A strange mist covered the middle of the chamber.

He slowly approached.

"That's probably a bad idea."

He stopped.

"...Definitely a bad idea."

He stared at the mist.

Then at the empty corridor behind him.

There was nowhere else to go.

Bell sighed.

"Fine."

He took another step.

Then another.

The mist slowly parted.

Bell's breathing stopped.

His eyes widened.

"...What?"

He had reached the center.

And for the first time since arriving in this strange place...

Bell understood something.

He wasn't alone.

There was someone—or something—waiting for him.

Something ancient.

Something that had been waiting for a very, very long time.

Bell couldn't move.

His entire body felt frozen.

"What... is that?"

A faint light appeared within the darkness.

Then another.

And another.

Until dozens of strange symbols began illuminating the chamber.

The walls started glowing.

The floor beneath Bell's feet trembled.

And from somewhere directly in front of him...

A voice whispered.

"You finally came."

Bell's eyes widened.

"...Who are you?"

Silence.

Then the darkness opened.

Bell saw what was hidden at the center of the ancient chamber.

His expression changed completely.

Because what stood before him...

Was something that should not have been there.

Something that would change his entire life.

And Bell had no idea...

That this was only the beginning.

Worked for 6s

Chapter Two: My Personal Assistant

Continuing from the cliffhanger of Chapter One

Bell slowly approached the strange being standing at the center of the empty space.

There was no ground beneath his feet, yet he somehow knew he was standing.

There was no sky above him, yet he could look upward.

There was no wind, no temperature, no sound.

Just an endless, pale space.

And the being.

It stood quietly, waiting for him.

Bell stopped a few steps away.

He stared at it.

The being stared back.

For several seconds, neither of them spoke.

Bell eventually tilted his head.

“...Are you going to attack me?”

The being's body emitted a faint glow.

“No.”

Its voice was strangely calm.

Bell blinked.

“You're not?”

“No.”

“Are you a monster?”

“No.”

“A god?”

“No.”

“A spirit?”

“No.”

“Then... what are you?”

The being paused.

Its glow became slightly brighter.

“I am here to speak with you.”

Bell frowned.

“That doesn't answer my question.”

“I am aware.”

“Then why didn't you answer it?”

“Because you did not ask a question that I can answer.”

Bell stared at it.

“...Huh?”

For the first time, Bell felt a little irritated.

He crossed his arms.

“That's unfair.”

“I apologize.”

The being bowed its head slightly.

Bell's irritation immediately disappeared.

“...You're really polite.”

“I was instructed to be.”

“By who?”

A pause.

The glow around the being flickered.

“I cannot tell you.”

Bell narrowed his eyes.

“Why?”

“I cannot tell you that either.”

“Then what can you tell me?”

The being remained silent for a moment.

Then—

“This place is called the Land of Dreams.”

Bell looked around.

“The Land of Dreams?”

“Yes.”

“Why am I here?”

“You are confined here temporarily.”

Bell's expression stiffened.

“Confined?”

“Yes.”

“Am I trapped?”

“Yes.”

Bell took a step backward.

His eyes widened.

“Then I am trapped!”

The being's glow brightened.

“Please remain calm.”

“How am I supposed to remain calm?!”

“You are safe.”

“How do you know?!”

“Because you are under my supervision.”

Bell stared at it.

“...Your supervision?”

“Yes.”

“Are you guarding me?”

“Yes.”

“Against what?”

The being paused.

“Yourself.”

Bell became silent.

“...What does that mean?”

“It means you are not ready.”

“For what?”

Another pause.

“Change.”

Bell didn't understand.

He looked down at himself.

His small hands.

His clothes.

His body.

Everything looked normal.

“What kind of change?”

“A mental one.”

Bell's face became blank.

“A... mental change?”

“Yes.”

“Are you going to change my brain?”

“No.”

“Erase my memories?”

“No.”

“Make me forget people?”

“No.”

“Make me smarter?”

The being paused.

“Yes.”

Bell's eyes widened.

“Really?”

“Among other things.”

Bell suddenly became interested.

“What else?”

“That depends on you.”

Bell thought about it.

Then he pointed at the being.

“So you're basically my teacher?”

“No.”

“Then my guardian?”

“No.”

“My jailer?”

“No.”

“Then what are you?”

The being simply answered:

“I am here to assist you.”

Bell stared.

“Assist me with what?”

“Everything you require.”

“Everything?”

“Yes.”

Bell's eyes slowly widened.

“Does that mean you're my personal assistant?”

The being's glow flickered.

“That description is acceptable.”

Bell grinned.

“Then I'll call you my personal assistant!”

“If that is your preference.”

“Do you have a name?”

Silence.

Bell waited.

The being didn't answer.

“...You don't?”

“I have a designation.”

“What is it?”

“I cannot tell you.”

Bell's smile disappeared.

“You really can't tell me anything.”

“That is an accurate observation.”

Bell sighed.

“Fine.”

He sat down.

Or at least attempted to.

There was no ground.

Yet somehow, the moment he decided to sit, something supported him.

Bell looked down.

“...What?”

The being said nothing.

Bell poked the invisible surface beneath him.

“This place is weird.”

“Yes.”

“Can I leave?”

“Not yet.”

“When?”

“When you are ready.”

“How long will that take?”

The being looked at him.

“Time here does not function as it does outside.”

Bell frowned.

“What does that mean?”

“You may experience days.”

The being's glow intensified.

“Then weeks.”

Another flicker.

“Then years.”

Bell's expression slowly changed.

“Years?”

“Yes.”

“But I won't grow older?”

“No.”

“Won't get hungry?”

“No.”

“Thirsty?”

“No.”

“Sleepy?”

“No.”

Bell stared at his own hands.

He suddenly realized something.

He hadn't eaten.

He hadn't drunk anything.

He hadn't even felt tired.

Yet he didn't feel uncomfortable.

“How long have I already been here?”

The being answered immediately.

“Your perception cannot accurately measure it.”

Bell scratched his head.

“That sounds complicated.”

“It is.”

Bell sighed.

“Can I ask you something else?”

“Yes.”

“Will I be alone?”

The being's glow softened.

“No.”

Bell looked up.

“I'll be here.”

For some reason, those words made Bell feel slightly better.

“Okay.”

He smiled.

“Then I'll ask you something.”

“Proceed.”

“What is outside?”

The being remained silent.

Bell waited.

“What is the world outside this place?”

“I cannot answer that yet.”

“Why?”

“Because you are not ready.”

Bell puffed his cheeks.

“You keep saying that.”

“Yes.”

“That's annoying.”

“I apologize.”

Bell laughed.

“You apologize a lot.”

“I was designed to be polite.”

“Who designed you?”

Silence.

Bell pointed accusingly.

“See? You did it again!”

“I apologize.”

Bell burst out laughing.

The being simply stood there.

Its glow pulsed gently.

And for the first time since Bell had arrived in that strange place, he didn't feel afraid.

Days passed.

Or perhaps weeks.

Bell wasn't sure.

He asked questions.

The being answered.

Sometimes immediately.

Sometimes after long pauses.

Sometimes it simply said that it couldn't answer.

Bell learned that the strange space could respond to his thoughts.

If he wanted somewhere to sit, something appeared.

If he wanted something to read, books appeared.

If he wanted to practice writing, paper and pencils appeared.

If he wanted to learn mathematics, the answers were never simply given to him.

Instead, the being taught him.

“Why does two plus two equal four?”

“Because two quantities added to another two quantities produce a quantity of four.”

Bell frowned.

“That's just repeating the answer.”

“Correct.”

“That isn't teaching!”

“Then let us approach it differently.”

The being created four small glowing spheres.

“Count them.”

“One... two... three... four.”

“Now divide them into two groups.”

Bell separated them.

“Two and two.”

“Now combine them.”

Bell pushed the groups together.

“Four.”

The being nodded.

“Therefore?”

Bell smiled.

“Two plus two equals four.”

“Correct.”

Bell grinned.

“I understand!”

The being glowed.

Bell noticed it.

“You glow whenever I learn something.”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I am acknowledging your progress.”

Bell stared at it.

“Are you happy?”

“No.”

“Sad?”

“No.”

“Excited?”

“No.”

“Then why do you glow?”

The being paused.

“Because you asked a meaningful question.”

Bell tilted his head.

“That doesn't explain anything.”

“It is not supposed to.”

Bell stared at the mysterious figure.

For a moment, he wondered if there was more to it.

Something the being wasn't telling him.

Something hidden beneath every answer.

But he was only ten.

Eventually, curiosity won over suspicion.

“Can we learn something else?”

“Yes.”

“What?”

“You choose.”

Bell thought for a while.

“Everything.”

The being became completely still.

“Everything?”

Bell nodded enthusiastically.

“Yes!”

A faint glow appeared around them.

“Then we shall begin.”

And so they did.

Bell learned mathematics.

History.

Language.

Science.

Logic.

Memory.

Observation.

Reading.

Writing.

He learned how to question assumptions.

How to recognize patterns.

How to think before speaking.

How to break complicated problems into smaller ones.

Whenever Bell made a mistake, the being didn't ridicule him.

It simply explained.

Whenever Bell succeeded, it glowed.

And whenever Bell became frustrated—

“I can't do this!”

“You can.”

“No, I can't!”

“You have failed seven times.”

Bell stared.

“That's supposed to make me feel better?”

“No.”

“Then why say it?”

“Because you have attempted it seven times.”

Bell blinked.

“...So?”

“You have not given up.”

Bell became quiet.

Then he smiled.

“...Oh.”

The being continued.

“That is progress.”

Bell eventually stopped asking how long he had been there.

Days became weeks.

Weeks became months.

Months became years.

At least, that was how Bell perceived it.

He could not tell whether a year had truly passed.

There was no sunrise.

No sunset.

No clock.

No calendar.

Only lessons.

Questions.

Answers.

And conversations.

Sometimes Bell would simply sit beside the mysterious being.

Neither of them would speak.

And somehow, the silence never felt uncomfortable.

One day, Bell asked:

“Are you my friend?”

The being didn't answer immediately.

Bell waited.

Finally—

“I am your assistant.”

“That wasn't my question.”

Silence.

Bell smiled.

“So you don't know?”

“I am still determining the appropriate answer.”

Bell laughed.

“Then think about it.”

“I will.”

Bell leaned backward.

“Good.”

The strange being's light softly illuminated the endless space.

Neither Bell nor the being knew exactly how much time had passed.

But one thing had changed.

The frightened ten-year-old who had first awakened in the Land of Dreams was slowly disappearing.

Not his memories.

Not his identity.

Something else.

Something deeper.

His way of thinking.

His understanding.

His ability to question.

And somewhere within that endless dream, an unseen process continued.

Bell did not know who had placed him there.

He did not know what the being truly was.

He did not know what awaited him outside.

But for now...

He had someone to talk to.

And someone who would answer.

Even if the answers were sometimes:

“I cannot tell you.”

“You are not ready.”

Or simply—

“Ask again.”

Absolutely. Bell should **not physically age, grow stronger, or undergo bodily changes inside the dream**. The development should be entirely **mental/educational**, with the real-world Bell remaining the same physically.

Chapter Three: The Origin

— An unknown amount of time later —

Mysterious Being's POV

"Oh, Master... why?"

"Why must I wait?"

"When will you return?"

The being remained alone within the land of dreams.

It had no way of knowing how much time had truly passed.

There was no sun.

No moon.

No seasons.

Nothing that could properly mark the passage of time.

So it calculated.

Seconds.

Minutes.

Hours.

Days.

Years.

It calculated the possible moment of its master's return again and again.

Yet the result never changed.

Unknown.

"Why, Master?"

"Did you forget me?"

The thought remained unanswered.

— Later —

Bell began returning to the land of dreams more frequently.

To him, the place was strange.

It didn't behave like the real world.

There was no hunger.

No physical exhaustion.

And most importantly, his body did not truly change there.

He could learn.

He could think.

He could practice.

But when he awakened, he was still Bell.

The being understood this perfectly.

Therefore, it focused on what could actually be changed.

His mind.

— Much later —

The lessons became more complicated.

Basic mathematics became advanced mathematics.

Numbers became equations.

Equations became calculus.

Then came science.

Physics.

Logic.

Observation.

Problem-solving.

The being even taught him swordsmanship and archery through repeated practice within the dream.

Bell would make mistakes.

The being would correct him.

Bell would try again.

And again.

And again.

There was no need for his body to grow stronger inside the dream.

The purpose was not to give him physical strength.

It was to teach him **how to understand**.

Over time, Bell began noticing something peculiar.

Sometimes he would know the answer before the being explained it.

Sometimes a thought would appear in his mind that he couldn't remember having learned.

And sometimes...

he could almost feel the presence of the being thinking alongside him.

Bell never confronted it directly.

Not yet.

But he was no longer completely unaware.

He had begun to understand that the presence within his dreams was not simply a product of his imagination.

There was something there.

Something that had existed before he understood it.

Something that was patiently teaching him.

And something that was waiting.

— Eventually —

The boundary between Bell and the being became thinner.

The being gradually integrated itself into Bell's mind.

Not taking control.

Not changing his body.

Not replacing his thoughts.

It simply became another presence within his consciousness.

A guide.

A teacher.

A silent observer.

Bell could sense it now.

Not clearly.

Not completely.

But enough.

You're there... aren't you?

The being said nothing.

Bell didn't press the matter.

Instead, he continued learning.

And deep within the land of dreams, the being continued to wait for the one person it had been waiting for since before Bell ever arrived.

Its master.

"Why must I wait..."

"When will you come back?"

Absolutely. I'll keep your core events and mechanics, but make the scene feel more like an actual chapter: more dialogue, Bell's analytical personality, and a little tension around the secret wand.

Chapter Four: Our Secret

Bell woke to sunlight spilling through the window.

He stared at the ceiling for several seconds.

Then he blinked.

Once.

Twice.

Nothing had changed.

The same room. The same wooden ceiling. The same faint sounds of the village waking outside.

Yet Bell knew something was different.

He knew things now.

Not everything. Not even close.

But enough.

He sat up and looked toward the window.

“Another sunny day.”

His eyes narrowed slightly.

“Good.”

He got dressed, ate a simple breakfast, and headed toward the farm.

The moment he arrived, he spotted his grandfather working in the field.

“Good morning, Grandpa.”

The old man looked over his shoulder.

“Oh? You're early today.”

“I couldn't sleep anymore.”

“Couldn't sleep?”

Bell nodded.

“Too many things to think about.”

His grandfather chuckled.

“At your age, you're already worrying about too many things?”

“I'm not worrying.”

“Then what are you doing?”

“Calculating.”

His grandfather stared at him.

“...Calculating?”

Bell paused.

“Nothing.”

“That's what I thought.”

Bell grabbed the farming tools and began working.

For several hours, he observed everything.

The soil.

The crops.

The water distribution.

The tools.

Even the way his grandfather moved.

Eventually, Bell stopped.

“Grandpa?”

“Hm?”

“What is magic?”

The old man's hands stopped moving.

“Magic?”

“Yes.”

“Why are you suddenly asking about that?”

Bell looked down at his hands.

“I heard about it.”

“From where?”

“...Nothing.”

His grandfather raised an eyebrow.

“You've been saying 'nothing' a lot lately.”

Bell remained silent.

His grandfather eventually sighed.

“Magic is... difficult to explain.”

“Can humans use it?”

“Some can.”

“Can I?”

“Bell.”

“Yes?”

“Don't rush into things you don't understand.”

Bell looked at him.

“Why?”

“Because magic isn't a toy.”

His grandfather's expression became unusually serious.

“People have hurt themselves trying to use it. Some have hurt others.”

Bell nodded.

“I understand.”

“Do you?”

“Yes.”

The answer came too quickly.

His grandfather stared at him for a moment before shaking his head.

“Just promise me you won't do anything foolish.”

Bell looked toward the forest.

“I promise.”

He wasn't lying.

At least, not completely.

That night, the village became quiet.

The moon hung above the trees.

Bell waited.

He listened.

Nothing.

He slowly opened the door.

Creaaak.

Bell froze.

He looked back.

Everyone was asleep.

“...That was close.”

He slipped outside and quietly made his way toward the secluded part of the village.

Once he was far enough from the houses, Bell stopped.

He reached into his bag.

“Finally.”

He pulled out several sheets of paper.

Blueprints.

They were crude by the standards of someone with proper tools, but the calculations covering them were anything but crude.

At the center of the design was something resembling a long wooden stick.

A wand.

Bell unfolded the main blueprint.

“So, let's review.”

He placed it on the ground.

“In this world, the wand doesn't create magic.”

He pointed at the diagram.

“It simply reduces the amount of effort required to form a magic circle.”

He tapped another section.

“Twenty-five percent.”

Bell frowned.

“That's not enough.”

A voice suddenly spoke behind him.

“An interesting conclusion.”

Bell didn't turn around.

“I knew you were there.”

“I assumed as much.”

Bell continued studying the blueprint.

“The problem isn't the wand itself.”

“Then what is?”

“The design.”

The voice remained silent.

Bell picked up a piece of wood.

“It's too compact.”

“Compactness is generally considered advantageous.”

“Not here.”

He held the wood against the blueprint.

“The structure forces the magic to travel through too many unnecessary points.”

“And your solution?”

“Start over.”

Bell smiled faintly.

“Not improve the existing design.”

He placed the old blueprint aside.

“Rebuild it from scratch.”

There was a brief silence.

“You are confident.”

“No.”

Bell picked up his tools.

“I'm curious.”

“That is a dangerous distinction.”

“Maybe.”

He began working.

Hours passed.

The moon slowly moved across the sky.

Bell carved.

Measured.

Adjusted.

Recalculated.

Several times, he stopped and stared at the design.

“No.”

He removed a section.

“Too much resistance.”

He replaced another component.

“Better.”

He paused.

“Still inefficient.”

The voice watched silently.

Eventually, Bell tightened the final component.

Click.

He stared at the finished wand.

It was simple.

Plain.

Almost unimpressive.

Bell slowly raised it.

“Finished.”

The voice approached.

“You believe it is functional?”

“There's only one way to find out.”

Bell examined the wand again.

“Estimated output increase... twelve percent.”

He looked at his calculations.

“Mental consumption reduced by approximately five percent.”

He smiled.

“And effective range increased by forty percent.”

There was a pause.

The voice finally spoke.

“Its working functions are commendable, per se.”

Bell glanced sideways.

“But?”

“It is heavily restricted by the materials available to you.”

Bell looked at the wand.

“So it's passable.”

“Yes.”

“That's good enough.”

“For a prototype.”

Bell suddenly looked toward the forest.

Then back at the wand.

“Do you think I could offend some elves by making this?”

The voice was silent.

Bell continued.

“I mean, this wood is from the Forest of Wishe.”

“You knowingly used material originating from their territory?”

“I didn't exactly ask permission.”

“Then I must say...”

The voice paused.

“Maybe.”

Bell stared at the wand.

“That's not reassuring.”

“It was not intended to be.”

Bell sighed.

“Great.”

He pointed the wand toward a nearby tree.

“No elves are going to come after me tonight, right?”

“I cannot guarantee that.”

“Wonderful.”

Bell took a stance.

“Let's test it.”

The voice became slightly more serious.

“Be careful.”

“I'm always careful.”

“That statement is statistically questionable.”

Bell ignored him.

He extended his arm.

The wand began to glow faintly.

Bell's eyes widened.

“So that's how it feels.”

Mana gathered at the tip.

He concentrated.

“Magic.”

The light intensified.

“Mana Bullet.”

BOOM!

The projectile shot forward.

A nearby target exploded apart.

Bell stared.

Silence.

Then he slowly lowered the wand.

“...That was stronger than expected.”

The voice answered calmly.

“Your calculations appear to have been correct.”

Bell looked at the destroyed target.

A small smile appeared on his face.

“So it works.”

He looked down at the wand.

“Our little secret, then.”

The voice gave no immediate response.

Bell glanced toward the darkness behind him.

“You agree?”

After a moment, the voice replied.

“Your secret is safe.”

Bell smiled.

“Good.”

He looked toward the sleeping village in the distance.

“Then tomorrow...”

His grip tightened around the wand.

“We will improve it.”

Chapter Five: Trial and Success?

The days that followed were surprisingly productive.

Bell had become interested in a simple question:

What could he make if he stopped thinking about what was impossible and started thinking about why things happened?

He didn't have access to complicated machinery.

He didn't have perfect materials.

And he certainly didn't have all the answers.

But he had something useful.

Curiosity.

If something behaved a certain way, there had to be a reason.

And if there was a reason, perhaps that reason could be used.

Bell's first project was something surprisingly ordinary.

A water bottle.

He had noticed that water left outside gradually became warm.

That wasn't mysterious.

The surrounding air was warmer than the water, so heat gradually moved into it.

Bell stared at the bottle on his workbench.

"Then the problem isn't making cold water."

He tapped the side.

"It's keeping the heat out."

He began experimenting.

Different materials.

Different thicknesses.

Different arrangements.

Some worked poorly.

Some worked slightly better.

One attempt made the bottle unnecessarily heavy.

Another was too fragile.

Eventually, Bell combined insulation with a small mechanical cooling system.

It wasn't elegant.

It certainly wasn't pretty.

But when he finished the latest version, he carefully filled the bottle and waited.

After some time, Bell touched it.

His eyebrows rose.

"...It worked."

He opened it and took a drink.

Cold.

Bell smiled.

Not because he had created something extraordinary.

Rather, because the method had worked.

He had taken a simple problem, broken it into smaller problems, and solved them one at a time.

That was enough.

His next project was more ambitious.

A crossbow.

Bell already understood the basic principle.

A flexible material could store energy when bent.

Release that energy suddenly, and it could propel something forward.

The difficulty was making the mechanism reliable.

His first design barely moved.

The second snapped.

The third fired, but the entire mechanism shook violently.

Bell stared at the broken pieces.

"...Back to the drawing board."

He didn't become frustrated.

Failure was useful.

Every broken component told him something about what the design couldn't handle.

Eventually, he replaced parts, adjusted the tension, strengthened the frame, and created a spring-assisted mechanism.

He carefully loaded it.

Pulled the trigger.

THUNK!

The bolt struck the target.

Bell stared at it.

Then he walked over and examined the mechanism.

"Better."

He wasn't satisfied yet.

The trigger was too stiff.

The spring was stronger than necessary.

And the frame needed reinforcement.

Still...

It worked.

The boots were the strangest experiment.

Bell had noticed something obvious.

A compressed spring wanted to return to its original shape.

That meant it could store energy.

If he could release that energy at the right moment, it could assist his jump.

Simple.

In theory.

In practice—

"Let's try it."

Bell crouched.

The springs compressed.

Click.

He jumped.

BOING!

"WH—?!"

Bell suddenly went much higher than expected.

His arms flailed.

"WAIT!"

He landed awkwardly and rolled across the grass.

For several seconds, he simply lay there.

Then he slowly sat up.

He looked at the boots.

"...That was higher."

He rubbed his back.

"Much higher."

Bell wasn't discouraged.

If anything, he was fascinated.

The basic idea worked.

The problem was control.

He began making notes.

Spring strength.

Compression distance.

Weight distribution.

Landing force.

Bell looked at the list.

"Back to testing."

Later that afternoon, Bell sat beside his grandfather.

His grandfather had watched most of the experiments without interfering.

Eventually, Bell decided to ask something else.

"Grandfather."

"Hm?"

"What are magic stones?"

His grandfather glanced at him.

"Why are you suddenly interested in those?"

"I've heard people talk about them."

Bell paused.

"And I realized I don't actually understand them."

His grandfather smiled.

"That's a good reason to ask."

He began explaining.

Magic stones had been part of the world's history for a very long time. Their uses had expanded over generations, and different civilizations had developed different ways of utilizing them.

Some were used for magic.

Others were incorporated into tools and devices.

Their properties made them valuable, but their exact origins and nature weren't completely understood.

Bell listened carefully.

He occasionally asked questions.

"Why do some stones behave differently?"

"Because their properties aren't identical."

"Can their power be exhausted?"

"Some can. Some behave differently."

"Does anyone know exactly where they came from?"

His grandfather shook his head.

"Not with certainty."

Bell nodded.

That answer interested him.

"So even scholars don't completely understand them."

"Correct."

Bell thought for a moment.

"What about the gods?"

His grandfather paused.

Then he laughed softly.

"Even gods don't know everything."

Bell looked at him.

"Really?"

"Of course. A god is powerful, Bell. That doesn't mean a god possesses every piece of knowledge in existence."

Bell smiled.

"I suppose that makes sense."

His grandfather studied him for a moment.

"You ask strange questions."

"I like understanding things."

"That's obvious."

The old man chuckled.

"Just remember something."

"What?"

"Understanding one thing doesn't mean you understand everything connected to it."

Bell became quiet.

His grandfather continued.

"Knowledge can make a person confident. Sometimes too confident."

Bell looked toward the sky.

"I'll be careful."

His grandfather smiled.

"Good."

That conversation gave Bell something he needed.

Not answers.

Context.

He could continue asking questions without pretending to know everything.

And that was important.

Bell knew things.

He understood certain principles.

He could reason through problems.

But there was still an enormous amount of this world that he didn't understand.

Pretending otherwise would only make him careless.

There was, however, one secret Bell couldn't afford to treat so casually.

The being.

Bell's recollection

Bell remembered the conversation clearly.

There hadn't been a room.

There hadn't been a body.

There had simply been a presence.

Something that was difficult to describe because every attempt to understand it seemed to fail.

Bell had asked the obvious question.

"What are you?"

The answer had been simple.

> "We are beyond this world's perception."

Bell had thought about that.

Then he had asked:

"Even beyond the gods?"

The answer came without hesitation.

> "Not even god knows."

Bell had remained silent.

He had asked one more question.

"Then what are you?"

There was a pause.

> "Something you do not yet need to understand."

That answer had stayed with him.

The being hadn't taught him how to build anything.

It hadn't given him inventions.

It hadn't explained the laws of the world.

And Bell preferred it that way.

Whatever the being was, Bell didn't want his achievements to depend on it.

His inventions were his own.

His reasoning was his own.

If something worked, he wanted to understand why it worked.

If something failed, he wanted to understand why it failed.

The being was different.

It was something outside the boundaries Bell could currently comprehend.

And that made it dangerous to rely upon.

Bell had therefore made a rule for himself.

Never reveal it.

Not to his grandfather.

Not to his friends.

Not to anyone.

Especially not to the gods.

Bell returned to the present.

He looked at the three inventions sitting nearby.

The cooling bottle.

The spring-assisted crossbow.

The jumping boots.

None of them were perfect.

But they were proof.

Proof that he could take an idea, investigate it, test it, fail, adjust it, and eventually make it work.

Bell smiled.

"I wonder what I can make next."

He picked up a piece of paper and began writing.

Not because he already knew the answer.

Because he wanted to find it.

And somewhere deep inside him, he understood something important.

The world was much larger than what he currently understood.

There were gods.

There was magic.

There were magic stones.

And there was something even stranger that existed beyond the understanding of gods.

Bell didn't know what the future held.

So he would prepare.

Not by relying on some mysterious power.

Not by assuming he already knew everything.

But by learning.

Experimenting.

And thinking.

One problem at a time.

Chapter Six: To the Ones We Loved

Three years had passed.

A lot could change in three years.

For Bell, it had been enough time to turn a pile of half-finished theories, burned notebooks, and several near-disasters into things that actually worked.

His workshop had become almost unrecognizable.

Metal parts covered the tables. Magic circles were drawn across the floor, walls, and even the ceiling. Books were stacked wherever there was enough space to keep them from catching fire.

And, somehow, Bell was smiling.

He held up a small piece of darkened iron.

“Finally.”

He tapped it with his finger.

Clang.

The sound traveled through the metal.

Instead of breaking, the iron briefly glowed with a faint blue light.

The energy disappeared into the material.

Bell's eyes sparkled.

“Success.”

He had named it synthetic metal.

It wasn't truly synthetic in the conventional sense. It was iron altered through a combination of alchemy, magic, and an absurd amount of mathematics. The material could absorb kinetic force and temporarily store it.

But energy couldn't simply disappear.

So Bell developed another component.

A receiver.

Usually a magic stone.

The synthetic metal could transfer the stored energy into it, sacrificing the receiver in the process.

It was inefficient.

Expensive.

Dangerous.

And absolutely fascinating.

Bell grinned.

“Now I just need to make it cheaper.”

A pile of ruined magic stones sat behind him.

He looked at them.

“…Much cheaper.”

His attention shifted to another set of notes.

Synthetic Magic.

A completely new branch of magic.

Unlike traditional magic, which relied heavily on established formulas and magic circles, Synthetic Magic treated magic almost like an engineering problem.

Matter.

Energy.

Atomic structure.

Magical interaction.

Probability.

Numbers upon numbers upon numbers.

It was complicated enough that Bell occasionally stared at his own equations and wondered if he'd accidentally invented a new language.

But it worked.

More importantly—

It worked without destroying the world.

That was a surprisingly important requirement.

One of his more practical creations was a spell he called Disturb Magic.

It wasn't powerful.

It didn't overpower an enemy's spell.

It simply interfered with the formation of a magic circle.

If the enemy relied on a magic circle and Bell's magical level was sufficient, he could disrupt the structure before the spell completed.

Against someone significantly stronger, it wouldn't work.

Against magic that didn't require a circle, it was useless.

But against the right opponent?

It could turn a terrifying spell into nothing more than a collection of glowing lines.

Then there were the boots.

Bell looked down at them.

They were completely ordinary-looking.

That was the point.

A thin layer of enchanted material covered the soles, dispersing the vibration produced when his feet struck the ground.

They didn't make him silent.

They simply made him harder to hear.

And finally—

His favorite.

A small metal sphere sat on the table.

A concussive blast grenade.

Cheap.

Simple.

Reproducible.

No rare materials.

No legendary artifacts.

Just alchemy, a pressure mechanism, and a carefully controlled magical reaction.

Bell picked one up.

“Much better than throwing rocks.”

He paused.

“…Probably.”

The Bandit Raid

That afternoon, Bell was nowhere near his workshop.

He was lying flat on a rocky ridge overlooking a forest road.

Below him, a group of bandits had stopped a merchant caravan.

Bell counted them.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Five.

Seven.

Ten.

He sighed.

“Ten.”

His hand rested against the ground.

A faint magical circle appeared beneath his palm.

Then vanished.

Bell didn't need a grand spell.

The nearest bandit suddenly collapsed.

Thud.

The others looked around.

“What happened?”

Bell moved.

The enchanted boots barely made a sound.

One bandit turned.

Too late.

Bell struck him in the back of the knee, dropped him, and continued forward.

Another raised his sword.

Bell stepped aside.

The blade passed through empty air.

A short burst of magic struck the man's chest.

Bang!

He flew backward.

The remaining bandits finally realized what was happening.

“There's someone here!”

“Where?!”

“Find him!”

Bell smiled.

“Too late.”

He threw something.

The little metal sphere landed in the center of the group.

One bandit stared at it.

“…What's that?”

Bell snapped his fingers.

BOOM!

The concussive blast threw dust and debris into the air.

Bell walked through the cloud.

One.

Two.

Three.

He disabled them quickly, deliberately.

No wasted movement.

No unnecessary spells.

Every attack had a purpose.

By the time the dust settled, the road was quiet.

Bell looked at the unconscious bandits.

“That's everyone.”

He turned toward the merchant caravan.

The merchants stared at him.

One of them slowly raised a hand.

“Are… are you with the army?”

Bell shook his head.

“No.”

“A knight?”

“No.”

“A mage?”

Bell considered it.

“Technically.”

The merchant looked at the unconscious bandits.

Then at Bell.

Then back at the bandits.

“…Thank you?”

Bell gave him a small wave.

“Stay on the main road. There are probably more nearby.”

He turned and walked away.

For Bell, it had been an ordinary afternoon.

He had no idea that while he was hunting bandits—

home was burning.

The Village

The first warning was the sound of the bells.

Once.

Twice.

Then repeatedly.

The villagers froze.

Someone shouted from the northern watchtower.

“GOBLINS!”

Panic spread through the village.

People ran outside.

Mothers pulled children from the streets.

Farmers grabbed whatever weapons they could find.

Spears.

Axes.

Knives.

Hammers.

Anything.

Then they saw them.

A mass of green figures emerged from the forest.

Dozens.

Goblin warriors.

Behind them came larger creatures.

And at their center—

A hobgoblin.

It was enormous.

Its body was covered in crude armor, and a massive weapon rested across its shoulder.

The village guard captain stared at it.

“Everyone…”

His grip tightened around his spear.

“Hold the line.”

The goblins charged.

The first wave crashed against the village barricade.

CRASH!

Wood splintered.

The villagers screamed.

The goblins climbed over the barricade.

One made it across.

Then another.

A villager swung an axe.

THUD.

The creature fell.

Another goblin lunged.

A spear pierced its chest.

The villagers were terrified.

But they fought.

They had nowhere else to go.

The goblins poured into the streets.

Windows shattered.

Doors were kicked open.

Smoke rose from the houses.

The hobgoblin roared and charged through the barricade.

Several villagers were thrown aside.

“RUN!”

“No!”

“We can't!”

“Keep them away from the children!”

The village became chaos.

Yet slowly—

The goblins began to lose.

The villagers knew the streets.

They knew the houses.

They knew every alley and every corner.

They fought together.

One group drew the goblins toward the square.

Another attacked from behind.

Archers fired from rooftops.

Even those who couldn't fight carried stones, water, or wounded villagers away from the battlefield.

The hobgoblin eventually reached the center of the village.

It raised its weapon.

The villagers froze.

Then—

A spear struck its shoulder.

The old man holding it stepped forward.

Bell's grandfather.

His body was already exhausted.

Blood ran down his arm.

But he didn't move backward.

“Not…”

He tightened his grip.

“…one more step.”

The hobgoblin roared.

It swung.

The old man barely dodged.

The weapon smashed into the ground.

He countered.

Again.

And again.

Every movement became slower.

But he refused to fall.

Around him, the villagers continued fighting.

Finally, the hobgoblin stumbled.

The villagers saw the opening.

“NOW!”

Everyone attacked.

Spears.

Axes.

Arrows.

Magic.

The hobgoblin finally collapsed.

The remaining goblins scattered.

Some fled into the forest.

Others were surrounded.

The village had survived.

But survival had come at a terrible price.

The Last Light

When the fighting ended, nobody celebrated.

There were too many bodies.

Too many broken homes.

Too many empty places where people should have been standing.

The old man sat beneath the village's great tree.

Several villagers gathered around him.

His breathing was shallow.

His weapon lay beside him.

Someone knelt down.

“Grandfather…”

He smiled weakly.

“Don't call me that like I'm already dead.”

A few people laughed through their tears.

He looked toward the village.

Children were being carried out of damaged houses.

The wounded were being treated.

The fires were slowly being extinguished.

His eyes softened.

“We protected them.”

Someone held his hand.

“Yes.”

“We won?”

“Yes.”

The old man closed his eyes.

For a moment, everything became quiet.

Then he whispered:

“Good.”

His breathing stopped.

No one spoke.

The wind moved through the leaves above him.

Then—

Something happened.

A faint light appeared around the old man's body.

At first, it was barely visible.

Then it grew brighter.

And brighter.

The villagers stepped backward.

The light rose into the sky.

A column of golden-white radiance pierced the clouds.

It illuminated the entire village.

The wounded stopped.

The children looked upward.

Even those mourning in the streets turned their heads.

The pillar reached higher and higher until it seemed to touch the heavens themselves.

For one brief moment, the villagers could almost imagine a figure standing within the light.

Not a warrior.

Not a king.

Just an old man.

Standing tall.

Looking back at the village one last time.

Then the light began to disappear.

Slowly.

Quietly.

Like a soul returning home.

The clouds above opened.

Sunlight poured through.

And the pillar vanished.

Nothing remained except drifting golden particles carried away by the wind.

One of the villagers whispered:

“He's gone.”

Another answered through tears.

“No.”

They looked toward the sky.

“He's gone home.”

Far away, on a lonely road, Bell suddenly stopped walking.

He looked toward the distant horizon.

For reasons he couldn't explain—

His chest tightened.

He stared at the strange pillar of light fading beyond the mountains.

“…Grandfather?”

And for the first time in three years—

Bell ran.
Chapter Seven: Time Has Come

Bell didn't cry.

He didn't mourn.

He didn't look back at the house that had once been his home, now reduced to a blackened skeleton beneath the smoke-filled sky.

The village was still burning.

Flames crawled across wooden walls, roofs collapsed one after another, and the smell of ash filled the air. Somewhere in the distance, people were shouting, searching for survivors, calling the names of those who had disappeared during the siege.

Bell heard them.

He simply didn't answer.

There was no point.

He had already made his decision.

Bell walked toward his workshop with steady steps, his expression empty. His clothes were dirty, his body exhausted, and several cuts marked his arms and face. Yet none of that mattered.

The workshop was damaged, but thankfully, most of its interior remained intact.

He pushed open the door.

Immediately, Bell began gathering everything he could carry.

Tools.

Weapons.

Metal scraps.

Ropes.

A small hammer.

Several knives.

Containers.

Food.

Clothing.

Anything that could potentially be useful on the road.

He moved quickly, refusing to waste even a second.

Every item had a purpose.

Every tool could become something else if necessary.

He checked the storage shelves twice before taking the remaining materials and placing them into several bags.

Then he stopped.

His eyes moved toward the corner of the workshop.

There was a small wooden box.

Bell walked toward it and opened the lid.

Inside were several objects he had carefully collected over the years.

He stared at them for several seconds.

Memories attempted to surface.

His old life.

The people he had known.

The days before the siege.

The peaceful moments that now seemed impossibly distant.

Bell closed the box.

"Not anymore."

He packed only what was necessary.

Everything else could stay behind.

When he finally left the workshop, the sun had already begun disappearing beyond the horizon.

Bell returned to what remained of his house.

He stood outside for a moment.

The building was almost completely destroyed.

It would be easy for someone to assume that nobody could have survived inside.

That was exactly what Bell needed.

He began preparing the final part of his plan.

It wasn't complicated.

In fact, simplicity was what made it believable.

Bell created evidence suggesting that he had died during the siege.

A damaged section of the house.

A few belongings left behind.

Burned pieces of clothing.

Enough remains that nobody would bother searching too deeply.

The villagers were already exhausted.

They had lost homes.

Friends.

Family.

The last thing they needed was another mystery.

Bell understood that.

He wasn't trying to deceive them because he hated them.

He simply couldn't remain there anymore.

If people believed Bell had died, they would eventually mourn him.

Then they would move on.

That was the natural order of things.

And Bell needed to become someone else.

Someone with no past.

Someone who could leave without being followed by questions.

He looked around the village one last time.

The streets were covered in ash.

The place where children once played was empty.

The small shops where villagers used to gather were damaged or destroyed.

Bell felt something inside him tighten.

But he forced himself to ignore it.

There was no turning back.

He adjusted the bags over his shoulders.

Then he walked away.

No farewell.

No final words.

No promises.

Nothing.

By morning, the villagers would believe Bell had died during the siege.

And perhaps that was better.

There was no reason to mourn someone who wasn't truly dead.

Bell wasn't like everyone else.

He was a god.

His kind lived differently.

Their lives were governed by rules that ordinary people could never understand.

If he stayed, more questions would eventually come.

If he remained connected to the village, someone might eventually discover the truth.

So Bell chose the only path he could think of.

Disappear.

Start again.

And travel to the place where countless dreams, ambitions, and adventures gathered.

Orario.

The city of adventurers.

The city surrounding the Dungeon.

The place where gods descended to the mortal world and Familia fought for fame, wealth, and power.

Bell had heard stories about it for years.

Now, he would see it for himself.

He began walking before sunrise.

The road stretched endlessly ahead.

For the first few hours, Bell said nothing.

He simply walked.

His feet hurt.

His shoulders became sore from carrying the equipment.

But he continued.

Every step placed more distance between himself and the village.

Every step made returning more difficult.

Eventually, Bell stopped at the top of a small hill.

He turned around.

The village was barely visible in the distance.

Smoke still rose into the sky.

Bell stared at it.

For a moment, he almost felt the urge to return.

Almost.

Then he turned away.

"That's enough."

He continued toward the road leading east.

Toward Orario.

Toward a new life.

Toward whatever waited for him beyond the horizon.

He didn't know what would happen when he arrived.

He didn't know which gods he would encounter.

He didn't know what dangers awaited him inside the Dungeon.

And he certainly didn't know how much his life was about to change.

But Bell knew one thing.

His old life was over.

Whether the world believed he was dead or not didn't matter anymore.

Bell Cranel had disappeared.

And someone new was about to arrive in Orario.

Absolutely. I'd make the first two scenes establish the mysterious woman without revealing who she is, then make Bell's encounter feel increasingly wrong before anything is actually revealed.

Chapter Eight: An Unfaithful Encounter

Scene One — The Search

She walked with an elegance that made even her peers envy her. For what felt like an eternity, she had waited, watched, and searched for the other half fate had promised her.

Yet she had found nothing.

Or perhaps… she had been searching in the wrong place.

Woman: "How many years has it been?"

Her attendant glanced at her from behind.

Attendant: "My lady?"

Woman: "Nothing."

She smiled faintly, though there was no warmth in it.

Attendant: “You have been searching for him for a very long time.”

Woman: “Him?”

Attendant: “The one fate promised you.”

The woman slowly turned her gaze toward the horizon.

Woman: “Fate promises many things.”

Attendant: “And you don't believe it?”

Woman: “I believe fate is patient.”

She paused.

Woman: “But I am beginning to wonder whether it is also a liar.”

The attendant fell silent.

For a moment, only the sound of her footsteps remained.

Attendant: “Then why continue searching?”

The woman smiled.

Woman: “Because if I stop…”

Her eyes narrowed.

Woman: “…I may never learn the truth.”

Scene Two — The Silver Light

The silver-haired beauty sat inside the carriage beside a towering man whose presence alone made the carriage feel smaller.

He was a Boaz—silent, broad-shouldered, and armed.

She leaned against the window.

Then she saw it.

A faint silver light flickering in the distance.

Her eyes immediately sharpened.

Woman: “…Stop.”

The carriage slowed.

Boaz: “My lady?”

She raised one delicate finger toward the distant glow.

Woman: “Do you see that?”

The Boaz looked.

Boaz: “A light.”

Woman: “No.”

She stared at it.

Woman: “That isn't a light.”

Boaz: “Then what is it?”

She didn't answer.

The silver glow pulsed once.

Her expression changed.

Woman: “Turn the carriage.”

Boaz: “Toward it?”

Woman: “Yes.”

Boaz: “We don't know what is waiting for us there.”

She finally looked at him.

Woman: “That's precisely why we're going.”

Boaz: “My lady, if this is dangerous—”

Woman: “Then we'll discover how dangerous it is.”

The Boaz hesitated.

Woman: “Go.”

The horses turned.

The carriage began moving toward the silver light.

And somewhere beyond the distant trees, something seemed to be waiting.

Scene Three — Bell

Bell had stopped counting the days.

The road beneath his feet had become indistinguishable from the countless roads he had already crossed.

His body was exhausted.

His clothes were stained with dust.

His throat burned.

But his magic could still provide him with one necessity.

Water.

He raised his hand.

A faint magical structure formed across his palm.

Synthetic magic.

The surrounding mana twisted.

Condensation gathered.

Then—

Drip.

A small amount of water fell into his cupped hand.

Bell: “…Finally.”

He drank.

For a few precious seconds, everything was quiet.

Then—

Clop.

Bell froze.

His eyes slowly opened.

*Clop.

Another hoofbeat.

Then another.

Closer.

Much closer.

His breathing stopped.

The sound wasn't coming from the road ahead.

It was coming from behind him.

Bell slowly lowered his hand.

The water slipped between his fingers.

Bell: “…Horses?”

Silence.

Then the sound came again.

CLACK.

CLACK.

CLACK.

Fast.

Far too fast.

Bell turned his head.

Nothing.

Only the empty road.

The trees.

The wind.

And yet the hoofbeats continued.

CLACK—CLACK—CLACK—CLACK!

Bell's instincts screamed.

Something was approaching.

He couldn't see it.

He couldn't sense it.

But it was there.

The trees suddenly trembled.

Birds exploded from their nests and fled into the sky.

Bell slowly stood.

Bell: “…Who's there?”

No answer.

The hoofbeats stopped.

Dead silence.

Bell's fingers tightened.

His magic began gathering around his hand.

Bell: “I asked…”

His voice lowered.

Bell: “…who's there?”

Nothing.

Then, from somewhere deep within the darkness of the trees—

Clop.

One hoofbeat.

Bell's pupils contracted.

That wasn't coming from the road.

It was coming from inside the forest.

Another hoofbeat.

Clop.

Closer.

Bell took one step backward.

His synthetic magic flickered.

Something moved between the trees.

He couldn't make out its shape.

Then he saw two faint reflections.

Eyes.

Watching him.

Bell stopped breathing.

The eyes disappeared.

For several seconds, there was nothing.

Then a woman's voice whispered from the darkness.

???: “Bell…”

His blood ran cold.

He had never told anyone his name.

And the voice sounded as though it had been waiting for him.

For a very, very long time.

Chapter Nine — Goddess of Magic

Bell's consciousness vanished the instant something struck him from behind.

He barely had time to turn before darkness swallowed his vision.

When Bell finally stirred again, the first thing he noticed was the smell of smoke and herbs.

The second was the unfamiliar ceiling above him.

Canvas.

A tent?

He slowly opened his eyes and tried to move.

His body felt strangely heavy.

Bell remained still for a moment, studying his surroundings. A small lantern burned beside him, casting warm light across the tent. Several shelves were filled with bottles, scrolls, and strange-looking objects that Bell couldn't identify.

Then he noticed the woman sitting across from him.

She was watching him.

Not with hostility.

Not even with suspicion.

She was simply... fascinated.

Her gaze followed every small movement of his face.

Bell swallowed.

Who is she? And why am I here?

Before speaking aloud, he instinctively reached toward the strange presence within his mind.

What happened?

The answer came almost immediately.

You were ambushed. Your attacker carried you here. You have been unconscious for approximately—

Bell stopped listening.

His eyes returned to the woman.

She had stood up.

Slowly, she approached his bed.

There was something unusual about her presence. She didn't need to raise her voice or threaten him. Somehow, the entire tent seemed to become quieter whenever she moved.

She leaned slightly closer.

Her eyes softened.

"Interesting..."

Bell frowned.

"What's interesting?"

The woman's lips curved into a faint smile.

"Your soul."

"My... soul?"

She nodded.

"I have seen countless souls."

Her voice was gentle, almost hypnotic.

"But yours..."

She paused, studying him as though trying to remember something from a distant age.

"It shines."

Bell didn't know how to respond.

The woman continued.

"Like a star that survived the death of its own sky."

Bell's expression changed.

That wasn't something a normal person could see.

"Who are you?"

Instead of answering, she tilted her head.

"You're cautious."

"I was kidnapped."

A small laugh escaped her.

"Kidnapped?"

She glanced toward the entrance of the tent.

"I suppose that's one way of describing it."

Bell narrowed his eyes.

"Then what would you call it?"

"An invitation."

"An invitation doesn't usually involve knocking someone unconscious."

"Ah."

She smiled.

"That part wasn't my idea."

Bell remembered the voice he had heard before losing consciousness.

"Why do you need to do it harder? Can you just politely ask him?"

So someone had objected to the attack.

That didn't make the situation much better.

The woman sat beside him.

Bell immediately shifted backward.

She noticed.

Rather than becoming offended, she seemed amused.

"Don't be afraid."

"I'm not."

"You're lying."

Bell frowned.

She smiled again.

"Adorable."

Bell's face tightened.

"Who are you?"

This time, she finally answered.

"My name is Freya."

The name struck something inside Bell.

Not a memory.

Something deeper.

The presence within his mind reacted.

Freya.

Bell's eyes widened.

The information began unfolding inside his thoughts.

Goddess Freya.

Goddess of war.

Goddess of beauty.

Goddess of fertility.

Bell stared at her.

There was one more title.

One he hadn't expected.

His expression slowly changed.

"You're..."

Freya watched his realization with obvious amusement.

"Yes?"

Bell whispered,

"The Goddess of Magic."

Silence.

For the first time, Freya's smile disappeared.

Then she laughed softly.

"Now you've discovered the interesting part."

The lantern beside them suddenly flickered.

Every flame in the tent turned blue.

Bell froze.

Freya raised one finger.

A tiny sphere of light appeared above it.

It wasn't fire.

It wasn't a spell Bell recognized.

It was something purer.

Ancient.

The sphere expanded until the entire tent was illuminated by a strange, beautiful radiance.

Freya looked directly into Bell's eyes.

"You thought magic was something you learned."

The light reflected in her eyes.

"But magic was never something humanity created."

She closed her fingers.

The light vanished.

"It was something humanity was given."

Bell stared at her.

Freya leaned closer, her voice becoming almost a whisper.

"And I..."

A faint smile returned to her lips.

"...am the one who gave it to them."

Bell's heart stopped for a moment.

Freya stood.

"Now, Bell."

She extended her hand.

"Shall we talk about why your soul shines like a star from an age that should have disappeared long ago?”

Chapter Ten: What is Magic?

In the beginning, there was nothing.

And from that nothing came the first spark.

From the spark came energy.

From energy came matter.

And when matter came into existence, chaos followed.

The first particles collided. They merged, separated, disappeared, and appeared again. The laws that governed them were unstable, constantly changing as creation struggled to define itself.

There was no order.

There was no balance.

There was only existence—and the endless struggle for that existence to remain.

And so, the gods intervened.

Among those tasked with observing the newly formed universe was Freya, a goddess entrusted with watching over the strange phenomena that emerged beyond the boundaries of ordinary creation.

It was during one such observation that she discovered something unusual.

An anomaly.

At first, it appeared to be nothing more than a secluded point in space.

There was no star.

No planet.

No living creature.

Nothing that should have attracted the attention of the gods.

Yet matter continuously appeared within that region.

And then it was destroyed.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Creation and destruction occurred simultaneously.

Something was being born and annihilated at the same time.

Freya named the phenomenon an Elemental Disturbance.

The name was eventually shortened among the gods to Disturbance.

But the name did little to explain what they had discovered.

The laws of nature should have prevented such a phenomenon from existing.

Matter should not simply appear from nothing.

Energy should not accumulate without cause.

An element should not suddenly change its properties merely because it existed within a particular location.

Yet it happened.

The gods observed.

They experimented.

They attempted to destroy the anomaly.

They attempted to contain it.

They attempted to understand it.

Every attempt failed.

The disturbance would simply reappear somewhere else.

Sometimes it manifested as heat.

Sometimes as pressure.

Sometimes as a violent reaction between elements.

Sometimes it caused water to move without gravity.

Sometimes fire appeared without fuel.

Sometimes the earth itself seemed to reject the laws that governed it.

And eventually, the gods realized something.

The disturbance was not an enemy.

It was not a creature.

It was not an energy source.

It was a fluctuation in the fundamental structure of reality itself.

Reality was not perfectly stable.

There were imperfections.

Tiny cracks in the rules.

Places where matter and energy behaved differently.

The gods called these phenomena Fluctuations.

And after countless attempts, the gods succeeded in taming them.

Not controlling them completely.

Not eliminating them.

Only stabilizing them enough that they could exist without tearing apart the surrounding world.

The gods believed their work was finished.

They were wrong.

The fluctuations spread.

Slowly at first.

Then across the world.

The different races began to encounter them.

They saw fire appearing without wood.

They saw water moving against gravity.

They saw stones floating in the air.

They saw lightning summoned from empty skies.

They saw wounds closing without medicine.

They saw impossible things.

The gods called them fluctuations.

The races called them something else.

Magic.

Bell had heard this story before.

Several times, in fact.

He had heard different versions from different people.

Some claimed magic was a blessing given to the races by the gods.

Others claimed it was the remnants of the world's creation.

Some scholars believed magic was simply another form of energy.

And there were even religious sects that believed magic was the physical manifestation of divine will.

Bell knew that most of those explanations were incomplete.

He also knew that Freya's explanation was probably simplified for his benefit.

So he listened.

Quietly.

His expression remained neutral.

Occasionally, he nodded.

Occasionally, he tilted his head slightly as though trying to understand something complicated.

To Freya, he looked like a boy hearing the concept for the first time.

A rather clueless boy.

She continued explaining.

"The reason magic can produce different effects," Freya said, "is because fluctuations do not behave identically everywhere. Their characteristics depend upon the environment, the elements surrounding them, and the stability of the region."

Bell nodded.

"Uh-huh."

Freya paused.

"Do you understand?"

Bell stared at her.

Then he slowly nodded again.

"I think so."

"You think so?"

"Yes."

Freya smiled faintly.

"What part don't you understand?"

Bell looked toward the sky.

"All of it."

Freya blinked.

"...All of it?"

"Yes."

For a moment, she simply stared at him.

Bell maintained the most innocent expression he could produce.

Inside, however, he was amused.

That should work.

He had learned something important during his time dealing with people.

Looking intelligent attracted attention.

Looking ignorant made people explain things.

And when someone believed they were teaching you something, they naturally revealed more information than they intended.

Freya seemed particularly susceptible to it.

She sighed.

"Very well. Let me simplify it."

Bell nodded enthusiastically.

Freya raised one finger.

"Imagine reality as a river."

Bell listened.

"Normally, the river flows in one direction. That flow represents the natural laws of the world."

She raised another finger.

"Magic is what happens when something causes the river to fluctuate."

Bell tilted his head.

"So... magic is like water?"

"No."

"Then I don't understand."

Freya's expression became slightly exasperated.

"It is an analogy."

"Oh."

Bell nodded seriously.

"I understand now."

"You clearly don't."

Bell looked away.

"...A little."

Freya sighed again.

She had no idea that Bell understood considerably more than he was letting on.

And Bell intended to keep it that way.

The explanation continued for several minutes.

Freya explained how magical fluctuations could be concentrated, dispersed, absorbed, and manipulated.

She explained that different races had developed different methods of interacting with them.

Some used chants.

Some used gestures.

Some used magical formations.

Others relied on innate abilities.

Humans had developed particularly complicated systems of magic, relying heavily on knowledge and technique.

Bell listened to every word.

Not because he needed the lesson.

Because Freya was revealing information.

And information was valuable.

Eventually, Freya stopped.

"That is the basic explanation of magic."

Bell nodded.

"So magic is fluctuations."

"Yes."

"And fluctuations are caused by the world becoming unstable."

"Essentially."

"And the gods discovered them first."

"Yes."

"And then everyone learned how to use them."

"Over a very long period of time."

Bell nodded thoughtfully.

"I see."

Freya smiled.

"Good."

Bell smiled back.

She thinks I understand nothing.

That was exactly what he wanted.

A few seconds passed.

Then Freya's expression changed.

She looked around.

The road was empty.

There were no houses nearby.

No merchants.

No travelers.

No guards.

And yet Bell was standing alone in the middle of it.

Freya narrowed her eyes.

"Wait."

Bell looked at her.

"Hm?"

"What are you doing?"

"Standing."

"I can see that."

Bell looked down at himself.

Then back at Freya.

"...Walking?"

"You aren't walking."

"Oh."

Freya crossed her arms.

"You are standing in the middle of the road."

Bell looked around.

Indeed.

He was standing directly in the center of the road.

"Oh."

Freya stared at him.

"Are you lost?"

Bell considered the question.

"No."

Freya's eyes narrowed.

"Did bandits steal from you?"

"No."

"Are you waiting for someone?"

"No."

"Did you run away from home?"

"No."

"Are you injured?"

"No."

"Then why are you standing here?"

Bell remained silent.

This was the moment he had been waiting for.

He knew that Freya possessed a method of detecting lies.

Not a perfect one.

Nothing was perfect.

And that was precisely why it could be abused.

The trick was not to lie.

The trick was to answer the question while avoiding the information the question was actually trying to obtain.

Bell looked at Freya with an expression of genuine confusion.

Then he pointed down the road.

"I was going that way."

Freya followed his finger.

"That doesn't answer my question."

Bell looked puzzled.

"It does."

"No, it doesn't."

"I was going that way."

"Why?"

Bell shrugged.

"I wanted to."

Freya stared at him.

"...Why did you want to?"

Bell thought for a moment.

"Because I wanted to go there."

Freya's eyebrow twitched.

"You are deliberately being difficult."

Bell's expression became innocent.

"I'm not."

Freya studied him.

The lie detection gave her nothing.

Because technically, he wasn't lying.

He really had been going that way.

He really did want to go there.

But that wasn't what she wanted to know.

She tried again.

"Where are you from?"

Bell paused.

Then answered honestly.

"Somewhere."

Freya's expression went blank.

"Somewhere?"

"Yes."

"Where?"

"Somewhere else."

Freya slowly closed her eyes.

Is he an idiot?

From her perspective, Bell appeared completely genuine.

There was no obvious deception.

No nervousness.

No hesitation consistent with a deliberate lie.

Just an apparently confused young man giving frustratingly useless answers.

She opened her eyes again.

"Bell."

"Yes?"

"Do you know where you are?"

Bell looked around.

He examined the road.

The trees.

The distant mountains.

Then he looked at Freya.

"...No."

Freya sighed.

Finally.

An honest answer.

"Do you know where you were going?"

Bell nodded.

"Yes."

"Where?"

Bell pointed again.

"That way."

Freya stared at him.

Bell stared back.

For several seconds, neither moved.

Then Freya put a hand against her forehead.

"You are the strangest lost person I have ever met."

Bell smiled faintly.

"Thank you."

"That wasn't a compliment."

"Oh."

He looked down.

"Sorry."

Freya studied him again.

Something about him bothered her.

Not because he appeared dangerous.

Quite the opposite.

He appeared almost painfully ordinary.

A young man standing in the middle of a road.

No luggage.

No obvious weapon.

No companions.

No destination.

And apparently no idea where he was.

Yet something didn't quite fit.

Freya couldn't determine what it was.

Her ability could detect deception.

But it couldn't read someone's intentions.

It couldn't force a person to answer a question they had not been asked.

And it certainly couldn't distinguish between ignorance and deliberate misunderstanding when both produced the same answer.

Bell had discovered that weakness long ago.

And he intended to exploit it for as long as possible.

Freya finally sighed.

"Fine."

She turned toward the road.

"Come with me."

Bell blinked.

"Where?"

"Somewhere safe."

Bell hesitated.

Then smiled.

"Okay."

Freya started walking.

Bell followed.

Neither of them noticed the faint shimmer in the air behind them.

A tiny fluctuation.

Almost invisible.

Almost nonexistent.

For the briefest moment, the air distorted.

Then it disappeared.

Bell stopped.

He looked back.

Freya continued walking.

"Are you coming?"

Bell stared at the empty road.

"...Yeah."

He followed her.

But for the first time since they had met, the clueless expression disappeared from his face.

For just a moment.

Because Bell had noticed something.

The fluctuation.

And unlike Freya...

He knew exactly what it was.

Absolutely. I'll keep the chapter centered on **Bell's arrival in Orario**, Freya's attempt to recruit him, the 100,000-valis parting gift, and Bell's first realization that this is where his real adventure

begins. I'll also make the farewell more poetic and let the unanswered questions about the gods and Dungeon linger rather than explaining everything immediately.

Chapter Eleven: Crossroads

Bell Cranel woke to the warmth of sunlight.

For several seconds, he simply stared upward.

The ceiling of the wagon was illuminated by thin streams of golden light that slipped through the gaps in the wooden frame. The gentle swaying beneath him told him that they were still moving.

For a moment, Bell forgot where he was.

Then reality returned.

Three days.

Three days since they had begun traveling toward Orario.

Bell slowly sat up and rubbed his eyes.

Outside, the sound of wheels rolling over the road mixed with the occasional clop of horse hooves. Voices drifted through the morning air.

He pushed aside the curtain.

"Good morning, Bell."

Bell nearly jumped.

Freya was sitting near the front of the carriage, looking back at him with that familiar, almost amused smile.

"G-Good morning."

"You sleep quite soundly."

"Really?"

"Like a child."

Bell scratched his cheek awkwardly.

"I guess I was tired."

Freya's eyes lingered on him.

"You have been thinking a great deal these past few days."

Bell froze.

"Have I?"

"Yes."

"Is it that obvious?"

"To me."

She smiled.

Bell looked away.

There were many things occupying his thoughts.

Orario.

The Dungeon.

Familias.

Adventurers.

Gods.

And, perhaps most importantly...

What was he supposed to do once he arrived?

He had spent so long thinking about reaching Orario that he had never truly considered what would happen afterward.

The dream had always been simple.

Become an adventurer.

But dreams became considerably more complicated when they were finally within reach.

Bell glanced toward Freya.

There was something he had wanted to ask her.

"Freya?"

"Hm?"

"Can I ask you something?"

"Of course."

Bell hesitated.

"How do I... join a Familia?"

Freya's expression changed almost imperceptibly.

Then she smiled.

"Oh?"

Bell immediately became nervous.

"Is that a strange question?"

"Not at all."

Freya turned her gaze toward the road.

"To become an adventurer, you generally need the blessing of a god or goddess."

"The Falna."

"Yes."

Bell nodded.

He had heard about it before.

A divine blessing.

A power bestowed upon mortals by the gods who had descended into the Lower World.

"Once you find a god willing to accept you," Freya continued, "you become a member of their Familia. The god grants you their blessing, and from there, you can begin developing your abilities."

"So I just need to find a god who will accept me?"

"Essentially."

Bell nodded thoughtfully.

That sounded simple.

Perhaps too simple.

"Then..."

He looked at Freya.

"How difficult is it to join one?"

Freya's smile widened.

"That depends on the Familia."

Bell blinked.

"Some gods accept almost anyone who asks. Others are considerably more selective."

"What about the powerful Familias?"

"They tend to have standards."

Bell lowered his head.

That was what he had feared.

"So I probably won't be able to join one."

Freya raised an eyebrow.

"Why?"

"Because I'm weak."

"You are?"

Bell looked at her.

"Yes."

Freya laughed softly.

"You say that as though it were a permanent condition."

"I mean right now."

Bell clenched his fists.

"I don't have any experience. I've never been inside the Dungeon. I don't have any achievements. I don't have anything that would make a Familia want me."

Freya watched him silently.

Bell continued.

"And if they only want strong adventurers..."

He sighed.

"I don't think I'll qualify."

Freya leaned slightly toward him.

"Then join mine."

Bell stared.

"...What?"

"My Familia."

Bell's ears turned red.

"No!"

The answer came so quickly that even Freya seemed amused.

"You didn't even think about it."

"I-I did!"

"You thought for less than a second."

"Because I already know!"

Bell waved his hands frantically.

"I can't just join your Familia!"

"Why not?"

"Because..."

He struggled to explain.

Freya waited patiently.

Bell finally lowered his head.

"I'm not strong enough."

Silence.

Freya's expression softened.

"Bell."

"Yes?"

"You seem to misunderstand something."

She reached forward and gently touched his chin, lifting his face.

"Strength isn't the only thing I see."

Bell's crimson eyes met hers.

"You have something more interesting."

Bell swallowed.

"What?"

Freya smiled.

"I'll tell you when you're ready."

Bell's face became even redder.

"But still..."

"Still?"

"I can't."

Freya sighed theatrically.

"How cruel."

"I'm sorry."

"You reject me without even considering it."

"I'm really sorry."

"Perhaps I should be more persuasive."

"Please don't."

Freya laughed.

The conversation eventually faded into comfortable silence.

The road continued.

Morning became afternoon.

Afternoon became evening.

And the landscape slowly changed.

The farther they traveled, the more Bell noticed signs of civilization.

More roads.

More travelers.

More merchants.

More adventurers.

Then, on the third morning...

Bell saw something in the distance.

At first, he thought it was a mountain.

A massive silhouette rose beyond the horizon.

It was so enormous that Bell couldn't understand what he was seeing.

The carriage continued forward.

The silhouette grew.

And grew.

Until finally Bell stood up.

"What..."

His voice escaped him without permission.

Freya looked toward him.

"Beautiful, isn't it?"

Bell couldn't answer.

Orario.

The city appeared to dominate the entire horizon.

Its walls were enormous, built like a fortress capable of resisting armies.

But the walls themselves were not what captured Bell's attention.

It was what stood within them.

A colossal tower.

White stone rose higher and higher, disappearing into the sky.

The structure seemed less like a building and more like a mountain created by human hands.

Its upper reaches vanished into the clouds.

Bell stared upward.

"Is that..."

"The Tower of Babel."

Freya's voice carried a strange reverence.

Bell had heard of it.

The Tower of Babel.

The enormous structure standing at the center of Orario.

The Dungeon lay beneath it.

The Dungeon.

The reason adventurers came here.

The reason gods had gathered here.

The reason this city had become the center of the world.

Bell's heart began beating faster.

I'm really here.

His hands trembled.

For years, Orario had existed only in his imagination.

A distant city.

A place of adventure.

A place where heroes were born.

Now it was directly in front of him.

The carriage slowly approached the gates.

Bell could see people everywhere.

Adventurers carrying swords.

Merchants pulling carts.

Children running through the streets.

Demi-humans of countless races.

Humans.

Beastmen.

Elves.

Dwarves.

People from every corner of the world.

Bell stared in wonder.

"So many people..."

Freya smiled.

"This city attracts people who desire something."

"Something?"

"Power. Wealth. Fame."

She paused.

"Adventure."

Bell's eyes widened.

"And some come here searching for answers."

Bell glanced toward her.

"Answers?"

Freya looked toward the Tower.

"Everyone has their own reason."

The carriage passed through the enormous gate.

Bell felt his heart pound.

This was it.

The moment he had been waiting for.

His adventure was about to begin.

Yet strangely...

He felt more nervous than excited.

The carriage eventually stopped.

Freya stepped down first.

Bell followed.

The moment his feet touched the stone pavement of Orario, he looked around.

Noise surrounded him.

Merchants shouting.

Adventurers laughing.

Blacksmiths hammering metal.

Children playing.

The smell of food filled the air.

Bell slowly turned toward the enormous tower.

Somewhere beneath that structure was the Dungeon.

A place that no one had completely conquered.

A place filled with monsters.

A place whose depths remained unknown.

Bell clenched his fists.

I'm going there.

Not today.

Perhaps not tomorrow.

But eventually.

He would enter those depths.

He would become stronger.

He would discover what waited beneath Orario.

And perhaps...

He would discover why the gods had descended into the Lower World in the first place.

Why had they abandoned the heavens?

Why had they chosen to live among mortals?

Why did they give humans the Falna?

Why did the Dungeon exist?

And why did the gods seem to know so much about it?

Bell had no answers.

Only questions.

Freya approached him.

"Bell."

He turned.

She held something in her hand.

A small leather pouch.

She extended it toward him.

Bell looked confused.

"What's this?"

"Take it."

He accepted it.

The pouch felt heavier than expected.

Bell opened it slightly.

His eyes widened.

Gold and silver coins gleamed inside.

"Freya..."

"Consider it assistance."

"I can't accept this."

"You can."

"But—"

"There are things you will need."

Bell looked inside again.

"How much is this?"

"One hundred thousand valis."

Bell nearly dropped the pouch.

"ONE HUNDRED THOUSAND?!"

Several nearby people turned toward them.

Bell quickly lowered his voice.

"That's too much!"

Freya smiled.

"Then consider it an investment."

"An investment?"

"Yes."

She stepped closer.

"I want to see what becomes of you."

Bell stared at her.

Freya reached out and gently placed a hand against his head.

"Don't disappoint me."

Bell's face reddened.

"I won't."

"I know."

For a moment, neither spoke.

The noise of Orario seemed to fade into the background.

Bell looked at the woman standing before him.

Freya.

Someone he still couldn't completely understand.

Someone who had helped him reach this city.

Someone who had offered him a place in her Familia.

And someone who, despite everything, seemed to believe in him.

"Thank you."

The words were quiet.

But sincere.

Freya smiled.

"You're welcome."

She stepped back.

Bell suddenly felt something strange.

The realization that this was goodbye.

At least for now.

He looked at the carriage.

The road behind them stretched toward the horizon.

Three days.

Three days of traveling.

Three days of conversations.

Three days of slowly becoming accustomed to the presence of these people.

And now...

The road split.

One path would carry Freya onward.

The other belonged to Bell.

A crossroads.

Freya turned toward her carriage.

Bell watched.

"Freya."

She stopped.

Bell hesitated.

"Will I see you again?"

Freya looked over her shoulder.

Her smile was gentle.

"Orario is a large city."

She paused.

"But it is not large enough to hide forever."

Bell smiled.

"I'll remember that."

Freya stepped into the carriage.

Before the curtain closed, she looked at him one final time.

"Bell."

"Yes?"

"Become strong."

Bell nodded.

"I will."

"Become someone worthy of the dreams you carry."

His eyes widened slightly.

"And when the time comes..."

Freya's smile became mysterious.

"Perhaps you'll understand why I wanted you."

The curtain fell.

The carriage began moving.

Bell stood still.

The wheels slowly carried Freya away.

He watched the carriage disappear into the crowded streets.

For some reason, he couldn't bring himself to move.

The wind passed through his white hair.

The pouch of valis hung heavily at his side.

The city roared around him.

Yet Bell felt strangely alone.

He looked down at the money.

Then toward the Tower of Babel.

Then toward the vast city surrounding it.

He took a deep breath.

"Okay..."

His hand tightened around the pouch.

"This is it."

No grandfather.

No Freya.

No carriage.

No familiar road.

Just him.

Bell Cranel.

Standing at the beginning of something he had dreamed about for years.

He looked toward the Tower again.

The structure disappeared into the heavens.

Its uppermost reaches seemed almost to touch the domain from which the gods had descended.

Bell felt a shiver.

The Dungeon is beneath that.

His heart began beating faster.

The Dungeon.

A place filled with monsters.

A place where adventurers risked their lives every day.

A place that held secrets no one had completely uncovered.

Bell didn't know what awaited him.

He didn't know which god would accept him.

He didn't know whether he would become strong.

He didn't know whether he would ever become a hero.

He didn't even know where he would sleep tonight.

Bell looked around.

"...I should probably solve that one first."

He sighed.

His stomach growled.

Bell froze.

"...And food."

Another growl.

"Definitely food."

For the first time since entering Orario, Bell laughed.

A small, nervous laugh.

But it was genuine.

He started walking.

One step.

Then another.

The streets of Orario opened before him.

People passed on either side.

Adventurers headed toward the Dungeon.

Merchants shouted about their goods.

Gods walked among mortals.

Somewhere beneath the enormous tower, monsters waited.

Somewhere within the city, a Familia waited for a new member.

And somewhere beyond all of that...

Were answers.

Bell didn't know what questions he would have to ask to find them.

But he intended to find them.

The gods had come down to the Lower World for a reason.

The Dungeon existed for a reason.

The Falna existed for a reason.

And if the world had kept those answers hidden for so long...

Then perhaps an adventurer was exactly the kind of person who should go looking for them.

Bell stopped at the intersection.

Several roads stretched before him.

He looked left.

Then right.

Then up at the towering Babel.

A strange feeling settled in his chest.

It wasn't fear.

It wasn't excitement.

It was the feeling of standing before an enormous door.

A door that, once opened, could never truly be closed again.

Bell smiled.

"Let's see where this road takes me."

And with that...

Bell Cranel stepped deeper into Orario.

Toward the Dungeon.

Toward the gods.

Toward the Familias.

Toward the secrets hidden beneath the city.

Toward a future he couldn't yet imagine.

His adventure had finally begun.

Chapter Twelve: Hostess of Fertility

Bell had been wandering through Orario for nearly an hour before finally stopping one of the guards.

“Excuse me,” Bell said politely. “Do you know where I can find an inn?”

The guard looked at him for a moment before pointing down one of the streets.

“Looking for a cheap place?”

“Something like that.”

“Then try the Hostess of Fertility. It’s not too far from here. You’ll know it when you see it.”

Bell thanked him and followed the directions.

By the time he arrived, evening had already settled over the city.

The building was considerably livelier than Bell had expected.

Laughter spilled through the open windows. The smell of cooked food drifted into the street, accompanied by the clinking of glasses and the occasional loud shout from inside.

Bell paused at the entrance.

So this is an inn?

He stepped inside.

The atmosphere immediately changed.

There were adventurers everywhere.

Some were eating, others drinking, while several groups were loudly discussing their latest adventures in the Dungeon.

Bell quietly scanned the room.

Then—

His instincts screamed.

Danger.

Bell's eyes shifted toward the waitresses.

One.

Two.

Three.

Then another.

Every single one carried an aura that was completely abnormal.

They're strong.

Very strong.

Bell had encountered people with powerful presences before. He had learned quickly that reacting visibly to such things was a good way to attract unnecessary attention.

So he did what he had learned to do.

Nothing.

Bell calmly walked toward an empty corner table and sat down.

Just act normal.

A waitress approached him.

But before she could say anything, someone else caught Bell's attention.

Ashen-silver hair.

Bell's eyes narrowed slightly.

He studied the person's face.

There was something familiar about it.

Not the appearance.

The feeling.

Bell leaned slightly closer and quietly said,

“You are truly beautiful... even in someone else's face.”

The words were barely audible.

Only the two of them could have heard.

The person's expression froze.

For several seconds, there was complete silence.

Then—

“Eh?”

The person suddenly turned red.

Without saying another word, they hurried toward the kitchen.

Bell blinked.

Did I say something wrong?

He sat there alone.

A few seconds later, a massive presence approached from behind.

Bell felt the floorboards creak.

He slowly looked up.

The owner of the establishment stood before him.

“What'll it be?”

Bell glanced at the menu.

“Pasta, please. And some fruit juice.”

“That's it?”

“Yes, please.”

The owner stared at him for another moment.

“You're a strange one.”

Bell smiled awkwardly.

“I've heard that before.”

“Hmph.”

She turned away.

“Coming right up.”

Bell relaxed.

A few minutes later, his food arrived.

He thanked her and began eating.

Surprisingly, the food was excellent.

This is actually really good.

For the first time since arriving in Orario, Bell felt himself genuinely relax.

He ate quietly while listening to the surrounding conversations.

“Did you hear? That party went down to the eighteenth floor—”

“Seriously?”

“Yeah! They said they barely made it back alive!”

Bell continued eating.

So this is what an adventurer's life is like.

He took another bite.

Then another.

Everything seemed peaceful.

Almost too peaceful.

Bell's instincts suddenly stirred again.

...What?

He stopped eating.

The room hadn't changed.

Nobody appeared to be attacking him.

Nobody was even looking at him.

Yet something had changed.

Bell slowly lowered his fork.

His eyes moved toward the entrance.

The tavern door had opened.

Someone had just walked inside.

Bell couldn't see their face.

Only a silhouette.

But the moment that presence entered the room—

Every instinct Bell possessed screamed the same warning.

Run.

Bell's fingers tightened around his fork.

That's...

The newcomer took one step forward.

The surrounding conversations gradually died down.

One by one, the adventurers stopped talking.

Even the waitresses became still.

Bell slowly turned his head.

The newcomer stopped.

Then, from beneath the shadow of the hood, came a quiet voice.

“...So you're here.”

Bell's eyes widened.

The voice was familiar.

Far too familiar.

And then—

The newcomer looked directly at him.

Bell's heartbeat stopped.

No way...

The stranger smiled.

“Bell.”

To be continued.

Absolutely. I’ll keep the core events you gave me, but expand the chapter into a proper reunion: Lefiya recognizes Bell immediately, has quietly remembered their first meeting for years, and the recruitment conversation carries some emotional weight rather than feeling like a simple exposition scene.

Chapter Thirteen: Lefiya

Bell had always considered himself rather unlucky.

Not catastrophically unlucky.

He had never been struck by lightning while standing beneath a tree, nor had he fallen into a volcano, nor had an ancient god personally cursed him.

His misfortune was more… ordinary.

Doors closed at the wrong time.

People misunderstood him.

He somehow ended up involved in situations that had nothing to do with him.

And whenever he tried to avoid trouble, trouble seemed to notice him first.

This particular incident was one of those occasions.

It had been three days since Bell had awakened from the strange land of dreams.

The memory still lingered in the back of his mind.

A strange place.

Strange people.

Strange sensations.

And, most importantly, the feeling that he had been asleep for far longer than he actually had.

Bell had decided not to dwell on it.

There were things he understood.

There were things he didn't.

And there were things that were better left alone.

At the moment, he had more practical concerns.

He was standing on a hill overlooking a forest road.

His eyes moved slowly across the trees.

Nothing.

He listened.

Wind.

Leaves.

Birds.

Nothing unusual.

Bell crouched down and touched the earth.

There were tracks.

Several.

Small.

Irregular.

He frowned.

"Kobolds."

He stood.

There were more tracks than there should have been.

That wasn't particularly concerning by itself. Kobolds were weak monsters, and Bell had dealt with far worse.

But then he heard it.

A distant scream.

Bell's head snapped toward the road.

Then came the unmistakable sound of wood breaking.

A horse whinnied in panic.

Bell sighed.

"Of course."

He disappeared from the hill.

The carriage had already been surrounded.

Six kobolds.

No.

Eight.

Two were attacking the horses while the others were attempting to break through the carriage doors.

The driver was lying unconscious on the ground.

Inside the carriage, several passengers were screaming.

One kobold raised its club.

Bell arrived before it could strike.

THUD!

His fist connected with the monster's jaw.

The kobold flew sideways and crashed into another.

Bell landed between the carriage and the remaining monsters.

The kobolds stared at him.

Bell stared back.

"...You're really making my patrol difficult."

One of them growled.

Bell stepped forward.

The first attacked.

Bell sidestepped.

The club passed beside his head.

He caught the monster's wrist and pulled.

The kobold stumbled forward.

Bell struck it in the stomach.

It collapsed.

Another came from behind.

Bell turned.

His elbow struck its chest.

CRACK.

The creature flew backward.

The remaining kobolds hesitated.

Bell tilted his head.

"Are you going to run?"

They growled.

Bell sighed.

"That's what I thought."

A few seconds later, the road was quiet.

Eight kobolds lay unconscious or dead around the carriage.

Bell looked around.

"No other monsters."

He walked toward the carriage.

"Is everyone alright?"

There was silence.

Then the door opened slightly.

A pair of frightened eyes appeared.

"We're... we're safe?"

Bell nodded.

"Yes."

One by one, the passengers climbed out.

An elderly merchant.

Two servants.

A young couple.

And finally—

A girl.

No.

An elf.

Bell paused.

She had long orange hair that seemed almost golden beneath the afternoon sunlight.

Her pointed ears immediately identified her.

An elf.

She looked young.

Very young, in fact.

But there was something unusual about her.

Her eyes.

They weren't the eyes of someone accustomed to being helpless.

They were sharp.

Determined.

Yet at that moment, they were also trembling.

She looked at the monsters scattered across the road.

Then at Bell.

Then back at the monsters.

"...You defeated all of them?"

Bell scratched his cheek.

"They weren't particularly strong."

The elf stared at him.

"You... you're a strange person."

Bell blinked.

"Is that a compliment?"

She seemed to realize what she had said.

"No! I mean—yes! I mean..."

Her face began turning red.

Bell tilted his head.

"Are you feeling sick?"

"I'm perfectly healthy!"

"Oh."

The elf took a breath.

Then bowed deeply.

"Thank you!"

Bell blinked.

"For what?"

"For saving us!"

She lifted her head.

"If you hadn't arrived..."

Her voice became quieter.

"I don't know what would have happened."

Bell looked away.

"It's nothing."

"It isn't nothing."

The elf reached into her belongings.

She hesitated.

Then pulled out a small branch.

It wasn't particularly impressive.

A simple branch from a nearby tree.

She held it out to him.

"Here."

Bell looked at it.

"A branch?"

Her face became even redder.

"Yes."

"...Why?"

"I-I don't know!"

Bell stared.

The elf stared.

The branch remained between them.

Finally, Bell accepted it.

"Thank you."

The elf looked relieved.

Then she suddenly remembered something.

"Oh!"

Bell looked at her.

"I forgot!"

"Forgot what?"

"My name!"

Bell stared.

She stared back.

"...Your name?"

"I forgot to introduce myself!"

Bell almost smiled.

"That's okay."

"No, it isn't!"

She took a deep breath.

"My name is—"

Bell glanced toward the carriage.

The driver was beginning to wake.

Bell's attention shifted.

"I should make sure he's alright."

"But—"

"I'll see you around."

The elf froze.

Bell turned and hurried toward the driver.

The elf watched him leave.

Then she realized something.

"Wait!"

Bell stopped.

He turned around.

The elf opened her mouth.

But no words came.

She had completely forgotten what she wanted to say.

Bell smiled faintly.

"My name is Bell."

Then he turned around and continued toward the driver.

The elf remained standing there.

Bell.

That was his name.

She looked down at the branch in his hand.

Then back at him.

Her cheeks became red again.

"...Bell."

Years passed.

The world changed.

People changed.

And the girl who had once stood beside a carriage surrounded by defeated kobolds was no exception.

She grew.

She trained.

She studied.

She failed.

She succeeded.

She cried.

She became angry.

She became stronger.

And eventually, she became known throughout the world.

Lefiya Viridis.

A prodigious elven mage.

A member of the Loki Familia.

A respected magic scholar.

A name spoken with admiration by adventurers and scholars alike.

She had achieved things she once believed impossible.

But there was one memory she never forgot.

A boy on a forest road.

A red-eyed adventurer who defeated eight monsters as though it were nothing.

A strange boy who accepted a meaningless branch without questioning it.

And most importantly—

A boy who had introduced himself before she had even managed to say her own name.

Bell.

She had wondered about him many times.

Where was he?

Was he alive?

Had he become an adventurer?

Had he joined a Familia?

Was he strong?

Did he remember her?

Lefiya had never admitted it to anyone.

Not even to herself.

But every time she heard rumors about an unusual adventurer, she listened.

Every time a new name became famous, she checked.

And every time she heard someone mention a white-haired, red-eyed young man...

Her heart stopped for half a second.

Most of the time, it wasn't him.

Until one day—

It was.

Lefiya stood outside the building.

She had been standing there for several minutes.

She adjusted her clothes.

Then adjusted them again.

She checked her hair.

Then immediately realized she had checked it three times already.

"This is ridiculous."

She took a breath.

She had fought monsters.

She had faced terrifying situations.

She had cast magic capable of destroying entire groups of enemies.

She was Lefiya Viridis.

Why was she nervous?

Because today she was going to meet him.

After all these years.

The boy from the forest road.

The boy she had waited for.

She had known for some time that he was coming.

She had heard about him.

She had seen reports.

She had even seen him from a distance once.

But she had never approached him.

Not yet.

She wanted their reunion to be meaningful.

She wanted to know whether he remembered.

Whether that day meant anything to him.

Whether she had been nothing more than another stranger he had rescued.

The thought hurt more than she wanted to admit.

Then—

Footsteps.

Lefiya's heart jumped.

She looked up.

Bell approached.

He looked different.

Older.

Stronger.

Yet unmistakably himself.

White hair.

Red eyes.

The same expression.

The same calmness.

Bell stopped in front of her.

For several seconds, neither spoke.

Lefiya's hands tightened.

Bell looked at her.

Then smiled.

"Long time no see."

Lefiya froze.

"You..."

Bell tilted his head.

"What?"

"You remember me?"

"Of course."

Lefiya's eyes widened.

"Of course?"

Bell nodded.

"You gave me a branch."

Her face turned bright red.

"You remember that?!"

"It was unusual."

"I knew it!"

Bell chuckled.

Lefiya looked away.

She had spent years wondering whether he remembered.

And his answer was so simple.

Of course.

Those two words meant more to her than he could possibly know.

Bell looked at her carefully.

"You've changed."

Lefiya glanced back.

"Changed?"

"You're stronger."

She blinked.

"How can you tell?"

Bell's expression became thoughtful.

"Your aura."

Lefiya stiffened.

"My... aura?"

Bell nodded.

"It's powerful."

She suddenly remembered.

He had always been able to notice things other people couldn't.

Even back then.

That was one of the things that had fascinated her.

"You haven't changed at all."

Bell raised an eyebrow.

"Is that good?"

"I haven't decided."

Bell smiled.

Then he looked at her for another moment.

His expression became mischievous.

"So..."

He folded his arms.

"What does the revered Lefiya Viridis, great magic scholar and woman known throughout the world, possibly want with humble little me?"

Lefiya's face immediately became red.

"W-Wait!"

Bell continued.

"Surely someone as important as you wouldn't personally come looking for someone like me without a reason."

"You..."

She took a breath.

Then another.

She had rehearsed this conversation.

Countless times.

She had imagined what she would say.

How she would say it.

How confident she would sound.

None of it survived the moment she actually stood before him.

She looked directly into his red eyes.

"Bell Cranel."

Her voice steadied.

"I've come to personally recruit you."

Bell's expression changed.

"Recruit me?"

"Yes."

"Into the Loki Familia?"

Lefiya nodded.

Bell was silent.

She watched him carefully.

"You already know?"

"I had a feeling."

"Of course you did..."

Lefiya sighed.

Bell smiled.

"But why?"

That question made her pause.

Because there were many answers.

Because he was strong.

Because his potential was extraordinary.

Because Loki Familia needed someone like him.

Because his skills would complement theirs.

Because the executives had discussed him.

Because she personally wanted him there.

But those were only parts of the truth.

Lefiya looked at him.

"Because I remember you."

Bell's expression softened.

"The boy who saved me that day didn't ask who I was."

She looked down.

"He didn't ask what I could give him."

"He didn't ask whether I was important."

"He simply saw someone in danger and helped."

Her hands tightened.

"I've met many adventurers since then."

"Some are strong."

"Some are famous."

"Some are kind."

"But I've never forgotten you."

Bell remained silent.

Lefiya continued.

"Perhaps that's selfish."

"Perhaps I'm letting one childhood memory influence something that should be decided logically."

She looked up.

"But when I heard you were coming to Orario..."

She smiled faintly.

"I realized I had been waiting."

Bell stared at her.

"For me?"

Lefiya nodded.

"Yes."

Her voice was quiet.

"I've been waiting for the day I'd meet you again."

Bell didn't immediately respond.

For once, the usually composed expression on his face disappeared.

He looked almost surprised.

Lefiya smiled.

"You're probably wondering why."

"Maybe."

"Then I'll tell you."

She stepped closer.

"Because you were the first adventurer I ever saw who made me want to become stronger."

Bell blinked.

"I did?"

"You probably don't remember."

"I remember you."

"No."

She shook her head.

"I mean what happened afterward."

Lefiya looked toward the sky.

"After you left that day, I kept thinking about you."

"The way you fought."

"The way you didn't hesitate."

"The way you looked at danger."

"You made being strong seem... simple."

Bell frowned slightly.

"It isn't."

"I know."

She smiled.

"That's why I trained."

Bell looked at her.

Lefiya continued.

"I wanted to become someone who could stand beside people like you."

A quiet breeze passed between them.

Bell finally smiled.

"Then you've succeeded."

Lefiya froze.

"What?"

Bell nodded toward her.

"You're strong."

Her eyes widened.

"You really think so?"

"I know so."

Lefiya's cheeks reddened.

She looked away quickly.

"You're unfair."

"Why?"

"Because..."

She smiled despite herself.

"...I waited years to hear that."

Bell's expression softened.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Bell looked toward the city.

"Tell me something."

"What?"

"Why now?"

Lefiya blinked.

"Why recruit me now?"

She corrected herself.

"You."

Bell nodded.

Lefiya thought for a moment.

"Because Loki Familia isn't looking for someone ordinary."

"And you're not ordinary."

Bell laughed.

"I've heard that before."

"I'm serious."

"So am I."

Lefiya's expression became determined.

"Come with us."

Bell looked at her.

"Join Loki Familia."

She held his gaze.

"Not because we want to use your strength."

"Not because we think you owe us anything."

"But because I believe you belong among people who can understand what you're capable of becoming."

Bell was silent.

Lefiya's voice softened.

"And..."

She hesitated.

"I'd like to see how far you go."

Bell smiled.

"Is that another reason you've been waiting?"

Lefiya's face became red.

"Don't tease me!"

"I'm not."

"You are!"

Bell laughed.

Lefiya tried to maintain her dignity.

She failed.

Eventually, she laughed too.

The years between them suddenly seemed much shorter.

The boy on the forest road was still there.

And so was the girl who had watched him leave.

Only now—

They were no longer children.

They stood as adventurers.

Equals.

And perhaps, for the first time, they were standing at the beginning of the same road.

Bell looked at her.

"I'll think about it."

Lefiya blinked.

"You will?"

"Yes."

She smiled.

"That's enough."

Bell looked at her curiously.

"You're not going to pressure me?"

Lefiya shook her head.

"No."

She paused.

Then smiled.

"I've already waited this long."

Bell laughed.

"Fair enough."

Lefiya turned away.

Her expression softened.

She had finally found him.

The person she had spent years wondering about.

And somehow, after all those years, Bell was still Bell.

The same boy.

The same eyes.

The same strange kindness.

Lefiya quietly touched the small branch she had kept all those years.

She had never thrown it away.

Not once.

Bell noticed the movement.

"Do you still have it?"

Lefiya froze.

Then slowly looked at him.

"...You noticed?"

Bell smiled.

"I notice things."

She stared at him for several seconds.

Then she laughed softly.

"Of course you do."

Bell started walking.

Lefiya followed.

And for the first time in years, she no longer had to wonder where he was.

He was right beside her.

Chapter Fourteen: The Decision

Three days had passed since Bell's impromptu recruitment attempt.

He had tried everything.

He visited one Familia after another, hoping that at least one of them would give him a chance. He introduced himself, explained his situation, and even demonstrated a little of what he could do.

But the answer was always the same.

"Sorry, we're not recruiting."

"We're looking for experienced adventurers."

"You should try somewhere else."

Some were polite.

Some barely acknowledged him.

And a few didn't even bother hiding their disappointment.

Bell slowly began to understand.

Being strong wasn't enough.

Without a Familia, without a god or goddess willing to take him in, he had no place in Orario.

And there was another problem.

The moment word spread that the mysterious young adventurer had been noticed by the Loki Familia, the other Familias became even more hesitant.

No one wanted to pick a fight over a newcomer who had already attracted the attention of one of the city's greatest powers.

Bell didn't know that.

All he knew was that another day had passed.

Then another.

By the third day, Bell stood outside another Familia's headquarters.

"Excuse me... Are you accepting new members?"

The response came almost immediately.

"No."

"Oh..."

Bell lowered his head.

"I understand. Thank you for your time."

He turned around.

Another rejection.

For a moment, Bell considered simply giving up.

Maybe this was a mistake.

Maybe he had expected too much.

Maybe he really wasn't ready for Orario.

Then he remembered why he had come.

His grandfather.

The stories.

The dream of becoming an adventurer.

Bell clenched his fists.

"I'm not giving up yet."

He had one option left.

And, strangely enough, it was the same option he had been avoiding.

The Loki Familia.

Later that day, Bell finally stood before the entrance to the Loki Familia's headquarters.

He stared at the enormous building.

"So... this is it."

He took a deep breath.

Then walked inside.

Bell expected to be greeted by someone.

Instead, the moment he entered the training grounds, he stopped.

Something was wrong.

The entire place was unusually quiet.

Not peaceful.

Quiet.

Bell's instincts immediately reacted.

He slowly looked ahead.

Several people were standing in the training field.

Not ordinary adventurers.

The executives of the Loki Familia.

Riveria.

Gareth.

And several other high-ranking members.

Bell's eyes widened.

"Why are they all here...?"

Then his gaze moved toward the center of the field.

One man stepped forward.

Blond hair.

Small stature.

But an overwhelming presence.

Finn Deimne.

The captain of the Loki Familia.

Bell immediately became alert.

Finn smiled.

"Bell Cranel."

"Y-Yes?"

"You've been looking for a Familia."

Bell nodded cautiously.

"Yes."

Finn planted his spear against the ground.

"Then let's see if you're worthy of joining ours."

Bell's eyes widened.

"Wait... what?"

Finn raised his weapon.

"I challenge you to a duel."

The entire training ground fell silent.

Bell stared at the captain.

"A duel...?"

Finn's smile remained.

"Show us what you've got."

Bell slowly tightened his grip.

He had spent three days being rejected.

He had spent three days wondering whether he belonged in Orario.

And now, standing before him, was the captain of one of the strongest Familias in the world.

Bell took a step forward.

"Fine."

Finn's eyes sharpened.

"Good."

He lowered his stance.

"Then prove to us..."

"Why we should let you join the Loki Familia."

Bell's heart began pounding.

The next instant—

Finn disappeared from his sight.

Chapter Fifteen: The Duel

The moment Finn stepped forward, Bell's instincts screamed.

His body moved before his mind could catch up.

A translucent barrier erupted before him.

BOOM!

Finn's spear crashed into it.

The barrier shattered instantly.

Bell's eyes widened.

"Too strong!"

He twisted his body in midair, narrowly avoiding the second strike. The spear grazed his clothes as he flipped backward.

Finn didn't pursue immediately.

He simply watched.

"You're fast," Finn said calmly. "But you're relying too much on your instincts."

Bell landed several meters away.

"Then I'll just have to rely on something else."

A magic circle appeared beneath his palm.

"Magic?"

Finn's eyes sharpened.

Bell thrust his hand forward.

"**Magic Missile!**"

Several glowing projectiles erupted from the circle and screamed toward Finn.

Finn immediately dashed sideways.

BOOM! BOOM! BOOM!

The field disappeared beneath a series of explosions.

Dust and debris filled the air.

Bell suddenly launched himself upward.

"Now!"

He raised his hand.

Another magic circle formed.

Finn's eyes followed him through the smoke.

"He's attacking from above?"

The answer came immediately.

BOOM!

A concentrated blast slammed into the ground.

Bell was thrown backward by his own explosion.

He twisted in the air, landed on one foot, and skidded several meters.

His clothes were torn.

His breathing had become heavier.

But he smiled.

"That actually worked."

Finn emerged from the smoke.

A few scratches marked his armor.

"Interesting."

Bell reached behind him.

Several strange spherical objects materialized in his hands.

Finn stared.

"What are those?"

Bell grinned.

"Something I made."

He threw them.

"Catch."

Finn's expression changed.

The spheres landed around him.

CLICK.

Finn's eyes widened.

"Oh."

BOOOOOOM!

A series of concussive explosions erupted simultaneously.

The shockwave ripped across the training field.

Finn was momentarily swallowed by smoke.

Bell didn't hesitate.

He sprinted forward.

"I have to keep him from recovering."

He summoned his staff.

The weapon materialized into his hand.

Bell planted its tip against the ground.

A massive magic circle spread outward.

Three meters.

Then four.

The air itself seemed to distort.

Finn emerged from the smoke, slightly bruised.

He looked at the enormous circle beneath his feet.

His instincts warned him.

"Bad."

He immediately moved.

One step.

Two.

Then—

He stopped.

Finn looked down.

His foot had crossed the edge of the circle.

Yet somehow, his body refused to move beyond it.

His eyes narrowed.

"A barrier?"

Bell raised his staff.

"No."

The magic circle pulsed.

"It's worse."

Finn looked at him.

Bell's expression became completely serious.

Then he began to chant.

"Fluctuate..."

The atmosphere grew unnaturally still.

"Materialize..."

The surrounding mana seemed to bend toward the circle.

Finn tightened his grip on his spear.

"What exactly are you planning, Bell?"

Bell looked directly at him.

"Annihilate."

The magic circle turned black.

"ANTI-MATTER."

Silence.

No explosion.

No thunder.

No flash.

Nothing.

Finn waited.

"...That's it?"

Then he noticed something.

The edge of his armor was disappearing.

Not breaking.

Not burning.

Disappearing.

Finn's eyes widened.

"What?"

He immediately attempted to leap away.

His body wouldn't move.

The space around him seemed to have become a prison.

The next moment—

Nothing happened.

And yet Finn felt something terrifying.

The very existence of the space around him was being erased.

His armor was damaged.

His skin was bruised.

His spear trembled in his hand.

But there was no impact.

No sound.

No heat.

No smoke.

Just annihilation.

Bell's staff shook slightly in his hands.

He was struggling to maintain the spell.

"He's still standing..."

Finn looked toward him.

Then, slowly—

He smiled.

Bell blinked.

"You're smiling?"

Finn laughed quietly.

"Yeah."

The magic finally dissipated.

Finn dropped to the ground, landing on one knee.

Bell immediately lowered his staff.

"Are you okay?"

Finn looked at his damaged armor, then back at Bell.

"Kid..."

He stood.

"You just attacked me with magic I've never seen before."

Bell scratched his cheek.

"I... might have gone a little too far."

"A little?"

Finn laughed.

"You tried to erase me from existence."

Bell became nervous.

"Sorry."

Finn walked toward him.

Bell instinctively prepared another spell.

Finn noticed.

"Relax."

He stopped directly in front of Bell.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Finn extended his hand.

"Welcome to the Familia."

Bell stared at the offered hand.

"...You're accepting me?"

Finn smiled.

"After that?"

He glanced at the destroyed training field.

"Absolutely."

Bell slowly took his hand.

Finn's grip tightened.

"But there's one condition."

Bell looked up.

"What?"

Finn's smile became slightly mischievous.

"Next time you use that anti-matter spell..."

He glanced at the ruined field.

"Warn me first."

Bell laughed.

"I'll try."

Finn shook his head.

"No."

He pulled Bell forward.

"Don't *try.*"

"**Do it.**"

And with that, Bell officially became a member of the Loki Familia.

Chapter Sixteen: Doubt and Regret

Bell remained silent for several moments after Finn's challenge.

The offer was tempting.

There was no denying that.

The Loki Familia was one of the strongest familias in Orario. Joining them would immediately give Bell access to experienced adventurers, resources, information about the Dungeon, and opportunities that most newcomers could only dream of. If his sole objective was survival and rapid advancement, accepting the offer would have been the logical choice.

But Bell wasn't thinking only about survival.

He was thinking about what kind of adventurer he wanted to become.

If he entered an established familia now, he would inevitably become one piece of an already functioning machine. The Loki Familia already had its hierarchy, its strategies, its expectations, and its established elites. Finn was the captain. Riveria was the strategist and mage. Gareth was the powerhouse. Beneath them were countless experienced adventurers who had already developed their own positions.

Bell would be joining their system.

He wouldn't be building his own.

That distinction mattered.

Bell lowered his gaze.

"No."

Finn's expression changed slightly.

"Are you certain?"

"Yes."

Bell answered calmly.

"I appreciate the offer. More than you probably realize. But I don't think joining the Loki Familia is the right choice for me."

There was no arrogance in his voice.

No attempt to insult them.

It was simply a decision.

Finn studied him for several seconds before giving a faint smile.

"That's quite an answer for someone your age."

Bell didn't respond immediately.

His thoughts were already somewhere else.

The duel.

The spell.

Finn.

Bell replayed the exchange in his head.

Finn was a Level Six adventurer.

That fact alone was enough to make Bell cautious.

During their duel, Bell had deliberately used magic that he believed would create distance rather than cause serious injury. Yet even with Finn's experience, the explosion had forced him to absorb a considerable amount of the impact.

Bell narrowed his eyes.

That bothered him.

Not because he had defeated Finn.

He hadn't.

The duel had been brief, chaotic, and heavily dependent on surprise. Finn had been testing him just as much as Bell had been testing Finn.

What bothered Bell was something more fundamental.

Their combat styles didn't fit together.

Finn fought like a veteran.

Every movement had purpose. Every step conserved energy. He could read an opponent's rhythm and exploit the smallest opening. Bell, meanwhile, relied heavily on adaptability, magic, mobility, and unconventional attacks.

Individually, both styles were effective.

Together?

That was the problem.

Bell mentally reconstructed the battlefield.

If he had been fighting alongside Finn rather than against him, how would they coordinate?

Finn would naturally move toward the enemy.

Bell would naturally create distance.

Finn relied on physical pressure.

Bell relied on ranged magic and sudden bursts of movement.

If Bell launched an explosive spell while Finn was engaging an enemy, there was a possibility of catching Finn in the blast.

If Finn rushed forward while Bell prepared a spell, Bell would have to interrupt his casting.

Their strengths weren't naturally complementary.

At least, not yet.

And that was dangerous.

Bell wasn't going to join a familia simply because it was powerful.

He needed people whose abilities could actually work with his own.

More importantly, he needed the freedom to develop without constantly adjusting himself to someone else's established system.

Perhaps that was selfish.

Perhaps it was even foolish.

But Bell had learned something important.

Strength wasn't simply a matter of standing beside stronger people.

It was about understanding what you could become when you weren't constantly being forced into someone else's shape.

Bell finally looked at Finn.

"Maybe I'm making a mistake."

Finn raised an eyebrow.

"Maybe?"

"I'm aware that declining your offer could be the wrong decision."

Bell's expression remained calm.

"But if I accept simply because you're stronger than me, then I'm not really making a decision. I'm just following the safest path."

Finn stared at him.

Then he laughed quietly.

"You've certainly got some strange ideas."

Bell gave a small smile.

"I've been told that before."

The conversation eventually ended.

Bell left the manor alone.

The moment he stepped outside, the noise of Orario swallowed him.

Adventurers walked through the streets. Merchants shouted their prices. Children ran between adults. The smell of cooked meat drifted through the air.

Bell walked without a particular destination.

His thoughts remained occupied.

Had he made the correct choice?

The Loki Familia could have offered him almost everything he needed.

Training.

Protection.

Knowledge.

Connections.

And yet he had walked away.

Bell sighed.

"Maybe I'm an idiot."

His stomach answered before his brain could.

Growl.

Bell stopped.

He slowly looked down.

"Apparently, I'm also hungry."

He glanced around.

There were food stalls scattered along the street.

Bell's eyes immediately settled on one.

Fried potatoes.

Cheap.

Simple.

Perfect.

He approached the stall and reached for his pouch.

"One serving, please."

"Coming right up!"

The vendor handed him a small paper container filled with golden-brown potato balls.

Bell took one.

He bit into it.

Warm.

Crunchy.

Soft inside.

For the first time since leaving the Loki manor, his thoughts became quiet.

"This was a good decision."

He reached for another.

Then he noticed the person standing behind the stall.

Jet-black hair.

Deep blue eyes.

Small stature.

She looked young.

Very young.

Yet something about her presence made Bell stop.

It wasn't simply beauty.

There was something strangely familiar about her.

Bell's instincts reacted before his mind could properly process it.

Not danger.

Something else.

Something he couldn't identify.

The girl tilted her head.

"What?"

Bell stared at her.

His analytical mind immediately began cataloguing the details.

Small frame.

No obvious armor.

No visible weapon.

Yet her posture wasn't that of an ordinary civilian.

Her eyes were sharp.

Her expression was lively.

And there was an inexplicable pressure surrounding her.

Bell's instincts screamed one conclusion.

Divine.

Before he could stop himself, he asked—

"Are you a goddess?"

The girl froze.

Bell froze.

Even the vendor seemed to pause.

"Huh?"

The girl's face slowly turned red.

"W-Wha—?! Why would you suddenly ask something like that?!"

Bell blinked.

"Because you look like one."

"That's not an answer!"

Bell tilted his head.

"It is from my perspective."

The girl stared at him.

Then she burst into laughter.

"Ahahahaha! You're really strange!"

Bell didn't understand why.

But something about her laughter made him feel strangely comfortable.

He looked at her again.

There was no overwhelming aura now.

No intimidating presence.

Just a girl selling food on the street.

And yet Bell couldn't shake the feeling that meeting her wasn't an accident.

He had spent the entire day calculating risks.

Familia.

Strength.

Compatibility.

Growth.

The future.

He had rejected one of the greatest familias in Orario because he wanted to choose his own path.

And now, standing in front of a small food stall, he suddenly wondered whether choosing one's own path meant walking it alone.

The girl extended a potato ball toward him.

"Here."

Bell looked at it.

"What is that?"

"A free sample."

"Why?"

"Because you look like you're thinking too much."

Bell stared at her.

She smiled.

"Sometimes you should just eat."

Bell slowly accepted the potato ball.

He took a bite.

For some reason, the warmth spreading through him wasn't coming from the food.

For the first time since arriving in Orario, Bell didn't feel like he needed to calculate what would happen next.

He simply stood there.

Eating.

Talking.

Listening.

And somehow, that ordinary moment felt more important than the grand offer he had just rejected.

Bell looked at the girl again.

"What's your name?"

She smiled proudly.

"Hestia."

Bell repeated the name silently.

Hestia.

He didn't know it yet.

But the decision he had made at the Loki manor would soon be overshadowed by another decision.

One that would change his entire life.

Worked for 14s

Chapter Seventeen: Hearth

The offer from the Loki Familia had been declined.

Bell had spent the following days thinking about what came next.

He needed a Familia.

Not because he wanted protection. Not because he wanted someone to carry him through the Dungeon.

He simply needed a place where he could finally establish himself.

And somehow, that search had led him to a tiny goddess who had almost nothing.

Bell stood before the small goddess with his hands clasped behind his back.

Hestia stared at him.

Bell stared back.

Neither spoke.

The silence continued for several seconds.

“...So,” Hestia finally said, pointing at herself. “You want to join my Familia?”

“Yes.”

“You do realize I don't have a Familia, right?”

“Yes.”

“You realize I don't have a single member?”

“Yes.”

“I don't even have money.”

“I noticed.”

Hestia's eyebrow twitched.

“Then why are you asking me?!”

Bell tilted his head.

“Because you accepted me.”

That answer completely disarmed her.

Hestia blinked.

Bell continued.

“I don't need a powerful Familia. I don't need a famous one. I just need somewhere I can belong.”

Hestia stared at him for a long moment.

Then her expression softened.

“You really are strange, Bell Cranel.”

“I've been told that before.”

She smiled.

“Fine.”

Bell's eyes widened slightly.

“You'll join?”

“Of course!”

Hestia puffed out her chest proudly.

“From this moment onward, you are the first member of the Hestia Familia!”

Bell looked at her.

“...The first?”

“The first!”

“So technically, this Familia didn't exist until now.”

“Don't ruin the moment!”

Bell smiled faintly.

“Understood.”

Hestia placed both hands on her hips.

“And don't think you're getting away from the formal ceremony. I still need to give you my Falna.”

Bell nodded.

“That is actually the main reason I came.”

“Then what are we waiting for?”

The journey to Hestia's residence was considerably less impressive than Bell had expected.

They eventually arrived at an old abandoned church.

Bell stopped.

He looked up.

The building was worn down, with cracked stone, broken windows, and weeds growing through portions of the structure.

“This is it?”

Hestia scratched the back of her head.

“Technically... yes.”

Bell looked at her.

“You live here?”

“It's better than sleeping outside.”

Bell walked through the entrance.

Dust covered nearly everything.

Old furniture was scattered around the interior, and some of the wooden structures had begun to rot.

Yet Bell didn't complain.

Instead, something about the place made him strangely nostalgic.

It reminded him of his old hideout.

Not because it looked the same.

Because it was small.

Quiet.

Hidden.

A place where nobody expected anything from him.

Bell walked deeper inside.

Hestia followed.

“There is a basement underneath,” she explained. “It's not very big, but there's enough room for three people.”

Bell inspected it.

The basement was crude, but structurally sound.

A few broken shelves.

An old table.

Two usable beds.

A storage area.

A small cooking space.

Bell looked around.

“We can work with this.”

Hestia stared at him.

“We?”

Bell picked up a broken wooden board.

“Yes.”

He examined it.

“This can be repaired.”

He pointed toward the shelves.

“These can be cleaned.”

Then toward the wall.

“That leak can be sealed.”

Hestia's eyes sparkled.

“You're going to help fix the church?”

“It's our home now.”

Hestia froze.

“Our... home?”

Bell nodded.

“Yes.”

For some reason, those two words hit Hestia harder than any compliment could have.

She turned her face away.

“...You're pretty good at saying things like that without realizing it.”

Bell didn't understand.

“What?”

“Nothing!”

It took several hours.

Bell repaired what he could.

He cleaned the basement.

He reorganized the storage area.

He fixed the broken table and even managed to reinforce one of the damaged wooden supports.

Hestia watched him work.

“You've done this before.”

Bell paused.

“Yes.”

“Where?”

Bell looked toward the old wooden wall.

“Somewhere far away.”

Hestia noticed the change in his voice.

She didn't press.

Instead, she quietly handed him another piece of cloth.

“Then let's make this place better than wherever you came from.”

Bell looked at her.

A small smile appeared.

“I'd like that.”

Eventually, the work was finished.

Hestia stood in the center of the basement and looked around.

It wasn't beautiful.

It wasn't luxurious.

But it was clean.

It was warm.

It was livable.

For the first time in a long while, Bell felt that he had somewhere to return to.

Hestia turned around.

“Bell.”

“Yes?”

“It's time.”

Bell nodded.

“The Falna.”

Hestia's expression became serious.

“Lie down.”

Bell did so.

Hestia sat behind him.

She gently placed her fingers against his back.

“Don't move.”

“I won't.”

“Ready?”

“Yes.”

Hestia closed her eyes.

Divine power began to flow.

Something changed.

The moment Hestia's Falna touched Bell's body—

Her expression vanished.

Her eyes widened.

“What...?”

The divine light spread across his back.

And then—

Hestia saw it.

Not merely his body.

Not merely his potential.

She saw his soul.

Her breath stopped.

It was enormous.

Not physically.

Something deeper.

The soul before her seemed to contain layers upon layers of experience that should not have existed within a fourteen-year-old boy.

Magic.

Combat.

Knowledge.

Instinct.

Alchemy.

Countless disciplines.

Countless memories.

And beneath all of it—

Something frighteningly calm.

Hestia's hands trembled.

“Bell...”

“Yes?”

“...What exactly are you?”

Bell turned his head slightly.

“A human.”

Hestia swallowed.

“Are you sure?”

Bell thought about it.

“Mostly.”

“Mostly?!”

The Falna continued.

Numbers began forming.

At first they flickered.

Then they changed.

Then changed again.

Hestia stared at the status appearing before her.

Her divine eyes struggled to interpret it.

Finally, the Falna stabilized.

[Falna]

Name: Bell Cranel
Race: Human?
Age: 14
Level: 1

Basic Abilities

Ability	Rank	Value
Strength	S	999
Endurance	S	999
Dexterity	S	999
Agility	S	999
Magic	S	999

Total Basic Ability Value: 4995

Hestia stared.

Silence.

Bell glanced over his shoulder.

“Is something wrong?”

Hestia's eye twitched.

“Something wrong?”

“Yes.”

“Bell.”

“Yes?”

“You're Level One.”

“I know.”

“Those numbers are completely absurd!”

Bell looked at his status.

“Are they?”

“Yes!”

Hestia pointed aggressively at the Falna.

“Most Level Ones don't just appear with every category at the absolute limit!”

Bell considered this.

“I suppose that's unusual.”

“Unusual?!”

Hestia almost collapsed.

Then she noticed the rest.

Her expression became even more complicated.

Skills

Alchemy
The ability to understand, manipulate, refine, and combine materials through alchemical principles.

Synthetase
Allows Bell to combine compatible materials, properties, magical effects, and substances into a new result.

Mana Control
Extremely precise manipulation of magical energy.

Divination
Allows Bell to perceive possibilities, magical phenomena, hidden properties, and certain future probabilities.

The Flow
An advanced combat perception ability allowing Bell to perceive movement, momentum, intent, and the natural flow of battle.

Hestia's eyes widened.

“Five skills...”

Bell remained silent.

She continued reading.

Magic

Alchemical Magic
Magic specializing in material transformation, creation, refinement, and magical synthesis.

Barrier
Creates defensive magical barriers capable of resisting physical and magical attacks.

Explosion
Concentrated destructive magic producing explosive force.

Annihilation
High-output destructive magic capable of erasing or overwhelming targets through concentrated magical energy.

Elemental Magic
Allows manipulation and application of elemental magical phenomena.

Healing Magic
Restorative magic capable of repairing injuries and stabilizing damaged bodies.

Copy Magic
Allows Bell to reproduce observed magical structures and techniques under suitable conditions.

Hestia slowly lowered the parchment.

“Bell.”

“Yes?”

“Where did you learn all of this?”

Bell stared at the ceiling.

“Practice.”

“...That's not an answer.”

“It is technically an answer.”

Hestia sighed.

“You're impossible.”

Bell smiled.

But then Hestia noticed another section.

Her expression became blank.

“There's more.”

Bell looked at her.

“More?”

“Developmental Abilities.”

She stared at the list.

And stared.

And stared.

Developmental Abilities

Archery — Mastery and development of ranged combat with bows.

Mage — Enhances magical proficiency and magical development.

Swordsmanship — Proficiency with swords and bladed weapons.

Spearmanship — Proficiency with spears and polearms.

Intuition — Heightened perception and instinctive decision-making.

Initiative — Increased effectiveness when taking the first action in combat.

Fist — Proficiency in unarmed combat.

Martial Arts — Broad mastery of physical combat techniques.

Acrobatics — Advanced control of movement, balance, jumping, landing, and aerial maneuvering.

Evasion — Improved ability to avoid attacks through movement and prediction.

Endurance — Increased ability to continue physical activity under extreme conditions.

Survival — Knowledge and instinct for surviving hostile environments.

Scouting — Detection, tracking, reconnaissance, and environmental awareness.

Stealth — Suppression of presence and movement noise.

Alchemy — Advanced practical development of alchemical techniques.

Craftsmanship — Ability to construct, repair, and modify equipment.

Engineering — Understanding of mechanisms, structures, and practical devices.

Cooking — Advanced preparation and preservation of food.

Weaving — Ability to manipulate and produce textiles.

Calligraphy — Advanced control of written symbols and precise inscription.

Herbalism — Identification and application of medicinal and magical plants.

Mining — Knowledge of minerals, ores, and underground environments.

Monster Knowledge — Recognition of monster anatomy, behavior, weaknesses, and materials.

Magic Theory — Understanding of magical principles and spell structures.

Mana Perception — Detection and interpretation of magical energy.

Concentration — Ability to maintain mental focus under pressure.

Mental Resistance — Resistance to fear, mental interference, and psychological pressure.

Adaptation — Ability to adjust quickly to unfamiliar environments and combat situations.

Learning — Accelerated acquisition of practical knowledge through observation and experience.

Improvisation — Ability to create solutions using limited resources.

Precision — Exceptional control over fine movements and energy manipulation.

Weapon Mastery — Broad familiarity with multiple weapon types.

Hand-to-Hand Combat — Advanced close-range combat proficiency.

Tactical Analysis — Ability to rapidly analyze opponents and battlefield conditions.

Hestia slowly lowered the parchment.

“...Bell.”

“Yes?”

“This isn't a Falna.”

Bell blinked.

“What is it?”

Hestia stared at him.

“It's a résumé.”

Bell couldn't help himself.

He laughed.

A genuine laugh.

Hestia stared for a moment.

Then she smiled.

“Fine.”

She placed the parchment down.

“Whatever you are...”

She gently placed her hand on Bell's head.

“Welcome to the Hestia Familia.”

Bell's smile faded slightly.

His eyes softened.

“Thank you.”

Hestia smiled.

“And Bell?”

“Yes?”

“You said you wanted a place to belong.”

“Yes.”

She pointed toward the basement.

“Then stop calling it the church.”

Bell looked around.

Hestia grinned.

“It's our home now.”

Bell looked around once more.

The old stone.

The repaired table.

The small beds.

The dim light.

Nothing about the place was impressive.

Yet somehow—

It felt different.

For the first time since arriving in Orario, Bell didn't feel like he was merely passing through.

He had a goddess.

He had a Familia.

And now—

He had a hearth.

Bell quietly nodded.

“...Our home.”

Above them, the old church remained silent.

But beneath its broken roof, something new had begun.

The smallest Familia in Orario had just gained its first adventurer.

And neither Bell nor Hestia yet understood what that meant.

Because the status written upon Bell's back wasn't merely powerful.

It was something the gods of Orario had never seen before.

Chapter Eighteen: The Registration

Hestia stared at the status before her, her eyes practically sparkling.

“Bell! Do you understand what this means?! Your stats are—”

“Hestia.”

Bell's voice was unusually firm.

Hestia paused.

Bell slowly turned toward her.

“Don't.”

“But they're incredible!”

“I know.”

“Then why shouldn't I be excited?”

“Because someone else might hear you.”

Hestia's expression immediately changed.

Bell pointed toward the Falna she had been holding.

“I need you to keep this hidden. At least for now.”

Hestia frowned. “But you're going to become an adventurer. People will need to know your abilities.”

“They don't need to know everything.”

Bell took the status sheet from her and looked over it again.

“If someone sees these numbers, especially without me having any history as an adventurer, they'll start asking questions.”

Hestia reluctantly nodded.

“Fine…”

Bell continued, “I'll need a copy for registration, though. The Guild probably needs the basic information from my Falna.”

Hestia sighed.

“So you want me to make a copy?”

“Exactly. One that doesn't reveal anything unnecessary.”

Hestia looked at him for a moment before smiling.

“You're already thinking like an adventurer.”

Bell gave her a dry look.

“I'm thinking like someone who doesn't want strangers staring at him.”

“Same thing.”

By the time Bell reached the Guild, it was already around noon.

The building wasn't nearly as crowded as he had expected.

A handful of adventurers moved through the large hall, some speaking with receptionists while others were checking information posted around the room.

Bell walked toward the counter.

A young elf sitting behind the desk noticed him almost immediately.

She had long brown hair, pointed ears, and a calm but attentive expression.

“Good afternoon,” she said politely. “Are you here for something specific?”

Bell stopped in front of her.

“Yes. I'd like to register as an adventurer.”

The elf blinked.

“You're an adventurer candidate?”

“Yes.”

She looked him over.

He didn't appear injured. His clothes weren't particularly worn. And, most importantly, he didn't have the appearance of someone who had spent years fighting monsters.

“Have you registered with the Guild before?”

“No.”

“I see.”

She reached for some documents.

“Then this should be fairly straightforward. I'll need your name first.”

“Bell Cranel.”

She wrote it down.

“Age?”

“Fourteen.”

Her pen stopped.

“Fourteen?”

Bell nodded.

The elf stared at him for a second longer.

“You're rather young.”

“I've been told that.”

That answer caught her off guard.

She smiled faintly.

“I suppose you have.”

She continued filling out the form.

“My name is Eina Tulle. I'm an advisor here at the Guild.”

“Bell.”

“I know.”

Bell looked at her.

Eina smiled.

“You already told me.”

“…Right.”

She continued.

“Do you have any experience in the Dungeon?”

“A little.”

“A little?”

Bell hesitated.

“I've fought monsters before.”

Eina's expression became more serious.

“How many times have you entered the Dungeon?”

“Not many.”

“And you intend to enter again after registering?”

“Yes.”

Eina put her pen down.

“Bell.”

There was something different in her voice now.

Bell looked at her.

“The Dungeon isn't something you should take lightly.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

Her concern wasn't exaggerated. She wasn't trying to scare him for the sake of it.

She genuinely looked worried.

Eina leaned slightly forward.

“You're fourteen years old. You have little experience, and from what you've told me, you don't seem to have anyone accompanying you.”

Bell remained silent.

Eina continued.

“I'm not saying you can't become an adventurer. But rushing into the Dungeon without proper preparation is dangerous.”

“I understand.”

“Then promise me you'll at least listen to an advisor before going down.”

Bell considered her words.

“You're offering to advise me?”

“Yes.”

Eina gave him a small smile.

“That's what I'm here for.”

Bell looked at her for several seconds.

There was no hidden agenda in her expression.

She simply seemed concerned.

“I appreciate it.”

“Then—”

“But I think I'll manage on my own.”

Eina's smile disappeared slightly.

“You're declining?”

“Yes.”

“May I ask why?”

Bell thought carefully before answering.

“I don't want to depend on someone else to decide how I should grow.”

Eina frowned.

“That isn't what an advisor does.”

“I know.”

“Then what are you afraid of?”

Bell shook his head.

“Nothing.”

Eina clearly didn't believe him.

“Bell, being independent and refusing help aren't the same thing.”

That made Bell pause.

Eina's expression softened.

“I've watched plenty of young adventurers walk through those doors convinced they can handle everything themselves.”

She glanced toward the Guild's entrance.

“Some came back injured.”

Her eyes returned to Bell.

“Some didn't come back at all.”

Bell's expression became serious.

“I understand your concern.”

“Do you?”

“Yes.”

“And you're still going?”

“Yes.”

Eina sighed.

“You really are stubborn.”

Bell gave a small smile.

“I've been told that too.”

For a moment, Eina simply stared at him.

Then she picked up her pen again.

“Fine.”

Bell blinked.

“Fine?”

“I won't force you.”

She resumed filling out the registration.

“But I'm going to say this once.”

Her tone became firm.

“If you ever find yourself in trouble, come back to the Guild. Don't let pride convince you that asking for help makes you weak.”

Bell nodded.

“I'll remember that.”

Eina looked at him carefully.

“Good.”

She finished the remaining paperwork and examined the copy of his Falna.

Everything necessary was there.

“Your registration is complete.”

She slid the document across the counter.

“Congratulations, Bell Cranel. You're officially an adventurer.”

Bell looked down at the registration.

For a moment, he simply stared at it.

Then he smiled.

“Thank you.”

Eina watched him quietly.

There was something about the way he looked at that document that bothered her.

Not because he was excited.

Because he looked like someone who had already decided exactly where he was going.

And Eina had the uneasy feeling that Bell Cranel was going to walk straight into danger before he realized just how dangerous Orario could be.

“Bell.”

He looked back.

“Please be careful.”

Bell gave her a reassuring smile.

“I will.”

Eina watched him leave.

She wasn't convinced.

Not even a little.

Chapter Nineteen: The Dungeon and?

The Dungeon.

Bell stood before the enormous entrance, staring into the darkness beyond.

For some reason, the place felt familiar.

Not because he had been here before.

He knew he hadn't.

Yet something about the Dungeon made the hairs on the back of his neck rise.

Bell took a step forward.

The moment he crossed the entrance, he felt it.

A strange sensation.

Almost like something was pulling him deeper.

Come.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

Another step.

Come inside.

He stopped.

"...Interesting."

He looked around.

There was no visible force. Nothing was physically dragging him forward. Yet the sensation was unmistakable.

It was as though the Dungeon itself was calling to him.

Bell remained still for a moment.

Is this normal?

He didn't know.

But something about it bothered him.

He had learned enough about the Dungeon to understand one simple fact.

It was not a harmless place.

It was alive.

It produced monsters.

It responded to intruders.

And it killed adventurers.

Bell slowly exhaled.

Maybe this is just the Dungeon's nature.

He remembered the feeling of being watched.

Or maybe it's something specifically directed at me.

His hand tightened slightly.

He didn't like the second possibility.

Bell shook his head.

Don't overthink it.

He had come here for a reason.

To test himself.

To understand the monsters.

And, most importantly, to make some money.

He started walking.

The first monster appeared only a short distance inside.

A goblin.

It spotted Bell and immediately charged.

Bell didn't move.

The goblin raised its weapon.

At the last moment, Bell stepped sideways.

The attack missed.

His hand struck the goblin's chest.

The monster flew backward and crashed against the wall.

Bell walked over and finished it.

He crouched down and retrieved the magic stone.

He stared at it.

So this is the value of a Dungeon monster.

Bell placed it away.

Another goblin appeared.

Then another.

The pattern continued.

Bell carefully tested his abilities against them.

He didn't immediately use his strongest magic.

There was no point.

I need to know the baseline.

He wanted to understand exactly how dangerous these monsters were compared to the enemies he had already faced.

The answer became obvious very quickly.

Weak.

A goblin swung at him.

Bell avoided it effortlessly.

Another tried to attack from behind.

He heard it coming.

He turned and knocked it down.

Very weak.

He wasn't being arrogant.

He was simply making an assessment.

These monsters were dangerous to ordinary people.

But to Bell?

They were barely a threat.

The kobolds were somewhat stronger.

They were faster and more aggressive than the goblins.

Bell still had little difficulty dealing with them.

So these are the monsters adventurers encounter on the early floors.

He continued downward.

Floor one.

Floor two.

Floor three.

Bell didn't rush.

He deliberately took his time.

Every encounter gave him another opportunity to test his movement, reactions, and magic.

He also paid attention to the Dungeon itself.

The walls.

The corridors.

The sounds.

The way the monsters appeared.

Everything.

The Dungeon is almost like an ecosystem.

Bell stopped after entering the fourth floor.

He looked down the corridor.

The strange sensation returned.

That invisible pull.

Stronger this time.

Come deeper.

Bell frowned.

For a moment, his curiosity almost won.

What happens if I keep going?

He could probably handle the monsters.

At least the ones he had encountered so far.

But that wasn't the point.

Bell had no reason to gamble his life just to satisfy his curiosity.

I came here to test the waters.

He looked at the corridor ahead.

And I've tested them.

Bell turned around.

"That's enough for today."

He wasn't ashamed of stopping.

In fact, he considered it good judgment.

Strength doesn't mean charging forward without thinking.

He had already learned that lesson the hard way.

Instead of going deeper, Bell began searching the fourth floor.

If he wasn't going to continue downward, he might as well make the trip worthwhile.

He hunted monsters methodically.

One goblin.

Then another.

A kobold.

Two goblins.

Another kobold.

He collected every magic stone he could.

The process was almost routine.

Bell's thoughts wandered while he worked.

I wonder what my Familia thinks about me coming here alone.

He smiled faintly.

They'd probably tell me to be careful.

That thought made him pause.

Unlike before, he wasn't completely alone in Orario anymore.

He had people.

A place he could return to.

A Familia that had accepted him.

Yet Bell still couldn't completely shake his habit of relying on himself.

I need to learn how to balance that.

Being part of a Familia didn't mean he had to abandon his independence.

But it also didn't mean he should pretend he had nobody.

Bell continued hunting.

Eventually, he counted his spoils.

Twenty-six goblins.

Fourteen kobolds.

Bell looked at the collection of magic stones.

That's quite a lot.

He mentally calculated their value.

A goblin magic stone was worth **130 valis**.

Twenty-six of them would give him:

26 × 130 = 3,380 valis.

The kobold magic stones were worth **200 valis each**.

Fourteen would give:

14 × 200 = 2,800 valis.

Bell added the numbers together.

6,180 valis.

His eyebrows rose slightly.

6,180...

That wasn't bad for a relatively short expedition.

And I barely went anywhere.

He looked back toward the deeper floors.

If I went farther...

Bell immediately stopped that thought.

"No."

He shook his head.

Don't get greedy.

The Dungeon had already given him enough information for one day.

He didn't need to push his luck.

Bell made his way back toward the surface.

As he walked, the strange sensation continued.

The deeper he went, the more noticeable it became.

The Dungeon seemed to be calling him.

Come back.

Bell glanced over his shoulder.

His expression became serious.

I definitely felt that.

He didn't know whether it was merely his imagination or something more.

But he would remember it.

Eventually, Bell reached the surface.

The sunlight was almost blinding after spending so much time underground.

He squinted and covered his eyes.

"Ah..."

He stood there for a moment.

The feeling of the Dungeon's presence slowly faded.

Bell looked back at the entrance.

So strange.

He couldn't explain it.

Maybe every adventurer experienced something similar.

Maybe the Dungeon simply had an atmosphere that affected people.

Or maybe—

It was reacting to me.

Bell didn't like that possibility.

But he couldn't dismiss it either.

He turned away.

I'll investigate it later.

For now, he had another task.

The magic stones needed to be exchanged.

Bell headed toward the exchange station.

Inside, adventurers were constantly coming and going.

Some carried small bags.

Others had sacks filled with magic stones.

Bell joined the line.

When his turn came, he placed his collection on the counter.

The employee began sorting them.

"Goblins... twenty-six."

Bell nodded.

"Kobolds... fourteen."

The employee calculated the total.

"That comes to 6,180 valis."

Bell received the payment.

He looked at the money in his hand.

Not bad.

He put it away carefully.

It wasn't an enormous amount.

But it was enough to cover several necessities.

And more importantly—

I earned it myself.

Bell walked out of the exchange station.

The afternoon sun was beginning to fade.

He started making his way home.

His thoughts returned to the Dungeon.

The strange attraction.

The sensation of being called.

The feeling that something was waiting deeper below.

Bell sighed.

"Why do I have a feeling this isn't the last time?"

He continued walking.

Next time, I'll be more prepared.

For now, though, there was no reason to rush.

He had his Familia.

He had somewhere to sleep.

He had enough money for the moment.

And he had survived his first proper Dungeon expedition.

That was enough.

Bell eventually arrived home.

He opened the door, stepped inside, and placed the remaining money somewhere safe.

Then he sat down.

For several minutes, he said nothing.

The Dungeon remained in his thoughts.

Bell closed his eyes.

That feeling...

He remembered the invisible pull.

What exactly were you trying to do?

Silence.

Bell opened his eyes.

He couldn't answer the question.

Not yet.

But there was one thing he was certain of.

The Dungeon had noticed him.

And Bell had a strange feeling that, sooner or later...

he would notice it too.

Worked for 10s

Chapter Twenty: Simple Plan

Morning came quietly.

Bell woke earlier than usual.

For several minutes, he simply stared at the ceiling, his mind already running through yesterday's events.

Finn.

The duel.

The Loki Familia.

The fact that a Level Six adventurer had been forced to take him seriously.

Bell slowly sat up.

"I'm missing something."

He had spent most of his time thinking about combat—how to survive stronger opponents, how to make his magic more efficient, how to compensate for his lack of Falna.

But there was another question he had barely considered.

The Dungeon itself.

Bell looked toward the window.

"The Dungeon produces monsters."

He paused.

"But how?"

That question had been bothering him ever since he entered Orario.

Monsters didn't simply appear from nowhere.

At least, not logically.

There had to be some mechanism.

And if there was a mechanism...

"Then maybe I can understand it."

A faint smile appeared on Bell's face.

It was, admittedly, a crazy idea.

But crazy ideas had become surprisingly useful lately.

Before leaving, Bell made breakfast.

Nothing elaborate.

Just something light and filling for Hestia.

He placed the food on the table before she woke and quietly prepared his equipment.

"I'll be back later."

Bell hesitated.

"Hopefully."

Considering everything that had happened recently, he decided not to make promises about the Dungeon.

He headed toward Babel and eventually entered the Dungeon.

Bell deliberately avoided the usual adventurer routes.

He went deeper into a relatively secluded section where there was little chance of another adventurer interfering with his experiment.

Once he found a suitable area, he stopped.

He placed his equipment down.

Then he stared at the wall.

"All right."

He touched it.

Rock.

Cold.

Hard.

Completely ordinary.

Bell narrowed his eyes.

"So... what am I looking for?"

He didn't know.

That was the problem.

His original plan had sounded much better in his head.

He began with the simplest approach.

He examined the surface.

Then the cracks.

Then the areas where monsters had previously emerged.

Nothing.

He tapped the wall.

Tok.

He tapped it again.

Tok.

"That's not helping."

Bell sighed.

He tried magic.

A small amount of mana flowed through his hand.

He carefully pushed it into the wall.

Nothing happened.

"Maybe the Dungeon doesn't respond to foreign magic."

He tried again.

Nothing.

Then again.

Still nothing.

An hour passed.

Then two.

Bell sat down.

"This was a stupid idea."

He looked at the wall.

The wall remained completely indifferent to his suffering.

"I'm literally arguing with a rock."

Still, he didn't leave.

Instead, Bell began changing his method.

He started measuring.

He compared sections of the wall.

He scratched small marks into the stone and observed how the material responded to magic.

He tried heating a tiny section.

Then cooling it.

He applied magic from different angles.

He even pressed his ear against the wall and listened.

Nothing.

The hours dragged on.

His stomach growled.

"I should've brought more food."

He ignored it.

By afternoon, Bell was covered in dust.

His notebook contained pages of failed observations.

Different stone densities.

Different magical responses.

Different cracks.

Nothing useful.

Yet Bell refused to stop.

Because somewhere in the back of his mind, something wasn't making sense.

The Dungeon was too strange.

The monsters were too consistent.

The floors were too structured.

And the walls...

"They're not just walls."

Bell froze.

He slowly looked at the stone again.

He placed his palm against it.

Then closed his eyes.

Instead of trying to force his magic into the wall, Bell stopped using his own magic altogether.

He simply observed.

He waited.

And waited.

Minutes passed.

Then he felt something.

A faint pulse.

Bell's eyes opened.

"There."

It was incredibly weak.

Almost impossible to notice.

Another pulse came.

Then another.

Not from the same location.

Bell immediately pressed both hands against the wall.

"It's moving."

Not physically.

Something was traveling through the Dungeon.

A signal.

Bell followed it.

He spent the next several hours tracing the faint magical fluctuations from one section to another.

Every time he thought he'd found the source, the signal disappeared.

He had to start over.

Several times.

At one point, Bell nearly gave up.

Then, just before evening, he saw something.

Not with his eyes.

With magic.

Thin lines existed inside the stone.

They weren't cracks.

They were conduits.

Intricate magical pathways ran throughout the Dungeon wall, connecting one point to another.

Bell stared in disbelief.

"Magic circuits..."

He carefully followed one.

It branched.

Then branched again.

Hundreds of tiny pathways formed a structure far more complicated than anything Bell had encountered before.

And then he noticed something else.

The pathways weren't random.

They formed a pattern.

A magic circle.

Bell's breathing stopped.

"It's invisible."

Not completely.

Rather, it existed on a layer that ordinary perception couldn't reach.

The Dungeon wasn't merely made of stone.

The walls themselves were part of a gigantic magical system.

Bell quickly pulled out his notebook.

He began copying the pattern.

One line at a time.

He couldn't rush it.

A single mistake could completely change the structure.

His hand cramped.

He erased.

Started again.

Compared the pattern.

Corrected another section.

Then another.

Hours passed.

The Dungeon grew darker around him.

Bell didn't notice.

His entire world had narrowed to the magic circle in front of him.

"This isn't a spell."

He studied it.

"It's a function."

A command.

A mechanism.

Something designed to produce a specific result.

Bell swallowed.

He finally understood.

"This is how the Dungeon creates monsters."

The thought sent a chill through him.

He looked at the surrounding walls.

"Then if I reproduce the function..."

Bell stopped.

His heart began beating faster.

"I could summon one myself."

It was dangerous.

Probably incredibly stupid.

But Bell had already spent an entire day getting this far.

He wasn't going to stop now.

He carefully recreated the circle on the floor.

He adjusted every line.

Every connection.

Every magical pathway.

Then he poured a small amount of mana into it.

Nothing happened.

Bell frowned.

"Wrong."

He adjusted the outer ring.

Tried again.

Still nothing.

He altered the central connection.

Again.

Nothing.

Bell sat there for several minutes.

Then he noticed something he'd overlooked.

"The Dungeon doesn't create monsters using magic alone."

The circle wasn't simply a summoning spell.

It was connected to the Dungeon itself.

Bell had to reproduce that connection.

He extended the circle's pathways toward the nearby wall.

Slowly.

Carefully.

The moment the final line connected—

WHUM.

The entire chamber trembled.

Bell immediately jumped backward.

The magic circle lit up.

Mana surged through the lines.

The air distorted.

Something began forming in the center.

Bell raised his hand defensively.

"Come on..."

The shape solidified.

A monster appeared.

Bell prepared himself for an attack.

But it didn't attack.

The creature simply stood there.

Confused.

Then it looked toward Bell.

Bell stared back.

Nothing happened.

No aggression.

No charge.

No roar.

The monster simply remained still.

Bell slowly lowered his hand.

"It's... tame?"

He cautiously approached.

The creature didn't attack.

Bell extended his hand.

It hesitated.

Then allowed him to touch it.

Bell's eyes widened.

A laugh escaped him.

Not because the experiment had worked.

But because he finally understood what he had accomplished.

He hadn't simply summoned a monster.

He had discovered a hidden part of the Dungeon.

And more importantly...

He had proven that he could understand something everyone else had simply accepted as impossible.

Bell looked at the monster.

Then at the magic circle.

Then back at his notebook.

"I spent an entire day doing this..."

He smiled tiredly.

"And it was worth it."

For once, Bell wasn't thinking about Finn.

Or the Loki Familia.

Or Falna.

He wasn't thinking about proving himself against someone stronger.

He had found something that belonged entirely to him.

A question.

An experiment.

An answer.

And a new direction.

Bell gently placed his hand against the monster's head.

"If the Dungeon has rules..."

His eyes turned toward the endless darkness beyond the chamber.

"Then maybe those rules can be understood."

And for Bell, that realization was more valuable than the monster standing beside him.

Because strength could be measured.

Magic could be learned.

Weapons could be improved.

But understanding the Dungeon itself?

That could change everything.

Worked for 6s

Chapter Twenty-One: Equivalent Exchange

The Dungeon was quieter than Bell expected.

Not silent.

It could never truly be silent.

There was always the distant sound of footsteps against stone, the occasional roar of a monster, the clatter of weapons, and the faint dripping of water somewhere beyond the corridor.

But Bell barely noticed any of it.

His attention was fixed on the creature standing several meters in front of him.

A goblin.

It was small, green-skinned, and armed with nothing more than a crude club.

Yet Bell wasn't looking at its appearance.

He was looking at its existence.

The goblin shifted from one foot to another.

Bell shifted.

The goblin shifted again.

Bell narrowed his eyes.

Interesting.

He raised his right hand.

The goblin raised its right hand.

Bell lowered it.

The goblin lowered its hand.

Bell stared.

"...Are you copying me?"

The goblin blinked.

"Grak."

Bell sighed.

"That's probably a no."

The goblin scratched its head.

Bell couldn't help but smile.

It's alive.

That was the strange part.

He had expected his summoning magic to produce something closer to a magical puppet.

Something that appeared, obeyed commands, fought, and disappeared.

Instead, the creature behaved almost like an ordinary monster.

It looked around.

It reacted to sounds.

It occasionally scratched itself.

It had even eaten when Bell gave it food.

And, most strangely of all...

It seemed capable of understanding.

Not language.

Not complex concepts.

But simple instructions.

Bell crouched down.

"Sit."

The goblin hesitated.

Then it sat.

Bell's eyes widened slightly.

So it understands.

He had already known that.

But seeing it happen again made the realization feel different.

Bell rested his elbows against his knees.

His mind began working.

Why?

That was the question.

Why could his summoned creature behave like this?

Why could something created by magic function almost like a natural monster?

And perhaps more importantly—

Why does it have a magic stone?

Bell slowly placed a hand against his chest.

His own Falna was there.

Hestia's Falna.

The divine blessing that had changed his life.

He had already learned that the Falna transformed his potential into something measurable, something that allowed him to grow through experience.

But this...

This was different.

His summoned goblin didn't possess a Falna.

Yet it possessed a magical core.

A magic stone.

Bell looked at the creature again.

The Dungeon creates monsters.

That much was obvious.

Monsters possess magic stones.

Also obvious.

My summoning creates a monster-like creature.

Again, obvious.

But if his summoning could reproduce even a fraction of the Dungeon's method...

Then perhaps understanding his own magic required understanding the Dungeon.

Bell stood.

"Let's think."

The goblin looked at him.

Bell began pacing.

First possibility.

"Independence."

He raised one finger.

"Once a monster is created, it receives the ability to function independently."

He glanced at the goblin.

"Walking. Running. Eating. Fighting. Avoiding danger."

The goblin looked at its club.

Bell pointed at it.

"Even knowing how to use a weapon."

The goblin raised the club.

Bell nodded.

"Exactly."

The Dungeon doesn't need to manually control every movement.

That would be absurd.

If the Dungeon had to consciously control every monster, the sheer number of monsters throughout its countless floors would be impossible to manage.

Therefore—

Monsters must possess some form of autonomous behavior.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"But that still doesn't explain consciousness."

The goblin tilted its head.

Bell looked at it.

"You aren't just moving because I tell you to."

The goblin made a strange sound.

"You react to things around you."

Bell crouched again.

"That means there's something inside you making decisions."

The goblin stared at him.

Bell smiled faintly.

"Or at least something close enough."

He stood again.

Second possibility.

"Power source."

Bell raised another finger.

"Summoning magic consumes mana."

His gaze drifted toward the magic circle beneath the goblin.

"That's unavoidable."

His Falna enhanced his abilities.

His mind understood magical structures.

His body supplied the necessary energy.

But maintaining a summoned creature should require continuous magical expenditure.

Yet the goblin wasn't fading.

It wasn't weakening.

It wasn't collapsing.

Bell had summoned it quite some time ago.

And it remained perfectly functional.

So where is the energy coming from?

Bell stared at the goblin's chest.

"The magic stone."

The goblin looked down.

Bell walked closer.

He placed his palm against its chest.

The sensation was faint.

But unmistakable.

There was magical energy concentrated within it.

Not exactly the same as his own mana.

Something denser.

Something more stable.

Bell's eyes sharpened.

"So that's where you're getting it."

He stepped back.

"If a summoned creature needs energy to maintain its existence, then the magic stone could act as an internal reservoir."

Bell began thinking aloud.

"Instead of continuously supplying mana from outside, the summoning process establishes a core that stores magical energy."

He paused.

"And if that's the case..."

Bell looked toward the Dungeon walls.

"...then perhaps the Dungeon does something similar."

The idea made him uncomfortable.

The Dungeon didn't merely create monsters.

It created monsters that could continue existing.

That required energy.

And magic stones were the most obvious candidate.

Bell lowered his hand.

Third possibility.

He hesitated before raising another finger.

"Forced summoning."

The goblin stared at him.

Bell frowned.

"A summoned creature isn't exactly the same as a natural creature."

He looked at it carefully.

"It has a body."

"Grak."

"It can eat."

The goblin immediately looked toward the food.

Bell sighed.

"...Apparently, that's the part you care about."

He continued.

"It can rest."

The goblin yawned.

Bell paused.

"...And apparently you're proving my point."

The goblin sat down.

Bell smiled.

"It can fight."

The goblin immediately stood again.

Bell stared.

"...You're making this surprisingly easy."

For a moment, Bell laughed.

But his expression soon became serious again.

"You're a semi-living creature."

The words sounded strange when spoken aloud.

"Not entirely artificial. Not entirely natural."

Bell's eyes became distant.

And that's where the problem begins.

Because the goblin wasn't simply following predetermined commands.

Bell had seen it react.

It had shown hesitation.

Curiosity.

Fear.

Even preference.

That last part was particularly strange.

Bell remembered how the goblin had looked at him when he first approached.

It hadn't looked at him like a puppet looking at its master.

It had looked at him like a creature looking at something it didn't understand.

Bell slowly lowered his gaze.

Does it know that I created it?

The thought sent an uncomfortable chill through him.

He looked at the goblin.

"...Do you know who I am?"

The goblin stared back.

"Grak."

Bell sighed.

"Of course."

He stood.

"We'll figure it out later."

But Bell knew he wouldn't forget.

Eventually, Bell decided it was time to leave.

The Dungeon wasn't the place to perform endless experiments.

Not when other adventurers could appear at any moment.

Not when monsters could wander into the area.

And certainly not when he had no idea what would happen if his summoning magic attracted attention.

Bell looked at the goblin.

"Come on."

The goblin followed.

They walked together for some time.

Bell occasionally looked backward.

The goblin remained behind him.

It didn't need constant commands.

It simply followed.

That bothered him more than it should have.

It's learning.

Bell wasn't sure whether that was a good thing.

Eventually they reached a safer area.

Bell stopped.

The goblin stopped as well.

Bell looked at it for several seconds.

Then he raised his hand.

"...Unsummon."

A magical circle appeared beneath the goblin.

The creature froze.

Its eyes widened.

Bell immediately noticed.

Fear.

Again.

Bell's expression softened.

"It's fine."

The goblin stared at him.

"I'm not killing you."

The magic circle grew brighter.

"I'm ending the summoning."

The goblin took one step backward.

Bell hesitated.

For some reason, that simple movement felt strangely painful.

Why are you afraid?

He couldn't answer the question.

Then—

Whoosh.

The goblin's body dissolved into particles of light.

The Dungeon became quiet again.

Bell stood there alone.

His hand remained raised.

Slowly, he lowered it.

"...What happens to you?"

There was no answer.

Bell closed his eyes.

Do you disappear?

Do you return somewhere?

Do you die?

He didn't know.

And that uncertainty bothered him.

More than it should have.

Bell turned toward the exit.

I'll ask Hestia.

There was only one problem.

He had a feeling that whatever answer she gave him...

He might not like it.

That night, Bell sat across from Hestia.

Dinner had already been served.

Normally, Hestia would have been happily talking about food, money, or something she wanted Bell to buy for her.

Tonight, however, she noticed Bell's expression.

She lowered her fork.

"...Bell?"

Bell looked up.

"Yes?"

"You've been staring at your food for five minutes."

Bell looked down.

His meal was untouched.

"Oh."

Hestia leaned closer.

"Something happened in the Dungeon?"

Bell nodded.

"I discovered something."

Hestia's expression became cautious.

"Something dangerous?"

"I don't know."

That answer made her even more nervous.

Bell finally picked up his fork, but he didn't eat.

Instead, he asked,

"Hestia."

"Yes?"

"What do you know about the Dungeon?"

Hestia blinked.

"That's a rather large question."

"I know."

Bell looked directly at her.

"So I'll ask something specific."

Hestia slowly put down her fork.

"Go ahead."

"How does the Dungeon control monsters?"

The room became quiet.

Hestia's expression changed.

Bell noticed immediately.

She knows.

Not everything.

Perhaps not the answer.

But enough to recognize what he was asking.

Hestia folded her hands.

"What made you ask that?"

"I summoned a goblin."

Hestia's eyes widened.

"...You what?"

Bell calmly repeated himself.

"I summoned a goblin."

"Bell!"

Hestia shot to her feet.

"You summoned a monster?!"

"Yes."

"Inside the Dungeon?"

"Yes."

"Was it hostile?"

"Not toward me."

"Did it attack you?"

"No."

"Did it hurt you?"

"No."

Hestia slowly sat down.

Her expression remained troubled.

Bell continued.

"The strange part wasn't the summoning itself."

He placed his hand over his chest.

"It had a magic stone."

Hestia's eyes narrowed.

Bell continued.

"It could move independently. Eat. Rest. Fight."

He paused.

"And it seemed conscious."

Hestia didn't interrupt.

Bell leaned forward.

"I came up with three possibilities."

"Three?"

"First, monsters possess some form of independence after being born."

Hestia nodded.

"Second, the magic stone acts as a power source."

Her expression became more serious.

"And third..."

Bell hesitated.

"...the creature is some kind of forced summon. A semi-living being created by magic."

Hestia remained silent.

Bell looked at her.

"How close am I?"

Hestia sighed.

"You've been thinking too much."

Bell smiled slightly.

"You know me."

"I do."

Hestia leaned back.

"Bell..."

She paused.

"You understand that the Dungeon isn't simply a hole in the ground filled with monsters, right?"

Bell nodded.

"I've suspected that for a while."

"No."

Hestia shook her head.

"You haven't."

Bell's expression became serious.

Hestia looked toward the floor.

"The Dungeon..."

Her voice became quieter.

"...is alive."

Bell froze.

"...Alive?"

"Yes."

"Like a living creature?"

"Not exactly."

Hestia searched for the right words.

"It's different from us. Different from animals. But it responds."

Bell's mind immediately returned to the goblin.

"So the monsters..."

"Are created by it."

"Like organs?"

Hestia nodded.

"That's one way to think about it."

Bell's eyes widened.

"So it doesn't need to control every monster individually."

"Correct."

"Then what I thought was wrong."

"What did you think?"

Bell leaned back.

"I thought the Dungeon was issuing commands to every monster."

Hestia shook her head.

"It's much simpler than that."

Bell waited.

"The Dungeon creates them with their instincts already inside them."

Bell's eyes sharpened.

"Like a program."

Hestia blinked.

"A what?"

"Never mind."

Bell looked down.

So my first theory was correct.

But then another question surfaced.

"The magic stones."

Hestia nodded.

"They're connected to the Dungeon."

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"How?"

"That's complicated."

"Try me."

Hestia sighed.

"Bell, you're asking about things that even gods don't completely understand."

"Then tell me what you do know."

Hestia stared at him.

For a moment, she seemed reluctant.

Then she spoke.

"Magic stones are not simply batteries."

Bell's eyes widened slightly.

"They're the condensed essence of a monster."

Bell immediately remembered his experiment.

"So when the monster dies..."

"The Dungeon produces something in return."

Bell's expression changed.

"Equivalent exchange."

Hestia looked at him.

"Exactly."

Bell's thoughts began moving faster.

"A monster is created."

"Yes."

"It consumes food and energy."

"Yes."

"It grows."

"Yes."

"It eventually dies."

"Yes."

"And its magic stone remains."

Hestia nodded.

Bell stared at the table.

"So the Dungeon creates something..."

He slowly clenched his fist.

"...and receives something back."

Hestia didn't answer.

Bell looked up.

"What does it receive?"

Hestia's expression became unusually serious.

"We don't know."

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"Nothing?"

"That's not what I said."

Hestia leaned forward.

"We know that monsters appear."

"We know that monsters die."

"We know magic stones remain."

"But we don't know the Dungeon's ultimate purpose."

Bell became silent.

Then he remembered something.

"Hestia."

"Hm?"

"When I unsummoned the goblin..."

He paused.

"It looked afraid."

Hestia's expression softened.

Bell continued.

"It knew something was happening."

His voice became quieter.

"It wasn't just following instructions."

Hestia didn't immediately respond.

Bell looked down.

"Does that mean monsters are conscious?"

"Some more than others."

"And they have their own will?"

"To an extent."

Bell's eyes darkened.

"Then what's the difference between a monster and a person?"

Hestia's expression became complicated.

"Bell..."

"I'm serious."

"I know."

The goddess reached across the table and placed her hand over his.

"A monster is still a monster."

Bell didn't look convinced.

"But..."

Hestia continued.

"...that doesn't mean every monster is mindless."

Bell's eyes widened.

She squeezed his hand.

"That's something you need to remember."

Bell remained silent.

His mind returned to the goblin.

The way it copied him.

The way it followed him.

The way it looked at him before disappearing.

And suddenly, his experiment no longer felt like an experiment.

It felt like he had briefly created a life.

Then erased it.

Bell whispered,

"...Equivalent exchange."

Hestia looked at him.

"What?"

Bell stared into the distance.

"Maybe that's what magic really is."

His fingers slowly tightened around hers.

"You give something..."

He paused.

"...and you get something back."

Hestia smiled faintly.

"That's a surprisingly mature conclusion."

Bell shook his head.

"No."

He looked directly at her.

"I think I've only understood the beginning."

Hestia's smile disappeared.

Because she knew exactly what Bell's expression meant.

He wasn't satisfied.

He had found another question.

And Bell had never been very good at leaving questions unanswered.

If the Dungeon creates monsters...

If monsters possess consciousness...

If magic stones are the price of their existence...

Then there was one question Bell couldn't stop thinking about.

Who—or what—was the Dungeon paying?

And for the first time, Bell realized that discovering the answer might be far more dangerous than discovering the Dungeon's deepest floor.

Chapter Twenty-Two: Promise

Recollection

The city had not always been this peaceful.

There had been a time when the name **Orario** carried a different weight.

A time when its streets were stained with blood.

When adventurers disappeared without a trace.

When monsters were not the only things lurking in the darkness.

When gods, familias, criminals, and monsters fought beneath the shadow of the Dungeon—and ordinary people were caught between them.

The Dark Ages.

An era that most of the present generation knew only through fragments.

Old stories.

Half-forgotten records.

Names that were spoken carefully, if they were spoken at all.

But Freya remembered.

She remembered more than she wished she did.

The room was quiet.

Freya stood before a large window, looking down upon Orario.

The city was beautiful tonight.

Golden lights stretched across the streets like rivers of stars. Voices drifted upward from taverns and markets. Adventurers walked beneath the moonlight, some returning from the Dungeon, others preparing themselves for tomorrow.

Children laughed somewhere in the distance.

People lived.

People dreamed.

People believed tomorrow would come.

Freya stared at them.

Then her eyes moved toward a particular figure.

A silver-haired boy.

Even from this distance, there was something unmistakable about him.

A light.

Not merely his appearance.

Something deeper.

Something within him.

Freya's expression slowly changed.

“...He has your hair.”

Her voice was barely audible.

She placed her hand against the window.

“Just as bright.”

A faint smile touched her lips.

“But yours always flickered.”

Her smile disappeared.

“His doesn't.”

The memory returned.

A woman.

A voice.

A promise.

And the terrible era that had swallowed so many lives.

Freya closed her eyes.

“Alfia...”

She whispered the name into the empty room.

No one answered.

Of course no one did.

She hadn't expected an answer.

Still, she continued.

“Tell me something.”

Her fingers tightened against the glass.

“Why were you so cruel?”

Her voice carried no anger.

Only sorrow.

“Why did you have to go that far?”

The city continued moving beneath her.

Freya watched the boy.

“He doesn't even know.”

Her eyes softened.

“He doesn't know what happened.”

He didn't know the names.

He didn't know the sacrifices.

He didn't know how much blood had been spilled before he ever opened his eyes to the world.

And that was exactly how it was supposed to be.

Freya lowered her head.

“You made certain of that, didn't you?”

Silence.

“You wanted him to live without carrying it.”

She laughed quietly.

It was a bitter sound.

“You were always terrible at asking for things.”

Her expression became distant.

“Even at the end.”

She remembered the conversation clearly.

Alfia had been standing before her.

The woman looked exhausted.

Not weak.

Never weak.

Even then, there had been something terrifying about her.

But beneath that strength...

There had been desperation.

Not for herself.

For someone else.

Freya had stared at her for a long time before finally asking:

“Why?”

Alfia didn't answer.

Freya stepped closer.

“You've already lost so much.”

Nothing.

“You've sacrificed everything.”

Still nothing.

“And you're still asking for more?”

Alfia's eyes remained fixed somewhere beyond the room.

Freya's voice hardened.

“For him?”

A faint movement.

That was all.

Freya understood.

Her expression twisted.

“You're willing to let him hate you.”

Silence.

“You're willing to let him believe you were nothing but a monster.”

No response.

“You're willing to disappear from his life entirely.”

Alfia finally spoke.

“Yes.”

One word.

Quiet.

Certain.

Freya stared at her.

“You're insane.”

Perhaps.

Alfia gave the faintest smile.

“Maybe.”

“Then why?”

This time, Alfia looked at her.

And Freya saw it.

That expression.

A mother's love.

A sister's love.

Something far deeper than words.

“He shouldn't have to know.”

Freya's eyes narrowed.

“Know what?”

“What it cost.”

Silence.

Alfia looked away.

“He deserves a chance to live normally.”

Freya's voice became softer.

“And if he asks about you?”

“Then let him ask.”

“And when he finds out?”

Alfia closed her eyes.

“He won't.”

“You sound certain.”

“I have to be.”

Freya shook her head.

“You're placing an impossible burden on everyone around him.”

“I know.”

“You're asking me to protect someone who doesn't even know why he needs protecting.”

“I know.”

“You're asking me to watch over a future you may never see.”

Alfia smiled faintly.

“That's why I'm asking you.”

Freya said nothing.

Alfia continued.

“Whatever happens to me...”

Her voice became quieter.

“Don't let him inherit our sins.”

The words struck harder than Freya expected.

“Our sins?”

“Yes.”

Alfia looked toward the window.

“Let the past remain buried.”

Freya followed her gaze.

“And the people who suffered?”

Alfia's expression darkened.

“They deserve to be remembered.”

“Then why hide everything?”

“Because remembering isn't the same as carrying.”

Freya fell silent.

Alfia looked back at her.

“Let him walk forward.”

The memory faded.

Freya opened her eyes.

Her reflection stared back at her.

For a moment, she wondered whether she had imagined the entire conversation.

Then she looked at the silver-haired boy again.

No.

She hadn't.

He was there.

Alive.

Growing.

Walking through the world Alfia had desperately wanted him to see.

Freya's eyes glistened.

“Was this what you wanted?”

The boy disappeared behind a building.

Freya's gaze followed him.

“A safer Orario?”

She whispered.

“For that boy?”

Her voice trembled.

“You went that far for this?”

She looked toward the heavens.

“Why were you so desperate?”

Nothing answered.

Freya closed her eyes.

Then another memory surfaced.

A different place.

A different night.

The Maiden of Silence.

Freya had stood before her once, unable to find the right words.

For once, even Freya—the goddess who could bend hearts with a smile—had felt powerless.

She remembered looking at the Maiden.

“Whatever happens...”

Her voice had trembled.

“I will protect him.”

The Maiden said nothing.

Freya continued.

“No matter what happens to the world.”

Silence.

“No matter what happens to Orario.”

Silence.

“No matter what happens to me.”

Still nothing.

Freya lowered her head.

“So please...”

Her voice cracked.

“Please make their suffering painless.”

She swallowed the lump in her throat.

“For him.”

A tear slipped down her cheek.

“For the people of Orario.”

The Maiden of Silence had not answered.

She had simply looked at Freya.

Quietly.

Endlessly.

And somehow...

That silence had been an answer.

Freya opened her eyes.

The present returned.

The city was still there.

Beautiful.

Alive.

Unaware.

She looked toward the silver-haired boy once more.

Something about him made her chest ache.

He didn't know.

He couldn't know.

And perhaps that was the greatest gift they could give him.

To allow him to become something other than the tragedy that came before him.

Freya whispered:

“You're becoming exactly what she wanted.”

A small smile appeared.

“You don't even know it.”

The boy continued onward.

His silver hair caught the moonlight for an instant.

Freya's eyes followed him.

A single thought crossed her mind.

Keep walking.

Not toward the past.

Not toward the graves.

Not toward the sins of those who came before him.

Forward.

Only forward.

Freya placed her hand over her heart.

“I made a promise.”

Her voice was barely more than a whisper.

“And I intend to keep it.”

She looked toward the heavens.

“Whatever happens...”

The goddess smiled sadly.

“I'll protect him.”

The night remained silent.

But Freya no longer needed an answer.

Because somewhere beneath that same moon, the boy continued walking.

Unaware of the Dark Ages.

Unaware of the blood spilled before his birth.

Unaware of the woman whose desperate choices had helped shape the world he now lived in.

Unaware of the promise made on his behalf.

And perhaps...

That was the point.

He didn't need to know.

Not yet.

For now, he only needed to keep walking.

And Freya would make certain that the path ahead remained open.

Even if she had to stand alone between him and the darkness that had once consumed Orario.

Worked for 7s

Chapter Twenty-Three: Dispel Is Too Overpowered

Bell had always considered himself a cautious person.

Not because he was afraid.

Fear was useful. It told him when something was dangerous, when he was missing information, when he was about to make a mistake.

What Bell disliked was acting without understanding.

And that was precisely why he had spent the last several days doing something most adventurers would probably consider insane.

He was studying the Dungeon.

Not fighting it.

Not exploring it.

Studying it.

Bell stood alone in a quiet section of the Dungeon, staring at the remains of a monster that had disappeared only moments ago.

There was no corpse.

No blood.

No magic stone.

Nothing.

Just an empty patch of stone floor.

Bell slowly lowered his hand.

"...It works."

His expression remained calm, but his mind was anything but.

The theory was correct.

At least, partially.

Bell had suspected for some time that the monsters of the Dungeon weren't truly biological creatures in the conventional sense.

They behaved like living beings.

They possessed instincts.

They could hunt.

They could reproduce through the Dungeon's own strange mechanisms.

But whenever Bell examined them closely with his abilities, something bothered him.

Their existence felt... artificial.

Too artificial.

Like something had taken mana and given it a temporary shape.

If that is the case...

Bell had one obvious solution.

Dispel.

It was one of the abilities Bell considered absurdly powerful.

If something was created or sustained through magical energy, then theoretically...

He could remove it.

The problem was identifying exactly what he needed to dispel.

At first, Bell had assumed that every monster possessed its own independent magical source.

That assumption had been reasonable.

A monster appeared.

It lived.

It fought.

It died.

Therefore, Bell had assumed there must be some kind of magical core maintaining its existence.

So he tested it.

One monster.

Then another.

Then another.

And another.

Eventually, Bell began deliberately seeking out monsters rather than avoiding them.

He didn't attack them.

He observed.

He waited.

He traced their magical signatures.

And when he found what he believed to be their source—

Dispel.

The monster vanished.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

Interesting.

He repeated the experiment.

Again.

And again.

And again.

The result remained the same.

If he could correctly identify the source sustaining the monster's magical existence, Dispel didn't merely weaken it.

It erased the foundation holding it together.

Bell stared at the empty space.

"...That's broken."

He couldn't help muttering it.

There was no other appropriate description.

A normal adventurer had to fight a monster.

A strong adventurer could overpower a monster.

A powerful adventurer could destroy several monsters at once.

But Bell?

If his theory was correct...

He didn't have to fight them at all.

He simply had to remove the thing that made them exist.

But there has to be a limitation.

Bell wasn't arrogant enough to believe he had discovered an ability without a weakness.

Everything had one.

Magic had one.

Skills had one.

Even the Dungeon had one.

So he began searching for the limitation.

His first discovery came when he reached deeper into the Dungeon.

The monsters were stronger.

Their magical structures were denser.

Their presence felt different.

Bell crouched beside one of the strange areas he had begun calling a pantry.

The name was ridiculous.

He knew that.

But it fit.

The Dungeon seemed to maintain enormous reservoirs of magical energy throughout its floors.

These reservoirs weren't merely sources of power.

They were infrastructure.

Bell had discovered that monsters weren't individually carrying all the magical energy required to maintain themselves.

Instead, the Dungeon appeared to provide that energy.

A monster was almost like a device plugged into an enormous magical power grid.

Bell placed his hand against the wall.

His eyes narrowed.

Mana flowed beneath the stone.

Not randomly.

It moved.

It circulated.

It connected.

So that's why.

Bell's mind raced.

The Dungeon doesn't create every monster from scratch and then give each one its own independent source.

That would be wasteful.

And the Dungeon didn't seem interested in wasting anything.

It creates a central reservoir.

A massive one.

Then it distributes the energy throughout the floor.

Bell smiled faintly.

"...Lazy."

The Dungeon had effectively solved the same problem an engineer would.

Why maintain hundreds of individual power sources when one enormous one could supply everything?

Bell stood.

So if I destroy the monster's connection to the pantry...

His eyes sharpened.

That became his next experiment.

Bell spent an absurd amount of time traveling between the pantries.

He memorized their locations.

He observed their size.

He studied the flow of mana.

He tested how quickly the energy replenished.

He watched monsters appear.

He watched monsters disappear.

He tested Dispel on individual monsters.

Then groups.

Then monsters farther away from the pantry.

Then monsters closer to it.

He even deliberately allowed several monsters to surround him while he searched for the invisible magical connection between them and the Dungeon.

It was dangerous.

But Bell considered the risk necessary.

If I'm wrong, I'll learn something.

If I'm right, I'll learn something even more important.

That was how Bell approached the Dungeon now.

Every monster was an experiment.

Every floor was a laboratory.

Every pantry was a question.

And eventually—

He found the pattern.

Bell stood inside one of the enormous mana reservoirs, staring at the glowing mass of magical energy before him.

His expression slowly changed.

"So that's it."

He had finally understood.

The monsters weren't the true source.

The pantry was.

The Dungeon supplied the monsters from these massive reservoirs.

The monsters were simply the products of the system.

Bell looked down at his hand.

Then back toward the pantry.

If I erase the source...

His expression became strangely serious.

"...How much disappears?"

He raised his hand.

The magic formed.

The air trembled.

Then—

Dispel.

The effect spread.

For a brief moment, the entire chamber seemed to hold its breath.

The magical reservoir flickered.

The monsters nearby suddenly stopped moving.

One.

Two.

Five.

Ten.

Then—

They disappeared.

Bell's eyes widened.

The entire area became silent.

No growling.

No footsteps.

No monsters.

Nothing.

Bell slowly lowered his hand.

"...Oh."

He stared.

Then he laughed quietly.

Not from amusement.

From disbelief.

So that's what it does.

His mind immediately began calculating.

If one pantry sustains the monsters of an entire section...

Then removing the pantry removes the monsters.

He looked toward the corridor.

And if every floor has its own supply...

His smile vanished.

There was a problem.

A very obvious one.

Bell had already tested this.

The method worked on the first floor.

It worked on the second.

Third.

Fourth.

Fifth.

But when he reached the sixth floor—

Nothing.

His Dispel had failed.

Not completely.

He could sense the magical structure.

He could identify the pantry.

He could even touch the edge of its magical influence.

But he couldn't erase it.

Bell had initially thought his theory was wrong.

So he went back.

He repeated the experiment.

Again.

And again.

Nothing.

Eventually, he sat down against the wall.

"...Why?"

Bell stared at his hand.

The principle hasn't changed.

The monsters haven't changed.

The pantry exists.

The mana exists.

My Dispel works.

So what changed?

His eyes slowly narrowed.

Then the answer came to him.

Bell looked toward the deeper floor.

"...Me."

Silence.

The Dungeon hadn't changed.

The magic hadn't changed.

The structure hadn't changed.

His level had.

More specifically—

His ability to interfere with the system had reached its limit.

The first five floors were within his effective range.

The sixth floor wasn't.

Bell leaned his head against the wall.

"So that's the threshold."

He smiled.

Not happily.

Almost admiringly.

The Dungeon had finally given him a wall he couldn't simply ignore.

Interesting.

For the first time in days, Bell felt genuinely excited.

Because now he knew exactly what the limitation was.

His Dispel wasn't absolute.

It was dependent on the difference between his own magical authority and the thing he was trying to erase.

The stronger the Dungeon's structure became, the more difficult it was to interfere with.

And the sixth floor was simply beyond his current reach.

Bell stood.

He looked back toward the stairs.

I've solved the monster problem.

At least, the part that mattered to him.

He had discovered how the Dungeon sustained its monsters.

He had discovered the existence of the pantries.

He had discovered why Dispel worked.

And, most importantly—

He had discovered why it eventually stopped working.

Bell began walking.

His footsteps echoed through the corridor.

But his mind was already somewhere else.

If the Dungeon has a system...

And I can interfere with that system...

His expression became thoughtful.

Then the next question is obvious.

He touched his chest.

The Falna.

That mysterious blessing granted by the gods.

A system that transformed ordinary people into adventurers.

A system that recorded abilities.

Levels.

Development Abilities.

Skills.

Magic.

Growth.

Bell had always treated the Falna as something fundamentally different from the Dungeon.

But now...

He wasn't so sure.

The Dungeon has a structure.

The Dungeon has rules.

The Dungeon has a source.

And the Falna has rules too.

Bell's eyes became colder.

Who decided those rules?

He continued walking.

His thoughts became increasingly dangerous.

What exactly happens when someone levels up?

Where does the increase in ability actually come from?

Why does Excelia become converted into growth?

Why are abilities written into the Status?

Why can gods read them?

And most importantly...

Bell stopped.

His shadow stretched across the stone floor.

He looked down at his hand.

A faint smile appeared.

"...Can the system be exploited?"

That question was far more dangerous than anything he had asked about the Dungeon.

Because Bell wasn't asking how to become stronger.

He was asking whether the rules themselves could be manipulated.

He had spent generations' worth of assumptions tearing apart the Dungeon's method of producing monsters.

Now he had another system in front of him.

The Falna.

And Bell intended to understand it.

Completely.

If Dispel can interfere with the Dungeon's foundation...

His eyes narrowed.

Then perhaps I don't need to follow the Falna's rules either.

He resumed walking.

But Bell didn't notice something.

Far behind him, deep within the Dungeon—

The mana he had erased was beginning to move again.

Not naturally.

Not randomly.

Something was reconstructing it.

And for the briefest moment, the Dungeon seemed to react to the disturbance Bell had created.

As though...

For the first time—

something inside the Dungeon had noticed him.

Worked for 7s

Chapter Twenty-Four: Miscalculation

Two weeks had passed since Bell Cranel joined the Hestia Familia.

Surprisingly, things were going smoothly.

There had been no major problems.

Hestia was still Hestia—loud, affectionate, and occasionally troublesome—but Bell had quickly adapted to his new circumstances. The Familia had a home, he had access to the Dungeon, and, most importantly, he finally had a place where he could conduct his experiments without constantly worrying about someone discovering them.

His research had progressed considerably.

The strange summons he had created were especially useful.

At first, Bell had assumed they were nothing more than temporary constructs. Something that could be created, given a task, and eventually dismissed.

He had been wrong.

They could be modified.

Their appearance, physical characteristics, intelligence, behavior, and even certain functions could be adjusted.

That discovery had opened an entirely new branch of research.

Bell had even attempted something more ambitious.

A perfect replica of himself.

The result had been... almost perfect.

Almost.

The replica could move, speak, think, and perform tasks exactly as Bell intended.

The problem was the cost.

Maintaining something that complicated continuously consumed an absurd amount of Mind.

Bell had eventually discovered a workaround.

The replica didn't necessarily have to remain in the physical world.

He could store it inside the strange space he had begun calling the 'Universe.'

Inside that space, the replica remained dormant but retained its memories and functions.

Essentially, Bell had created a second version of himself that could be retrieved whenever necessary.

Useful.

But Bell had learned something else.

Useful doesn't mean efficient.

And efficiency was becoming increasingly important.

The fifth floor of the Dungeon was relatively calm.

Bell walked through the stone corridor, his eyes occasionally scanning the surroundings.

Adventurers were everywhere.

Some groups were resting against the walls.

Others were preparing to descend deeper.

A few were already discussing their earnings.

"How many magic stones did we get?"

"Thirty-seven."

"Thirty-seven?"

"That's what I counted."

"Then we're splitting them evenly."

"Absolutely not. You almost got yourself killed twice."

"I was protecting you!"

"You were running away!"

Bell quietly walked past them.

Another group was having a different conversation.

"If we sell these at the Guild, how much do you think we'll get?"

"Depends on the size."

"Then we should probably sell them individually."

"That takes longer."

"So?"

"So I'm hungry."

Bell almost smiled.

The Dungeon was dangerous.

But somehow, people still found time to argue about money and food.

A supporter sat nearby with a small notebook in his hands.

"Three swords need repairs. Two potions left. Four days of food."

The adventurer beside him sighed.

"How much?"

"Too much."

"That's not a number."

"It's a warning."

Another adventurer laughed.

"That's why I don't bring a supporter."

His companion immediately turned toward him.

"And that's why you almost died on the third floor last week."

"That was unrelated."

"It was absolutely related."

Bell continued walking.

His expression remained neutral.

But his senses were quietly monitoring everything around him.

Noise.

Movement.

Mana fluctuations.

Air pressure.

Footsteps.

Nothing unusual.

Then—

Bell stopped.

His eyes narrowed.

Something had changed.

His instincts screamed.

Danger.

Something was approaching.

Fast.

Extremely fast.

The conversations around him continued for another second.

Then Bell heard it.

A roar.

"WHAT THE—?!"

"MONSTER!"

"GET OUT OF THE WAY!"

"RUN!"

The corridor erupted into chaos.

Adventurers scrambled to their feet.

Someone dropped their sword.

Another adventurer grabbed his supporter and pulled him backward.

"What floor is this?!"

"Fifth!"

"Then what the hell is that?!"

Bell didn't answer.

His senses had already identified the direction.

Something massive was coming.

And judging from the sound—

It was moving directly toward them.

The next instant, everything seemed to slow.

Bell's perception sharpened.

The world became strangely quiet.

His hand moved toward his weapon.

A compact handbow appeared in his grasp.

Bell raised it.

The others barely had time to understand what he was doing.

He pulled the string.

"Mark."

A small projectile launched.

It traveled directly toward the approaching roar.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"Ignite."

The projectile exploded.

BOOM!

The blast shook the corridor.

Dust erupted from the stone floor.

Several adventurers covered their faces.

"What was that?!"

"Magic?!"

"No! That came from the white-haired kid!"

The dust cleared.

And something enormous emerged from it.

A massive humanoid monster.

Muscular.

Red-skinned.

With enormous horns protruding from its head.

A Minotaur.

One adventurer's face went pale.

"A Minotaur?!"

"On the fifth floor?!"

"That's impossible!"

Bell stared at the creature.

So that's what it is.

The Minotaur shook its head.

The explosion had stunned it.

But only temporarily.

Its eyes locked onto Bell.

Then it roared.

"ROOOOOAAARRR!"

The monster charged.

Bell immediately moved.

"Move!"

The surrounding adventurers finally reacted.

"GET OUT OF THE WAY!"

"RUN!"

The Minotaur crashed forward.

Its massive feet smashed into the stone floor.

Adventurers scattered in every direction.

Bell jumped backward.

The monster's fist slammed into the place where he had been standing.

BOOM!

Stone shattered.

Bell landed several meters away.

Strength is considerable.

The Minotaur turned.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

Speed isn't bad either.

The monster charged again.

Bell ran.

Not away.

Around it.

He intentionally drew the Minotaur deeper into the corridor.

"Hey! Kid!"

Bell ignored the shouting.

"He's leading it somewhere!"

"Is he crazy?!"

"That thing will crush him!"

Bell turned sharply at an intersection.

The Minotaur followed.

Exactly as expected.

Bell stopped at the end of the corridor.

A dead end.

The Minotaur roared triumphantly.

It raised both arms.

Bell calmly lifted his hand.

"Scatter."

Several small magical circles appeared around him.

The adventurers watching from a distance froze.

"What is he doing?"

"I don't know."

"Those aren't normal magic circles."

The circles released several small spheres.

Bell stepped backward.

"Burst."

The spheres detonated.

BOOM! BOOM! BOOM! BOOM!

The explosions struck the Minotaur from different directions.

The monster staggered.

Its balance was disrupted.

Bell immediately followed.

"Again."

More spheres appeared.

"Scatter."

They surrounded the monster.

"Burst."

Another barrage.

The Minotaur stumbled.

Its movements became increasingly erratic.

Bell observed it carefully.

Concussive force.

Not enough penetration.

But it works.

The Minotaur swung blindly.

Bell ducked underneath its arm.

The monster's fist struck the wall.

CRACK!

Bell moved to its side.

His hand extended.

A faint blue magic circle appeared.

"Freeze."

Ice erupted from the ground.

Several thick spikes shot upward.

They pierced into the Minotaur's leg.

The monster screamed.

"ROOOAAARR!"

Its movement stopped.

Bell didn't hesitate.

Another magic circle appeared.

Then another.

And another.

The Minotaur looked toward him.

For the first time, Bell saw something resembling fear in its eyes.

Bell raised his hand.

"Hold."

The ice spread.

It locked the monster's legs in place.

Bell inhaled.

The next spell required more concentration.

The surrounding air seemed to vibrate.

Several adventurers watching from a distance instinctively covered their ears.

"What is that?"

"I don't know."

"Something's wrong with the air."

Bell pointed toward the Minotaur.

"Concentrate."

Mana gathered into a tiny point.

It wasn't flashy.

There was no giant explosion.

No enormous beam.

Instead—

The air around Bell's hand distorted.

Then he released it.

BOOM.

The Minotaur's body violently jerked.

A small area of its armor-like hide had been struck.

Bell's eyes sharpened.

Effective.

The Minotaur roared and struggled against the ice.

Bell fired again.

"Concentrate."

BOOM!

Again.

"Concentrate."

BOOM!

Again.

"Concentrate."

BOOM!

The Minotaur's body trembled.

Blood began to flow.

The creature attempted to move.

Bell adjusted his aim.

The spell creates an extremely concentrated mana disturbance.

The sudden pressure differential produces cavitation.

The collapse releases destructive force over a tiny area.

Essentially...

Bell's eyes narrowed.

It punches through things.

The Minotaur's thick hide offered almost no protection.

Bell fired again.

"Concentrate."

BOOM!

The Minotaur collapsed.

Its enormous body slammed into the ground.

Silence followed.

Bell lowered his hand.

The magic circles disappeared.

For several seconds, nobody spoke.

Then—

"Did..."

One adventurer swallowed.

"Did that kid just kill a Minotaur?"

Another stared at the corpse.

"Yeah."

"But..."

He looked at Bell.

"How?"

The first adventurer shook his head.

"I don't know."

A supporter slowly peeked around the corner.

"Was that magic?"

"Some of it."

"Some?"

"I saw explosions, ice, and... whatever the hell that last thing was."

Another adventurer approached cautiously.

"Hey, kid."

Bell turned toward him.

The man hesitated.

"Are you alone?"

"Yes."

"You're a solo adventurer?"

"For now."

"For now?"

Bell nodded.

The man looked toward the dead Minotaur.

Then back at Bell.

"You're either incredibly brave or incredibly stupid."

Bell considered that.

"...Possibly both."

A few adventurers laughed nervously.

One of them pointed at the Minotaur.

"Are you going to take the magic stone?"

Bell looked at the corpse.

"Yes."

"Then you should hurry. The Dungeon might send another monster."

Bell nodded.

He approached the Minotaur.

But before he could begin extracting the magic stone—

He stopped.

His senses changed.

Again.

Not a monster.

Someone else.

Someone had been watching him.

The entire time.

Bell slowly looked toward the upper section of the corridor.

Nothing.

Only stone.

Darkness.

Empty space.

Yet Bell knew.

Someone is there.

His eyes narrowed.

Since before the Minotaur appeared.

Bell didn't turn his head completely.

Instead, he calmly crouched beside the Minotaur.

His hand touched the corpse.

But his mind was elsewhere.

So that was the real reason I felt uneasy.

The Minotaur had been dangerous.

But it wasn't the most dangerous thing in this corridor.

Bell continued extracting the magic stone as though nothing had happened.

His expression remained calm.

But his senses were locked onto the darkness.

Someone was observing my entire battle.

And they haven't left.

Bell's fingers tightened slightly.

For the first time that day, he wondered whether his battle had really been a battle at all—

Or merely a demonstration someone had been waiting to see.

And somewhere beyond the corridor, hidden from Bell's sight...

someone smiled.

Chapter Twenty-Five: Spectre

The conclusion came to Bell quietly.

The Minotaur had escaped the Loki Familia.

Not from him.

From them.

Bell stood in the Dungeon corridor, staring at the bloodied trail disappearing deeper into the darkness. The sounds of distant battle had already faded.

He replayed what he had witnessed.

The hesitation.

The positioning.

The delay.

The sheer difference between what should have happened and what actually happened.

A Level 5 shouldn't have trouble keeping up with a Level 2 monster.

Bell crouched down and picked up the Minotaur's magic stone.

Especially not one that is already injured.

There had been anger in their eyes when they realized the monster had escaped.

But Bell hadn't sensed hatred.

Only frustration.

Perhaps that was what bothered him most.

"They're angry," Bell muttered.

He looked toward the direction the Loki Familia had disappeared.

"But why?"

He already knew the answer.

Because they made a mistake.

Bell stood.

"Not my problem."

He turned away.

He wasn't arrogant enough to lecture experienced adventurers. And he certainly wasn't foolish enough to insert himself into someone else's familia affairs.

They'll figure it out eventually.

The magic stone rested in his hand.

Or they won't.

Bell shrugged.

"Either way, I have my own problems."

And with that, he casually began walking toward the surface.

By the time Bell returned, there were already plenty of witnesses.

Adventurers had seen the fight.

They had seen the Minotaur.

More importantly, they had seen Bell kill it.

There was little room for anyone to dispute who had actually slain the monster.

The magic stone was therefore legally his.

Bell looked down at it as he walked through the streets of Orario.

"So much trouble for something this small."

He held the stone up toward the sunlight.

A faint crimson glow passed through its surface.

Still... this should sell for a decent amount.

Bell's stomach growled.

He lowered the stone.

"...After food."

The moment Bell entered the church, Hestia looked up.

"Bell!"

"Hestia."

"You came back!"

She immediately rushed toward him.

"Are you hurt? Are you bleeding? Did something happen?"

"I'm fine."

"You're sure?"

"Yes."

Hestia narrowed her eyes.

"You look suspiciously calm."

Bell paused.

"I killed a Minotaur."

Silence.

Hestia blinked.

"...You what?"

Bell casually held up the magic stone.

"I killed a Minotaur."

"YOU KILLED A MINOTAUR?!"

Her voice echoed throughout the church.

Bell winced.

"Hestia, please lower your voice."

"How am I supposed to lower my voice?!"

She grabbed his shoulders.

"Bell! A Minotaur!"

"Yes."

"Those things are dangerous!"

"I noticed."

"And you fought one?!"

"Yes."

"ALONE?!"

Bell looked away.

"...Mostly."

Hestia's eye twitched.

"Bell Cranel."

"Yes?"

"Sit."

Bell obeyed.

Hestia sighed deeply.

"You're going to give me gray hair."

"I thought gods didn't age."

"That's not the point!"

Bell smiled faintly.

Hestia eventually calmed down.

Then Bell's expression became serious.

"Hestia."

"Hm?"

"I need you to check my status."

Hestia stared at him.

"You think you're ready?"

Bell nodded.

"I believe so."

There was something different in his voice.

Not excitement.

Certainty.

Hestia understood.

"...All right."

She prepared the ritual.

Bell knelt before her.

The needle pricked his finger.

A few drops of blood fell.

Hestia's divine power began flowing through his body.

The status sheet slowly revealed itself.

Hestia's eyes widened.

Again.

And again.

She read the numbers.

"...Bell."

"Yes?"

"You've changed."

Bell lowered his head.

"I know."

His fists tightened.

I've reached the point where another level isn't just a possibility.

It's necessary.

But Hestia didn't immediately announce anything.

Instead, she stared at his back.

"There is something unusual here."

Bell glanced over his shoulder.

"Unusual?"

"Your growth."

She smiled faintly.

"You're not growing like an ordinary adventurer."

Bell remained silent.

I know.

He didn't say it aloud.

Because the truth was something even Bell didn't fully understand.

That night, Bell sat alone.

The church was silent.

The city beyond the walls was still alive, but inside, there was nothing.

He stared at the ceiling.

Silence isn't an answer.

He had learned that much.

The Minotaur.

The Loki Familia.

His own growth.

The strange attention surrounding him.

Something was happening.

He could feel it.

But who was he?

Just Bell Cranel.

A newcomer.

A Level 2 adventurer, at least for now.

No famous familia.

No legendary title.

No great reputation.

If I speak now, what would happen?

Nothing.

Or worse.

People would start asking questions he couldn't answer.

Bell closed his eyes.

"...Not yet."

He turned over.

"Tomorrow."

And eventually, sleep took him.

Morning arrived exactly as Bell expected.

With trouble.

Bell opened his eyes.

He stared at the ceiling.

"...Of course."

He got out of bed.

Whatever happened next, he would deal with it.

Life doesn't stop throwing problems at you just because you're tired.

Bell smiled slightly.

So I'll just keep moving.

Later that day, Bell stood in an empty training area.

A magic circle appeared in front of him.

He stared at it.

The circle was large.

Very large.

Bell had noticed something during his previous battles.

Magic wasn't simply about the spell itself.

The magic circle acted as a framework.

It determined how much magical power could be channeled, stabilized, and released.

A larger circle allowed him to construct a more complex magical phenomenon.

But complexity required energy.

Bell raised his hand.

"Let's test the theory."

The circle began glowing.

If the circle is larger, the magical structure has more space.

More space means more magical energy can be distributed.

But if I don't need the full structure...

His eyes narrowed.

Then why use the full circle?

He reduced the size.

The magic circle shrank.

The light weakened.

Bell's expression sharpened.

"Interesting."

He concentrated.

The important factor isn't simply the size.

It's the relationship between mana input and magical output.

Bell estimated the ratio.

For his current technique, approximately **20 units of mana were required to properly sustain a one-meter magic circle** at full output.

That meant a large circle was powerful—but expensive.

Bell stared at the smaller circle.

"So..."

He reduced it again.

The circle became tiny.

A fraction of the original size.

The magical pressure dropped dramatically.

Bell smiled.

"Less mana."

He injected energy.

The circle stabilized.

Then—

BOOM!

A small explosion erupted several meters away.

Bell's eyes widened.

"It worked."

The power was obviously weaker.

Much weaker.

But that wasn't the point.

If one large circle consumes the equivalent of twenty small ones...

His thoughts accelerated.

Then I don't have to make one large circle.

He raised both hands.

One small circle appeared.

Then another.

Then another.

Then another.

Within seconds, several tiny magic circles floated around him.

Bell stared at them.

"...Let's see."

He released them.

BOOM. BOOM. BOOM. BOOM.

Multiple explosions scattered across the training area.

Bell's eyes widened.

The circles individually possessed only about **five percent of the destructive power of his original full-sized spell**.

But that weakness was compensated for by quantity.

One large spell could deliver overwhelming destruction to a single area.

The smaller circles could distribute that same magical expenditure across numerous points.

Bell slowly lowered his hand.

"So the trade-off is..."

He began calculating aloud.

"Power per circle decreases..."

He raised another circle.

"But casting efficiency increases."

Another appeared.

"And if the energy cost is reduced enough..."

Another.

"...I can multiply the number of casts."

Bell looked at the dozens of small circles surrounding him.

His expression slowly changed.

A grin appeared.

Twenty.

If the energy cost is divided correctly, I could theoretically produce twenty smaller attacks for roughly the mana cost of one full-scale spell.

He paused.

Not twenty times the power.

Twenty attacks.

That distinction mattered.

Bell understood it immediately.

One hammer isn't always better than twenty knives.

He looked at the annihilation magic forming inside the miniature circles.

The original spell had been designed around overwhelming force.

A single attack.

A single target.

A single point of destruction.

But this?

This was different.

I don't need every attack to destroy everything.

He raised his hand.

The circles shifted positions.

"Then..."

Bell's eyes sharpened.

"I'll change how I use annihilation."

The circles vanished.

He immediately began constructing another set.

Smaller.

Faster.

More precise.

Large circles for overwhelming targets.

Small circles for repeated attacks.

Multiple circles for area control.

And if I can eventually reduce the casting time...

Bell's expression became serious.

Then I won't have to choose between power and speed.

He looked at his hand.

For the first time, Bell realized something important.

His magic didn't need to become stronger.

Not immediately.

It needed to become **smarter**.

Bell smiled.

"...Now that's useful."

And somewhere beyond the training grounds, completely unaware of what Bell had just discovered, another adventurer was beginning to hear rumors about the white-haired newcomer who had slain a Minotaur.

A rumor that would soon lead Bell toward a title he never expected.

Spectre.

Absolutely. The only change is “Spectre” → “Spectre”. Everything else remains unchanged.

Worked for 12s

Chapter Twenty-Six: Confrontation

The Hostess of Fertility was already lively by the time Bell arrived.

It was not yet crowded enough to be difficult to find a seat, but the tables were beginning to fill one by one. The smell of roasted meat, freshly baked bread, soup, and alcohol drifted through the warm interior.

Bell looked around.

Half the tables were occupied.

Perfect.

He had deliberately come early.

After spending so much time in Orario, Bell had learned something important.

The Hostess of Fertility was not merely an inn.

It was a battlefield.

And arriving late meant losing the battle for a table.

Bell quietly smiled.

"I planned this perfectly."

A familiar voice answered from behind him.

"Bell!"

He turned.

Hestia stood there with a bright smile, her hands clasped behind her back.

"You're early!"

"I know."

Bell pointed proudly toward the relatively empty dining area.

"I secured us a table."

Hestia's eyes sparkled.

"My Bell!"

She immediately grabbed his arm.

"You really are becoming dependable!"

Bell chuckled.

"I've always been dependable."

"Not when food is involved."

"That's unfair."

They walked toward one of the tables.

Bell had become surprisingly familiar with the waitresses over the past few days.

At first, most of them had treated him with cautious curiosity.

After all, he was the strange young adventurer everyone had begun calling the Spectre.

But that had gradually changed.

Especially with one particular elf.

Bell glanced toward the counter.

Ryuu was preparing several drinks.

Their relationship had become slightly strange.

It had all started with Bell trying to apologize.

He had eventually found Ryuu alone and carefully explained that the sacred branch she had given him had been turned into his wand.

He had expected her to be angry.

Instead—

Ryuu had simply stopped functioning.

Her face had gone red.

Her thoughts had apparently short-circuited.

And Bell had spent several minutes wondering if elves simply malfunctioned when confronted with excessive sincerity.

Since then, Ryuu had become noticeably awkward around him.

Bell smiled faintly.

"Good evening, Ryuu."

Ryuu nearly dropped the glass in her hand.

"Good evening."

Her response came slightly too quickly.

Bell didn't notice.

Hestia did.

She narrowed her eyes.

Interesting.

The two sat down.

Bell ordered dinner.

Hestia ordered enough food to make Bell question whether gods actually needed to eat.

"You ordered too much."

"Nonsense."

"That's enough food for three people."

"I'm a goddess."

"That doesn't explain anything."

"It explains everything."

Bell sighed.

"Whatever you say."

Their food arrived.

For a while, Bell simply enjoyed himself.

No dungeon.

No monsters.

No gods making strange offers.

No mysterious powers.

No people calling him Spectre.

Just dinner.

Just Hestia.

For once, Bell could relax.

Then—

"WE HAVE RESERVATIONS!"

The entire tavern seemed to pause.

Bell slowly turned his head.

A waitress stood near the entrance.

Several large tables had already been cleared.

Her expression was almost resigned.

"They're here."

Hestia blinked.

"Who?"

Bell already knew.

A group began entering the Hostess.

At the front was a small woman with red hair and an almost permanent mischievous smile.

Loki.

Behind her came Finn.

Then Riveria.

Gareth.

Ais.

And the rest of the Loki Familia's returning expedition members.

They had reserved several tables.

Apparently, the expedition's return demanded a celebration.

Loki immediately raised her arms.

"FOOD!"

Several adventurers laughed.

"Drinks!"

More cheers followed.

The Hostess became considerably louder.

Bell quietly continued eating.

Hestia stared at the incoming group.

"Why are they here?"

"Because they reserved the place."

"I know that."

"Then why ask?"

"Because I don't like it."

Bell smiled.

"Try enjoying dinner."

Hestia pouted.

"I am enjoying dinner."

"You look angry."

"I'm enjoying being angry."

Bell shook his head.

Across the room, the Loki Familia settled into their tables.

Orders began arriving almost immediately.

Meat.

Stew.

Bread.

Wine.

Ale.

More meat.

Loki looked particularly pleased.

The expedition had returned alive.

For adventurers, that was worth celebrating.

Bell tried not to pay attention.

He focused on his food.

Ignore them.

That was the simplest solution.

Unfortunately, peace rarely survived for long in Orario.

Especially when alcohol was involved.

A rough voice suddenly carried across the tavern.

"So that's him?"

Bell's fork stopped halfway to his mouth.

The voice came from one of the Loki Familia tables.

A gray-haired werewolf sat there.

Bete Loga.

He was already drinking.

Several empty cups sat near him.

His eyes were fixed on Bell.

"So that's the damn Spectre."

The tavern gradually became quieter.

Hestia's expression hardened.

Bell slowly put his fork down.

Bete leaned back.

"I heard about what happened."

He laughed.

"That little bastard appeared on the floor, killed a Minotaur, and dragged everyone out like some damn hero."

Bell said nothing.

Bete continued.

"Should've left them."

A few members of the Loki Familia looked uncomfortable.

Finn's eyes narrowed slightly.

"Bete."

"What?"

"Enough."

Bete ignored him.

"The weak die."

His voice became harsher.

"That's how the Dungeon works."

Bell stared at his plate.

His expression remained calm.

Inside, however, his thoughts were considerably less charitable.

Drunk retard.

That was the simplest explanation.

Someone had lost people.

Someone had survived.

And now he needed something to blame.

Bell understood that.

He didn't approve of it.

But he understood it.

Bete continued.

"Should've just let those weaklings die on that floor."

Hestia's fingers tightened around her fork.

"Bell..."

"I'm fine."

Bell's voice was quiet.

He picked up his fork again.

"He's drunk."

Bete laughed.

"And you should be thankful."

Bell paused.

"For what?"

Bete pointed toward him.

"The Minotaur."

His grin became ugly.

"You got handed a free kill because the Loki Familia did the work."

Bell's eyes lifted.

"The Minotaur was mine."

Bete's smile disappeared for a moment.

Bell immediately looked back down.

"That's enough."

He wasn't interested.

He didn't want to fight.

Not here.

Not inside the Hostess.

Too many civilians.

Too many tables.

Too many people who would get hurt if things escalated.

Bell knew exactly how dangerous he could become when he stopped holding back.

He had no intention of proving it inside a tavern.

Then—

Ais spoke.

"He defeated it."

The table became quiet.

Bete turned.

"What?"

Ais looked toward Bell.

Her expression remained as calm as ever.

"I saw him."

Bell looked at her.

For a moment, their eyes met.

Bell remembered her.

The beautiful blonde swordswoman.

The Sword Princess.

Ais Wallenstein.

She had been there.

She had seen him fight the Minotaur.

Bete's face changed.

"You saw him?"

Ais nodded.

"Yes."

"You're sure?"

"Yes."

Bete stared at Bell.

Bell stared back.

Ais continued.

"He defeated the Minotaur."

Bete's expression slowly twisted.

"So that's how it is."

His voice became colder.

"You."

Bell said nothing.

Bete stood.

"And here I thought the Spectre was some pathetic little adventurer hiding behind tricks."

He walked closer.

Bell remained seated.

Bete stopped in front of him.

"What's your level?"

Bell didn't answer.

"Answer me."

Silence.

Bete laughed.

"Right."

He looked toward the others.

"He's faking it."

Hestia frowned.

"Excuse me?"

"There's no way some kid like this is actually that strong."

Bete leaned closer.

"You're either hiding your level or someone gave you a damn blessing I haven't heard about."

Bell remained silent.

His eyes were calm.

That somehow irritated Bete even more.

"Say something."

Bell finally spoke.

"I don't have anything to say."

Bete's eyebrow twitched.

"Nothing?"

"No."

Bell looked directly into his eyes.

"You're drunk."

A few people at the tables went silent.

Bete's grin returned.

"You're right."

He suddenly moved.

Bell's instincts screamed.

Bete's hand seized his shoulder.

Fast.

The next instant—

"Bell!"

Bete yanked him from his chair.

Bell's body was thrown across the tavern.

He smashed through the entrance.

Wood cracked.

The street outside erupted into noise.

Bell reacted instantly.

Magic circles appeared around him.

One barrier.

Two.

Three.

Several layers formed beneath his body.

BOOM!

The barriers shattered one after another.

But each absorbed part of the impact.

Bell rolled across the street and stopped.

Dust rose around him.

His shoulder hurt.

His ribs hurt.

But nothing was broken.

Bell slowly stood.

He looked toward the tavern.

Bete emerged.

"Get up."

Bell sighed.

"You really want to do this?"

"Yes."

"Outside?"

"Unless you're too scared."

Bell looked around.

People were already backing away.

He could see frightened civilians.

Merchants.

Adventurers.

Children being pulled away by their parents.

Bell's eyes hardened.

Not here.

He stepped backward.

"Fine."

Bete grinned.

"Running?"

"I'm choosing the location."

Bell turned and moved toward a wider area farther from the crowded streets.

Bete followed.

The Loki Familia poured out of the Hostess.

Hestia stood at the entrance.

"Bell!"

"I'm fine!"

He raised a hand.

"Stay there."

Bete suddenly lunged.

Bell twisted aside.

A claw passed beside his face.

Bell countered with a mana-coated fist.

BOOM!

His fist struck Bete's ribs.

Bete staggered.

His eyes widened.

What the hell?

Bell didn't give him time.

Another punch.

Bete blocked.

The impact forced him backward.

"You're fast!"

Bete swung.

Bell ducked.

The claw passed over his head.

Bell drove his elbow into Bete's stomach.

Bete grunted.

Then the werewolf's knee struck Bell in the ribs.

CRACK!

Bell was thrown sideways.

Pain exploded through his body.

He landed on one knee.

His hand pressed against his side.

A healing spell immediately activated.

The pain began fading.

Bete stared.

"You heal?"

Bell stood.

"Sometimes."

Bete rushed him.

Bell's fist met Bete's.

The collision produced a sharp crack.

Both stepped backward.

Bell shook his hand.

His physical strength is absurd.

Bete grinned.

"Not bad."

Bell said nothing.

The fight continued.

Punch.

Kick.

Block.

Counter.

The two moved rapidly through the streets.

Bell's advantage was precision and magic enhancement.

Bete's advantage was raw physical ability.

The werewolf was faster.

Stronger.

More experienced in close combat.

But Bell had one advantage Bete hadn't accounted for.

He didn't care about winning conventionally.

Bell coated his arms in mana.

His muscles became reinforced.

His movements accelerated.

When Bete struck him, Bell healed.

When Bell's knuckles split, they healed.

When his ribs cracked, they repaired.

Bell kept moving.

Don't overpower him.

Outlast him.

Bete snarled.

"Why won't you stay down?!"

Bell ducked beneath another claw.

"Because you're not very good at making me."

He punched Bete in the jaw.

Bete stumbled.

"YOU—!"

Bete charged.

Bell jumped backward.

The two finally reached an open clearing.

Bell stopped.

Bete stopped several meters away.

The werewolf breathed heavily.

Bell's clothes were torn.

Blood stained his face.

But his eyes remained clear.

Bete wiped blood from his mouth.

"You're a strange bastard."

Bell said nothing.

He raised one hand.

A magic circle appeared.

Bete's expression changed.

"Magic?"

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"Yes."

Bete prepared himself.

"Then cast it."

Bell didn't attack.

Instead, he looked around.

There were no civilians nearby.

No buildings close enough to be damaged.

No allies within the immediate area.

Perfect.

Bell raised his other hand.

A transparent barrier appeared.

Not around himself.

Around Bete.

Bete looked around.

"What?"

Bell stepped backward.

Bete slammed his fist against the barrier.

"HEY!"

The barrier didn't break.

Bell's expression was emotionless.

"You're going to hate this."

Bete snarled.

"Break it!"

Bell didn't respond.

A second magic circle appeared.

Then a third.

The air around the barrier began to distort.

Ais, watching from a distance, immediately noticed something was wrong.

"That's not a normal attack."

Finn's expression became serious.

"Everyone stay back."

Riveria's eyes narrowed.

"What is he doing?"

Finn didn't answer.

Inside the barrier, Bete suddenly felt something change.

The air felt wrong.

His breathing became heavier.

Bell spoke quietly.

"Annihilation."

The spell activated.

There was no enormous explosion.

No giant beam.

No dramatic flash.

Instead—

The space inside the barrier became unnaturally still.

The air itself began to disappear.

Not violently.

Not visibly.

Just—

Gone.

Bete inhaled.

Nothing.

His eyes widened.

He tried again.

His lungs received almost nothing.

Bell stood outside the barrier.

His voice remained calm.

"I'm not trying to kill you."

Bete slammed his fist into the barrier.

"LET ME OUT!"

Bell watched him carefully.

The werewolf's movements became increasingly frantic.

Bete struck the barrier again.

And again.

Bell's spell wasn't designed to crush him.

It wasn't designed to burn him.

It was simply denying him the one thing his body desperately needed.

Air.

A few seconds passed.

Bete's movements slowed.

His knees buckled.

He fell.

The spell ended.

The barrier disappeared.

Fresh air rushed into the clearing.

Bete lay motionless.

Bell walked toward him.

He crouched beside the werewolf.

Bete was breathing faintly.

Alive.

Unconscious.

Bell sighed.

"Idiot."

He stood.

Behind him—

Nobody spoke.

The Loki Familia stared.

Hestia stared.

The waitresses stared.

Even Loki had lost her usual grin.

Finn's eyes remained fixed on Bell.

"What..."

Gareth slowly lowered his cup.

"What in the world was that?"

Riveria's expression was severe.

"He deliberately created a sealed barrier."

Finn nodded.

"And then used magic that altered the environment inside it."

Ais stared at Bell.

Her expression was unusually focused.

"He didn't attack Bete directly."

"No," Finn said.

"He attacked the conditions necessary for Bete to fight."

Bell turned toward them.

Their eyes met.

Finn's expression changed slightly.

Bell simply shrugged.

"He started the fight."

Hestia immediately ran toward him.

"Bell!"

She reached him and grabbed his arms.

"Are you hurt?!"

"I'm fine."

"You're bleeding!"

"It'll heal."

"That's not the point!"

Bell looked down at himself.

His clothes were ruined.

"Ah."

Hestia's eyes widened.

"You can't just say 'ah'!"

Bell smiled awkwardly.

"I'm sorry."

Hestia stared at him.

Then she hugged him.

Bell froze.

"You're an idiot."

"I'm aware."

"You could've been killed."

"I wasn't."

"That doesn't make it better!"

Bell patted her head.

"I'm okay."

Hestia tightened her grip.

"You better be."

Behind them, Loki finally spoke.

"Well..."

Everyone turned.

Loki scratched her cheek.

"That certainly wasn't how I expected dinner to go."

Finn sighed.

"Neither did I."

Riveria looked toward the unconscious Bete.

"He was reckless."

Finn nodded.

"He provoked someone he didn't understand."

His eyes returned to Bell.

"But I admit..."

Finn's smile became faint.

"I didn't expect the Spectre to respond like that."

Bell glanced at him.

"I didn't want to fight him."

Finn raised an eyebrow.

"You didn't want to?"

"No."

Bell looked at the unconscious werewolf.

"He made that decision himself."

Ais quietly approached.

Bell looked at her.

She stopped several steps away.

"You were holding back."

Bell blinked.

"What?"

Ais looked toward the destroyed street.

"You could have used stronger magic."

Bell was silent.

Then he nodded.

"Probably."

Ais stared at him.

"Why didn't you?"

Bell glanced toward the surrounding buildings.

"Because people live here."

Ais said nothing.

Bell continued.

"I don't want to win a fight by destroying someone's home."

For some reason, those words made Ais stare at him for several seconds.

Loki suddenly grinned.

"Oi, Ais."

Ais turned.

"What?"

Loki leaned closer.

"Didn't you know?"

"Know what?"

Loki pointed toward Bell.

"He's the guy we tried recruiting."

Ais blinked.

Her eyes widened slightly.

"...What?"

Finn closed his eyes.

Riveria sighed.

Gareth laughed.

Loki continued.

"He turned us down."

Ais looked back at Bell.

"You declined?"

Bell nodded.

"Yes."

"Why?"

Bell thought for a moment.

"I wanted to make my own path."

Ais tilted her head.

Bell smiled faintly.

"Besides, I don't think I would've fit."

Finn chuckled.

"That much has become obvious."

Hestia puffed her cheeks.

"Of course he doesn't fit with them."

Loki laughed.

"You're still claiming him?"

Hestia immediately pointed at Bell.

"He's mine!"

Bell sighed.

"Please don't say it like that."

The surrounding adventurers laughed.

Even Finn smiled.

But Bell's eyes drifted toward Bete.

The werewolf was still unconscious.

Bell's expression became thoughtful.

That could have ended much worse.

He looked toward the sky.

The night had become strangely quiet.

Then Bell heard a voice beside him.

"Bell."

He turned.

Ais stood there.

She looked at him with the same unreadable expression.

"You've changed."

Bell stared at her.

"Have I?"

Ais nodded.

"Yes."

She paused.

"You're stronger."

Bell smiled.

"Maybe."

Ais looked toward the Hostess.

Then back toward Bell.

"Will you fight us again?"

Bell thought about it.

"Hopefully not."

Ais tilted her head.

"Why?"

"Because I was supposed to be having dinner."

For the first time that night—

Ais smiled.

Just barely.

Bell looked at her.

Then at the destroyed street.

Then at the unconscious werewolf.

He sighed.

"Can I at least finish my meal?"

From the entrance of the Hostess, Hestia shouted—

"YES!"

Loki shouted immediately afterward—

"NO!"

Bell closed his eyes.

This city is exhausting.

And somewhere behind him, Finn quietly watched the young man who had once declined Loki Familia.

The captain's expression became thoughtful.

Because one thing had become painfully obvious.

The so-called Spectre wasn't merely strong.

He was learning.

And that was far more dangerous.

Worked for 8s

Chapter Twenty-Seven: Uproar

The Guild had never been this quiet.

Not because there were no people inside.

There were too many.

Adventurers, merchants, Guild employees, gods, executives of various Familias, and even representatives from organizations that normally had little reason to involve themselves in the affairs of a single adventurer.

All of them had gathered because of one name.

Bell Cranel.

An incident had occurred.

And rather than allowing rumors to spread through Orario unchecked, the Guild had launched a joint investigation.

The accusations were serious.

Concealment.

Falna modification.

Unlawful aggression.

Bell had been informed of the charges.

He had not resisted.

He had not attempted to flee.

He had simply listened.

Then, when the Guild officials came to escort him away, Bell calmly extended his hands.

"I'll cooperate."

The Guild employee looked almost surprised.

"You understand that you're being detained?"

"Yes."

"And you understand that these accusations could carry serious consequences?"

"I understand."

Bell lowered his gaze.

"I haven't committed any of those crimes."

The employee hesitated.

"Then why cooperate?"

Bell looked toward the gathered crowd.

"Because if I'm innocent, there's no reason for me to run."

His voice remained calm.

"Let the investigation prove it."

The trial was held on neutral ground.

A place where no Familia could claim authority over another.

And, perhaps most importantly, a place where the gods could be questioned without the proceedings becoming a simple argument between rival Familias.

The chosen deity was Hermes.

The moment Hermes stepped forward, the murmuring crowd gradually fell silent.

Hermes looked unusually serious.

"This investigation concerns three primary allegations."

He raised one finger.

"First, concealment."

A second finger.

"Second, unlawful alteration or modification of Falna."

A third.

"And finally, unlawful aggression."

Bell stood at the center of the room.

He did not look nervous.

He did not look angry.

He simply listened.

Hermes turned toward him.

"Bell Cranel, do you understand the charges?"

"I do."

"Do you intend to contest them?"

"I'll answer whatever I'm asked."

A few gods exchanged glances.

That answer was neither defiant nor submissive.

It was simply practical.

Hermes smiled faintly.

"Very well."

He turned toward the gathered gods.

"Let us begin with the Falna."

A goddess immediately spoke.

"The boy's growth is abnormal."

Another deity followed.

"Not merely abnormal. Suspicious."

"He rose too quickly."

"His abilities don't correspond with his recorded experience."

"There are discrepancies."

"Then the question is obvious."

A god leaned forward.

"Was his Falna altered?"

The room became tense.

Hermes raised his hand.

"That is precisely what must be established."

He looked toward Hestia.

"Hestia."

Hestia stiffened.

"Yes?"

"Did you modify Bell Cranel's Falna?"

"No!"

Her answer came instantly.

"I never did anything like that!"

Several gods began talking at once.

"Of course she would deny it."

"She has every reason to."

"Enough."

Hermes's voice cut through the room.

"Let us approach this logically."

He turned toward the assembled gods.

"Every god here knows that Arcanum cannot simply be hidden from another god's perception."

The room quieted.

"If Hestia had deliberately manipulated Bell's Falna using divine power, another god capable of perceiving Arcanum would have noticed."

Hermes looked toward Hestia.

"Furthermore, when Hestia first recruited Bell, was there any suspicious activity?"

"No."

The answer came from several deities almost simultaneously.

Hermes nodded.

"Then the accusation of Falna modification lacks sufficient evidence."

One god frowned.

"That doesn't explain his growth."

"No," Hermes replied.

"But it does mean that we cannot simply declare Hestia guilty because his growth is unusual."

Bell remained silent.

His eyes moved across the room.

Gods.

Familia leaders.

Adventurers.

Every one of them wanted something.

Some wanted answers.

Some wanted control.

Some were simply curious.

And some were afraid.

Bell understood that much.

They're not really judging whether I broke a rule.

They're trying to determine what I am.

Hermes continued.

"Then we move to the second matter."

He looked directly at Bell.

"Concealment."

The atmosphere changed.

This accusation carried more weight.

A god spoke.

"During the Dark Ages, foreign adventurers deliberately concealed their levels."

Another added:

"They infiltrated Familias."

"They caused internal conflicts."

"They provided information to dark factions."

"They deliberately concealed their strength to destabilize Orario."

A third deity slammed a hand against the table.

"That precedent cannot be ignored!"

Bell finally spoke.

"Why?"

The room fell silent.

The god looked at him.

"What did you say?"

Bell raised his head.

"Why would you care if I do so?"

Several gods frowned.

Bell continued.

"Does it change anything?"

He looked around the room.

"If I am a higher level than someone else, what does revealing it accomplish?"

No one answered.

Bell continued.

"Suppose I'm stronger than them."

His voice remained even.

"Then what happens?"

"They become cautious."

"They become afraid."

"They change how they treat me."

"And if I reveal everything I can do?"

Bell paused.

"Then every deity gains information about me."

His eyes narrowed slightly.

"My strengths."

"My weaknesses."

"My abilities."

"My habits."

"Everything."

A god interrupted.

"That is precisely why concealment is suspicious."

Bell turned toward him.

"No."

His answer was immediate.

"It's precisely why concealment is reasonable."

A murmur spread through the room.

Bell continued.

"Why would I reveal my true level if doing so only makes things more complicated?"

He folded his arms.

"If I'm a level higher than them, it's going to get dirty."

His gaze moved from god to god.

"People will compare themselves to me."

"Familias will compare themselves to each other."

"Some will challenge me."

"Some will try to recruit me."

"And some will try to eliminate me."

Bell's expression hardened.

"But if I reveal my true level, what happens next?"

No one spoke.

Bell answered his own question.

"That deity's Familia will be pressured to publicly reveal their own adventurers' Falna."

Several gods immediately began whispering.

Bell continued.

"And then everyone knows."

"Everyone knows who is strong."

"Everyone knows who is weak."

"Everyone knows what abilities they possess."

"Everyone knows who they can defeat."

"And who they can't."

He slowly exhaled.

"So tell me."

Bell looked directly at the gods.

"Why would I voluntarily create that situation?"

Silence.

Hermes watched him carefully.

Bell's thoughts continued.

They're afraid of what they don't know.

But revealing everything would only give them more reasons to interfere.

Information is power.

And I don't intend to hand mine over for free.

One god finally spoke.

"Then you admit that you are concealing something."

Bell answered calmly.

"I admit that I value privacy."

The god narrowed his eyes.

"Those are not the same thing."

"No."

Bell smiled faintly.

"They aren't."

The gods discussed among themselves.

The room became louder.

Some demanded Bell's Falna be revealed.

Others argued that forcing him to reveal everything would violate the very principles they claimed to uphold.

Eventually, Hermes raised his hand.

"There is another method."

Everyone looked toward him.

"Lie detection."

Bell's eyes shifted slightly.

A few gods nodded.

"Effective."

"Reliable against mortals."

"If he is lying, we'll know."

Bell said nothing.

A deity stepped forward.

"Bell Cranel."

The god's voice carried divine authority.

"State your level."

Bell looked at him.

"Level Two."

The god waited.

Nothing happened.

Another deity attempted to determine whether Bell was lying.

Again, nothing.

The gods exchanged confused glances.

Hermes frowned.

"Interesting."

Bell simply stood there.

Hermes looked at him.

"When did you reach Level Two?"

"Recently."

"How?"

Bell answered plainly.

"After defeating the Minotaur."

A god immediately asked:

"What level was the Minotaur?"

"Level Two."

The room became quiet.

That answer made sense.

A Level Two adventurer defeating a Level Two monster was unusual only in the normal sense of adventuring.

It was not the impossible mystery everyone had expected.

Hermes's expression changed.

"Then that isn't the mystery."

Bell looked at him.

Hermes slowly turned toward the gathered gods.

"The Minotaur was Level Two."

His eyes returned to Bell.

"So the question remains..."

He paused.

"How did a Level Two adventurer defeat Bete Loga?"

The room erupted.

"Exactly!"

"That's the problem!"

"That is impossible!"

"He's Level Two!"

"Bete is Level Five!"

Bell remained completely still.

The shouting continued around him.

But inside his mind, everything became quiet.

So that's what they're really interested in.

Not the Minotaur.

Not my level.

Bete.

Bell remembered the battle.

The speed.

The pressure.

The overwhelming difference in physical ability.

Bete had been faster.

Stronger.

More experienced.

Bell had known that from the beginning.

I couldn't overpower him.

So I didn't try.

Hermes stared at him.

"How?"

Bell finally answered.

"I didn't defeat him through strength."

The room quieted.

Bell continued.

"I made the fight one he couldn't win."

Hermes's eyes narrowed.

"And how did you accomplish that?"

Bell looked toward him.

"I changed the conditions."

A god scoffed.

"That doesn't explain anything."

Bell's gaze shifted toward him.

"It explains everything."

He paused.

"Bete was stronger than me."

"Faster than me."

"More experienced than me."

"If I fought him according to his rules, I would lose."

Bell's expression became colder.

"So I changed the rules."

Hermes stared at him for several seconds.

"And that..."

He slowly smiled.

"...is precisely what we are trying to understand."

The final accusation remained.

Unlawful aggression.

Bell was accused of initiating the confrontation with Bete.

Bell denied it.

"I didn't start the fight."

One god immediately challenged him.

"You expect us to believe that?"

"Yes."

"You fought a Level Five adventurer."

"He attacked first."

"And yet you continued fighting."

Bell nodded.

"Yes."

"Then you admit to engaging in combat."

"I admit to defending myself."

The god leaned forward.

"You could have surrendered."

Bell's eyes sharpened.

"And let him continue?"

Silence.

Bell continued.

"There were people around us."

Hermes listened carefully.

"I moved the fight away from the crowd."

"Why?"

"Because if we fought there, people would get hurt."

A god frowned.

"You could have simply fled."

Bell shook his head.

"I tried."

The room became silent again.

Bell continued.

"But running wasn't enough."

He looked down briefly.

"Bete was faster."

His hands tightened slightly.

"If I stayed near the crowd, someone would eventually be caught between us."

"So I moved."

"Again and again."

"Until there was enough distance."

Bell looked toward the gods.

"I didn't want spectators."

"I didn't want casualties."

"And I didn't want anyone else involved."

One god spoke.

"Then how did you defeat him?"

Bell was silent for a moment.

Then he answered.

"I didn't."

Several gods frowned.

"What?"

Bell raised his eyes.

"I didn't defeat him by overpowering him."

He paused.

"He exhausted himself."

A murmur spread throughout the room.

Bell continued.

"He had the advantage in almost everything."

"Speed."

"Strength."

"Experience."

"But there was one thing he couldn't ignore."

Hermes leaned forward.

"What?"

Bell answered quietly.

"Air."

The room fell completely silent.

Bell continued.

"I forced the battle into conditions where his own strength became irrelevant."

"Bete could hit harder than me."

"He could move faster than me."

"He could react faster than me."

"But none of that mattered if he couldn't breathe."

A god stared at him.

"So you're saying..."

"Yes."

Bell nodded.

"He lost because he ran out of air."

Another deity slammed their hand against the table.

"That's absurd!"

"No."

Bell's voice remained calm.

"It's simply not a contest of strength."

The deity glared at him.

Bell continued.

"You wanted to know how a Level Two defeated a Level Five."

He looked around the room.

"I didn't."

"I never defeated a Level Five through raw strength."

"I survived him."

"I adapted."

"I changed the battlefield."

"And eventually, his body reached its limit."

Hermes remained silent.

The gods whispered among themselves.

Some looked disturbed.

Others looked fascinated.

A few looked genuinely afraid.

Bell watched them.

They wanted to know whether I was hiding strength.

But that's the wrong question.

Strength isn't always about how much power you have.

Sometimes it's about whether you can force someone stronger than you to fight a battle they were never prepared to fight.

Hermes finally stood.

The room slowly quieted.

"After reviewing the evidence..."

He looked toward Bell.

"The charge of Falna modification is unsupported."

He raised his voice.

"The charge of concealment is likewise insufficient to establish wrongdoing."

A pause.

"And regarding unlawful aggression..."

Hermes looked toward the records.

"The evidence indicates that Bell Cranel did not initiate the confrontation."

Several gods protested.

Hermes continued over them.

"Furthermore, his movement away from the populated area reduced the risk of civilian casualties."

The room quieted again.

"His subsequent actions constituted self-defense."

Hermes looked directly at Bell.

"Therefore..."

He paused.

"Bell Cranel is not guilty."

The words echoed through the chamber.

For several seconds, nobody moved.

Bell simply closed his eyes.

A quiet breath escaped him.

It's over.

Or at least...

This part is.

He opened his eyes.

Across the room, the gods were still staring at him.

Not like a criminal anymore.

Not exactly.

Something had changed.

They were looking at him as though he were a question.

A question none of them had an answer to.

Bell slowly turned away.

And somewhere among the gathered gods, one deity whispered:

"Level Two..."

Another answered quietly.

"Yes."

"Then what exactly is that boy?"

Bell stopped for half a second.

He heard them.

He didn't turn around.

A faint smile appeared on his face.

That's the question, isn't it?

Chapter Twenty-Eight: Break

For the first time in several days, Bell Cranel did nothing.

He simply sat on the edge of his bed.

The room was quiet.

Too quiet.

Bell stared at the wall in front of him, his crimson eyes fixed upon a spot that did not exist.

His mind, however, refused to be still.

What exactly did I lose?

The question had been circling his thoughts ever since the trial ended.

Privacy.

That was the obvious answer.

His movements had been watched. His abilities had been exposed. People had begun to take an interest in him, and Bell had learned something rather unpleasant about the world.

Once people knew you were valuable, they stopped treating you like a person.

They treated you like an opportunity.

Bell slowly exhaled.

"I hate this."

He leaned backward, allowing himself to fall onto the bed.

The ceiling stared back at him.

For once, he did not immediately begin calculating.

He did not analyze his enemies.

He did not think about the Dungeon.

He did not think about Familia politics.

He did not think about improving his magic.

He simply lay there.

I need a break.

Not because he was tired.

At least, not entirely.

He was tired of constantly reacting.

Every time he solved one problem, another appeared.

Every time he gained an advantage, someone found a way to threaten it.

If I keep moving like this, eventually I'll make a mistake.

And Bell hated making mistakes.

His eyes slowly closed.

"One week."

He opened them again.

"One week to think."

A faint smile appeared on his face.

"Not a vacation."

He sat up.

"A strategic retreat."

Day One

Bell slept.

He slept longer than usual.

Then he ate.

Then he slept again.

Hestia noticed immediately.

"Bell!"

The door burst open.

Bell, who had been lying on the couch doing absolutely nothing, slowly turned his head.

"Hm?"

"You've been lying there for hours!"

"Yes."

"You're supposed to be training!"

"No."

Hestia froze.

"No?"

Bell shook his head.

"I've decided to take a break."

Hestia stared at him.

"Are you sick?"

"No."

"Did someone curse you?"

"No."

"Did you hit your head?"

Bell gave her a blank expression.

"No."

Hestia narrowed her eyes.

"Then who are you and what did you do to my Bell?"

Bell sighed.

"I just need time."

Hestia's expression softened.

"Oh."

Bell looked away.

"I've been reacting to everything around me. I need to stop and decide what I want to do next."

There was a moment of silence.

Then Hestia smiled.

"Okay."

Bell blinked.

"That's it?"

"What else am I supposed to say?"

"I expected an argument."

"You're allowed to rest, you know."

Bell looked at her.

Hestia crossed her arms.

"Just don't turn one week into one month."

"I won't."

"And don't forget to eat."

"I won't."

"And don't experiment with anything dangerous inside the house."

Bell paused.

"...I'll try."

"Bell."

"Fine."

Hestia smiled.

"Good."

Bell leaned back against the couch.

For the first time in a long while, he allowed himself to breathe.

Day Two

Bell began working.

Not training.

Not fighting.

Designing.

He spread sheets of paper across the table.

Diagrams covered the surface.

Human anatomy.

Magic circuits.

Magical energy flow.

Structural composition.

Falna compatibility.

A rough sketch of a humanoid body sat at the center.

Bell stared at it.

"The replica..."

His fingers tapped against the table.

"The mistake was treating it like another Bell."

He crossed out several lines.

"No."

Another line.

"It's not supposed to replace me."

He drew a second figure.

"It's supposed to take my place when someone thinks they're attacking me."

His eyes sharpened.

"A decoy."

That single realization changed everything.

The replica did not need to be Bell.

It only needed to **look** like Bell.

It needed to behave enough like him to fool someone watching from a distance.

And most importantly—

Bell himself needed to remain somewhere else.

If they attack the clone, they think they've found me.

His pencil stopped.

But I'm not there.

A dangerous smile slowly appeared.

"That's much better."

Day Three

The next problem was obvious.

Falna.

Bell stared at the unfinished replica.

It possessed a body.

It possessed a magical core.

It possessed an artificial structure that could imitate his appearance.

But could it possess a Falna?

Bell looked toward Hestia.

"Can you put a Falna on it?"

Hestia nearly dropped the cup in her hand.

"On that?"

"Yes."

"Bell, that's a magical construct!"

"I know."

"That's not how Falna works."

"I know."

"Then why are you asking me?"

"Because I don't know either."

Hestia stared at him.

Bell smiled innocently.

She sighed.

"You really are troublesome."

"I've been told that."

Hestia approached the replica.

She placed her hand against its back.

"All right."

Bell's expression became serious.

"If this fails—"

"It won't hurt?"

"I don't know."

Hestia immediately looked at him.

"Bell!"

"I'm being honest."

"That's not reassuring!"

Bell stepped backward.

"Just try."

Hestia sighed.

"Fine."

The ritual began.

Divine power flowed.

The room became strangely quiet.

Bell watched every fluctuation of energy.

The artificial body trembled.

The magic stone inside its chest pulsed.

Then—

Something changed.

Bell's eyes widened.

The replica opened its eyes.

Hestia stared.

"...It worked."

Bell immediately approached.

"What happened?"

"I don't know."

"Check the Falna."

Hestia examined it.

Her expression became increasingly confused.

"Bell..."

"What?"

"It has a skill."

Bell froze.

"A skill?"

Hestia nodded slowly.

"It appears to be passive."

"What does it do?"

Hestia looked at the status.

Then back at Bell.

"It copies your physical parameters."

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"How much?"

"Approximately eighty percent."

Bell became silent.

"And magic?"

"Half."

He stared at the replica.

Eighty percent of his physical abilities.

Half of his magical capabilities.

Bell slowly smiled.

"Interesting."

Hestia did not smile.

"There is a problem."

"Of course there is."

"The body isn't stable."

Bell looked toward the replica.

"What happens?"

"Four hours."

"Only four?"

"After that, the artificial body begins to collapse."

Bell's smile disappeared.

"Then it returns to its original state?"

"No."

Hestia shook her head.

"It dissolves."

Bell stared at the clone.

Four hours.

Too short.

He walked around it.

Examined its joints.

Its magical circuits.

Its core.

He touched the magic stone embedded within its chest.

"Everything is functioning."

"Yes."

"Then why four hours?"

"The body is consuming energy to maintain its existence."

Bell's eyes sharpened.

"Then the problem isn't the body."

Hestia tilted her head.

"What?"

"The core."

Day Four

Bell barely slept.

He spent the entire night working.

Notes accumulated across the table.

Failed calculations were thrown onto the floor.

Several magical circuits were redesigned.

The replica collapsed twice.

The third attempt lasted only three hours and forty-seven minutes.

Bell stared at it.

"Progress."

Hestia, half asleep nearby, raised her head.

"That's your definition of progress?"

"It lasted twenty minutes longer."

"Bell..."

"I'm getting somewhere."

"You need sleep."

"I'll sleep after I solve this."

"You said that six hours ago."

Bell ignored her.

His attention remained on the magic stone.

The body isn't consuming Mind.

It's consuming the core itself.

That was the weakness.

The magic stone was not merely supplying energy.

It was acting as an anchor.

It was constantly compensating for the contradiction of an artificial body existing without natural life.

Bell's fingers tightened around his pen.

"What if..."

He stopped.

His eyes widened.

"What if I reinforce the core?"

Hestia looked up.

"With what?"

Bell looked at the pile of potions and magical materials.

Then he looked at his own hands.

"Mind."

Hestia's expression changed.

"Bell, don't—"

"I can replenish it."

"That's not the point."

Bell stood.

He walked toward the clone.

"I don't need to make the body more efficient."

His hand rested against the magic stone.

"I need to make the core stronger."

Day Five

The experiment began at dawn.

Bell poured an enormous amount of Mind into the magic stone.

The room filled with light.

The replica's body trembled violently.

Hestia shielded her eyes.

"Bell!"

"Don't interrupt!"

"The energy is fluctuating!"

"I know!"

"You're going to overload it!"

"I know!"

The magic stone cracked.

Bell's eyes widened.

Too much.

He immediately adjusted the flow.

The energy compressed.

Again.

Again.

Again.

The crack disappeared.

The light became brighter.

The artificial body began to dissolve.

Bell's heart stopped.

"No..."

The clone's arms broke apart into particles.

Its chest disappeared.

Its head began to fade.

Bell gritted his teeth.

I failed.

Then—

The particles stopped.

They began moving toward the magic stone.

Hestia stared.

"Bell..."

The fragments condensed.

The magic stone pulsed.

Once.

Twice.

Then—

BOOM.

A brilliant flash filled the room.

Bell raised his arm to shield his eyes.

The light slowly faded.

Silence.

Bell lowered his arm.

Standing in front of him...

was himself.

Not an imitation.

Not a rough replica.

Not a humanoid construct.

Bell Cranel.

The same silver-white hair.

The same crimson eyes.

The same face.

The same height.

The same expression.

The clone looked down at its hands.

Then slowly raised its head.

Bell stared.

The clone stared back.

Neither spoke.

Hestia's mouth hung open.

"...Bell?"

The clone looked at her.

"Yes?"

Bell froze.

Hestia froze.

The original Bell slowly pointed at himself.

"Who are you?"

The clone looked at him.

"I believe I am your replica."

Bell's expression became completely blank.

"...You can talk."

"Apparently."

Hestia slowly walked around them.

"There's two Bells."

Bell looked at the clone.

The clone looked back.

"Apparently."

Hestia's face twitched.

"Stop saying apparently!"

Both Bells looked at her simultaneously.

Hestia screamed.

Day Six

The clone did not disappear.

One hour passed.

Then two.

Then four.

Eight.

Twelve.

Nothing happened.

Bell checked the magical structure again.

Still stable.

He checked the core.

Stable.

He checked the body's magical circulation.

Stable.

Finally, he sat down.

"This shouldn't be possible."

The clone sat across from him.

"Yet it is."

Bell stared at him.

"You have your own thoughts."

"Yes."

"Your own judgment?"

"I believe so."

"Can you disobey me?"

The clone paused.

"I don't know."

Bell frowned.

"Try."

The clone looked at him.

"No."

Bell blinked.

"...What?"

"I don't want to."

Bell leaned back.

"So you can."

"I suppose."

Bell became silent.

That answer bothered him.

It was not a machine.

It was not simply following instructions.

It was thinking.

I didn't create another body.

He looked at the clone.

I created another me.

For several minutes, Bell said nothing.

Then the clone spoke.

"Are you afraid?"

Bell looked up.

"...Yes."

"Of me?"

Bell shook his head.

"No."

He looked toward the floor.

"Of what I might have created."

The clone considered his words.

"Then perhaps you should not use me."

Bell smiled faintly.

"That's not going to happen."

The clone smiled back.

"I expected as much."

Day Seven

Bell began testing.

Walking.

Talking.

Eating.

Fighting.

Casting magic.

Reading.

Reacting to sudden attacks.

The results were disturbing.

The clone could imitate Bell's mannerisms.

It could learn.

It could improvise.

It could make decisions.

And more importantly—

it could pass as Bell.

Bell stood behind a wall while the clone walked through the streets.

Nobody noticed.

Nobody questioned it.

Even people who knew Bell did not immediately realize anything was wrong.

Bell watched from a distance.

Perfect.

Then another thought occurred to him.

He returned to Hestia.

"Can the gods detect it?"

Hestia frowned.

"What do you mean?"

"The lie detector."

Hestia understood immediately.

Her expression became serious.

"I don't think so."

"Why?"

"Because..."

She looked at the clone.

"It isn't technically alive."

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"Exactly."

A small smile appeared.

"Then it can bypass them."

Hestia stared at Bell.

"You're really going to use this."

Bell looked toward the clone.

His expression became calm.

"I have to."

The clone stood beside him.

"Why?"

Bell answered without hesitation.

"Because they're already looking for me."

He looked at the pages scattered across the table.

Days of work.

Failed designs.

Broken prototypes.

Countless calculations.

All of it had led to this.

The first true breakthrough.

But Bell knew better than anyone that a breakthrough was not the same as a finished product.

The clone still needed adjustments.

Its behavior had to be refined.

Its combat instincts needed calibration.

Its magical output needed to be controlled.

Its memories needed limits.

Its personality needed to be carefully managed.

And there was one question Bell still hadn't answered.

How far can I make it resemble me without making it another person entirely?

Bell looked at his duplicate.

The clone looked back.

Two identical crimson eyes met.

Bell slowly stood.

"Tomorrow, we start again."

The clone nodded.

"Understood."

Bell gathered his papers.

He looked exhausted.

But his eyes were alive again.

For the first time since the trial, he no longer felt like he was merely reacting to the world.

He was building something.

Something that could give him distance.

Something that could take risks in his place.

Something that could walk into danger while the real Bell remained hidden.

A decoy.

A shield.

A second face.

Bell glanced toward the window.

The sun was setting over Orario.

I'm running out of time.

His hand tightened around the papers.

So I'll just have to become faster.

Behind him, the clone stood perfectly still.

Waiting.

Watching.

Learning.

And neither Bell nor Hestia noticed the most important change.

The clone had begun to wonder what it meant to be **Bell Cranel**.

And that question—

was going to become a problem later.

Worked for 9s

Chapter Twenty-Nine: Turing Test

Bell had made many questionable decisions in his life.

Walking into the Dungeon without proper preparation.

Trusting people who probably shouldn't have been trusted.

Challenging opponents vastly stronger than himself.

And, apparently, creating a perfect duplicate of himself and then deciding to let it walk around Orario unsupervised for an entire day.

That last one was quickly climbing the list.

Bell stood on the rooftop, watching the figure below.

His figure.

The same white hair.

The same red eyes.

The same face.

The same body.

The same mana signature.

Even the same faint habit of tilting his head whenever he encountered something unfamiliar.

The only difference was that Bell knew exactly what the creature was.

A copy.

A vessel constructed from his own existence.

And Bell wanted to know something.

How much of him was actually inside it?

"Just one day," Bell muttered.

The clone looked up.

Their eyes met.

"You're sure about this?" the original Bell asked.

"Yes."

"You won't leave the city?"

"I have no reason to."

"You won't enter the Dungeon?"

"Not unless necessary."

"You won't start any trouble?"

The clone thought about it.

"...What constitutes trouble?"

Bell's eye twitched.

"Forget I asked."

The clone nodded.

Bell exhaled.

This should be fine.

It was not fine.

Not remotely.

The First Hour

The clone stepped into the street.

For several seconds, it simply stood there.

People passed around him.

Carriages rolled by.

Adventurers shouted to one another.

Shopkeepers called out their prices.

The smell of freshly baked bread drifted through the morning air.

The clone slowly looked left.

Then right.

It looked up at the sky.

Then down at its own hands.

Bell watched from several rooftops away.

What is it doing?

The clone remained motionless for another five seconds.

Then—

It walked right.

Bell blinked.

"...That's it?"

The clone entered a small café.

Bell followed.

The clone sat by the window.

A waitress approached.

"Good morning! What can I get you?"

The clone looked at the menu.

"Latte."

"Coming right up."

A few minutes later, a steaming cup was placed before him.

The clone picked it up.

Took a sip.

Its eyes widened slightly.

"...Good."

Bell stared.

It likes coffee?

Of course it did.

Bell liked coffee.

That realization somehow made the entire situation worse.

The clone continued drinking.

When it finished, it paid the bill.

"Thank you," the waitress said.

The clone nodded.

"You're welcome."

Then it left.

Bell followed.

Nothing happened.

No incident.

No abnormal behavior.

No attempt at world domination.

No sudden declaration of independence.

Nothing.

For the next several hours, the clone simply wandered.

It bought bread.

Watched a street performer.

Stopped to examine an antique sword.

Helped a merchant move a crate.

Then—

A scream.

"HELP!"

Bell's head snapped toward the sound.

A carriage had lost control.

A little girl stood frozen in the middle of the road.

The horse charged forward.

The clone moved.

It didn't think.

It simply disappeared.

A burst of mana erupted beneath its feet.

The clone appeared in front of the girl and scooped her into its arms.

The carriage passed within inches.

The clone landed safely.

The girl stared at him.

"Are you okay?"

She nodded.

The clone gently placed her down.

"Then go to your mother."

The girl's mother came running.

"Thank you! Thank you so much!"

The clone smiled.

"You're welcome."

Bell remained frozen on the rooftop.

His eyes narrowed.

That wasn't instinct.

It was.

But not merely instinct.

The clone had Bell's memories.

Bell knew what kind of person he was.

He knew how he would react to danger.

The clone had inherited that information.

But something else had come with it.

Intent.

Memories told the clone what Bell had done.

Intent told it why.

And that distinction was dangerous.

Very dangerous.

By noon, the clone seemed to have lost direction.

It wandered through the streets.

He stopped at a fountain.

Sat on a bench.

Watched children play.

Then noticed an elderly woman struggling with a basket.

He stood.

"Allow me."

"Oh, thank you, young man."

He carried it across the street.

Afterward, he stood there.

Thinking.

Bell watched from across the street.

The clone looked around.

Then sighed.

"I need something to do."

Bell frowned.

Something to do?

The clone's eyes wandered.

Then stopped.

A familiar green-haired elf was standing outside the Hostess of Fertility.

She was sweeping the entrance.

Bell's blood ran cold.

"No."

The clone started walking.

"No, no, no..."

The clone approached Ryuu.

Ryuu looked up.

"Welcome. If you're looking for a meal, we're not yet—"

"Ryuu."

She stopped.

Her ears twitched.

"You know my name?"

"Yes."

"Have we met?"

"Not directly."

Ryuu narrowed her eyes.

"Then how do you know me?"

The clone stared at her.

For a moment, he said nothing.

Then—

"I would like to ask you something."

Ryuu lowered the broom.

"What is it?"

"Would you go on a date with me?"

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Even the street seemed to stop.

Bell's soul left his body.

"...What?"

Ryuu stared.

The broom slipped from her fingers.

Clack.

She didn't move.

The clone remained completely calm.

Bell, meanwhile, was having a crisis.

WHY?!

The answer came immediately.

Because Bell liked Ryuu.

Not merely because she was beautiful.

Not because she was an elf.

Bell admired her.

Her sense of justice.

Her discipline.

Her kindness buried underneath years of pain.

Her determination to protect others despite believing herself unworthy of forgiveness.

Those feelings existed inside Bell.

The clone had inherited them.

But the clone didn't understand the distinction between admiration, affection, gratitude, and romantic attraction.

It had simply processed the information.

Bell likes Ryuu.

Therefore—

Ask Ryuu on a date.

Ryuu's face slowly turned red.

"You..."

She pointed at him.

"Are you serious?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

The clone answered honestly.

"I like you."

Ryuu's face became even redder.

"You cannot simply say something like that!"

"Why not?"

"Because!"

She opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Opened it again.

Nothing came out.

The clone waited patiently.

Ryuu suddenly turned around.

"I... need time to prepare."

"Prepare?"

"For this."

She stormed through the doors of the Hostess.

The door slammed shut.

Bell stared.

"...Prepare?"

The original Bell covered his face.

"Oh, I'm dead."

One hour later—

The door opened.

Ryuu stepped outside.

Bell nearly fell off the roof.

She was wearing a beautiful dress.

Nothing extravagant.

It was elegant, modest, and suited her perfectly.

Her long green hair was brushed carefully.

She looked nervous.

Very nervous.

But she had clearly made an effort.

The clone stared at her.

"You look beautiful."

Ryuu's cheeks turned pink.

"Thank you."

She looked at him.

Then frowned.

"...You're wearing the same clothes."

The clone looked down.

He was wearing his normal adventurer attire.

"That is correct."

Ryuu sighed.

"A date requires some effort."

The clone tilted his head.

Then mana flowed around him.

Bell's eyes widened.

The fabric shifted.

Threads rearranged themselves.

His clothing changed.

Within seconds, he stood before Ryuu in a black suit.

Ryuu blinked.

"...What?"

"I learned how to manipulate mana through clothing."

She stared.

"That is... not normal."

"I am aware."

Ryuu sighed.

"Well."

She looked him over.

"...It suits you."

"Thank you."

From the rooftop, Bell wanted to scream.

STOP BEING SO CASUAL ABOUT THIS!

The Date

Orario was beautiful that afternoon.

The sunlight poured between the enormous buildings.

The Tower of Babel rose above the city like a spear piercing the heavens.

Merchants filled the streets.

Adventurers passed in groups.

Children chased one another through the plazas.

Music drifted through the air.

For the first time, Ryuu wasn't walking as an employee of the Hostess.

She wasn't an adventurer.

She wasn't a warrior.

She was simply—

Ryuu.

And beside her walked Bell.

Or something that looked like Bell.

They visited food stalls.

The clone bought her grilled meat.

Then fruit.

Then a strange pastry neither of them recognized.

Ryuu took one bite.

Her expression became serious.

"...I don't like it."

The clone took the pastry.

"I'll finish it."

"You don't have to."

"I don't mind."

She smiled.

"You're strange."

"So I've been told."

They walked onward.

Eventually, they encountered a group of children playing with wooden swords.

One child pointed at Bell.

"Hey! Mister!"

The clone stopped.

"Yes?"

"Are you an adventurer?"

"Yes."

"Fight me!"

Ryuu covered her mouth.

The clone looked at the wooden sword.

Then at the child.

"Very well."

The next few minutes were chaos.

The children surrounded him.

The clone deliberately moved slowly.

He allowed them to strike him.

He dramatically fell backward.

The children erupted into laughter.

Ryuu watched from the side.

She smiled.

A genuine smile.

"You really are kind."

The clone looked at her.

"Was that in my memories?"

Ryuu's smile faded slightly.

"What?"

"My kindness."

She stared at him.

"I don't understand."

"I am trying to determine which parts of me are genuine."

Ryuu became quiet.

The clone looked at the children.

"I remember helping people."

He touched his chest.

"I remember wanting to help them."

Then he looked at Ryuu.

"But I don't know if I want those things because they are mine..."

He paused.

"...or because they belonged to him."

Ryuu understood.

Perhaps not completely.

But enough.

"You are still choosing what to do now."

The clone looked at her.

Ryuu smiled gently.

"Doesn't that make it yours?"

For the first time that day—

The clone had no immediate answer.

Later, a traveling band passed through the street.

Music filled the evening air.

The clone and Ryuu stopped to listen.

The melody was slow.

Beautiful.

Ryuu closed her eyes.

The wind carried her hair across her face.

Bell watched from afar.

He felt something strange.

The clone looked peaceful.

Not artificial.

Not mechanical.

Peaceful.

Ryuu opened her eyes.

"You enjoy music?"

"I don't know."

"Then why are you smiling?"

The clone touched his face.

He was smiling.

"I suppose I do."

Ryuu laughed softly.

"Then perhaps you are learning."

"Learning what?"

"How to be yourself."

The clone stared at her.

Those words remained with him.

They walked again.

And eventually encountered something even stranger.

A green-haired swordsman.

He had three swords.

One at his waist.

One at his other side.

And one—

Bell stared.

"...Why is he holding one in his mouth?"

Ryuu stared too.

The swordsman looked at them.

"What?"

The clone blinked.

"Nothing."

The swordsman narrowed his eyes.

"You got a problem?"

"No."

"Then stop staring."

The swordsman walked away.

Ryuu looked at Bell.

"That was certainly unusual."

"Very."

"Three swords."

"Yes."

"One in his mouth."

"Yes."

"...Why?"

"I don't know."

Neither of them noticed the swordsman glance backward.

He muttered something about weird people before disappearing into the crowd.

Bell watched him go.

What the hell was that?

For once, the clone had no answer.

Dinner

Night settled over Orario.

The city transformed.

Lanterns illuminated the streets.

The Tower of Babel reflected the orange glow of the sunset.

They found a quiet restaurant overlooking one of the city's canals.

Ryuu sat across from him.

A candle burned between them.

For a while, neither spoke.

Then Ryuu smiled.

"Today was pleasant."

"I agree."

"You don't have to sound so formal."

"I am attempting to be polite."

"I noticed."

She laughed.

The sound was soft.

The clone watched her.

"You seem happier."

Ryuu's expression changed.

"Happier?"

"Yes."

"Perhaps I am."

"Why?"

She looked down at her hands.

"Because I haven't done this in a long time."

"Done what?"

"Simply enjoyed a day."

The clone remained silent.

Ryuu eventually began talking.

About the city.

About adventuring.

About the Hostess.

About her companions.

About the things she liked.

She carefully avoided certain subjects.

There were memories she did not wish to touch.

The clone noticed.

"You don't have to tell me everything."

Ryuu looked up.

"Why?"

"Because some memories hurt."

Her eyes widened slightly.

The clone smiled.

"I understand."

Ryuu stared at him.

"Do you?"

"No."

He paused.

"But I know what it is like to carry memories that don't feel like they belong entirely to you."

Ryuu lowered her gaze.

"...You really are strange."

"I know."

She smiled.

Then, quietly—

"Thank you."

Their food arrived.

They ate.

They talked.

They laughed.

For several hours, the impossible happened.

Ryuu forgot that something about this situation was wrong.

She simply saw Bell.

A young man sitting across from her.

Listening.

Smiling.

Asking questions.

And somehow making her feel safe.

Eventually, the restaurant began closing.

The clone stood.

"I'll escort you home."

Ryuu nodded.

The streets were quieter now.

Moonlight painted the city silver.

They walked side by side.

Neither rushed.

When they finally reached the Hostess of Fertility, Ryuu stopped.

"This is me."

"I know."

She smiled.

"Thank you for today."

"I enjoyed it."

"I did too."

Silence.

Ryuu looked at him.

There was something uncertain in her eyes.

Something hopeful.

Something frightening.

"Bell."

"Yes?"

"Will you ask me again?"

The clone stared.

"Ask what?"

Ryuu's cheeks turned pink.

"...For another date."

He smiled.

"Yes."

She smiled back.

"Then I'll see you again."

"Good night, Ryuu."

"Good night, Bell."

She entered the tavern.

The door closed.

The clone stood alone beneath the moonlight.

For several seconds, he simply watched the door.

Then—

"I think I understand."

Bell, watching from the rooftop, frowned.

"What?"

The clone looked up.

Straight at him.

"I understand why you like her."

Bell froze.

The clone smiled.

"But I think..."

He looked toward the closed door.

"...I like her too."

Bell's expression went blank.

The clone turned and walked away.

Bell remained on the rooftop.

Completely motionless.

Then he slowly covered his face.

"...Yup."

He looked toward the moon.

"Original Bell..."

A long silence followed.

"...You're cooked."

And somewhere below, behind the closed doors of the Hostess of Fertility—

Ryuu was smiling.

Unaware that the person she had just gone on a date with had never existed before.

And unaware of the far more terrifying question waiting for Bell.

Because the test had never really been—

"Can the clone imitate Bell?"

It was—

"If the clone possesses Bell's memories, Bell's instincts, Bell's emotions, and Bell's intentions...

then which one of them is the original?"

Worked for 16s

Chapter Thirty: Divination

Bell sat in silence.

For several minutes, he did absolutely nothing.

He simply stared at the person sitting across from him.

The person stared back.

Same white hair.

Same red eyes.

Same face.

Same posture.

Same expression.

If Bell didn't know better, he would have sworn he was looking into a mirror.

Except mirrors didn't breathe.

And they certainly didn't look back.

Bell slowly exhaled.

“...This is going to be troublesome.”

The clone tilted its head.

“Troublesome?”

Bell froze.

He had forgotten that the clone could speak.

“Not you,” Bell muttered. “The situation.”

“I see.”

Bell rubbed his forehead.

I really created another me.

Even after everything that had happened, the reality still hadn't completely settled in his mind.

A second Bell existed.

A living, breathing copy capable of thinking, speaking, fighting, and acting independently.

And now Bell had to figure out how to use that fact without turning Orario into chaos.

He leaned back against the wall.

“Let's think practically.”

The clone nodded.

Bell grabbed a piece of parchment and began writing.

“First, we need a routine.”

“A routine?”

“Yes.”

He wrote several lines.

“Morning. Dungeon.”

The clone glanced at the parchment.

“Then?”

“You dive into the Dungeon.”

“Until?”

“Until you've completed whatever objective we've assigned.”

“And afterward?”

Bell continued writing.

“Guild. Report your progress. Sell magic stones. Handle any errands that need to be done.”

The clone nodded.

“Then return home.”

“That sounds simple.”

“It is.”

Bell stared at the parchment.

That's the point.

There was no reason to complicate things.

The clone didn't need to wander around Orario looking suspicious. It didn't need to meet adventurers unnecessarily. It didn't need to attract attention.

It simply needed to become another ordinary adventurer.

Someone who existed.

Someone who could move through the city while Bell himself disappeared into the Dungeon.

Bell tapped the parchment with his finger.

“You'll handle the surface.”

“And you?”

Bell's expression became serious.

“I'll stay below.”

“The Dungeon?”

“The eighteenth floor.”

The clone's eyes narrowed slightly.

“Camping?”

“Exactly.”

Bell leaned forward.

“I need time. A lot of it.”

His eyes drifted toward the wall.

“The eighteenth floor is different from the upper floors. The monsters, terrain, ecosystem... everything changes. If I'm going to understand the Dungeon, I need to observe it for longer periods.”

“And Excelia.”

Bell smiled faintly.

“That too.”

He wasn't going to waste the opportunity.

The Dungeon was dangerous.

But danger was also opportunity.

Every battle offered experience.

Every monster offered data.

Every discovery could become another piece of the puzzle.

If I can stay there long enough, I can grow without constantly traveling between the Dungeon and Orario.

That alone would save an enormous amount of time.

Bell looked at his clone.

“You'll be my presence in the city.”

The clone nodded.

“And you'll be my presence in the Dungeon.”

“More or less.”

Bell looked down at his notes.

Simple.

Efficient.

Almost perfect.

Then—

His eyes stopped.

One word suddenly appeared in his thoughts.

Divination.

Bell's expression changed.

“...Wait.”

The clone looked at him.

“What?”

Bell didn't answer immediately.

He stared at his own hand.

Divination.

A developmental ability.

He had remembered it before.

He had thought about it several times.

But every attempt to understand it had led nowhere.

What exactly does it mean?

It wasn't simply seeing the future.

At least, Bell didn't think so.

The word itself was too vague.

Could it reveal hidden information?

Could it detect something beyond ordinary perception?

Could it predict events?

Could it analyze possibilities?

Or perhaps—

Bell frowned.

Could it see something that already exists but cannot normally be perceived?

His gaze slowly shifted toward the clone.

The thought was ridiculous.

Which was precisely why he couldn't ignore it.

Bell stood.

“Come here.”

The clone approached.

Bell walked around it slowly.

He examined its body.

Its face.

Its eyes.

Its hands.

Nothing.

Everything appeared normal.

Yet Bell couldn't shake the feeling that there was something he was missing.

“If Divination is connected to information...” Bell murmured, “then perhaps the problem isn't activating it.”

The clone raised an eyebrow.

“Then what is the problem?”

“Knowing what I'm supposed to look for.”

Bell stopped.

He stared directly into the clone's eyes.

For a moment, neither moved.

Then Bell made a decision.

“Let's test something.”

He pulled a small knife from his belongings.

The clone immediately looked at it.

“What are you planning?”

“An experiment.”

“With a knife?”

“It's barely a knife.”

“That doesn't answer my question.”

Bell smiled.

“Relax.”

He pricked the tip of his finger.

A small bead of blood appeared.

The clone watched curiously.

Bell placed his finger above its hand.

One drop fell.

Plop.

The blood landed on the clone's skin.

Nothing happened.

Bell waited.

One second.

Two.

Three.

Nothing.

The blood simply remained there.

Bell's expression slowly flattened.

“...Of course.”

The clone looked at the droplet.

“Was something supposed to happen?”

“I was hoping.”

“For what?”

Bell wiped his finger.

“Something.”

“That is not very scientific.”

Bell looked at him.

“Since when did you become the reasonable one?”

“I've been reasonable since I was created.”

“That's debatable.”

The clone gave him a blank stare.

Bell sighed.

“Forget it.”

He examined the blood again.

No reaction.

No magical disturbance.

No change.

No sudden revelation.

Nothing.

Another dead end.

Bell's shoulders dropped slightly.

So that's not it.

He had already considered the possibility that his blood might serve as some kind of connection.

After all, the clone originated from him.

If Divination could perceive relationships, perhaps the blood could act as a medium.

But apparently not.

Bell wiped the blood away.

“Scrap that idea.”

“Completely?”

“For now.”

The clone looked at him.

“You seem disappointed.”

“I am.”

Bell returned to the parchment.

“That's how experimentation works.”

He began crossing out several notes.

“Hypothesis.”

Scratch.

“Test.”

Scratch.

“Failure.”

Scratch.

“Repeat.”

The clone watched silently.

Bell paused.

Then he smiled.

“Eventually something works.”

The room became quiet again.

For several moments, Bell simply stared at the discarded idea.

Divination.

He couldn't shake the feeling that he was approaching the answer from the wrong direction.

Maybe the ability wasn't meant to reveal the future.

Maybe it wasn't meant to see hidden things.

Maybe—

Bell stopped himself.

“No.”

He shook his head.

“Don't overthink it.”

The clone looked at him.

“You do that often.”

Bell frowned.

“Whose side are you on?”

“My own.”

Bell sighed.

“Fair enough.”

He rolled up the parchment.

“Enough experiments for today.”

The clone nodded.

“What happens now?”

Bell's expression sharpened.

“Now?”

He stood.

“Now we execute the plan.”

He pointed toward the door.

“You'll prepare for tomorrow's Dungeon run.”

“And you?”

Bell glanced toward his equipment.

“I'll prepare for the eighteenth floor.”

He paused.

Then looked back at the clone.

“And one more thing.”

“Yes?”

“If anything unusual happens while you're in the city—anything at all—you report it immediately.”

The clone's expression became serious.

“Understood.”

“No unnecessary risks.”

“Understood.”

“Don't attract attention.”

“Understood.”

“And don't start fights.”

The clone stared at him.

“You're the one who created me.”

Bell blinked.

“...That's exactly why I'm warning you.”

A faint smile appeared on the clone's face.

Bell turned away.

But as he walked toward the door, his smile disappeared.

His mind returned to that single word.

Divination.

He had dismissed it.

For now.

But somewhere deep inside, something bothered him.

It wasn't the failure.

It was the feeling that he had misunderstood the ability entirely.

Bell glanced back at the clone.

For the briefest moment, his red eyes narrowed.

If Divination really can reveal what cannot normally be seen...

His gaze lingered on his own face.

Then what exactly am I supposed to be seeing?

He opened the door.

Cold air entered the room.

Bell stepped outside.

Behind him, the clone followed.

Neither of them noticed the faintest shimmer that appeared for less than a heartbeat in the clone's eyes.

Then it vanished.

As though it had never existed.

Worked for 8s

Chapter Thirty-One: To Her Surprise

The throne room was silent.

Not the peaceful kind of silence.

It was the silence of a city holding its breath.

From the highest seat of power in Orario, Freya sat with one leg crossed over the other, her posture relaxed, her expression serene.

The throne belonged to her now.

Rightfully obtained.

No more hiding.

No more pretending.

No more watching Orario from the shadows while another name sat above the city.

She had finally claimed what she had desired.

And yet—

Freya could not enjoy it.

Her eyes were fixed upon a single figure far below.

Bell.

Even from this distance, she could see him.

That white-haired boy walking through the streets of Orario.

The boy whose presence had once made her soul tremble.

The boy whose very existence had been a brilliant star in her eyes.

The boy she had called beautiful.

The boy she had wanted.

The boy whose soul—

Freya's smile slowly disappeared.

"...What?"

Her fingers tightened around the armrest.

She looked again.

Then again.

Her divine eyes focused entirely on Bell.

Nothing.

There should have been light.

A magnificent light.

Something impossibly pure and brilliant.

Something that made every other soul around him look insignificant.

But now...

There was nothing.

Freya's breathing stopped.

"No..."

She leaned forward.

Bell continued walking.

His face was calm.

Too calm.

His steps were steady.

Too steady.

There was no visible injury.

No obvious sickness.

No blood.

No monster chasing him.

No immediate danger.

And yet Freya felt something far more frightening than any monster.

She couldn't see his light.

It was as if someone had extinguished a star.

Freya stood.

"Bell."

The name escaped her lips almost unconsciously.

A servant nearby immediately lowered their head.

"Lady Freya?"

"Nothing."

Her voice was unusually quiet.

The servant hesitated.

"Are you certain?"

Freya did not answer.

Her eyes remained fixed on Bell.

What happened to you?

Her mind began racing.

Did someone hurt you?

Did someone break you?

Was it the Dungeon?

Was it your familia?

Was it the gods?

Was it me?

That last thought made her expression darken.

Freya slowly sat down again.

No.

She refused to accept it.

There had to be an explanation.

She had watched Bell for so long.

She knew the way he smiled.

The way he looked at the Dungeon.

The way his eyes brightened whenever he discovered something new.

The way his heart raced when he encountered something extraordinary.

She knew his light.

Perhaps better than anyone.

And now—

It was gone.

Not dim.

Gone.

Freya lowered her gaze.

For the first time since claiming the throne, the ruler of Orario looked genuinely frightened.

"...He's hurting."

A conclusion formed in her mind.

Perhaps Bell had simply endured too much.

Too many events.

Too many revelations.

Too many people.

Too many expectations.

Perhaps something inside him had finally broken.

Freya's fingers slowly curled.

Then he must be happy.

The thought came suddenly.

Simple.

Absolute.

If his heart has become lost... then I will make him smile again.

Her expression softened.

"That is what I should do."

The servant looked at her in confusion.

"Lady Freya?"

Freya turned her head.

"Find Horn."

The servant immediately bowed.

"Yes."

Horn arrived shortly afterward.

She knelt before Freya.

"My goddess."

Freya studied her for several seconds.

Then she spoke.

"Horn."

"Yes."

"I want you to exchange places with me."

Horn blinked.

"...Again?"

Freya smiled.

"I want more time as Syr."

Horn's expression became complicated.

"My goddess, may I ask why?"

Freya looked toward the enormous windows overlooking Orario.

"Bell is unhappy."

Horn's eyes widened.

"Bell?"

"Yes."

Freya's voice carried something Horn rarely heard from her.

Concern.

Not jealousy.

Not obsession.

Concern.

"I looked at him today."

Freya paused.

"...And I couldn't see his light."

Horn's expression froze.

She understood immediately how serious that statement was.

"Are you saying—"

"I don't know."

Freya stood from the throne.

"That's the problem."

She walked toward the window.

Below, Orario continued moving.

Merchants shouted.

Adventurers laughed.

Children ran through the streets.

The city was alive.

But Freya's attention remained fixed upon one person.

"I don't know what happened."

She placed a hand against the glass.

"So I will find out."

Horn lowered her head.

"And if he truly is suffering?"

Freya smiled.

It was a beautiful smile.

But there was something dangerous beneath it.

"Then I'll make him happy."

Horn remained silent.

Freya continued.

"I don't care how long it takes."

Her eyes narrowed.

"I don't care what I have to arrange."

She turned around.

"And I don't care who gets in the way."

Horn swallowed.

"...Understood."

Freya's smile returned.

"Good."

That evening, Syr appeared.

Not Freya.

Syr.

A simple girl walking through Orario with a gentle smile.

She carried herself differently.

Her clothes were ordinary.

Her expression was warmer.

Her presence was deliberately unremarkable.

But inside—

Freya was thinking.

What makes Bell happy?

She knew.

Or at least, she believed she knew.

Food.

Adventure.

Interesting people.

The Dungeon.

A peaceful day.

A smile from someone he cared about.

Perhaps he needed companionship.

Perhaps he needed encouragement.

Perhaps he simply needed someone to listen.

Then I'll give him all of it.

Freya walked through the city.

Her eyes eventually found Bell.

He was sitting alone.

Freya stopped.

Her heart tightened.

There.

Bell wasn't crying.

He wasn't visibly miserable.

That almost made it worse.

He simply sat there.

Quiet.

Thinking.

Freya stared at him from across the street.

For a moment, the goddess who could command Familia members, manipulate kingdoms, and bend the course of Orario itself found herself uncertain.

She had never been afraid of power.

She had never been afraid of war.

She had never been afraid of losing.

But this?

A boy sitting silently?

That terrified her.

Freya took a breath.

Then smiled.

"All right."

She stepped forward.

"Let's start with something simple."

"Bell!"

Bell looked up.

His crimson eyes met hers.

"Syr?"

Freya smiled brightly.

"You're sitting here alone again."

"I just needed some time."

"Some time?"

"Yeah."

Freya sat beside him without asking.

"Then I'll keep you company."

Bell stared at her.

"You don't have to."

"I know."

She smiled.

"But I want to."

Bell looked away.

Freya watched him carefully.

There.

A tiny movement.

A slight shift in his expression.

Not happiness.

But recognition.

That's enough.

For now.

Freya placed her hands on her lap.

"So..."

She tilted her head.

"What do you want to eat?"

Bell blinked.

"...Eat?"

"Yes."

"I don't know."

"Then I'll choose."

"You always do that."

"Because I'm good at it."

Bell gave the faintest smile.

Freya's heart nearly stopped.

There.

She saw it.

A tiny spark.

A fragment.

Yes.

Her smile widened.

I found it.

But she didn't push.

She simply stood.

"Come on."

"Where?"

"Somewhere delicious."

Bell stared at her.

"Why?"

Syr extended her hand.

"Because you look like you need it."

Bell hesitated.

Then—

He took her hand.

Freya's eyes widened for half a second.

Her heart raced.

He took my hand.

She almost laughed.

Almost.

Instead, she simply smiled.

"Let's go."

And the two walked into the evening together.

But Freya wasn't finished.

Not remotely.

That night, she returned to her throne.

The smile from earlier had vanished.

Her expression was calm again.

Calculating.

She summoned Ottarl.

The massive warrior entered and knelt.

"My goddess."

Freya looked at him.

"Do you think Bell is unhappy?"

Ottarl remained silent for a moment.

Then answered honestly.

"I do not know."

Freya nodded.

"Good answer."

She looked down.

"Then I'll investigate."

Ottarl raised his head slightly.

"And if your efforts fail?"

Freya's eyes sharpened.

"Then I'll ask you."

Ottarl blinked.

"Me?"

"You understand Bell differently than I do."

The statement surprised him.

Freya smiled faintly.

"And you understand people better than you realize."

Ottarl lowered his head.

"If that is your command, I will answer."

Freya leaned back against the throne.

"Not yet."

Her eyes returned toward the distant city.

"Right now..."

A smile slowly appeared.

"...I want to try being Syr."

For Bell.

Not for Orario.

Not for her Familia.

Not for her own ambitions.

For him.

Freya closed her eyes.

You don't need to shine for me, Bell.

You don't need to become the hero everyone expects.

You don't even need to be strong.

Her fingers tightened around the throne.

Just smile.

A strange warmth filled her chest.

Then her smile became almost frighteningly determined.

And if someone took that smile away from you...

The goddess of beauty opened her eyes.

I'll find them.

Outside, the lights of Orario glittered beneath the night sky.

The city believed its new ruler was sitting peacefully upon her throne.

They were wrong.

Freya had already begun moving pieces across the board.

Horn would become Syr.

Syr would approach Bell.

Ottarl would stand ready.

Information would flow.

People would be watched.

Paths would quietly be altered.

Doors would open.

Obstacles would disappear.

Opportunities would appear at precisely the right moment.

Freya would pull strings from the shadows.

Not to conquer Orario.

Not this time.

She had a far more personal objective.

She wanted to restore a single light.

The light of the boy she had once considered the most brilliant soul she had ever seen.

And she would start tomorrow.

With something simple.

A meal.

A conversation.

A smile.

Freya looked toward the moonlit city.

"Bell..."

Her voice was barely a whisper.

"Let's see if I can surprise you."

She smiled.

And somewhere in Orario, completely unaware of the goddess's plans, Bell sneezed.

Freya's smile widened.

"...Yes."

Her eyes gleamed.

"This is only the beginning."

Chapter Thirty-Three: Vacation

The first peaceful morning in Orario felt suspiciously like a trap.

Bell Cranel sat at the edge of his bed, staring at the ceiling with the solemn expression of a man who had just discovered that the world had run out of problems for him to solve.

For several minutes, he did nothing.

Then he sighed.

"...I'm bored."

The words fell into the empty room with a weight disproportionate to their meaning.

Outside his window, Orario was already awake. Merchants were opening their stalls, adventurers were gathering near the main streets, and the distant clamor of the city drifted through the glass. Somewhere below, two men were arguing over the price of a breakfast skewer. A child laughed. A carriage rattled over the cobblestones.

Life continued.

Rather annoyingly, it continued without requiring anything from him.

Bell leaned forward, resting his elbows on his knees.

His recent efforts had finally begun to bear fruit. The existence of his clone had become a subject of considerable fascination throughout the city. Thanks to a carefully maintained pattern of appearances, the duplicate had become a convenient distraction for curious adventurers, suspicious gods, and anyone else who had developed an unhealthy interest in the white-haired newcomer.

Whenever someone tried to follow Bell, they found themselves chasing the wrong person.

Whenever someone attempted to corner him with questions, they were often greeted by a perfectly convincing smile and an equally convincing excuse.

The clone was doing an excellent job.

Too excellent, perhaps.

It had become difficult to remember the last time Bell had needed to intervene personally.

He had spent the previous several days checking his arrangements, examining the information his clone had gathered, and ensuring that none of his plans had developed any unexpected complications.

There were none.

No immediate threats. No urgent investigations. No troublesome individuals demanding his attention.

Nothing.

He stared at the ceiling again.

"Perhaps I should find something to do."

He paused.

"...What, exactly?"

That was the problem.

He could visit the Dungeon, but he had no pressing need to descend. He could explore the city, but he had already learned enough about its principal streets to navigate without thinking. He could gather information, but there was nothing in particular he needed to investigate.

And if he invented another problem merely to occupy himself, he would be doing precisely the sort of thing he had been trying to avoid.

Bell rubbed his face.

"I really have become my own worst enemy."

A knock came from the door.

"Come in."

The door opened.

Bell looked up.

Another Bell Cranel stood in the doorway.

The same white hair. The same red eyes. The same youthful face. The same deceptively harmless appearance that had fooled more people than either of them cared to count.

The clone leaned against the doorframe, holding a paper bag in one hand.

"I heard someone complaining about boredom," he said. "I came to witness the historic event."

Bell stared at him.

"Don't you have work to do?"

"I do."

"Then why are you here?"

"Because you told me to report anything unusual."

"And?"

The clone raised the paper bag.

"I found a bakery selling surprisingly good pastries. I considered it unusual enough to report."

Bell blinked.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Bell covered his face with one hand.

"I should never have given you independent judgment."

"You said that yesterday."

"I meant it yesterday, too."

The clone entered the room and dropped into the chair opposite him. He removed a pastry from the bag and examined it with the same seriousness another person might reserve for an unexploded magical device.

"Anyway, the city's getting used to me."

"That's good."

"Some people are starting to recognize me."

"That's less good."

"They think I'm you."

"That is literally the point."

"Yes, but one of them asked whether I had a younger brother."

Bell lowered his hand.

"...What did you say?"

"That I did."

"You don't have a younger brother."

"I know."

"Then why would you say that?"

The clone took a bite of his pastry.

"Because the man looked as if he was about to ask me to explain three separate rumors, and I decided giving him a new rumor would be more entertaining."

Bell stared at him in silence.

The clone chewed thoughtfully.

"Besides, technically, I'm younger than you."

"You're a copy of me."

"Which means I'm also technically your younger brother."

"That is not how family relationships work."

"Tell that to the people of Orario."

Bell opened his mouth, then closed it.

He had the distinct impression that arguing with his own duplicate was a mistake he would continue making for the foreseeable future.

"Fine," he said at last. "Just don't create a situation I have to clean up."

"I won't."

"You said that before you convinced a group of adventurers that I was secretly training to become a chef."

"They believed you could cook."

"I can cook."

"Then I see no problem."

Bell exhaled slowly.

The clone's expression softened into something less mischievous.

"Seriously, though. Things are quiet. You have time to rest. You should take advantage of it."

Bell glanced toward the window.

"Rest?"

"Yes. That thing people do when they aren't trying to control every possible outcome."

"I know what rest is."

"Do you?"

Bell looked back at him.

The clone smiled.

Bell did not.

"...You're becoming irritating."

"I learned from the best."

"Get out."

"Gladly."

The clone rose, taking the paper bag with him.

He stopped at the door and glanced over his shoulder.

"One more thing."

"What?"

"If you're planning to do absolutely nothing today, at least make sure you eat. It would be embarrassing if the great Bell Cranel were defeated by an empty stomach."

Bell picked up a pillow.

The clone disappeared into the corridor before it could hit him.

A moment later, Bell heard his own voice laughing outside.

He stared at the closed door.

Then, despite himself, he smiled.

For all his peculiarities, the clone was right about one thing.

There was nothing demanding his attention.

Nothing he could usefully accomplish by worrying.

Perhaps, for once, he could simply let the day pass.

Bell stood, changed into more comfortable clothes, and drew the curtains halfway across the window. The morning sunlight softened the room, transforming its familiar corners into warm patches of gold.

He lay down.

Just for a little while, he told himself.

He would wake up later, find something to eat, and decide what to do with the rest of the day.

There was no reason to think too much.

No reason to anticipate danger.

No reason to prepare for a catastrophe that had not happened.

His eyes closed.

The city continued to live beyond the window.

And Bell Cranel, who had spent so much of his life trying to stay one step ahead of the world, finally allowed himself to sleep.

He had no idea that the world was waiting for him on the other side.

The Dream

There was no moon.

Bell noticed that first.

He stood beneath an endless sky filled with stars, each one shining with a clarity that seemed almost artificial. They did not twinkle. They did not flicker. They hung motionless in the darkness, like countless pinholes punched through a vast black curtain.

There was no city beneath them.

No Orario.

No Tower of Babel.

No Dungeon.

Only a flat expanse of pale ground stretching into the distance, its surface smooth as glass and cold beneath his bare feet.

Bell looked down.

He was wearing his usual clothes.

His hands were uninjured. His breathing was steady. He could feel the night air against his skin, although there was no wind.

He turned slowly, examining the horizon.

Nothing moved.

"...A dream?"

His voice traveled farther than it should have.

The sound seemed to pass through the darkness without fading, returning to him from somewhere beyond the stars.

A dream.

The words echoed again.

Bell frowned.

He knew he was dreaming.

The realization came with an unsettling certainty, as though someone had placed the knowledge inside his head rather than allowing him to discover it himself.

He could feel the distinction between the dream and reality. He remembered lying in bed. He remembered the conversation with his clone. He remembered the sunlight through his curtains.

He could even remember the exact expression on the clone's face when he had made that ridiculous remark about cooking.

Everything was clear.

Too clear.

Bell pinched the back of his hand.

Nothing happened.

He pressed harder.

Still nothing.

He could feel the pressure. He could feel the slight ache in his fingers.

But the world refused to respond.

"Interesting."

He tried to move his right hand.

It obeyed.

He raised his left.

It obeyed.

Bell took a step forward.

The glass beneath his feet rippled.

He stopped immediately.

A circular wave spread from the point of contact, traveling across the pale surface without disturbing its reflection of the stars.

He looked down again.

There was no reflection of himself.

Only the sky.

A quiet unease settled in his stomach.

"All right," he murmured. "If this is a dream, then let's see how much control I have."

He imagined a door.

Nothing happened.

He imagined a staircase.

Nothing.

He tried to summon a familiar sensation, the subtle pressure of magical energy gathering beneath his skin.

For the briefest instant, he felt something answer.

Then it vanished.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

He tried again.

Nothing.

His expression grew serious.

Dreams were strange things. Even a lucid dream could resist deliberate control, and he had no reason to assume that his subconscious would obey every command.

Still, something about this place felt wrong.

Not frightening.

Not yet.

Simply wrong in a way he could not define.

He began walking.

With each step, the stars above him seemed to change.

At first, he thought it was an illusion caused by his movement. Then he noticed that the constellations were rearranging themselves into unfamiliar patterns.

One star vanished.

Another appeared in its place.

A cluster of seven became six.

Bell stopped.

The stars stopped changing.

He resumed walking.

They changed again.

He looked up for several seconds, carefully tracking one particular point of light. It moved when he moved, shifting across the sky as if following an invisible orbit centered on him.

Bell felt the first genuine chill of fear.

"...What are you?"

No answer came.

He looked toward the horizon.

A dark shape stood in the distance.

It had not been there before.

Bell was certain of it.

The figure was too far away to distinguish its features, but its silhouette appeared vaguely human. It stood perfectly still, facing him.

Bell narrowed his eyes.

"Hey!"

The figure did not move.

He took a step toward it.

The figure tilted its head.

Bell froze.

A second later, it vanished.

Not by moving away.

Not by fading into the darkness.

It was simply gone, as though the world had decided that it had never existed.

Bell's heartbeat quickened.

He forced himself to breathe slowly.

It's a dream.

He repeated the words in his mind.

Nothing here can hurt me.

The moment the thought formed, a sound emerged from somewhere behind him.

A faint, metallic scraping.

Bell spun around.

There was nothing.

The scraping came again.

Closer.

Something dragged across the glass beneath the darkness, leaving a sound like a blade being drawn over stone.

Bell stepped backward.

"Show yourself."

The sound stopped.

Silence returned.

Then, from somewhere impossibly far away, came a scream.

Bell's blood turned cold.

It was a woman's voice.

High, strained, and filled with such raw desperation that his body reacted before his mind could understand what he had heard.

He knew that voice.

He could not explain how.

He could not remember where he had heard it.

But he knew.

The scream came again.

This time, it was accompanied by a distant crash.

Bell turned toward the sound.

The stars above him trembled.

One by one, their light began to dim.

A narrow line of darkness appeared across the horizon, cutting through the pale ground like a crack in a mirror.

He stared at it.

Then another scream tore through the night.

"Help me!"

Bell's heart lurched.

He ran.

The ground stretched beneath him, but the distance ahead refused to shrink. The horizon remained just as far away, no matter how quickly he moved.

He increased his speed.

The scream came again.

"Please!"

He ran harder.

His breath grew ragged. His feet struck the glass with a sharp, rhythmic sound. The stars overhead began to streak, leaving thin trails of white light in the darkness.

And still, the horizon did not move.

Bell gritted his teeth.

"No."

He pushed himself faster.

"No, no, no—!"

The ground beneath his feet suddenly shattered.

He fell.

There was no impact.

No wind.

Only the sensation of plunging through an endless black abyss while the stars receded above him.

Bell twisted in midair, reaching for anything he could grasp.

His fingers closed around nothing.

The scream followed him down.

Then everything went white.

He landed on his knees.

The impact was real enough to hurt.

Bell sucked in a breath and looked up.

The sky had changed.

The stars were still there, but now they hung over a vast, ruined landscape. Jagged pillars of stone rose from a field of broken earth. The air shimmered with heat, and distant clouds of dust drifted across the horizon.

He knew this place.

The realization struck him with the force of a physical blow.

He had seen it before.

Not here.

Not in this world.

But somewhere buried in his memories, beyond the ordinary boundaries of recollection.

His hands began to tremble.

"No..."

He looked toward the center of the ruined landscape.

A gigantic shape lay sprawled among the shattered rocks, its armored body pierced by numerous wounds. Its segmented tail curled over the ground, and its enormous pincers rested motionless beside it.

The Scorpion.

Defeated.

Dead.

Bell stared at the monster.

His mind raced.

He remembered the battle.

The struggle.

The desperate calculations made under impossible pressure.

The moment when victory had finally become certain.

They had won.

He had won.

Then why—

A faint sound reached his ears.

A soft, wet cough.

Bell turned.

Someone was lying several paces away.

A woman.

Her body was partially obscured by drifting dust. Her long hair spread across the broken ground, and one of her hands rested against her chest.

Bell could not see her face.

He could not make out her features.

But the moment he saw her, something inside him collapsed.

His breath caught in his throat.

He knew her.

He knew her so well that the thought of forgetting her felt like a betrayal.

Yet when he tried to recall her name, his mind produced nothing.

Only an empty space.

A name-shaped wound.

"Hey..."

His voice emerged as a whisper.

He took a step toward her.

"Hey, can you hear me?"

The woman did not answer.

Bell hurried forward.

Then he stopped.

Something stood between them.

A tall, dark silhouette, its shape distorted by the shimmering air. It had no discernible face. Its outline flickered, sometimes resembling a person, sometimes something far less familiar.

Bell stared at it.

The figure did not look at him.

Instead, it looked toward the woman.

Bell's stomach twisted.

"Move."

The figure remained still.

"I said move."

He stepped forward.

The air became heavy.

A pressure settled over his shoulders, pressing him toward the ground. His knees bent involuntarily, and a sharp pain spread through his chest.

Bell clenched his teeth.

"What... is this?"

The figure lifted one hand.

The world went silent.

Not quiet.

Silent.

The wind stopped. The dust froze in the air. Even Bell's breathing seemed to vanish from his ears.

He could see the woman moving her lips.

He could see the faint rise and fall of her chest.

But he could hear nothing.

The figure lowered its hand.

Sound returned all at once.

A distant crash.

The woman's strained breathing.

And then—

"Bell..."

His entire body went rigid.

That voice.

He knew it.

He knew it with a certainty that made his heart ache.

"Bell..."

The woman was calling him.

He stumbled forward.

"I'm here!"

His voice cracked.

"I'm here! Just hold on!"

The silhouette tilted its head.

Bell tried to move around it.

The pressure increased.

His legs shook.

He forced one foot forward, then another. Every movement felt as though he were walking against an invisible wall.

The woman reached out.

Her fingers trembled.

Bell reached back.

Their hands were separated by only a few meters.

He could see the dust clinging to her skin. He could see the faint movement of her fingers as she struggled to reach him.

He was close enough to save her.

He only needed to take a few more steps.

"Come on..."

Bell's voice shook.

"Come on! Just a little farther!"

He pushed forward.

The pressure crushed him to his knees.

Pain exploded through his body.

He looked down at his hands.

They were shaking violently.

He tried to summon his magic.

Nothing.

He tried again.

Still nothing.

His fingers dug into the broken earth.

"No."

He forced himself upright.

"No, this isn't happening."

He took another step.

The silhouette raised its hand again.

Bell's body stopped responding.

He could not move his arms.

He could not move his legs.

He could not even turn his head.

Only his eyes remained free, and they were fixed on the woman lying helplessly before him.

The figure finally turned.

For the first time, Bell saw its face.

There was nothing there.

No eyes.

No mouth.

No nose.

Only a smooth, featureless surface that reflected the ruined landscape behind him.

Yet Bell felt as though it were smiling.

A voice emerged from nowhere.

Not from the figure.

Not from the sky.

Not from the earth.

It came from inside his own head.

You are too late.

Bell's eyes widened.

"No!"

You were too late before.

The voice sounded familiar.

It sounded like his own.

And you will be too late again.

The woman's fingers twitched.

Bell strained against the invisible force.

"Stop it!"

The voice continued.

You calculated the enemy's movements. You anticipated the attacks. You prepared for the worst possible outcome.

The silhouette took a step toward the woman.

Bell's heart hammered against his ribs.

You won.

Another step.

So why is she dying?

"SHUT UP!"

His scream tore through the silence.

The silhouette stopped.

For an instant, the entire landscape trembled.

Bell felt something inside him break free.

His right hand moved.

Only slightly.

But it moved.

He stared at it.

Then, with a sound somewhere between a sob and a growl, he forced his arm forward.

His fingers stretched toward the woman.

The distance between them seemed to expand.

One meter became five.

Five became ten.

The woman grew smaller.

The landscape stretched endlessly in every direction.

Bell tried to run, but his legs remained trapped.

He clawed at the ground.

"NO!"

His nails broke against the stone.

"I'M RIGHT HERE!"

The woman turned her head.

For the first time, he saw her face.

And the dream shattered.

Bell stood in the same ruined landscape.

The Scorpion was gone.

The broken earth was gone.

The woman was gone.

Only the stars remained.

He looked around wildly.

"Where is she?"

His voice echoed.

"Where did she go?"

Nothing answered.

Bell turned toward the horizon.

The featureless silhouette stood there again.

Far away.

Waiting.

He tried to approach it, but the ground beneath his feet had become a mirror. His reflection followed his movements with a slight delay.

He stopped.

The reflection continued walking.

Bell stared at it.

The reflected version of himself came to a halt several paces away. It looked up.

Its red eyes were filled with a terrible exhaustion.

Then it spoke.

"You know who she is."

Bell felt his throat tighten.

"...Who?"

The reflection smiled sadly.

"You know."

"Tell me!"

"You already know."

Bell stepped forward.

The reflection stepped back.

"Tell me her name!"

The reflection's smile disappeared.

For the first time, it looked angry.

"YOU WERE THERE!"

The stars overhead flickered.

Bell staggered.

Fragments of memories flashed through his mind.

A golden light.

A woman's hand reaching toward him.

The sound of wings beating against the night sky.

A distant voice, gentle and sorrowful, speaking a name he could not quite hear.

Then an image of himself, standing amid the ruins with blood on his hands.

Bell clutched his head.

"Stop..."

Another memory.

A bright, clear sky.

A beautiful woman standing beneath it.

Her expression peaceful.

Her eyes filled with an emotion he had never understood until the moment he saw them.

Love.

Grief.

Acceptance.

And something else.

Something that terrified him.

He reached toward the image.

It vanished.

Bell fell to his knees.

"No... no, I don't understand..."

The reflection crouched in front of him.

"Then remember."

"I can't!"

"Remember!"

"I CAN'T!"

The mirror cracked.

A thin line appeared between them, spreading rapidly across the glass.

Bell tried to stand, but the ground began to break apart. The reflection's face fractured into dozens of pieces, each one showing a different expression.

In one, Bell was crying.

In another, he was screaming.

In another, he stood perfectly still, staring at a lifeless body.

And in the final piece—

He was smiling.

A calm, empty smile.

The sight horrified him more than anything else.

Bell recoiled.

The reflection's voice grew quieter.

"How many times will you watch her die?"

Bell stopped breathing.

"What?"

The cracks spread farther.

"How many times will you be given the chance?"

The stars began to fall.

Not like shooting stars.

They dropped vertically from the sky, plunging toward the horizon without making a sound. Each one vanished before reaching the ground.

Bell looked up.

The sky was collapsing.

"What is this?!"

The reflection did not answer.

It merely stared at him.

Then the entire world went dark.

He heard her scream again.

This time, it came from directly behind him.

Bell spun around.

The woman stood beneath a sky without stars.

He could finally see her clearly.

Long hair.

A familiar face.

Eyes that seemed to contain the sorrow of an entire lifetime.

Artemis.

The name struck him like lightning.

"Artemis..."

She stood a short distance away, looking at him with an expression he could not bear to see.

She was crying.

Bell tried to approach her.

She took a step backward.

He stopped.

"Artemis?"

She lowered her eyes.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

Then she smiled.

It was a small smile.

A tender one.

The sort of smile someone might offer to comfort a child who had awakened from a nightmare.

And Bell hated it.

He hated the way it made his chest ache.

He hated the way it seemed to say that everything was already decided.

Most of all, he hated the feeling that he had seen that smile before.

"Don't..."

His voice trembled.

"Don't look at me like that."

Artemis raised her head.

Her lips moved.

Bell could not hear her words.

He shook his head.

"No. Don't do that. Don't tell me it's all right."

She reached toward him.

He rushed forward.

For one beautiful instant, their hands met.

Her fingers were warm.

Real.

Bell grabbed her hand with both of his, holding it as if the world itself were trying to tear her away.

"I've got you."

His eyes burned.

"I've got you now."

Artemis looked at him.

Her expression changed.

The smile faded.

And Bell saw something in her eyes that made his blood run cold.

She was afraid.

Not of him.

For him.

Her fingers tightened around his.

Then she whispered.

This time, he heard her.

"Bell... don't let me become the reason you lose yourself."

He froze.

The words were wrong.

They belonged to a conversation that had not happened.

A memory that did not exist.

Yet he understood them.

He understood them so completely that his heart began to race.

"Artemis, what are you talking about?"

She opened her mouth.

A sharp, metallic sound cut through the darkness.

Bell turned.

The Scorpion stood behind her.

Its enormous body towered over the landscape, its armored plates glistening beneath an invisible light. Its tail rose into the air, the deadly tip poised above Artemis's head.

Bell's eyes widened.

"No!"

He tried to pull her away.

She did not move.

The Scorpion's tail descended.

Bell screamed.

The world shattered.

The End That Had Already Happened

Bell was running.

He did not remember starting.

He did not know where he was going.

He only knew that Artemis was ahead of him, and that every second he spent watching her move farther away was another second he could never recover.

The battlefield stretched endlessly beneath the stars.

The Scorpion lay dead.

The battle was over.

They had won.

He had won.

And Artemis was dying.

Bell could hear her breathing now, each breath weaker than the last. He could hear the faint rustle of her clothes against the broken earth. He could hear his own footsteps pounding against the ground.

Every sound was painfully clear.

Every detail was merciless.

He could see the smallest movements of her fingers.

He could see her chest struggling to rise.

He could see the light in her eyes slowly fading.

And he could do nothing.

"Artemis!"

He fell beside her.

His hands moved instinctively, searching for wounds, for some way to stop what was happening. He tried to remember every healing method he knew. Every spell. Every technique. Every desperate possibility.

Nothing made sense.

His thoughts scattered.

There must be something.

There had to be.

He had prepared for this battle.

He had studied the enemy.

He had considered its capabilities, its weaknesses, its attack patterns.

He had made decisions.

He had taken risks.

He had fought with everything he possessed.

And he had won.

So why was she lying here?

Why was the person he wanted to protect most lying in front of him, dying while he knelt helplessly beside her?

"Please..."

He pressed his hands against her shoulders.

"Please, look at me."

Her eyes shifted toward him.

For one brief moment, she seemed to recognize him.

Her lips parted.

Bell leaned closer.

"Don't speak. Save your strength. I'll get you out of here. I'll find someone who can heal you. I'll—"

She coughed.

A thin line of blood appeared at the corner of her mouth.

Bell stopped talking.

His hands began to tremble.

"No..."

He stared at the blood.

It was such a small thing.

A little red against pale skin.

Yet it seemed to contain the entirety of the world.

He had seen blood before.

He had spilled it.

He had watched monsters collapse beneath his attacks and had stood among the aftermath of battles that left the ground stained red.

Blood was familiar.

Death was familiar.

But this—

This was different.

Because this time, the person dying was Artemis.

And no amount of familiarity could make him accept it.

"Artemis, please."

He tried to smile.

He did not know why.

Perhaps because he thought she might be frightened.

Perhaps because he wanted her to see that everything would be fine.

Perhaps because some foolish part of him believed that if he looked calm enough, the world would be forced to obey.

"It's all right. I've got you. Just stay with me, okay?"

His voice cracked.

"I've got you."

Artemis looked at him.

Her lips moved.

He bent closer.

And this time, he heard every word.

"Bell..."

"I'm here."

"I'm... sorry."

Bell went completely still.

For a moment, he could not understand what she had said.

Then his expression twisted.

"No."

He shook his head.

"No, don't apologize. Don't you dare apologize."

Her eyes grew distant.

Bell grabbed her hand.

"Artemis, listen to me. We won. Do you understand? We won. The Scorpion is dead. Everything we planned worked. You did your part. I did mine. We won."

He was speaking too quickly.

The words tumbled from his mouth without order or meaning.

"So why are you apologizing? Why are you lying here? Why can't you just—"

His voice broke.

He swallowed.

"Why can't you just get up?"

Artemis watched him.

Her fingers rested weakly in his grasp.

He held them tighter.

"Come on. You're stronger than this."

He knew how ridiculous he sounded.

He knew that strength had nothing to do with it.

But he could not stop.

"You've survived worse. You've endured things that would have broken other people. You're Artemis. You're—"

He choked on the words.

His vision blurred.

"You're supposed to be here."

The stars above them began to dim.

Bell did not notice.

He was staring at Artemis, desperately searching her face for some sign that he had misunderstood.

Some sign that she was still there.

Some sign that he had not arrived too late.

"Please."

His voice became a whisper.

"Please, don't do this to me."

Artemis's fingers moved.

He felt them brush against his palm.

For one terrible instant, hope surged through him.

He leaned closer.

"Yes. That's it. Hold on. Just a little longer."

Her hand tightened around his.

Then loosened.

Bell stared at her fingers.

He waited.

He waited for another movement.

Another breath.

Another sign.

Nothing came.

The silence stretched.

Bell slowly raised his head.

"Artemis?"

The stars went out.

One by one.

The battlefield disappeared into darkness, leaving only the two of them beneath an empty sky.

Bell could no longer see the Scorpion.

He could no longer see the ground.

He could barely see Artemis's face.

But he could still feel her hand in his.

He clung to it.

"Artemis?"

His voice echoed.

No answer.

He shook her gently.

"Artemis, wake up."

Nothing.

He shook her again.

"Wake up."

His voice rose.

"Artemis!"

The darkness swallowed the sound.

Bell bent over her, his forehead touching her hand.

His body shook.

He tried to breathe.

He could not.

He tried to speak.

Nothing came out.

And then, from somewhere beyond the darkness, a voice began to whisper.

You won.

Bell lifted his head.

You defeated the Scorpion.

His fingers tightened around Artemis's hand.

You accomplished everything you set out to do.

"No..."

You were prepared.

"Stop..."

You made the right decisions.

"STOP."

So why couldn't you save her?

Bell screamed.

The sound ripped through his throat, tearing out of him with a force that seemed to shake the stars themselves.

The battlefield flashed into existence.

For one instant, he saw Artemis lying beneath the endless sky.

Then he saw another image.

A woman reaching for him.

Another battlefield.

Another failure.

Another pair of lifeless eyes.

The images multiplied, overlapping until he could no longer distinguish one from another.

He saw himself standing in countless different places, making countless different decisions.

In one, he ran toward her.

In another, he hesitated.

In another, he attacked the Scorpion before it could strike.

In another, he chose a different strategy.

In another, he abandoned the battle entirely.

Every possibility ended the same way.

Artemis died.

Bell staggered backward.

"No..."

The voice returned.

You cannot change the outcome.

He shook his head violently.

"No!"

You cannot save everyone.

"NO!"

You are too weak.

Bell looked at his hands.

They were covered in blood.

He tried to wipe them against his clothes.

The blood remained.

He rubbed harder.

It spread across his palms, staining his fingers, soaking into the fabric.

He scrubbed at them until his skin burned.

Still, the blood would not disappear.

He stared at his hands.

Then, slowly, he looked back at Artemis.

He understood.

Not the dream.

Not the strange sky.

Not the voice.

He understood the one thing the nightmare had been trying to show him.

He had survived.

He had won.

He had done everything he believed he needed to do.

And still, the person he wanted to protect had died.

His knees struck the ground.

A sound escaped his throat.

It was not quite a sob.

Not quite a laugh.

Something broken in between.

"Why?"

The question came out quietly.

He stared at the ground.

"Why?"

The darkness did not answer.

He raised his head toward the stars.

"WHY?!"

His voice tore through the battlefield.

"WHAT DID I DO WRONG?!"

The stars trembled.

Bell clutched his head.

"I calculated everything! I considered the possibilities! I prepared for the enemy! I knew what we were facing! I fought with everything I had!"

His breathing became ragged.

"I WON!"

The words echoed across the endless darkness.

"I WON! SO WHY CAN'T I SAVE HER?!"

He slammed his fists against the ground.

The surface cracked beneath his hands.

"WHY AM I STILL TOO WEAK?!"

The battlefield dissolved.

He was standing alone beneath the stars again.

No Artemis.

No Scorpion.

No blood.

Only the endless sky.

And somewhere in the distance, a woman's voice whispered his name.

"Bell..."

He turned.

"Artemis?"

Nothing.

"Artemis!"

A faint light appeared on the horizon.

He ran toward it.

The light flickered.

For a brief instant, he saw her standing beneath it, her hair moving in a wind that did not exist.

She looked at him.

She smiled.

Then she disappeared.

Bell stopped running.

His hands hung at his sides.

The silence pressed against him.

He could feel something slipping away, something he could not name and could not bear to lose.

He reached toward the empty horizon.

"Please..."

The word was barely audible.

"Please, just give me one more chance."

The stars above him began to rearrange themselves.

A circle formed in the sky.

At its center, a single star burned brighter than all the others.

Bell stared at it.

The light pulsed once.

Then twice.

On the third pulse, a voice spoke from somewhere beyond the heavens.

Not the voice that had accused him.

Not the voice that had mocked him.

A voice that sounded ancient, distant, and unbearably tired.

The future has already begun to move.

Bell's eyes widened.

The star dimmed.

You have seen what must not be allowed to happen.

He tried to speak.

No sound emerged.

The voice continued.

But seeing is not saving.

The light vanished.

And the final words drifted down through the darkness like a sentence passed upon the dead.

Choose what you are willing to sacrifice.

Awakening

Bell woke with a strangled gasp.

He lurched upright so violently that his bed creaked beneath him.

For several seconds, he could do nothing but breathe.

His chest rose and fell in frantic, uneven bursts. Sweat covered his forehead, his neck, and his back. His hands gripped the bedsheets so tightly that his knuckles had turned white.

He stared into the room.

The familiar walls.

The half-drawn curtains.

The sunlight spilling across the floor.

The distant noise of Orario beyond the window.

Everything was normal.

Everything was exactly as it should have been.

And yet Bell could not stop shaking.

He pressed a hand against his chest.

His heart was pounding.

He looked down at his fingers.

No blood.

No wounds.

No signs of the battlefield.

He was alive.

He was in his room.

He had been dreaming.

"...A dream."

The words sounded hollow.

Bell wiped the sweat from his face and forced himself to breathe slowly.

He had experienced nightmares before. Anyone who had fought monsters long enough had dreamed of things they wished they could forget.

But this had been different.

He remembered every detail.

The stars.

The impossible landscape.

The faceless figure.

The reflection that had moved independently of him.

The woman whose name he had been unable to remember.

And Artemis.

Especially Artemis.

Bell closed his eyes.

The image returned immediately.

Her hand slipping from his.

Her expression.

Her final words.

He opened his eyes again.

"No..."

He swung his legs over the side of the bed and stood.

His knees nearly gave way.

He caught himself against the wall, breathing through the sudden wave of dizziness.

For a moment, he remained there, his forehead pressed against the cool surface.

Then his gaze shifted toward the window.

The sun was still shining.

The world had not changed.

But Bell had.

He could feel it in the pit of his stomach, in the persistent tremor of his hands, in the cold certainty that had settled behind his ribs.

He had not merely dreamed of a possible future.

Something had reached into his sleep and shown him a warning.

Or perhaps he had reached into the future himself.

His divination skill.

The thought emerged slowly.

Then it took hold.

Bell straightened.

He remembered the strange impressions he had experienced before, those brief moments when the world seemed to reveal something hidden beneath the surface of ordinary events. He had never fully understood the skill's purpose. Its messages had been vague, incomplete, and frustratingly difficult to interpret.

He had treated them as fragments of information.

Something to be examined.

Something to be analyzed.

Something that could be set aside until a more convenient time.

He had been wrong.

His divination had not shown him a simple glimpse of danger.

It had shown him a possibility that felt disturbingly close to certainty.

A future in which he defeated the enemy and still failed.

A future in which every calculation, every precaution, every carefully prepared plan proved insufficient to save the person who mattered.

Bell swallowed.

He turned toward the desk.

His notebook lay where he had left it, beside several sheets of paper covered in calculations and observations. A pen rested near the edge.

He walked toward it, intending to write everything down before the details faded.

Then he stopped.

His fingers hovered above the notebook.

What was he supposed to write?

Dreamed of Artemis dying?

Possible future?

Unidentified interference with divination?

He could record the sequence of events, the environmental anomalies, the apparent repetition of outcomes. He could analyze the dream's internal consistency, its impossible geography, and the way it had resisted his attempts to control it.

He could build a list of questions.

He could develop hypotheses.

He could even devise experiments to determine whether the next vision would respond to deliberate changes in his behavior.

But none of those things would change the one fact that mattered.

He had seen Artemis die.

And he had felt what it meant to be unable to save her.

Bell slowly lowered his hand.

For the first time in a long while, he was afraid to think.

Because if he thought too much, he might discover that the nightmare made sense.

That the sequence of events was possible.

That the battle could be won while the outcome he truly cared about was lost.

He looked down at his hands.

They were still trembling.

He closed them into fists.

Then he forced them open.

Again.

And again.

Until he could look at them without remembering the blood.

"...All right."

His voice was quiet.

Not calm.

Not confident.

But steady enough to hear.

"All right, Bell. Think."

He returned to the bed and sat down, elbows resting on his knees.

He would not allow fear to make his decisions for him. Fear could warn him, but it could not be allowed to dictate the answer. He needed information. He needed to understand the circumstances surrounding Artemis, the Scorpion, and the strange vision that had intruded upon his sleep.

He needed to determine whether the dream had shown him a fixed future, a possible future, or something else entirely.

But above all, he needed to act.

Not tomorrow.

Not after he had finished analyzing every detail.

Not when the danger had become obvious enough that even an idiot could recognize it.

Now.

Because if there was even a small chance that the dream represented something real, then every moment spent doing nothing was a moment he could never recover.

Bell took a slow breath.

His thoughts began to settle.

He could not save someone from a danger he did not understand. He could not prevent an outcome he had failed to identify. And he could not rely on victory alone to guarantee that the people beside him would survive.

The lesson was cruel.

But it was clear.

He had been thinking like someone whose primary objective was to defeat the enemy.

He needed to think like someone whose primary objective was to bring everyone home alive.

Those were not always the same thing.

A victorious battle could still become a tragedy.

A perfect strategy could still contain a fatal blind spot.

And the person standing beside him could pay the price for a mistake he had not even realized he had made.

Bell's jaw tightened.

He would not allow that to happen without a fight.

Not again.

Not to Artemis.

He rose and walked toward the window, pushing the curtains aside. Orario spread beneath him, bright and bustling beneath the morning sun. Adventurers moved through the streets, merchants called to passing customers, and the distant Tower of Babel rose above the rooftops like a monument to humanity's defiance of the unknown.

It was a city built upon danger.

A city that had learned to live with monsters, gods, ambition, and death.

And somewhere within that world, a future was approaching.

Bell could not see its shape.

He did not know when it would arrive.

He did not know whether the Scorpion represented a literal enemy, a memory, or a symbol of something he had yet to encounter.

He did not even know why Artemis had appeared in his dream.

But he knew what he had to do.

He would investigate.

He would prepare.

He would search for every missing piece, question every assumption, and examine every possibility that could lead to the outcome he had witnessed.

If his divination was a warning, he would heed it.

If it was a test, he would meet it.

And if it was a future that could still be changed, then he would tear that future apart before it had the chance to take shape.

He would not blindly trust his own calculations.

He would not mistake confidence for certainty.

He would not let the satisfaction of victory blind him to the cost of achieving it.

Most importantly, he would not allow the people he cared about to become acceptable losses in a plan that had gone wrong.

Bell lowered his gaze.

His reflection stared back at him from the window.

For a moment, he thought of the reflection in the dream, the one that had asked him how many times he would watch Artemis die.

He had no answer.

Not then.

But he had one now.

"Never again."

The words were quiet, but there was no hesitation in them.

He pressed his palm against the glass.

"I don't know what you were trying to show me. I don't know whether you're a warning from the future, a fragment of my own fear, or something that shouldn't exist at all. I don't know why I saw Artemis, why I remembered a battle I thought I had already won, or why the dream felt more real than any nightmare I've ever experienced."

His reflection remained silent.

"But I know what I felt. I know what it was like to reach for someone and find that my hands weren't enough. I know what it was like to win everything I thought I needed to win and still lose the one person I couldn't bear to lose."

He swallowed.

"And I refuse to accept that as the end of the story."

His fingers curled against the glass.

"I've spent too much time believing that preparation can protect me from every possible mistake. If I gather enough information, if I calculate enough outcomes, if I prepare enough contingencies, then surely I'll be able to find a path through whatever stands in front of me. I've treated uncertainty like an enemy that can be eliminated if I work hard enough. I've treated the future like a puzzle, something that will eventually surrender its answer if I examine every piece."

He let out a slow breath.

"That's arrogance, isn't it? Maybe not the kind that makes a person boast or look down on others. Maybe the quieter kind. The kind that convinces someone he can carry every

responsibility alone because he believes he's clever enough to understand the consequences. The kind that makes him think he can control the outcome simply because he's prepared for it."

He looked down at his trembling hand.

"I can't save everyone by thinking harder. I can't prevent every tragedy by predicting it. And I can't promise that the people who stand beside me will never be hurt, no matter how carefully I plan."

His voice grew quieter.

"But that doesn't mean I should stop trying. It doesn't mean I should accept a future just because I've seen it once. And it certainly doesn't mean I should let fear convince me that failure is inevitable."

He drew his hand away from the window.

"If Artemis is in danger, then I need to find out why. If the Scorpion is part of that danger, then I need to understand it before I face it. If there are circumstances I failed to consider, then I'll uncover them. If there's someone manipulating events behind the scenes, I'll find them. And if my own judgment is the weakness that puts her at risk, then I'll confront that weakness before it costs me another chance."

His eyes hardened.

"I won't make the mistake of thinking that defeating an enemy is the same as protecting the people I care about. I won't walk away from a battlefield congratulating myself on a victory while ignoring the price someone else paid for it. And I won't let a plan become more important than the lives it's supposed to protect."

He paused, remembering the warmth of Artemis's hand.

For a moment, his expression softened.

"I don't know what she means to me in that dream. I don't know why her voice felt so familiar, or why the thought of losing her hurt as though I'd already lived through it. Perhaps it's a memory. Perhaps it's a warning. Perhaps my mind has shown me a future that hasn't happened yet."

His throat tightened.

"Whatever it is, I won't treat her death as an unavoidable conclusion. I won't decide that nothing can be done before I've even begun to search for a solution. And I won't turn away simply because the answer might be frightening."

He closed his eyes briefly.

"When the time comes, I may be afraid. I may hesitate. I may make mistakes despite everything I do to prepare. I can't promise that I'll always know the right answer, and I can't pretend that determination alone will make me strong enough to overcome every obstacle."

He opened his eyes.

"But I can promise that I won't stop looking for a way forward. I'll question my assumptions. I'll ask for help when I need it. I'll change my plans when the evidence demands it. And if the future tries to corner me into choosing between a clean victory and the life of someone who trusts me, then I'll find another choice, even if I have to create it myself."

His gaze shifted toward the distant Tower of Babel.

"The dream told me that seeing isn't saving. Perhaps that's the only part of it I should believe without question. Knowing what might happen is useless if I allow that knowledge to become another excuse to hesitate. A warning is not a victory. A prediction is not a solution. And fear, no matter how convincing it sounds, is not proof that the future has already been decided."

Bell straightened.

"I don't know what awaits me, Artemis. I don't know whether I'll reach you in time, whether I'll understand the danger before it strikes, or whether I'll be forced to face something far beyond anything I've prepared for. But if there's a chance to change what I've seen, I'll take it. If there's a path I haven't discovered, I'll search for it. And if every path I know leads to the same terrible ending, then I'll stop following those paths and make a new one."

His expression became coldly resolute.

"Because I refuse to let a dream decide who lives and who dies. I refuse to let a single vision convince me that my choices no longer matter. And I refuse to stand helplessly beside someone I could have saved simply because I was too late to understand what was happening."

He lowered his head.

"So, whatever you are—whatever you were trying to show me—watch carefully. If this is a warning, I'll answer it. If it's a glimpse of the future, I'll challenge it. And if it's a threat, then you've made one mistake."

His red eyes lifted.

"You've shown me where I might fail."

A faint, humorless smile touched his lips.

"And now that I know failure is possible, I'll prepare for it."

He turned away from the window and reached for his notebook.

The day was no longer a vacation.

The clone could continue distracting Orario. The city could keep laughing at its strange new rumor. The sun could continue shining over streets filled with people who had no idea that anything was wrong.

Bell no longer had the luxury of pretending that nothing required his attention.

He sat at the desk, opened the notebook to a fresh page, and began writing.

Artemis. The Scorpion. The dream. The divination skill.

Four points.

Four mysteries.

And perhaps one future that could still be changed.

Bell stared at the words for a long moment.

Then he added a final line beneath them.

Objective: Save Artemis. Determine the cause. Prevent the outcome.

He set down the pen.

For the first time since waking, his hands had stopped shaking.

He did not mistake that for courage.

He knew fear would return. He knew the coming days might prove far more complicated than anything he could anticipate. And he knew that, somewhere ahead, there might be a moment when all his preparation would fail him again.

But he would face that moment when it came.

Until then, he would move.

He would investigate.

He would prepare.

And he would not surrender to a future he had not yet allowed to happen.

Bell Cranel looked toward the door.

"Vacation's over."

Outside, the stars had vanished in the morning light.

Yet somewhere beyond the reach of the sun, something had already begun to move.

And Bell, for the first time, had reason to believe that it was moving toward him.

Got it. I misunderstood the timeline. The scorpion encounter is part of Bell's dream, not something happening in the present. This chapter should focus on Bell quietly analyzing the dream, preparing contingencies, and developing the theory behind Permanent Erasure. The montage should show his thought process and gradual preparation, not an actual battle or a successful casting.

Chapter Thirty-Three: Limits — I

Bell remained silent for a long time after waking.

The dream had been vivid enough to leave an unpleasant impression, but its details were already beginning to blur. The desolate landscape, the unfamiliar sky, the immense scorpion—all of them were fragments of a scenario that had never actually happened.

Yet Bell did not dismiss it.

Dreams were unreliable sources of information. He had no reason to believe that the events he witnessed would occur exactly as imagined, nor was there any guarantee that the monster in his dream even existed.

But the dream had presented him with a useful question.

What would I do if I encountered an opponent capable of matching me physically, one whose strength might fall somewhere between Level Seven and Level Eight?

He leaned back and closed his eyes.

And what if conventional methods weren't enough?

That was the part worth considering.

Bell had no intention of preparing for every imaginable disaster. Such a task would be meaningless. There were too many variables, too many unknowns, and too many situations in which preparation could not compensate for a fundamental disadvantage.

Instead, he preferred to identify the limits of his current capabilities and determine what he could do when those limits became a problem.

The scorpion in his dream had simply provided a convenient hypothetical opponent.

A powerful one, certainly.

But still hypothetical.

"Let's start with the obvious."

Bell reached for a piece of paper.

"Assume the opponent is faster than I am, possesses exceptional defensive capabilities, and can adapt to repeated attacks."

He wrote the conditions down.

Then he added another.

Assume that prolonged combat favors the opponent.

He studied the list.

Direct confrontation would be inefficient. Repeatedly increasing the power of his attacks would consume more resources without guaranteeing a decisive result. Exploiting a weakness would be preferable, but that required information he might not possess at the beginning of an encounter.

There was also the possibility that his opponent could adapt faster than he could devise a countermeasure.

Bell tapped the paper with his pen.

"So the solution isn't necessarily to become stronger."

It was to change the problem.

If the enemy's advantage came from superior durability, he needed an approach that did not rely on overcoming that durability. If the enemy could withstand his attacks, he needed to consider whether the concept of an attack itself was too limiting.

He paused.

Instead of damaging the target, what if I removed the target from the equation entirely?

His expression gradually lost its casualness.

There it was again.

The idea he had spent years refusing to pursue seriously.

Permanent Erasure.

He wrote the name at the top of a fresh page.

For several moments, he did nothing else.

The concept was deceptively simple to describe and extraordinarily difficult to implement. It was not a spell in the conventional sense, nor was it merely an advanced application of destructive magic.

It was an attempt to manipulate the fluctuations underlying a region of space until the physical presence of a chosen target could no longer be maintained within the affected region.

Destruction and erasure were fundamentally different propositions.

A stone reduced to dust still existed as matter. A body vaporized by extreme heat had undergone a transformation. Even an object displaced into another location had not ceased to exist.

All those processes changed the target's state.

Permanent Erasure sought to do something more radical.

Not break it. Not burn it. Not move it somewhere else.

Remove its physical presence from the current configuration of reality.

Bell rubbed his forehead.

"Which sounds much easier when I put it that way."

The difficulty lay in the assumptions behind the concept.

His understanding of spatial fluctuations allowed him to imagine how a region could be disturbed, how competing fluctuations might interfere with one another, and how a system might be forced toward a different configuration.

But eliminating a target's physical presence was not the same as simply canceling a fluctuation.

A fluctuation could be canceled. A physical object could not be made nonexistent merely by wishing its surrounding space into a different state.

There was a missing mechanism.

Bell began listing the problems.

First, the boundary.

He would need to define precisely which region was affected. Without a stable boundary, the process could spread beyond its intended target or collapse before producing any meaningful effect.

Second, the physical state of the target.

He could not simply treat matter as an inconvenience and disregard what happened to it. Its mass, structure, and associated energy had to be accounted for somehow. If the technique merely converted the target into energy, it would be an extraordinarily dangerous form of destruction rather than true erasure.

Third, the energy transfer.

The principle that energy could neither be created nor destroyed in an isolated system could not be ignored simply because the proposed technique was unusual. Any viable model would need to explain how the process conserved energy, or establish the conditions under which the technique interacted with a larger system.

Fourth, stability.

Even if the first three problems could be solved theoretically, the process had to remain controlled from beginning to end.

One instability could invalidate everything.

Bell stared at the notes.

Four problems. And each one could become a research project of its own.

He almost laughed.

Almost.

He had spent enough time exploring unusual applications of his abilities to know that a promising concept was not the same as a workable technique.

Still, the idea had survived his scrutiny for a reason.

There was a potential advantage in changing the objective from damaging a target to altering the conditions under which its physical presence persisted. If the mechanism could be made to work, it might bypass defenses designed specifically to withstand conventional attacks.

That possibility alone justified further investigation.

But not reckless experimentation.

Bell turned to a new page and began outlining a sequence of hypothetical tests.

A small, inert object would be the logical starting point. No living target, no large mass, and no attempt at complete erasure. The first objective would be to determine whether a controlled boundary could be maintained without producing dangerous side effects.

Only after that would he consider manipulating the physical state of the object within the boundary.

The tests would have to be incremental.

If the boundary failed, he needed to understand why. If the energy transfer became unstable, he would need a way to terminate the process safely. If the results contradicted his model, he would revise the model rather than force the experiment to conform to his expectations.

And if I cannot establish a reliable stopping mechanism, I do not proceed.

He underlined that sentence.

It was an important distinction.

Permanent Erasure was not dangerous merely because it might be powerful. It was dangerous because he did not yet know how to define its failure conditions with sufficient precision.

An ordinary technique could be abandoned when its energy requirements became excessive or its structure began to collapse.

A process that altered the physical state of a region in an unprecedented way demanded more caution.

Bell would not build a weapon that he could neither control nor reliably stop.

Not even in pursuit of an advantage against a hypothetical Level Eight opponent.

The following days became a quiet routine of research and revision.

Bell divided his time between ordinary responsibilities and the problem he had chosen to investigate. He reviewed his previous observations, reconstructed old calculations, and discarded several approaches that initially appeared promising.

Some ideas failed because they relied on treating spatial fluctuations as if they were independent objects.

Others failed because they assumed that canceling the effects of a fluctuation would automatically remove the matter occupying the affected region.

It would not.

He repeatedly returned to that distinction.

Changing the space around something is not the same as changing the thing itself.

The realization forced him to reconsider the foundation of his theory.

He began treating the boundary not as a weapon, but as a controlled experimental region. Its purpose would be to isolate the intended effect, limit unintended interactions, and provide a defined volume within which the process could be studied.

He also began separating the technique into distinct stages.

Establishing the boundary.

Stabilizing the fluctuations.

Determining how the target's physical state interacted with the affected region.

Managing the associated energy transfer.

And finally, terminating the process without allowing residual instability to propagate.

Every stage depended on the one before it.

There would be no skipping ahead simply because he wanted results.

The work was slow.

At times, painfully so.

Several pages of calculations could be rendered useless by a single incorrect assumption. A promising arrangement could collapse under a minor change in the model. More than once, Bell found himself returning to a problem he had believed resolved, only to discover that his earlier solution had merely concealed the difficulty.

Yet he continued.

Not because he believed success was inevitable, but because each failure narrowed the range of possibilities.

Knowing why something cannot work is still useful. It saves me from trying the same mistake under different names.

He gradually developed a list of requirements that any future version of Permanent Erasure would have to satisfy.

It needed a clearly defined target region.

It needed a stable and measurable process.

It needed an explanation for the disposition of the target's matter and energy.

It needed to remain localized.

And it needed a reliable means of termination.

Until those conditions could be met, the technique would remain a theoretical project rather than a usable ability.

Bell was comfortable with that.

A half-finished technique was not a failure.

Pretending it was complete would be.

As the work progressed, his thoughts returned occasionally to the scorpion.

Not to the dream itself, but to the tactical problem it represented.

A physically superior opponent would punish inefficiency. An adaptive opponent would punish repetition. An opponent capable of matching his own abilities would force him to reconsider the assumptions on which he normally relied.

The answer was not to depend on Permanent Erasure alone.

That would merely replace one weakness with another.

He needed alternatives.

Bell began reviewing his existing repertoire, examining which abilities could be used defensively, which could create distance, and which could buy enough time for him to assess an unfamiliar enemy.

He considered how he might gather information without exposing himself unnecessarily. He thought about terrain, visibility, escape routes, and the possibility of disengaging from an unfavorable encounter.

He also considered the simplest solution of all.

Leaving.

There is no virtue in fighting an opponent on its own terms when I have no reason to do so.

A hypothetical Level Eight monster was a serious threat. That did not mean he had to defeat it immediately, nor did it mean that every encounter needed to end with one combatant dead.

Information could be more valuable than victory.

Survival could be more valuable than information.

And retreat could be the only rational option when neither victory nor useful information justified the risk.

Bell added another note to his preparations.

Do not commit to Permanent Erasure until the situation demands it and the conditions for safe use are satisfied.

He looked at the sentence for a moment, then nodded.

That was the purpose of preparation: not to force himself into using a particular solution, but to ensure that he had more than one available when circumstances became unfavorable.

Eventually, Bell set his pen down.

The pages before him contained no miraculous breakthrough. There was no completed formula, no perfected technique, and no guarantee that Permanent Erasure would ever become practical.

There were only hypotheses, rejected assumptions, revised calculations, and a clearer understanding of what remained unknown.

For now, that was enough.

He gathered the papers and arranged them carefully.

The dream had not revealed the future. The scorpion had not issued a prophecy, and its estimated level was nothing more than a hypothetical benchmark.

Bell understood all of that.

But the exercise had exposed a question he could no longer ignore.

What would happen when his existing abilities reached their limits?

He glanced at the page bearing the name of his unfinished technique.

I don't need to solve everything today.

That was the first sensible thought he had entertained in hours.

I only need to make sure that when the day comes, I understand what I'm attempting—and what it might cost me.

He closed the notebook.

Permanent Erasure remained incomplete. Its principles were uncertain, its risks unresolved, and its practical application far beyond his current reach.

But it no longer existed only as an idea he avoided.

It had become a problem he intended to solve.

And Bell had always been patient when the problem was worth the effort.

Chapter Thirty-Four: Limits — II

Techniques were fascinating things.

They were more than the mere repetition of movements or the refinement of a warrior's instincts. A technique could transform an ordinary strike into something extraordinary, turning strength into destruction and precision into an executioner's blade. With the right technique, a warrior could surpass the limits of his own body and produce an attack that seemed to defy the very laws governing the world.

A swordsman could enchant his weapon, gather his strength, and swing with such overwhelming force that even a mountain might be cleaved apart.

At least, that was the theory.

Bell Cranel knew of such a technique.

Heroes Afterglow.

A technique developed by the Zeus and Hera Familias, two legendary powers whose names had once commanded the greatest respect in Orario. Their adventurers had stood at the summit of the world, challenging monsters that ordinary people could scarcely imagine and pursuing feats that would be remembered long after their deaths.

Their legacy had left behind more than stories.

It had left behind techniques.

And among them was Heroes Afterglow, a method of dramatically amplifying the destructive power of an attack by gathering and concentrating the surrounding excelia into a single moment of release.

Bell could perform it.

To an extent.

He understood its structure, its underlying principles, and the method required to initiate the technique. He could feel the subtle changes in the atmosphere when excelia gathered around him. He could direct that energy, compress it, and channel it through his body before releasing it alongside an attack.

Yet, no matter how thoroughly he examined the technique, something remained beyond his grasp.

The difference between what he could perform and what the technique was truly capable of was simply too great.

He could imitate the form.

He could reproduce the effect.

But he could not reach its ultimate state.

Limit Off.

The name alone suggested something simple: a deliberate removal of one's restraints, a decision to unleash everything that had been held back.

That interpretation, however, was fundamentally wrong.

Limit Off was not a second stage of Heroes Afterglow. It was not an advanced variation that could be acquired through sufficient practice, nor was it a hidden technique waiting to be discovered by someone talented enough to understand its principles.

It was something else entirely.

A phenomenon in which the excelia permeating the surroundings was gathered and concentrated into a single attack, producing an overwhelming increase in power.

A temporary answer to the difference between levels.

An attack capable of surpassing the natural restrictions that governed combat between adventurers.

In theory, a Level One adventurer could use Limit Off to defeat a Level Three opponent with a single, properly executed strike.

The difference between their levels would not disappear. Their bodies would not suddenly become equal, and the weaker adventurer would not acquire the stronger one's experience.

Instead, for one fleeting moment, the attack itself could bridge that impossible gap.

It was an absurd prospect.

An adventurer's level represented far more than raw strength. It encompassed the accumulated benefits of Falna, the refinement of the body, and the advantages earned through growth and experience. Overcoming such a difference with a single attack should have been unreasonable.

Yet Limit Off offered precisely that possibility.

A miracle disguised as a technique.

And Bell could not use it.

He had spent countless hours attempting to understand its essence. He had analyzed its principles, tested its limits, and examined the accounts left behind by those who had witnessed the legendary adventurers of the past.

The more he learned, the less satisfied he became.

There was no reliable formula he could derive from the information available to him. No sequence of movements. No precise quantity of excelia. No particular emotional state that could be reproduced on command.

The technique resisted being reduced to a system.

And Bell hated systems that refused to explain themselves.

If the surrounding excelia can be gathered and concentrated, then there must be a mechanism governing the process.

His eyes followed the movement of his own hand as he slowly closed his fingers.

Energy does not gather itself without a cause. Even if the phenomenon appears miraculous, there must be conditions that allow it to occur.

He could accept an incomplete explanation.

He could even accept that his current knowledge was insufficient.

What he found intolerable was the possibility that the missing element could not be acquired through knowledge alone.

What am I missing?

The answer, he suspected, lay in the name itself.

Heroes Afterglow.

Limit Off.

They were not names chosen at random. Whoever had created the technique had understood something that Bell, despite his efforts, had yet to comprehend.

The technique was called Heroes Afterglow for a reason.

And Limit Off was not simply a command to unleash one's power.

It was a call.

A call for a hero to stand up.

A call for someone to fight when defeat seemed inevitable.

A call for someone to continue even when the price of victory could not be justified by reason alone.

A call to win a battle that should never have been winnable.

Bell stared at his palm.

What does it mean to be a hero?

He knew the stories.

Every child in the world had heard them. Heroes who slew dragons, heroes who rescued princesses, heroes who challenged evil gods and returned triumphant from impossible adventures.

But stories were convenient things.

They removed the hesitation before a battle, the fear that preceded a sacrifice, and the doubts that lingered after a victory. They turned complicated people into symbols and painful decisions into beautiful conclusions.

A hero could be praised for saving a hundred people.

But what of the one person he failed to save?

What of the innocent stranger who died because the hero had chosen to protect someone else?

What of the adventurer who risked his life for a person he had never met, knowing perfectly well that the stranger might never repay him, remember him, or even understand what he had sacrificed?

Why would anyone do such a thing?

Why should they?

Bell understood the practical reasons for helping others. Cooperation improved survival rates. Alliances created opportunities. Protecting allies preserved valuable resources, while rescuing civilians could prevent unnecessary losses.

Those were rational explanations.

They were also insufficient.

If a person helps another because doing so is advantageous, then the act is merely an exchange.

If a person risks his life because he expects a reward, then he is simply making a wager.

But what of someone who expects nothing in return?

His fingers tightened.

What makes that person move?

He could not find the answer within himself.

Not because Bell lacked the ability to recognize suffering, nor because he was incapable of understanding compassion. He knew that people experienced pain. He knew that fear could make even the strongest warrior hesitate, and that desperation could drive ordinary people to extraordinary acts.

He simply could not understand why another person's suffering should become one's own responsibility.

The world was vast.

Suffering was everywhere.

No individual possessed the strength to save everyone, and no amount of goodwill could change that fact. Even a powerful adventurer had limits. Even a god, for all the authority and divinity such a being possessed, could not simply erase every misfortune from the world.

Then why did heroes continue trying?

Was it foolishness?

An instinctive rejection of helplessness?

Or was there something within a hero that could not tolerate standing aside, even when reason insisted that doing so was the only sensible choice?

Bell lowered his hand.

He had no answer.

And without understanding that answer, he could not grasp Limit Off.

Perhaps the technique was not activated by a specific emotion. Perhaps it did not require a noble heart or an unshakable conviction. It would have been foolish to assume that every person capable of using it had to possess the same personality or beliefs.

But something connected the phenomenon to the idea of a hero.

Something that could not be reproduced simply by understanding the mathematics of excelia.

Something Bell had yet to discover.

How inconvenient.

The thought was almost enough to make him laugh.

He could study magic, develop new applications, refine his combat methods, and construct increasingly sophisticated strategies. Given sufficient time, he could turn unfamiliar principles into practical tools.

But this?

This was a question without a clear answer.

And for the first time in a while, Bell found himself facing a problem that could not be solved merely by thinking harder.

He would have to keep searching.

Until then, Heroes Afterglow would remain an incomplete achievement, and Limit Off would remain beyond his reach.

A locked door.

And he had not yet found the key.

The smell of dinner brought Bell back to the present.

By the time evening settled over Orario, the room had grown warm with the scent of freshly prepared food. The familiar sounds of dishes, utensils, and quiet conversation filled the Hestia Familia's home.

Bell sat at the table with his meal in front of him.

Across from him, Hestia was already halfway through her own dinner.

She had been talking for several minutes.

Bell had heard approximately a third of it.

"...and then I told her that there was absolutely no way I was going to wear something that ridiculous! Honestly, what kind of festival outfit has sleeves that long? How am I supposed to move around?"

Hestia waved her fork indignantly.

Bell chewed.

"Are you even listening to me, Bell?"

"Yes."

"What did I just say?"

"You don't like the sleeves."

"That's not all I said!"

"You also questioned the practicality of the outfit."

Hestia narrowed her eyes.

Bell swallowed his food.

"And you believe the proposed design would interfere with your movement during the festival."

For a moment, Hestia simply stared at him.

Then she pointed her fork at his face.

"You're doing that thing again!"

"What thing?"

"That thing where you repeat what I say in a way that makes it sound like you're writing a report!"

Bell tilted his head.

"I thought you wanted me to listen."

"I do! But you could at least sound interested!"

"I am interested."

"Then show it!"

Bell considered the matter.

"I see."

Hestia's cheeks puffed out.

"That's even worse!"

Bell quietly returned to his meal.

I should have anticipated this outcome.

He had, in fact, anticipated it. Hestia's complaints about his apparent lack of enthusiasm were a familiar occurrence. She wanted him to react more naturally, which usually meant providing the sort of response she expected rather than the most accurate response available.

Unfortunately, he had never found a reliable method of determining what that response should be.

It was a small but persistent mystery.

One he had no intention of investigating tonight.

He reached for his cup.

Then Hestia said something that caught his attention.

"Anyway, tomorrow is the Moon Festival!"

Bell stopped drinking.

Slowly, he lowered his cup.

"...The Moon Festival?"

Hestia blinked.

Then her expression brightened with the satisfaction of someone who had finally discovered a way to command another person's attention.

"Oh? Now you're listening!"

"Please continue."

"Look at you! Suddenly so interested!"

"Hestia."

"What?"

"What is the Moon Festival?"

She drew herself up, clearly delighted to have an audience at last.

"The Moon Festival is an annual celebration! Different parts of Orario have their own traditions, but the city becomes especially lively during the festival. There are stalls, performances, special foods, and all sorts of events. Some familias organize celebrations of their own, while others participate in the festivities throughout the city."

Bell listened without interrupting.

Hestia noticed.

Her smile grew.

"And, of course, there are decorations everywhere! Lanterns, moon-shaped ornaments, illuminated streets, the whole thing! It's especially beautiful after sunset."

"Is it connected to a particular deity?"

"Not exclusively. Different cultures have their own stories about the moon, and the festival has accumulated a lot of traditions over the years. Some people treat it as a celebration of the harvest, others as a night for making wishes or spending time with the people they care about."

She paused to take a bite.

"There's even a tradition in some places where people exchange little gifts beneath the moonlight."

Bell's expression remained composed.

Inside, however, his attention had sharpened.

A citywide celebration.

He set his utensils down.

"What sort of events will take place tomorrow?"

Hestia blinked again.

This time, she did not immediately respond.

Bell was asking questions.

Several questions, in fact.

Not the polite, perfunctory questions he sometimes asked to keep a conversation moving, but specific inquiries intended to extract useful information.

For Hestia, the distinction was unmistakable.

"Well..." She leaned forward. "There's a procession in one of the main districts, and a number of merchants will be setting up special stalls. There should be street performances, too. Depending on where you go, you might find musicians, dancers, storytellers, or adventurers demonstrating their skills."

"Demonstrations?"

"Of course! Some familias like showing off a little during festivals. It's an opportunity to attract attention, after all. Not everyone is interested in watching adventurers fight monsters in the Dungeon, but plenty of people enjoy seeing what they can do when there's no immediate danger."

Bell nodded.

"Will the major familias participate?"

"Some will. Others will be too busy with their own arrangements. It depends on the familia."

"Will there be any restrictions on entering their grounds?"

"That depends on the event. Public celebrations are open to everyone, but private gatherings are another matter. Why? Are you planning to visit someone?"

"No."

"Then why are you asking?"

"Because I would prefer to know what to expect before entering an unfamiliar environment."

Hestia stared at him.

"...You're going to treat a festival like an expedition, aren't you?"

"Preparation reduces unnecessary complications."

"It's a festival, Bell! Not a dangerous mission!"

"Those two things aren't mutually exclusive."

Hestia opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Then she sighed and pressed a hand against her forehead.

"Sometimes, I really don't know what goes on inside that head of yours."

Bell picked up his utensils again.

Neither do I, occasionally.

Outwardly, he remained attentive.

"Is there anything else I should know?"

Hestia lowered her hand.

"There is, actually."

Her voice had changed slightly.

Bell recognized the shift. Hestia was no longer merely describing the festival. She was preparing to tell him something she considered important.

He put his utensils down once more.

"Go ahead."

"Tomorrow's going to be crowded. Really crowded. The main streets will probably be packed from midday onward, and the areas near the biggest events might become difficult to navigate."

"Are there any particular areas I should avoid?"

"Not necessarily avoid. Just be careful. Crowds can be unpredictable, especially when people start moving toward the same attraction. And don't wander too far from the main streets if you don't know the area well."

Bell nodded.

"Understood."

"And don't get into trouble!"

"I generally try to avoid doing that."

"Bell."

"I'll be careful."

Hestia continued watching him for a moment, apparently deciding whether she believed him.

Eventually, she relented.

"Good. Also, if you see any suspicious activity, don't assume it's part of the festival. There will be plenty of people from outside Orario visiting, and not everyone who comes here has good intentions."

That earned a more thoughtful reaction.

Bell's gaze drifted toward the window.

The Dungeon made Orario famous, but the city was not merely a gathering place for adventurers. It was a center of commerce, politics, and competing interests. A festival that attracted visitors from beyond the city walls would create opportunities for all sorts of people.

Merchants could expand their businesses.

Familias could recruit potential members.

Travelers could exchange information.

And those with less honorable intentions could exploit the crowds.

An event that concentrates large numbers of people into predictable locations creates both opportunities and vulnerabilities.

He began mentally arranging the information.

The main streets would be crowded. Public events would draw predictable audiences. Familias might use the celebration to display their influence. Unfamiliar visitors would make it more difficult to distinguish ordinary behavior from suspicious activity.

Nothing especially unusual.

Nothing that justified immediate concern.

Still, he would be a fool to assume that a citywide celebration was incapable of producing complications.

I should familiarize myself with the event locations before tomorrow. If nothing happens, the preparation will have cost me little. If something does happen, I will have fewer variables to consider.

He glanced back at Hestia.

"Do you know where the main procession will begin?"

She blinked.

"Why do you want to know that?"

"So I can plan my route."

"You're actually planning to go?"

"Unless there's a reason I shouldn't."

Hestia's expression softened.

"No. Of course not."

For a moment, she seemed almost surprised.

Then a small smile appeared on her face.

"I was just wondering whether you'd spend the whole day cooped up here, studying something or tinkering with your magic."

Bell did not answer immediately.

He could have explained that he had no particular objection to festivals, only to the inconvenience of entering a crowded environment without sufficient information.

He could have told her that the celebration presented an opportunity to observe Orario under different conditions.

He could even have admitted that he was curious about the event itself.

Instead, he said, "I haven't decided what I'll do yet."

Hestia's smile widened.

"Well, you should go out and enjoy yourself! You don't have to turn everything into a research project."

"I'll keep that in mind."

"And if you find something delicious, bring some back!"

"That depends on what I find."

"Bell!"

"I'm joking."

Hestia froze.

Bell calmly resumed eating.

For several seconds, the room was silent.

Then Hestia pointed at him with her fork again.

"You're getting better at that!"

"At eating?"

"At teasing me!"

"Is that a good thing?"

"That depends on how often you do it!"

Bell gave the matter the same consideration he would have given any other uncertain proposition.

"I see."

Hestia groaned.

Dinner continued with Hestia explaining the festival's customs in greater detail.

Some of the information was practical. Certain streets would be closed to ordinary traffic during the procession. Merchants tended to raise their prices near the busiest attractions. Food stalls often sold special dishes that were only available during the celebration.

Other details were less useful.

Hestia described the decorations she wanted to see, the food she intended to try, and the possibility of finding a suitable outfit for the occasion.

Bell listened to all of it.

Mostly.

He asked a few more questions, particularly about the procession's route and the areas where the largest gatherings were expected to form. Hestia answered as best she could, occasionally interrupting herself to complain that he was asking too many questions.

Eventually, she set her utensils aside.

"By the way, Bell."

"Hm?"

"What are you going to do if you meet someone interesting tomorrow?"

Bell paused.

"Define interesting."

"Someone you'd like to talk to, obviously!"

"That depends on the circumstances."

Hestia stared at him.

"You're impossible."

"I've been told."

"You're supposed to say something like, 'I'll introduce myself and see where things go!'"

"Wouldn't that depend on whether the other person wanted to speak with me?"

Hestia's shoulders slumped.

"Why do I even try?"

Bell considered offering a more reassuring answer, but he suspected that doing so would only prolong the conversation.

Besides, he had no intention of making promises about an encounter that had not yet occurred.

Assuming I meet anyone worth talking to.

The thought was not dismissive. He simply had no particular expectations.

Festivals were social occasions, and social occasions were often filled with conversations that produced little beyond temporary amusement. He could appreciate the value of such interactions without feeling compelled to seek them out.

Still, Hestia had provided him with something useful.

A rough understanding of the event.

Its schedule, its crowds, its customs, and its potential complications.

For once, her tendency to talk at length had produced information he could immediately apply.

I should acknowledge that.

"Thank you for explaining everything."

Hestia looked up.

"...You're welcome?"

Her expression suggested she was uncertain how to respond to the sudden sincerity.

Bell inclined his head slightly.

"It was helpful."

A moment passed.

Then Hestia's face lit up.

"Hehehe! Of course it was! Your goddess knows everything about these things!"

Bell made no attempt to challenge that statement.

He simply returned to his dinner.

Not everything.

He had already identified several gaps in her account, though they were hardly important enough to mention.

But enough.

And sometimes, that was all a person needed.

Later, after dinner had ended and the dishes had been cleared away, Bell returned to his room.

The evening was quiet.

From outside came the distant sounds of Orario settling into the night. Somewhere beyond the walls, people were still working, drinking, arguing, or preparing for the celebration that would begin the following day.

The Moon Festival.

Bell sat at his desk and considered what he had learned.

He had no obligation to participate. He could spend the entire day studying, practicing his magic, or examining the problems that continued to occupy his thoughts.

Limit Off remained an unresolved question.

The nature of heroism remained an even more troublesome one.

Neither would disappear simply because the city had decided to celebrate.

Yet perhaps that was precisely why the festival deserved some consideration.

Heroes did not exist exclusively in stories about battles and monsters. If the concept meant anything beyond a convenient label for extraordinary individuals, it ought to have some connection to the ordinary lives those individuals supposedly protected.

Families gathering beneath lanterns.

Children running between food stalls.

Merchants hoping for a profitable day.

Strangers sharing a meal without needing a reason to do so.

People living their lives, often without ever considering how easily those lives could be disrupted.

Bell leaned back in his chair.

Is this what a hero is supposed to protect?

The question surfaced before he could dismiss it.

He had spent so long examining heroism as an abstract problem that he had begun to overlook the people contained within the concept.

Perhaps the answer was not something he could derive from the accounts of legendary adventurers.

Perhaps it could not be discovered through a technique's underlying principles, no matter how thoroughly he dissected them.

Perhaps the only way to understand it was to observe the world beyond the battlefield.

To see what people valued.

What they feared losing.

What made them laugh, and what caused them to grieve.

It was an inconvenient possibility.

It was also worth investigating.

Bell rose and walked to the window.

The moon hung above the city, pale light spilling across the rooftops. Orario's towers and walls stood in silhouette beneath it, their outlines familiar even in darkness.

Tomorrow, the streets would be filled with people.

The city would change, if only for a day.

And Bell, who had spent so much of his time trying to understand the extraordinary, would have an opportunity to observe something decidedly ordinary.

He was not certain what he expected to find.

But he had learned that uncertainty was not, by itself, a reason to abandon an investigation.

"Well," he murmured, watching the moon, "I suppose one day won't hurt."

It was not enthusiasm.

Not quite.

But it was a decision.

He turned away from the window and returned to his desk, already considering which tasks he could finish before morning.

Tomorrow was the Moon Festival.

And for once, Bell Cranel intended to step outside without treating the entire city as a problem that needed solving.

Whether he would succeed was another matter entirely.

Chapter Thirty-Five: Moon Festival

The morning sun rose over Orario, spilling its golden light across the city's countless rooftops. The streets, usually crowded with merchants, adventurers, and ordinary citizens going about their daily business, had transformed overnight into something altogether different.

Colorful banners stretched between buildings. Lanterns hung from wooden frames, waiting for the evening to illuminate them. Merchants hurried to arrange their stalls, while children darted through the streets with paper masks and little festival toys clutched in their hands.

The Moon Festival had arrived.

And Orario intended to celebrate it with all its heart.

Bell Cranel stood before the mirror in his temporary lodgings, fastening the final button of his shirt.

He examined his reflection for several seconds.

Then he tilted his head.

"Not bad."

He turned sideways.

"Could be better."

A pause.

"Though I suppose I shouldn't be wasting time judging my appearance."

Bell stepped away from the mirror and approached the table, where a small collection of objects had been laid out. A few coins, a folded map of the festival grounds, and a small pouch containing several magical tools.

His eyes lingered on the map.

There were dozens of stalls, games, performances, and public gatherings scattered throughout the city. The festival had been designed to accommodate everyone, from wealthy merchants to the poorest residents of Orario.

Which, naturally, meant there would be opportunities for observation.

And experimentation.

Bell picked up the map.

"Let's see. Food stalls in the eastern district, performances near the central plaza, carnival games around the main avenue..."

His finger traced a route across the paper.

"And the northern district has the largest gathering area."

He smiled faintly.

"Convenient."

The festival offered something that ordinary days rarely did: a chance to move through the city without attracting too much attention. Everyone would be distracted. The crowds would be dense, the streets noisy, and countless people would be wearing masks or costumes.

For someone who preferred observing without being observed, it was almost ideal.

Bell tucked the map away.

"All right. Time to get moving."

He reached for the door, then stopped.

A thought had occurred to him.

I should probably establish a few ground rules first.

He raised one hand.

A faint distortion rippled through the air.

For a moment, the room seemed to bend around him, as though reality itself had briefly forgotten its proper shape. Then the distortion vanished, leaving behind another Bell Cranel.

The newly created Bell looked around the room before turning toward the original.

"So," the clone said, "what exactly am I supposed to do?"

Bell considered him.

"Enjoy the festival."

The clone stared.

"That's it?"

"That's it."

"You're telling me that you created me to enjoy a festival?"

"Would you prefer a complicated assignment?"

The clone folded his arms.

"Frankly, yes. It would make more sense."

Bell laughed quietly.

"Then consider this an exercise in independent judgment. Eat whatever you want, visit whatever stalls interest you, and don't cause trouble."

"And if trouble finds me?"

"Try not to make it worse."

"That's remarkably vague."

"It's a remarkably vague festival."

The clone sighed.

Bell patted him on the shoulder.

"Besides, I trust your judgment."

The clone's expression softened for a brief moment before he caught himself.

"You're only saying that because you don't want to do everything yourself."

"Now you're learning."

"Go to hell."

"Have fun!"

Bell slipped through the doorway before his counterpart could reply.

Behind him, the clone stood in silence for a moment.

Then he looked at the door.

"...I really do hate that guy sometimes."

He paused.

"Which is unfortunate, considering that guy is me."

And with that, the two Bells went their separate ways.

I. An Ordinary Festival Date

By noon, the eastern district had become a river of people.

The smell of grilled meat mingled with the sweetness of candied fruit. Vendors shouted over one another, advertising everything from handmade jewelry to strange trinkets supposedly brought back from the Dungeon. Musicians played lively tunes at street corners, and the occasional burst of laughter rose above the general commotion.

Amid the crowd, a familiar pair walked side by side.

"Bell, look at that stall."

The clone followed the direction of Ryuu Lion's gaze.

A merchant had arranged several rows of colorful sweets on a wooden counter. Some resembled tiny flowers, others little animals, and a few appeared to have been shaped after monsters.

Ryuu regarded them with quiet curiosity.

"They're rather elaborate."

"Want to try some?"

She looked at him.

"Are you offering to buy them?"

"I thought that was generally how purchasing things worked."

"How insightful."

The clone placed a hand over his chest.

"Your praise wounds me, Ryuu. I was hoping for something more enthusiastic."

"You have my deepest admiration for understanding basic commerce."

"That's cold."

"Would you prefer that I lie?"

"No. Actually, no. Please don't."

Ryuu's lips curved into a small smile.

The expression was subtle, but the clone noticed it immediately.

Ah. There it is.

He had seen that smile countless times in his own memories. He knew its smallest variations: the restrained curve of her lips when amused, the faint narrowing of her eyes when suspicious, and the rare, almost imperceptible softness that appeared when she was genuinely comfortable.

This version of Ryuu was relaxed.

No tension in her shoulders. No habitual scanning of every alleyway. No hand hovering near a weapon.

For once, she was simply a woman enjoying an afternoon with someone she cared about.

The clone found that strangely reassuring.

"Two, please," he told the merchant.

The sweets were placed in a small paper tray. He handed one to Ryuu.

She examined it before taking a bite.

"...It's good."

"High praise indeed."

"You asked for my opinion."

"And I appreciate it."

They continued down the street, sampling food from several stalls. Ryuu chose a skewer of grilled meat, while the clone became unexpectedly interested in a vendor selling fried dumplings.

After their third stop, Ryuu glanced at him.

"You seem unusually enthusiastic about the food."

"Is that a problem?"

"No. I'm merely observing."

"Then allow me to observe that the dumplings here are excellent."

"You said that about the meat skewers."

"They were also excellent."

"And the sweets?"

"Excellent."

Ryuu gave him a long look.

"Your standards appear remarkably consistent."

"I believe in fairness."

"You believe in eating."

"That too."

She shook her head, but the smile remained.

For a while, they wandered without any particular destination. They watched a group of children perform a clumsy imitation of famous adventurers, stopped to listen to a street musician, and passed beneath rows of festival banners swaying gently in the breeze.

Eventually, Ryuu reached for his hand.

The clone looked down.

Then he looked at her.

"Something wrong?" she asked.

"No."

"Then why are you staring?"

"I'm trying to determine whether this is a trap."

Ryuu's expression became perfectly blank.

"Would you like me to let go?"

"No."

"Then stop talking."

He closed his fingers around hers.

"Understood."

Their hands remained joined as they disappeared into the crowd.

For several minutes, neither spoke.

The clone found himself wondering whether the original Bell ever allowed himself such moments. The real one was always thinking, calculating, preparing for the next problem before the current one had even finished unfolding.

It was a useful habit.

But perhaps there was a cost.

If he spends every waking moment trying to understand the world, when does he actually live in it?

The clone glanced at Ryuu.

She was watching a pair of children chase one another around a lantern stand.

Perhaps that's why he made me.

The thought lingered.

Perhaps this was not merely an experiment. Perhaps Bell had created a separate set of hands, eyes, and experiences so that some portion of himself could explore the things he would otherwise overlook.

Or perhaps he simply wanted an excuse to avoid shopping.

The clone decided not to give his creator too much credit.

"Ryuu?"

"Hm?"

"Would you like to visit the river later? I heard they're releasing floating lanterns tonight."

She looked at him for a moment.

"That sounds pleasant."

"Then it's a date."

"It already was one."

The clone stopped walking.

Ryuu continued for two steps before noticing.

She turned.

"What is it?"

He stared at her.

Then a slow smile spread across his face.

"...You really shouldn't say things like that without warning."

"Why?"

"Because I might start thinking I'm a lucky man."

Ryuu's cheeks colored ever so slightly.

"You are being ridiculous."

"Perhaps."

He resumed walking, still smiling.

Ryuu squeezed his hand once.

And for the remainder of the afternoon, the clone made a conscious effort not to think about anything complicated.

He almost succeeded.

II. The Apple Problem

Meanwhile, the original Bell Cranel was conducting an investigation of his own.

It involved apples.

Lots of apples.

He stood before a fruit stall, holding a bright red specimen in one hand. Its skin was smooth, its surface glossy, and its shape nearly perfect.

The merchant watched him expectantly.

"Freshly picked this morning, young man! Sweet, crisp, and full of juice. Best apples in the district!"

Bell nodded.

"How much?"

"Three valis each."

Bell bought one.

He inspected it for a moment, then took a bite.

Crunch.

He chewed slowly.

The merchant waited.

Bell swallowed.

"...Mostly water."

The merchant's smile faltered.

"I'm sorry?"

"The texture is good. The skin is intact. The sugar content seems acceptable, although I haven't measured it."

Bell took another bite.

"But the flavor is rather ordinary."

The merchant stared at him.

"Young man, it's an apple."

"Yes."

"What were you expecting?"

Bell considered the question seriously.

"Something more interesting."

The merchant opened his mouth, closed it, then pointed toward the street.

"There's a sweets stall three stalls down."

"I know."

"Then why are you buying apples?"

"Because I wanted to know what they tasted like."

The merchant looked as though he regretted opening his business that morning.

Bell thanked him and continued on his way.

An ordinary apple. An ordinary taste. An ordinary result.

He finished the fruit and discarded the core in a nearby receptacle.

Yet people are willing to travel considerable distances for certain varieties. Differences in soil, climate, cultivation methods, and storage conditions must account for much of that.

His gaze drifted toward another stall.

Or perhaps taste is simply one of those things that becomes more complicated the more closely you examine it.

He stopped before a display of green apples.

"...Should I test another?"

A passing child looked up at him.

"Big brother, are you talking to yourself?"

Bell glanced down.

"Yes."

"Why?"

"Because I'm the only one here who understands the question."

The child blinked.

Then, without another word, he ran back to his mother.

Bell watched him go.

"...That was probably unnecessary."

He picked up a green apple.

One more should be sufficient.

He paid for it and took a bite.

His expression did not change.

"Still mostly water."

A merchant nearby burst out laughing.

Bell looked toward him.

"Is there something amusing?"

"No, no! Nothing at all!"

The man turned away, shoulders shaking.

Bell sighed.

I should have bought a pear.

He continued through the festival, keeping a comfortable distance from the clone and Ryuu. There was no need to interfere with their outing. The separation was deliberate, and he had no intention of ruining it merely because he could.

Besides, observing the festival offered its own advantages.

He noticed which stalls attracted the largest crowds, which merchants were skilled at recognizing customers, and which carnival games seemed designed to produce an endless stream of disappointed participants.

Some games were honest.

Others were honest in the technical sense that the rules were displayed prominently, even if the odds were laughably unfavorable.

And then there were the games that seemed to operate on a completely different principle.

Bell slowed beside a booth where a muscular adventurer was attempting to knock down a row of wooden targets.

The man threw a ball.

Three targets fell.

The merchant smiled and handed him a small prize.

The adventurer laughed triumphantly.

Bell watched the next participant throw.

The ball struck the targets with considerably more force, yet none fell.

He tilted his head.

Interesting.

He moved closer.

The wooden targets appeared ordinary. The balls were slightly heavier than standard carnival equipment, but not enough to explain the discrepancy. The booth itself had been constructed on level ground.

There was, however, a faint metallic vibration beneath the counter.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

Magical assistance? Or mechanical interference?

The merchant caught him looking.

"Want to try, young man?"

Bell smiled politely.

"Perhaps later."

He walked away.

Definitely mechanical interference.

A faint grin appeared on his face.

I should investigate that after dinner.

He adjusted the collar of his shirt and continued toward the northern district.

The festival was becoming more interesting by the minute.

III. A Spear Beneath the Moon

Night descended upon Orario.

The last traces of sunlight disappeared behind the city's rooftops, and the full moon rose into a cloudless sky. Its pale radiance spilled across the streets, silvering the banners and lanterns, illuminating the Tower of Babel in the distance, and painting the festival grounds with an almost dreamlike beauty.

Then the lanterns were lit.

One by one, thousands of warm lights awakened throughout the city.

The streets erupted in celebration.

Musicians played louder. Children ran between the stalls with glowing toys. Couples gathered beneath the moonlight, and groups of adventurers competed in games of strength, accuracy, and sheer luck.

Some were winning.

Others were discovering that their confidence had been wildly misplaced.

"Impossible!"

A dwarf adventurer stood before a ring-toss booth, glaring at the wooden rings in his hand.

"I hit the bottle three times!"

"And you did wonderfully, sir!" the merchant replied with practiced cheerfulness. "Unfortunately, the ring did not remain on the bottle."

The dwarf's face darkened.

"That is the entire point of the game!"

A nearby group burst into laughter.

Bell passed them with a quiet smile.

The festival seems to be producing two distinct categories of people: those enjoying themselves, and those determined to make certain nobody else enjoys themselves either.

He turned into the northern plaza.

The crowd thickened immediately.

A large wooden stage had been erected in the center of the square, decorated with white and gold fabric. Behind it stood a massive stone pedestal, its surface carved with intricate patterns. Atop the pedestal lay an object that caught the moonlight.

A spear.

At least, that was what the crowd believed it to be.

A familiar figure stood upon the stage, waving both arms as though he were addressing an audience ten times larger.

"Gather up! Gather up, ladies and gentlemen!"

Bell stopped.

He recognized that voice.

The speaker wore his usual extravagant smile, and his clothing was so flamboyant that it could have been seen from the opposite end of the plaza.

Hermes.

The god of travel, commerce, and all manner of questionable schemes.

Bell's smile disappeared.

Oh, dear.

Hermes spread his arms wide.

"Tonight, under the blessing of the full moon, I present to you a challenge worthy of the greatest heroes of Orario!"

The crowd cheered.

"Before you stands a magnificent weapon, sealed within this ancient stone! A weapon whose true worth cannot be measured in valis alone!"

He gestured dramatically toward the pedestal.

"Whoever proves worthy of this spear shall claim it as their own! And that is not all!"

Hermes paused until the crowd had quieted.

"The victor shall also receive the opportunity to travel around the world!"

For a heartbeat, the plaza fell silent.

Then it exploded.

"A trip around the world?!"

"Is that real?"

"Where would we even go?"

"Forget the trip! Look at that spear!"

Hermes laughed, clearly delighted with the reaction.

"Naturally, all expenses for the journey will be covered! The victor need only prove their worth!"

Bell watched from the edge of the gathering.

An expensive prize. A valuable weapon. A crowd full of people willing to embarrass themselves for the chance to obtain both.

He folded his arms.

And Hermes is involved.

That last detail was the most concerning.

Hermes was many things, but Bell had never considered him a reliable judge of public entertainment.

There must be a catch.

Onstage, Hermes raised one finger.

"The rules are simple! Approach the stone, grasp the spear, and pull it free! No spells, no tools, and absolutely no interference from outside parties!"

He leaned forward, his smile widening.

"Let your strength, determination, and spirit decide your fate!"

A young adventurer immediately volunteered.

He strode onto the stage, rolled his shoulders, and grasped the weapon with both hands.

"All right! Watch this!"

He pulled.

Nothing happened.

He planted his feet more firmly and tried again.

The spear remained perfectly still.

The crowd began offering advice.

"Pull harder!"

"Use your legs!"

"Maybe you're holding it wrong!"

The adventurer gritted his teeth, gave one final desperate tug, and stumbled backward.

The spear did not move.

Hermes clapped enthusiastically.

"An admirable attempt! Unfortunately, the weapon has rejected you!"

The adventurer descended from the stage, his dignity somewhat worse for wear.

The next participant was a woman with impressive muscles. She approached the stone, wrapped both hands around the shaft, and pulled with enough force to make the pedestal creak.

Again, nothing happened.

Then came a dwarf.

Then a human adventurer.

Then a beastman who insisted that his superior grip would make the difference.

One by one, they failed.

The crowd grew louder with every unsuccessful attempt.

Bell remained still, observing.

Interesting. The stone isn't merely heavy. There is a binding enchantment, perhaps even several layers of magical reinforcement.

His gaze shifted toward Hermes.

But if the enchantment were that simple, someone would eventually overcome it through brute force. Unless the test isn't about strength at all.

He studied the weapon more closely.

Its shaft was slender. The tip, visible above the stone, seemed unusually narrow. Its balance looked wrong for a conventional spear, and the faintly curved contours near its head suggested a design intended for a different purpose.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

That's not a spear.

He tilted his head.

It's an arrow.

The realization brought a faint smile to his face.

Well, that's a rather interesting mistake.

Or perhaps it was not a mistake.

Bell's gaze moved from the weapon to the pedestal, then to the people attempting to pull it free.

If the object is an arrow, then the stone may not be a prison. It may be a seal.

The distinction was important.

A prison kept something inside.

A seal prevented something from being released.

And if the object had been sealed for a particular reason, brute force might not be the intended method of removal.

Bell's smile deepened.

Now I'm curious.

Unfortunately, curiosity was not the only thing occupying his attention.

A few streets away, the clone had also heard the commotion.

He turned toward the northern plaza.

"That sounds like Hermes."

Ryuu, standing beside him, gave a quiet sigh.

"That is rarely a good sign."

"You're telling me."

They approached the edge of the crowd, where the clone caught sight of the stage.

His expression changed.

"Oh."

Ryuu followed his gaze.

The weapon gleamed beneath the moonlight.

The clone studied it for several seconds before looking at Hermes.

"...No."

Ryuu glanced at him.

"What?"

"I'm not participating."

"I didn't ask you to."

"Good, because I was going to explain that I have no intention of being manipulated into some ridiculous competition."

Ryuu looked back at the stage.

"That is probably wise."

The clone nodded.

"Besides, I have a much more important appointment."

Ryuu raised an eyebrow.

"With whom?"

He lifted their joined hands.

"With my girlfriend."

For a moment, Ryuu simply stared at him.

Then she looked away.

"You are becoming increasingly shameless."

"Is that a complaint?"

"It is an observation."

"Then I'll accept it as a compliment."

She gave his hand a gentle squeeze.

"Come. Let us leave before someone recognizes me."

The clone's smile softened.

"Right."

Ryuu's position within the city was complicated enough without drawing unnecessary attention. Her reputation, her associations, and the circumstances surrounding her life meant that even an innocent public appearance could invite unwanted scrutiny.

He understood that.

More importantly, he respected it.

The clone turned away from the stage without another glance.

"Shall we visit the river?"

Ryuu nodded.

"Yes. I believe the lanterns should be released soon."

"Excellent. And afterward, we can find something to eat."

"You have already eaten several meals."

"And yet, somehow, I remain hungry."

"Truly a medical mystery."

"I may never recover."

"How tragic."

They disappeared into the crowd, their hands still joined.

Behind them, Hermes continued to entertain the gathering audience.

Neither of them noticed the original Bell moving toward the stage.

IV. The Man Without a Name

Bell did not approach the pedestal immediately.

Instead, he moved behind a nearby stall and examined the stage from a different angle.

The stone was old, or at least made to appear old. Its surface bore shallow carvings that resembled ancient script, though the symbols were too weathered to identify from a distance. A faint magical current surrounded the pedestal, rising in a thin spiral before vanishing into the night air.

The spear—or rather, the arrow—rested at the center.

Bell watched as another adventurer stepped forward.

The man was tall, broad-shouldered, and confident enough to announce his intentions before reaching the stage.

"Stand aside! If this weapon requires strength, then I'm the man for the job!"

He gripped the shaft.

His muscles tensed.

The crowd roared.

The stone remained motionless.

After several seconds, the adventurer released it and stepped back, breathing heavily.

Hermes placed a hand over his heart.

"Another valiant attempt! Truly, the spirit of adventure burns brightly in Orario!"

The adventurer muttered something unflattering under his breath and left.

Bell exhaled through his nose.

That makes seventeen.

He had been counting.

Seventeen attempts, all unsuccessful. Different body types, different levels of strength, different techniques. The result remains the same.

He glanced toward the pedestal.

The binding responds to something other than physical force.

He could have approached openly.

But the moment he did, people might remember his face. Some might recognize him from his previous activities, while others might simply become curious about a stranger who succeeded where experienced adventurers had failed.

Neither possibility appealed to him.

Bell preferred to decide when he became the center of attention.

And so, he changed his appearance.

The transformation began with a subtle ripple across his skin.

His features shifted gradually, the familiar lines of his face rearranging themselves into something different. His jaw became slightly more defined, his nose changed shape, and the proportions of his face settled into an entirely new arrangement.

His hair lengthened, darkening until it fell in smooth black strands past his shoulders.

His eyes remained watchful, but their appearance altered to complement the new face.

When the transformation was complete, Bell examined himself in the reflection of a nearby polished metal tray.

A stranger looked back.

He was handsome, certainly, but not so striking that people would remember him immediately. His face possessed a quiet, ordinary attractiveness—the kind that might draw a second glance without provoking a third.

Perfect.

Bell adjusted a loose strand of black hair.

"Not bad."

He turned his head slightly.

"Perhaps a little too clean-cut."

He considered changing his appearance again, then decided against it.

There was no reason to overcomplicate things.

The objective is to examine the weapon, not become the subject of a festival-wide investigation.

He straightened his clothes and stepped out from behind the stall.

The crowd parted only slightly as he approached, most people too focused on the stage to pay him much attention.

A pair of young adventurers glanced at him.

"Hey, are you going to try?"

Bell gave them a polite smile.

"Perhaps."

"Good luck. You'll need it."

"So I've heard."

Another man shook his head.

"Don't bother. Nobody can move it."

Bell glanced at the pedestal.

"Nobody?"

"Not a single person. Even some of the stronger adventurers tried."

"Then perhaps they're approaching the problem incorrectly."

The man laughed.

"That's what everyone says before they fail."

Bell nodded thoughtfully.

"Then I suppose I'll have to disappoint you."

He continued forward.

As he approached the stage, Hermes noticed him.

The god's smile brightened.

"Ah! A new challenger! Welcome, my friend! Are you here to test your strength against this mysterious weapon?"

Bell stopped at the foot of the stairs.

"Something like that."

"Excellent! Excellent! We welcome all brave souls, regardless of their background, profession, or experience!"

Hermes swept one arm toward the stone.

"Come, then! Let us see whether fortune favors you!"

Bell looked at him.

For a moment, their eyes met.

Hermes's smile never changed.

Yet Bell sensed something behind it.

Interest.

Not surprise, exactly. Not suspicion either.

Something more difficult to identify.

Does he recognize me?

Bell examined the god's expression.

No. If he does, he's very good at hiding it.

Then again, Hermes was Hermes.

The god could conceal a scheme behind a smile and make the smile seem like the most honest thing in the world.

Bell decided not to dwell on it.

"Thank you."

He climbed the stairs.

The crowd quieted as he approached the pedestal.

A few people whispered among themselves.

"Who is that?"

"Never seen him before."

"Looks like a traveler."

"Maybe he has a trick."

Bell heard every word.

He ignored them.

His attention was fixed on the object before him.

Up close, the distinction was unmistakable.

It was an arrow.

A magnificent one, to be sure, with a shaft that shimmered faintly beneath the moonlight. Its tip was concealed within the stone, while the exposed portion bore delicate engravings that seemed to shift whenever Bell moved his gaze.

He felt a faint pressure against his senses.

Not hostility.

Recognition.

Bell's fingers twitched.

So you can feel me, can you?

He studied the weapon.

Or perhaps you're responding to the magic surrounding me.

Either explanation was worth investigating.

Behind him, Hermes cleared his throat.

"Whenever you're ready, my friend!"

Bell turned his head slightly.

"One question."

"Certainly!"

"Has anyone examined the stone itself?"

Hermes blinked.

"Examined it?"

"The pedestal. Its construction, the inscriptions, the enchantments. Has anyone attempted to determine how the weapon is secured?"

A few people in the audience exchanged looks.

Hermes's smile became marginally wider.

"Why, my friend, that would spoil the mystery!"

Bell regarded him for a moment.

Then he nodded.

"I see."

Of course you haven't.

He faced the pedestal again.

Or you have, and you're deliberately avoiding the question.

Either way, the answer told him little.

Bell moved closer.

The carvings along the pedestal were old, but their arrangement was not random. The symbols formed concentric patterns, each layer feeding into the next. At the center, the magic gathered around the arrowhead.

He could sense the structure now.

A binding spell.

Several reinforcing layers.

And beneath them all, something else.

Something that felt less like a conventional enchantment and more like a command written directly into the fabric of the spell.

Do not release.

Bell's eyes narrowed.

That's unnecessarily forceful.

He almost laughed.

Whoever designed this had a remarkable lack of confidence in their own restraints.

The crowd watched as Bell extended his hand.

Hermes leaned forward.

Several people held their breath.

Bell's fingers closed around the shaft.

For an instant, nothing happened.

Then a faint tremor passed through the stone.

The audience gasped.

"Did you see that?"

"It moved!"

"No, it didn't!"

Bell felt the resistance immediately.

It was not physical.

The binding pressed against his hand, testing the nature of his magic, attempting to determine whether he possessed the qualities required to remove the weapon.

He allowed the process to continue for a moment.

Then his expression changed.

Ah.

Understanding settled into place.

The spell was not simply preventing the arrow from being removed.

It was actively searching for a particular condition.

A key.

An authorization.

Or perhaps a specific magical signature.

Bell's fingers tightened slightly.

I could force it. But that would be wasteful.

He looked at the stone.

And if I break the wrong part of the enchantment, I might damage the weapon.

That would be unfortunate.

He had already decided that he wanted to examine it.

Bell lowered his head as though concentrating on the task.

A quiet breath escaped him.

"Come on, then."

The words were barely audible.

He allowed a thread of his magic to flow through his fingertips, then subtly altered its nature. The energy dispersed into the binding, slipping between its layers like water through narrow cracks.

The crowd saw nothing unusual.

To them, the stranger was simply holding the weapon.

Hermes, however, stopped smiling for half a second.

Bell noticed.

There you are.

He kept his expression neutral.

So you can sense it after all.

The god's eyes followed the movement of Bell's fingers.

Then his familiar grin returned.

"Ah, such concentration! Truly, this is the spirit of a determined challenger!"

Bell almost sighed.

You really cannot help yourself, can you?

He returned his attention to the spell.

There.

A flaw.

Not a flaw in its construction, but in its assumption.

The enchantment had been designed to prevent unauthorized removal through strength, force, and conventional magical interference. It was robust against brute strength, but its structure relied upon the assumption that anyone attempting to remove the weapon would accept the rules governing the seal.

Bell found that assumption amusing.

You cannot keep something trapped by a rule if the rule itself can be dismantled.

He did not need to overpower the enchantment.

He merely needed to remove the part that made it function.

Bell released a controlled pulse of magic.

Dispel.

The word never left his lips.

No visible light appeared. No dramatic explosion shook the stage. No thunderous crack announced his success.

Instead, the magical current surrounding the pedestal simply ceased to exist.

One moment, the binding was there.

The next, it was gone.

Bell felt the resistance vanish beneath his fingers.

His expression remained unchanged.

That was easier than expected.

He began to pull.

The stone shuddered.

A low grinding sound rolled across the stage.

The crowd fell silent.

Hermes's eyes widened.

The arrow moved.

Slowly at first, then with increasing ease, it slid upward from the pedestal.

Cracks spread across the stone.

Bell released the final portion of the shaft.

The pedestal shattered.

A tremendous crash echoed through the plaza as the outer shell broke apart, sending fragments across the stage. People shouted and stumbled backward. A few adventurers raised their arms to shield themselves from the falling debris.

Bell stood in the center of it all, holding the freed weapon.

The arrow gleamed in his hand.

For a moment, the entire plaza seemed to forget how to breathe.

Then the shouting began.

"He did it!"

"The stone broke!"

"Who is that man?!"

"He actually pulled it out!"

Hermes stared at the ruined pedestal.

Then at Bell.

Then at the weapon.

For the first time that evening, the god seemed genuinely at a loss for words.

Bell examined the arrow in his hand.

Its shaft was cool against his palm. The engravings along its surface shimmered faintly, responding to something he could not quite identify.

He rotated it slightly, studying the tip.

Beautiful craftsmanship.

His eyes narrowed.

And this is certainly not an ordinary weapon.

He could feel the magic gathering within it, dormant but immense. The arrow seemed to possess a purpose beyond simply piercing a target.

A weapon made for a single, extraordinary shot.

Perhaps.

Or something far stranger.

Bell's thoughts raced ahead, assembling possibilities.

If this thing was sealed, then whoever placed it here must have had a reason. Hermes either knows exactly what it is or has somehow acquired an artifact whose nature he doesn't fully understand.

Neither possibility was comforting.

Bell looked toward the god.

Hermes had recovered enough to approach the center of the stage, his expression once again bright with theatrical delight.

"My, my! What a spectacular display!"

He threw both arms into the air.

"Ladies and gentlemen, we have a winner!"

The crowd erupted.

Bell barely heard them.

His attention had shifted elsewhere.

Something was approaching.

Not physically.

It was a presence, distant yet unmistakably directed toward him. It brushed against the edge of his awareness, carrying a strange familiarity that made his instincts stir.

He looked up at the moon.

Its light seemed brighter than before.

What is this feeling?

The arrow vibrated faintly in his grasp.

Bell's fingers tightened around the shaft.

Is this weapon responding to someone?

A breeze passed across the stage.

The festival banners fluttered overhead.

And then, through the roar of the crowd, a voice rang out.

A voice so melodious that the surrounding noise seemed to fade around it.

A voice filled with unmistakable joy, longing, and recognition.

Bell slowly turned toward its source.

The voice spoke again, warm and radiant beneath the full moon.

"My Orion!"

Chapter Thirty-Six: My Orion

Where could you be?

Perhaps we were never meant to meet. Perhaps the stars have woven a cruel fate in which I must wait for someone who will never come.

But even so, I want you to know.

I will love you in any form, in any shape, and in any race. I do not care what face you wear, what name you carry, or what kind of existence you possess.

My beloved Orion.

The one I have yet to meet.

The one I have waited for.

The one I believe fate has promised me.

Please.

You need to save me.

I want you to save me.

Save me.

Please, Orion. We are running out of time.

Can you hear my voice? Can you hear me calling for you? Please, answer me. Even if you cannot see me, even if you do not understand why I am calling, please respond.

I want to be saved by you.

Only you.

So please, find the beast that has enslaved me. Take my arrow. Draw your bow. And when you stand before that monster, pierce its thick head.

Kill it.

Before there is nothing left of me to save.

You could still remember the warmth of sunlight against your skin.

It was a ridiculous thing to remember when darkness had become your entire world, but your mind clung to such fragments with desperate tenderness. The warmth of the sun. The rustling of leaves. The laughter of nymphs. The endless blue of a sky that had once seemed too vast for anything terrible to exist beneath it.

And a promise.

Not one spoken aloud between two people who had already met. Not a vow sealed by a kiss, nor a memory of hands intertwined beneath the stars.

It was something far more uncertain.

A conviction.

A feeling that somewhere beyond the horizon of your existence, there was someone you were destined to encounter. Someone whose presence would change the course of your life.

Someone you had never seen, never spoken to, and yet had somehow come to cherish before his arrival.

You had named him Orion.

Perhaps the name was foolish. Perhaps it was nothing more than a dream woven from the loneliness of a goddess who had spent too long looking toward a future she could not touch.

But you had held on to it.

You had held on to him.

And now, imprisoned in a place where even the passage of time had become difficult to understand, that uncertain promise was the only thing keeping you from surrendering to despair.

You have to exist.

You must.

I refuse to believe that I have waited for nothing.

You tried to move.

Nothing happened.

Your body no longer answered your commands. The power that once flowed through your divine existence had been suppressed, leaving you helpless beneath the weight of something you could neither see nor comprehend.

You could feel yourself being consumed.

Not merely in body, but in spirit. Whatever held you captive was reaching into the very foundation of your existence, stripping away pieces of you with a patience more terrifying than any sudden violence.

And you were still conscious enough to understand.

That was the cruelty of it.

You were Artemis, goddess of the hunt. You had faced danger without hesitation and carried yourself with the confidence of someone who knew how to wield a bow. You had never believed yourself invincible, but you had always believed you could fight.

Now, you could not even raise your hand.

You could not draw your bow.

You could not save yourself.

So you prayed.

Not to your fellow gods. Not to the mortals who might one day remember your name. Not even to the distant stars that had watched over your countless hunts.

You prayed to a man you had never met.

Please, Orion.

I do not know your face.

I do not know your voice.

I do not know whether you will look at me with kindness, confusion, or disgust when we finally stand before one another.

But I want to meet you.

Even if fate has deceived me.

Even if I am wrong about everything.

I want to see you with my own eyes.

Your throat tightened around words no one could hear.

Come find me.

And if you cannot love me as I have imagined, then let me at least see the person I have waited for.

Just once.

Before the darkness takes everything.

The private room at Hermes Familia's headquarters was quiet.

Bell Cranel sat on one side of a polished wooden table, his hands resting loosely in front of him. Across from him, Hermes had abandoned his usual playful expression in favor of something considerably more serious.

Beside Bell sat a goddess with long blue hair.

Her appearance was striking, but it was not her beauty that held Bell's attention. It was the contradiction he sensed in her presence.

He had never met her before today.

He was certain of that.

And yet, the moment he had first heard her name, something from a dream had stirred in the back of his mind.

A fleeting image. A distant voice. The impression of someone calling for help from somewhere he could not reach.

The memory was frustratingly incomplete. Every time he tried to examine it, it slipped away, leaving behind only a vague feeling of unease.

He did not know whether the dream had anything to do with the goddess sitting beside him.

He certainly had no reason to believe that she knew him.

Still, the circumstances surrounding their meeting were too strange to dismiss.

Bell finally broke the silence.

"Before we discuss anything else, I would like to understand the situation."

Hermes raised an eyebrow.

"Straight to business? Not even a little small talk? You're becoming a rather serious young man, Bell."

"I apologize, Lord Hermes. But you've told me that a goddess is in danger, that an unknown creature is responsible, and that you need my help."

Bell met his gaze.

"I would prefer to understand the risks before making any decisions."

"Fair enough."

Hermes folded his hands on the table.

"The threat is real. Unfortunately, we know very little about it."

Bell frowned.

"How strong is it?"

"That is difficult to determine."

"Stronger than a Level Seven adventurer?"

"Possibly."

"Level Eight?"

"Possibly."

Bell exhaled quietly.

"Then we don't have a reliable estimate."

"Correct. Assigning it an adventurer's level would be misleading. We don't know whether its strength is physical, magical, divine, or something else entirely."

"What do we know?"

"That it has managed to imprison someone of considerable importance and that conventional methods have not provided a solution."

Bell considered the answer.

"Does it have a physical body?"

"We believe so."

"Can it use magic?"

"Unknown."

"Does it command monsters or other creatures?"

"Unknown."

"Has anyone seen it directly?"

Hermes hesitated.

"We have fragments of information, but nothing sufficient to establish its complete nature."

Bell leaned back.

The lack of information was troubling. Fighting a powerful enemy was one thing; fighting an enemy whose capabilities remained a mystery was another.

He needed to know what they were dealing with before he could determine how to help.

"Then what does it want?"

Hermes's expression darkened.

"That is one of the questions we have yet to answer."

Bell glanced toward the blue-haired goddess beside him.

She had remained quiet throughout the discussion. Her hands rested in her lap, her fingers occasionally tightening against the fabric of her dress.

There was a sadness in her expression that seemed to go beyond ordinary concern.

Bell hesitated before speaking.

"Lady Artemis?"

She turned toward him.

"Yes?"

"I hope you won't misunderstand me, but I have a question."

"Ask it."

"Are you the original Artemis?"

Hermes became still.

Bell continued before the god could interrupt.

"I have never met you before. At least, not that I can remember. But ever since I heard about this situation, I've had the feeling that something is connected to a dream I've experienced."

He frowned, searching for the right words.

"I can't remember enough to be certain. I don't know whether it was a warning, a coincidence, or simply a dream. But something about this situation feels familiar in a way I can't explain."

He looked directly at her.

"And from what Lord Hermes has told me, I understand that your existence is connected to the Artemis who has been captured. So I want to know what you are."

Hermes opened his mouth, then closed it.

For once, the god of commerce seemed reluctant to offer even a carefully worded explanation.

Artemis lowered her eyes.

"No," she answered.

Bell waited.

"I am not the original Artemis."

The answer was quiet, but firm.

Hermes sighed and leaned back in his chair.

"I suppose there's no point avoiding it now."

Artemis shook her head.

"This is not something you should answer for me, Hermes."

She turned toward Bell.

"The Artemis you have heard about is real. The goddess who once walked beneath the sun, who hunted monsters and lived among her followers, is real."

Her blue hair slipped over her shoulder as she lowered her head.

"But I am not her complete self."

Bell listened without interrupting.

"I am a fragment of her existence. I possess memories, emotions, and a portion of her divinity, but I am not the entirety of the goddess you seek to save."

"Are you a clone?"

"Not exactly."

"An avatar?"

"That might be a closer description, but it would not be entirely accurate."

Bell nodded slowly.

"Then you are connected to her."

"Yes."

"Can you communicate with her?"

For the first time, Artemis struggled to answer.

"I can feel her."

Her fingers tightened.

"Her fear. Her pain. Sometimes, I feel something that might be her trying to reach me. But I cannot hear her clearly, and I cannot send an answer."

She looked down at her hands.

"I do not know how much time she has left."

You are so far away.

I can feel your suffering, yet I cannot reach you.

I know the shape of your fear because it echoes inside me, but I cannot tell you that someone may be coming.

I cannot promise that the man I have waited for will arrive in time.

And I cannot even be certain that the promise I have cherished is real.

She drew a shaky breath.

What if I have imagined everything?

What if Orion is nothing more than a name I created to give my heart something to hold on to?

No.

I cannot believe that.

Artemis raised her head.

"My feelings are my own, Bell Cranel. I know that I am a fragment, and I know that my existence is different from hers. But that does not make my emotions false."

"I didn't say it did," Bell replied.

She looked at him, surprised.

Bell offered a small, earnest smile.

"I don't understand the nature of your existence, Lady Artemis. I won't pretend that I do. But if you can think, feel, and make your own decisions, then I believe you deserve to be treated as yourself."

For a moment, Artemis could only stare at him.

You would say something like that.

You, who know nothing about the promise I have made in my heart.

You, who have never met me, who have no reason to care about me, and who cannot possibly understand why your existence has become so important to someone you have never seen.

And yet, you speak as though my existence is enough.

Her heart ached with a feeling she could not name.

She had imagined meeting Orion countless times. In those private dreams, he had always appeared as someone who would understand her without needing an explanation.

But the young man before her was a stranger.

He had not recognized her. He had not spoken to her as though they shared a secret history. He had not claimed to know her heart.

He had simply listened.

Perhaps that was better.

Perhaps a promise was not the same as a memory, and destiny did not grant either person the right to decide what the other must feel.

"Thank you," she said softly.

Bell nodded.

Hermes cleared his throat.

"Now that we've addressed that matter, we should discuss our next steps."

Bell turned back toward him.

"First, we need to locate the original Artemis. Second, we need to identify the creature holding her captive. Third, we need to determine how to reach her without putting her life in further danger."

"Precisely," Hermes said. "And we must do so discreetly. If the creature has allies, or if another deity is involved, our actions could alert them."

"Do we have a location?"

"Not a precise one. The available information suggests that her prison lies somewhere beyond the ordinary boundaries of our world, but we have yet to establish a reliable way to reach it."

"Then gathering information should be our first priority."

"A sensible conclusion."

Bell ignored Hermes's teasing tone.

"Who has already investigated? What methods did they use? What happened when they attempted contact? And do we know why the original Artemis was targeted?"

Hermes's expression grew serious again.

"Those are the questions I intend to answer. I cannot promise that all of them will have answers."

"Then we'll work with what we have."

Artemis watched Bell carefully.

He was not acting like a man who believed himself destined to save her. He was not making grand promises or claiming that fate had brought them together.

He was simply trying to understand the problem before deciding how to confront it.

It was sensible.

It was cautious.

And, strangely enough, it made her feel safer.

"Bell Cranel," she said.

He turned toward her.

"I cannot promise that I will be able to guide you to the original. I cannot promise that the connection between us will remain stable, or that I will be able to help you understand the creature."

She hesitated.

"But if there is a chance to save her, I will do everything I can to help you."

Bell nodded.

"Then we'll work together."

He rose from his chair, and Artemis followed.

There was no dramatic vow between them. No sudden revelation that confirmed their destinies. No declaration that they belonged to one another.

Only an agreement to pursue the truth.

For Bell, it was the beginning of an investigation into a mystery that might be connected to a dream he could barely remember.

For Artemis, it was something else.

It was the first fragile step toward the person she had believed fate had promised her.

You are here.

Not because you remember me.

Not because you have promised to love me.

Not because you understand what I have felt in the darkness.

You are here because, for reasons neither of us understands, our paths have finally crossed.

She watched him speak with Hermes, discussing risks and possibilities with a seriousness that seemed almost at odds with his youthful appearance.

Perhaps this is how it must begin.

Perhaps I must learn to know you, rather than cling to the person I have imagined.

And perhaps, if fate has truly brought you to me, there will be time for the rest.

The meeting ended with Hermes promising to gather whatever information he could.

Bell left the room with more questions than answers.

The dream still troubled him. He could not shake the impression of a distant voice calling from somewhere beyond his reach, but he refused to treat a vague feeling as proof of anything.

He would investigate.

He would learn what had happened to the original Artemis.

And if there was a way to save her, he would consider it carefully.

Behind him, the blue-haired goddess remained by the window.

She watched the patch of sky visible between the curtains, searching for something she could not see.

Can you hear me now?

I have found him.

I do not know whether he is the Orion I have imagined. I do not know whether he will ever feel what I feel.

But he is here.

And I will not give up on you.

For one fleeting moment, something stirred within her.

A distant pulse.

A faint sensation, like a thread pulled taut across an immeasurable distance.

Artemis froze.

"Wait..."

Hermes turned toward her.

"What is it?"

She pressed a hand against her chest.

"I felt something."

"From the original?"

"I don't know."

Her voice trembled.

"It was only for a moment. I cannot tell whether it was her trying to reach me or something else."

Hermes approached her, his expression alert.

"Can you feel it again?"

Artemis closed her eyes.

She waited.

Nothing came.

The sensation had vanished as quickly as it had appeared.

Yet she could not forget it.

Was that you?

Did you hear me?

Are you still there?

Her eyes filled with tears she had spent too long refusing to shed.

Please, hold on a little longer.

I have found the person I have been waiting for.

I do not know what he will become to me, and I will not force him to fulfill a promise he has never made.

But I will bring him to you.

And then, perhaps, the truth will finally be revealed.

Far beyond the boundaries of the world, in a prison where time and hope had become indistinguishable, something ancient stirred.

A faint disturbance had crossed the darkness.

A connection had trembled.

And the beast holding Artemis captive had finally sensed that something was changing.

Someone was searching.

Someone who had no idea what awaited him.

Someone whose path had crossed the goddess's at last.

End of Chapter Thirty-Six.

Chapter Thirty-Seven: Traces

The Hermes Familia headquarters had never been a place Bell associated with tranquility.

Even by Orario's standards, the building possessed an unusual atmosphere. Its corridors were busy with messengers, merchants, adventurers, and the occasional suspicious-looking individual who seemed far too comfortable discussing matters that would have earned them a lengthy interrogation elsewhere. Information changed hands as casually as coins, and every smile seemed to conceal at least one unspoken intention.

It was, in every sense, a place suited to its patron.

Hermes himself sat behind his desk, examining a collection of documents with an expression of exaggerated concentration. Across from him stood Bell Cranel, whose attention had long since wandered away from the room's peculiar decorations.

Artemis stood beside Bell.

The goddess of the hunt had remained unusually quiet since their arrival. Her expression was composed, but the tension in her shoulders betrayed her impatience. For someone accustomed to tracking prey across vast wildernesses, being forced to depend on rumors and old records was an experience she found thoroughly unpleasant.

Hermes finally set his papers aside.

"Well, then." He leaned back in his chair and folded his hands behind his head. "I've asked around, checked what little information my children could obtain, and even consulted a few people who owe me favors. Unfortunately, the trail ends at the same place every time."

Bell raised his eyes.

"The Guild?"

"Precisely." Hermes snapped his fingers. "The last recorded expedition of the Artemis Familia. Officially, that is the final trace of your companions that can be verified without relying on rumors."

Artemis's fingers tightened around the fabric of her sleeve.

"Then why haven't we obtained the records?"

"Because the Guild doesn't distribute sensitive expedition reports to anyone who happens to ask nicely." Hermes offered her a cheerful smile. "Especially when those reports involve an entire Familia disappearing under circumstances that nobody wishes to explain."

"They were not merely an expedition," Artemis replied coldly. "They were my children."

For once, Hermes did not immediately answer with a joke.

His gaze softened for a brief moment before he sighed.

"I know."

The silence that followed was short, but heavy.

Bell had been watching the two gods carefully. He understood Artemis's frustration. Every passing hour brought them closer to the possibility that the trail had grown colder than they could afford. If the Guild possessed the information they needed, then allowing bureaucratic restrictions to delay them was an unnecessary waste of time.

However, breaking into the Guild's archives would create problems of its own.

And Bell preferred solutions that did not announce themselves to the entire city.

"Is there another way?" he asked.

Hermes turned toward him.

"There is always another way, Bell. The question is whether you are willing to accept the price."

"Money?"

"Sometimes."

"Favors?"

"Frequently."

"Blackmail?"

Hermes placed a hand over his chest.

"My dear boy, I am shocked. Do I look like the sort of god who would resort to something so crude?"

Bell stared at him.

Artemis stared at him.

Hermes maintained his smile for approximately three seconds before lowering his hand.

"All right, fine. Occasionally."

"Then what do you suggest?" Artemis asked, her patience visibly thinning.

Hermes rose from his chair and walked toward the window. Beyond the glass, Orario spread beneath the afternoon sunlight, its streets filled with merchants returning from the market and adventurers preparing for another descent into the Dungeon.

"There's someone who might help us understand what happened," he said. "Someone who has a rather interesting relationship with the city's secrets."

Bell's expression changed slightly.

"The Guildmaster?"

Hermes glanced over his shoulder.

"Good guess, but no."

"Someone above him, then?"

"Not quite."

Bell considered the possibilities.

Hermes's smile widened when he noticed the calculation behind the boy's eyes.

"You're getting warmer."

Artemis folded her arms.

"Hermes."

"Yes, yes. No need to look at me like that." He waved a hand dismissively. "We'll visit someone who can answer questions that the Guild would prefer to leave unanswered."

"And where might we find this person?"

Hermes turned back toward them.

"Daedalus Street."

Artemis's expression immediately darkened.

"The Daedalus Streets?" she repeated. "You intend to take us into that labyrinth?"

"Not the Dungeon, my dear Artemis. Merely a different sort of maze."

"That is hardly reassuring."

"Would you prefer to wait here while I negotiate with the Guild for several days?"

Artemis said nothing.

Hermes interpreted her silence as consent.

"Wonderful! Then we should get moving before the day grows any older."

He grabbed his cloak, slipped a small pouch of valis into his pocket, and headed toward the door with the carefree stride of a man preparing for an afternoon stroll rather than a journey into one of Orario's most dangerous districts.

Bell followed.

Artemis lingered for a moment, looking at the documents Hermes had left on his desk. Her gaze settled on the name written at the top of the report.

Artemis Familia.

She reached out and touched the paper.

"Please," she whispered, so quietly that neither of her companions heard her. "Let there be something left to find."

Then she turned and followed them.

Their journey began in the commercial quarter.

The Hermes Familia headquarters occupied a building that reflected its patron's peculiar nature: respectable enough to welcome merchants through the front entrance, yet discreet enough to accommodate visitors who preferred not to be seen. Its location placed it within reasonable walking distance of several major thoroughfares, allowing the Familia to maintain its extensive network of contacts throughout Orario.

Hermes led the way through the entrance and into the bustling streets.

"Ah, a fine afternoon!" he declared, stretching his arms. "The weather is pleasant, the markets are lively, and the city is full of opportunities. What more could a god ask for?"

"An answer," Artemis replied.

"Such impatience. You really should learn to enjoy the journey."

"I will enjoy it when my children are safe."

Hermes's smile faltered.

He looked at her for a moment before turning his attention to the road ahead.

"Fair enough."

Bell walked a short distance behind them, observing the city as they moved away from the busier commercial streets.

At first, their surroundings remained ordinary. Merchants shouted prices from their stalls. Children ran between pedestrians, chased by exasperated parents. Adventurers in leather armor carried weapons toward the Guild, while others returned from the Dungeon with packs filled with magic stones and monster materials.

But as they continued, the character of the streets gradually changed.

The broad avenues narrowed into winding roads. Buildings stood closer together, their upper floors leaning over the passages below. Colorful signs gave way to weather-beaten boards, and the crowds became increasingly sparse.

Bell noticed the changes long before Hermes acknowledged them.

The merchants here watched passersby with the practiced indifference of people who had learned that curiosity was an expensive habit. Several doorways concealed narrow passages, while others appeared to lead into buildings that were clearly larger on the inside than their exterior dimensions suggested.

Every few streets, Bell spotted a symbol scratched into the stonework.

Some marked directions.

Others appeared to have no purpose at all.

Or so an ordinary visitor might have believed.

Daedalus Streets, Bell thought.

He had heard enough about the district to understand its reputation. It was a sprawling network of passages and hidden connections that twisted beneath and between the city's buildings. Its confusing layout was more than a geographical inconvenience; it provided excellent cover for those who preferred their dealings beyond the reach of the law.

Even experienced adventurers could lose their way if they wandered without guidance.

Hermes, meanwhile, strolled along as if he were taking a leisurely tour through a familiar neighborhood.

"Tell me, Bell," the god said, casually stepping around a pile of discarded crates. "Have you ever visited this part of the city?"

"Yes."

Hermes stopped.

Artemis nearly walked into him.

"You have?"

Bell nodded.

"Not extensively. But I know enough to recognize the streets."

Hermes examined him from head to toe.

"Remarkable. Most newcomers would be lost before reaching the first major intersection."

"That depends on which intersections they consider major."

For a moment, Hermes simply stared.

Then he laughed.

"Ha! I see. You're the sort who pays attention to the details others overlook."

Bell offered no reply.

He had learned that explaining himself too readily only encouraged people to ask more questions.

Artemis, however, looked between them.

"Is there something unusual about this place that I should know?"

"Several things," Bell answered. "The streets aren't arranged in a way that makes sense if you assume the district was built all at once. Some routes connect to places that shouldn't be adjacent. Others lead to dead ends that weren't dead ends the last time someone checked."

"And you find that normal?"

"No. I find it useful."

Hermes's expression became increasingly intrigued.

"Bell, my boy, every time I think I've begun to understand you, you say something like that."

"Perhaps you should stop trying."

Artemis covered her mouth, suppressing a small laugh.

Hermes looked wounded.

"Both of you are being terribly unkind to a man who is helping you."

"You haven't helped us yet," Artemis pointed out.

"An unfortunate technicality."

They continued deeper into the district.

The cheerful sounds of the commercial quarter gradually disappeared behind them. Here, the air smelled of damp stone, old timber, and the faint metallic tang of workshops that operated long after respectable businesses had closed for the evening.

Their path descended along a sloping street before bending sharply to the left.

Hermes did not hesitate.

He passed a shuttered shop, crossed a narrow bridge connecting two buildings, and entered a passage so inconspicuous that Bell suspected most people would walk past it without noticing.

At the far end stood a blank wall.

No sign marked it. No windows interrupted its surface. Its stonework appeared weathered but unremarkable, matching the surrounding buildings well enough to escape casual scrutiny.

Hermes stopped before it.

"Here we are."

Artemis looked at the wall, then at Hermes.

"This is your destination?"

"Indeed."

"I see no entrance."

"That's the point."

Hermes turned toward Bell.

"Well? Anything interesting about it?"

Bell studied the wall.

The stones were arranged in an ordinary pattern, but the mortar along the lower edge had been repaired more recently than the surrounding surface. A narrow line disappeared beneath a layer of dust, forming a faint rectangle almost impossible to notice unless one knew where to look.

He stepped closer and ran his fingers lightly along the stone.

"A concealed door," he said.

Hermes's eyebrows rose.

"How did you—"

"The lower hinge must be recessed. Otherwise, the weight of the stone panel would leave visible stress marks around the frame." Bell withdrew his hand. "The wall is also slightly thicker than the neighboring structure. There's space behind it."

He glanced at the god.

"Am I supposed to pretend I didn't notice?"

Hermes stared at him.

Artemis looked from Bell to the wall, her expression shifting from suspicion to astonishment.

Then Hermes slowly broke into a grin.

"Oh, this is going to be interesting."

He turned back toward the concealed entrance and knocked.

Three quick taps.

A pause.

Two slower ones.

Another pause, followed by a final tap against a stone near the bottom of the panel.

Nothing happened.

Hermes waited.

The silence stretched.

A minute passed.

Then another.

Artemis's patience began to fray.

"How long must we—"

"Shhh."

Hermes raised a finger to his lips.

From somewhere beyond the wall came the faint sound of metal sliding against metal.

A narrow section of stone shifted inward.

An unseen mechanism clicked.

Then the entire panel moved aside with a low, grinding sound, revealing a dark opening.

A pair of eyes appeared in the gap.

They studied Hermes first, then moved to Artemis, and finally settled on Bell.

"You're late," a voice said.

Hermes beamed.

"And you are as charming as ever."

"Who are they?"

"Friends."

"That is not an answer."

"Potentially profitable acquaintances?"

The eyes narrowed.

Hermes sighed.

"Must we go through this every time?"

"Yes."

Bell quietly observed the exchange.

The person behind the wall had not asked why a goddess stood in the alley. Nor had they seemed particularly surprised by Hermes's arrival. Their concern appeared to be whether the visitors had been expected.

That alone told Bell something about the place.

It was not merely a hidden entrance.

It was a checkpoint.

Finally, the unseen attendant stepped aside.

"Get in. All three of you."

Hermes gestured grandly toward the opening.

"After you, ladies and gentlemen."

Artemis entered first, unwilling to waste another moment. Bell followed, and Hermes came last.

The stone panel slid shut behind them.

Darkness swallowed the alley.

For an instant, only the faint sounds of the mechanism echoed through the concealed passage. Then a series of lamps flickered to life, illuminating a corridor that stretched far beyond what the wall's exterior dimensions should have permitted.

The air was surprisingly fresh.

Bell noticed narrow ventilation shafts built into the ceiling, each fitted with discreet grilles. The lighting was steady, and the floor showed little sign of dampness despite the surrounding district's age.

This place had not been abandoned.

It had been maintained.

Carefully.

They followed the corridor deeper into the hidden structure. It widened into a spacious chamber furnished with tables, storage cabinets, and several doors leading to other rooms. A handful of people occupied the space, but none paid them more than a passing glance.

The atmosphere was almost disappointingly ordinary.

Hermes, however, seemed entirely at ease.

"See? Perfectly respectable."

Bell looked at a man who was quietly counting a stack of unfamiliar coins beside a locked chest.

"Of course."

Artemis ignored them both.

"Where is the person we're looking for?"

Hermes pointed toward the far end of the room.

"Downstairs."

A narrow staircase descended from the chamber, its stone steps disappearing into the earth. Unlike the concealed entrance above, the staircase appeared ancient, its walls bearing the marks of countless years.

As they descended, the temperature dropped.

The sounds of activity above gradually faded until the only noises were their footsteps and the soft rustling of Artemis's cloak.

Bell's attention sharpened.

There was something in the air.

A pressure he could not easily describe.

It was not the oppressive sensation of entering the Dungeon, nor the strange unease that sometimes accompanied the presence of powerful monsters. This was different—older, more deliberate.

The deeper they went, the more difficult it became to ignore.

Hermes's carefree expression had not disappeared, but even he had grown quieter.

Artemis noticed the change.

"What is it?" she whispered.

Hermes glanced at her.

"Nothing to worry about."

"That is precisely the sort of thing people say before something goes wrong."

"Then I shall endeavor to say it less often."

Bell continued down the stairs without comment.

At the bottom stood a heavy wooden door reinforced with dark metal. No guard waited beside it. No lock was visible.

Hermes stopped before the threshold.

For the first time since leaving his headquarters, he hesitated.

Bell noticed.

"Are you certain this is the right place?"

Hermes looked at the door.

"Oh, absolutely."

"Then why have you stopped?"

"Because, Bell, there is a difference between knowing where someone lives and deciding that disturbing them is a good idea."

Artemis stepped forward.

"We have come too far to turn back."

"That," Hermes muttered, "is exactly what I was afraid you'd say."

He pushed the door open.

Beyond it lay a circular chamber illuminated by four torches arranged around a stone altar.

Their flames burned without flickering.

There was no visible fuel, no smoke, and no trace of ash upon the floor. The light seemed to emerge from the fire itself, bathing the chamber in a pale, unwavering glow.

The walls were covered in inscriptions, some deeply carved into the stone, others so faint that they appeared to have been worn away by time. Their arrangement suggested neither decoration nor ordinary writing.

They formed a pattern.

A pattern that converged upon the altar at the chamber's center.

And from that altar radiated a divine presence so immense that even Hermes's usual levity seemed out of place.

Artemis stopped at the threshold.

Her eyes widened slightly.

Bell, however, continued forward.

He walked across the chamber with measured steps, his gaze fixed upon the altar. The divine pressure grew heavier around him, yet he showed no visible discomfort.

Hermes watched him in growing disbelief.

What in the world is this boy thinking?

He had expected Bell to hesitate. To ask questions. Perhaps to demand an explanation for why a hidden chamber beneath Daedalus Street possessed an atmosphere that felt as though it belonged to an entirely different age.

Instead, Bell walked as if he had come to visit an old acquaintance.

When he reached the altar, he stopped.

Then he lowered his head.

Not a casual nod.

Not the polite bow one offered a stranger.

It was a deliberate gesture of acknowledgment.

Hermes's smile vanished.

Artemis looked at Bell, confusion replacing her earlier determination.

"Bell?"

He did not answer her.

Instead, he addressed the presence filling the chamber.

"Oh, Great God of the Sky, who governs this city of Orario," Bell said calmly, his voice carrying through the chamber. "We have come seeking answers."

The flames of the four torches remained perfectly still.

No voice answered.

Hermes stared at Bell as though the boy had suddenly grown a second head.

Great God of the Sky?

His thoughts raced through the possibilities.

There were powerful deities whose authority extended across the heavens. There were ancient figures whose names survived in legends and whose domains were associated with the sky, thunder, or the ordering of the world.

But the manner in which Bell had spoken—

It was not a guess.

It was an address.

As though he knew exactly who—or what—was listening.

"Bell," Hermes said carefully, "perhaps we should discuss what you mean before you start making declarations like that."

Bell lifted his head slightly.

"I am merely being respectful."

"Respectful?" Hermes repeated under his breath. "You just addressed an unseen presence in a forbidden chamber as though you were greeting your grandfather at the breakfast table."

Bell considered that.

"Would you prefer that I be rude?"

Hermes opened his mouth.

Then closed it.

Artemis pressed a hand to her forehead.

"Bell, please tell me you know what you're doing."

"I have a reasonable idea."

"That is not reassuring."

"Then I shall try to be more precise."

Bell turned back toward the altar.

"There is a particular monster I wish to inquire about," he continued. "Although calling it a monster might be an understatement."

His expression grew serious.

"A calamity, perhaps. Something whose existence has left traces that even the Guild has chosen not to make public."

At that, the air seemed to grow heavier.

The flames bent inward.

Only slightly.

But Bell noticed.

So did Artemis.

Hermes's gaze darted toward the altar, and for the first time since they had entered the hidden chamber, he looked genuinely uncomfortable.

Bell continued without raising his voice.

"We have reason to believe that the last expedition of the Artemis Familia may have encountered something connected to it."

Artemis stepped forward.

"Please," she said, her voice quieter than before. "If you possess any knowledge of their fate, I beg you to tell us."

The goddess of the hunt stood with her hands clasped before her, no longer concerned with pride or appearances.

For all her divinity, she looked like someone standing before a closed door, afraid that opening it might reveal the answer she had dreaded for years.

Bell glanced at her.

Then he faced the altar once more.

"It would not be too difficult to answer a question about such an event, would it?"

He paused.

A faint smile touched his lips.

"Great-grandfather?"

Silence.

Absolute silence.

Hermes slowly turned his head toward Bell.

Artemis froze.

The word seemed to linger in the chamber long after Bell had spoken it.

Great-grandfather.

Hermes's mind went blank.

Then, all at once, a dozen questions collided inside his skull.

Great-grandfather?

Whose great-grandfather?

How long has this been going on?

Why has nobody told me?

He looked at Bell.

Then at the altar.

Then back at Bell.

The boy's expression remained perfectly composed.

Hermes had spent centuries cultivating information networks, trading secrets, manipulating circumstances, and uncovering truths that other people would never even realize existed.

He prided himself on knowing things.

On understanding people.

On recognizing the hidden threads connecting seemingly unrelated events.

Yet here he stood, in a concealed chamber beneath one of Orario's most treacherous districts, watching a young man casually address a mysterious divine presence as his great-grandfather.

And the worst part?

Bell did not appear to consider it remarkable.

Hermes slowly raised a hand and rubbed his face.

"Bell."

"Yes?"

"I have a question."

"Go ahead."

"How much do you actually know?"

Bell looked at him thoughtfully.

"About what?"

Hermes stared at him.

Artemis closed her eyes.

"Gods above," she whispered. "We are going to die here."

Bell, apparently deciding that the conversation had wandered away from its purpose, turned back toward the altar.

"Now, then," he said, his tone returning to its earlier calmness. "Shall we begin?"

For several heartbeats, nothing happened.

Then one of the four torches went out.

Not extinguished by wind.

Not deprived of fuel.

Its flame simply vanished, leaving behind a thin column of darkness.

A moment later, the second torch followed.

Then the third.

Hermes instinctively stepped back.

Artemis reached for the weapon at her side, her gaze fixed upon the altar.

Bell did not move.

The final flame burned alone.

Its light stretched across the stone floor, casting the three visitors' shadows against the walls.

And from somewhere beyond the altar, a voice finally answered.

"You have grown bold, little one."

Bell's smile faded into something quieter.

Something almost familiar.

"I had to learn from someone."

A low sound echoed through the chamber.

It might have been laughter.

Or perhaps the beginning of a warning.

"Then tell me, Bell Cranel. What do you intend to do when you learn what happened to the children of Artemis?"

Artemis stopped breathing.

Hermes felt every instinct he possessed scream at him to leave the chamber.

But Bell merely raised his eyes toward the darkness.

His answer came without hesitation.

"That depends on what you tell me next."

The last torch went out.

And the chamber fell into darkness.

Chapter Thirty-Eight: The Truth

I. The Land of Dreams

The world around Bell Cranel had no horizon.

There was only an endless expanse of pale clouds beneath a boundless celestial sky, where countless stars shimmered despite the absence of night. The air was still, yet Bell could feel a gentle breeze brushing against his skin. Beneath his feet lay a surface resembling polished glass, reflecting the heavens above as though he were standing upon the very edge of creation.

He had visited this place before.

Or, at the very least, he remembered it from a dream.

A figure stood a short distance away, his presence so overwhelming that the surrounding stars seemed insignificant by comparison. His appearance was difficult to describe. He possessed the form of a man, yet something about him transcended the limitations of mortal flesh. His robes resembled the night sky itself, adorned with constellations that shifted with every movement. His silver hair flowed freely, and his eyes held the quiet brilliance of stars that had witnessed the birth and death of worlds.

The Being regarded Bell with an expression of quiet amusement.

"Bell, are you ready?"

Bell straightened his posture.

He was still young, but even at that age, he had learned that some questions deserved more than an impulsive answer.

"I suppose that depends on what you intend to tell me, Lord Uranus."

The Being raised an eyebrow.

"Lord Uranus?"

"Would you prefer something else?"

"Perhaps 'Grandfather' would suffice."

Bell blinked.

Then he blinked again.

"...Grandfather?"

"Your hearing is perfectly fine, young man."

"But—"

Bell stopped himself, searching for the proper words.

Uranus waited patiently.

Finally, Bell exhaled.

"I apologize, but I believe there has been a misunderstanding. As far as I know, I am simply Bell Cranel. I have no recollection of being related to someone like you."

"An entirely reasonable objection."

Uranus clasped his hands behind his back and gazed toward the distant heavens.

"Then allow me to begin at the beginning. It would be rather irresponsible of me to announce that you are my descendant without explaining how such a thing came to pass."

Bell nodded slowly.

"I would appreciate that."

"Very well."

Uranus turned toward him.

"I am Uranus, the primordial personification of the sky, the heavens, and the celestial sphere. Before the Olympians established their dominion, before their divine order took its present shape, there existed powers whose origins reached far deeper into the foundations of the world."

His voice carried no boastfulness. He spoke as though reciting an old truth that had been forgotten by everyone except himself.

"Among those primordial beings, I am known as a Titan. Do not confuse that designation with the lesser distinctions your world's inhabitants have invented. The gods you know are powerful, certainly, but their existence and authority are not the beginning of all things."

Bell listened carefully.

He had encountered gods before. He had witnessed their extraordinary abilities, their strange personalities, and their seemingly limitless influence over the lives of mortals.

Yet Uranus spoke of them as though they were merely one chapter in a much older story.

"Then..." Bell hesitated. "Does that mean you existed before the gods?"

"Before many of them, yes. The passage of time means rather little when one has witnessed the heavens take shape."

Uranus paused.

"However, antiquity alone is not what makes me different from them. The distinction lies in what we are. A god may possess authority over an aspect of existence. A primordial being may be inseparable from the very foundation of that existence."

Bell lowered his eyes, considering the explanation.

"So, you are not simply a god who happens to be stronger than the others."

"Precisely. You are beginning to understand."

"Then why have you remained hidden?"

For the first time, Uranus laughed.

It was a gentle sound, but the stars surrounding them seemed to tremble in response.

"Hidden? My dear boy, I have never been particularly interested in being found."

"That sounds suspiciously convenient."

"Does it?"

"Yes."

"Good. A healthy suspicion is often more useful than blind reverence."

Bell could not help but smile faintly.

For all the overwhelming presence Uranus possessed, the ancient Being was speaking to him with the casual familiarity of an elderly relative indulging a curious child.

Then Uranus's expression softened.

"There is another matter we must discuss."

Bell's smile faded.

"Your origins."

"Mine?"

"Indeed."

Uranus approached him, and for a moment, the boundless heavens seemed to grow quieter.

"You are my great-grandson, Bell."

Bell stared at him.

"...I beg your pardon?"

"You heard me."

"I believe I did, but I would appreciate hearing it again in the hope that the words might somehow become more sensible."

"An admirable attempt at denial."

"Grandfather."

"Yes?"

"Please be serious."

"I am being serious."

Bell pressed his fingers against his forehead.

He had expected an explanation about the strange dreams, perhaps some hidden power within himself, or even a revelation about the nature of the world.

He had not expected his family tree to suddenly extend into primordial mythology.

"Then how?" Bell asked at last. "How am I related to you?"

"Through your paternal lineage. Your bloodline descends through the generations, connecting you to my grandson, Zeus."

Bell's expression became even more complicated.

"Zeus?"

"That Zeus, yes."

"The one associated with the Zeus Familia?"

"The very same."

Bell fell silent.

He knew the name. Almost everyone familiar with Orario's history knew it. The Zeus Familia had once been among the most powerful familias in the world, until its defeat by the Black Dragon brought its glorious era to an end.

And now Uranus was telling him that the legendary deity was his grandfather's grandson.

Technically, Bell was Zeus's grandson's grandson's descendant in the familial sense Uranus was describing—his great-grandson, according to the ancient Being's own account.

Bell took a slow breath.

"Then my family..."

"Has a considerably more complicated history than you imagined."

"That's one way to describe it."

"Would you prefer that I tell you your entire ancestry?"

"No!"

The answer escaped Bell before he could stop himself.

Uranus chuckled.

"Very well. We shall spare you a lecture that might last several days."

Bell shook his head, but his thoughts continued to race.

If Uranus was telling the truth, then his connection to the ancient powers of the world was not merely an accident. His origins reached into a history he had never known existed.

Yet something still troubled him.

"Grandfather, if I am your descendant, why have you only appeared to me now?"

Uranus's amusement diminished.

"Because knowledge is not always a gift, Bell. Sometimes it is a burden that arrives before its bearer is ready."

He looked toward the distant stars.

"You are young. Your journey is only beginning, and the world you are about to enter is full of dangers that even the gods do not fully understand. Had I revealed everything to you earlier, you might have spent your life searching for answers instead of discovering who you wished to become."

Bell listened without interruption.

"Then why tell me now?"

"Because there are moments when ignorance ceases to be protection and becomes a danger."

Uranus turned back to him.

"And because, whether you understand it or not, you are my descendant. I would rather see you face the world with some knowledge of your origins than wander blindly into dangers that could have been avoided."

For a moment, Bell had no answer.

There was something strangely comforting about hearing those words from someone so ancient.

He had spent much of his life moving forward without knowing where his path would lead. He had learned to survive through observation, patience, and a willingness to accept that the world rarely offered simple explanations.

Now, for the first time, a piece of that world was reaching back toward him.

"Thank you," Bell said quietly.

Uranus regarded him with approval.

"You need not thank me for telling you the truth."

"Perhaps not. But I can still be grateful that you chose to tell me."

"An answer worthy of my great-grandson."

Bell looked up at him.

"Then there is something I would like to ask."

"Go ahead."

"If I am truly your descendant, does that mean I am destined to follow a path chosen by my ancestors?"

The question lingered between them.

Uranus did not answer immediately.

Instead, he studied Bell with an intensity that seemed to penetrate beyond appearances, beyond the body, and into the young man's very nature.

"No."

The answer was simple.

Bell blinked.

"No?"

"Your ancestry explains where you came from. It does not dictate where you must go."

Uranus lifted one hand, and the stars above them began to move. Constellations shifted across the heavens, forming unfamiliar patterns before dissolving into scattered points of light.

"Fate is a curious thing. Mortals often imagine it as a road already laid before them, with every turn decided in advance. Others insist that fate does not exist at all. Both positions are rather convenient, for they allow people to avoid confronting the choices they make."

He lowered his hand.

"Your blood may connect you to the past, Bell, but your decisions will determine what that connection means."

Bell absorbed those words in silence.

"Then I can choose my own path?"

"You always could."

Uranus smiled.

"Even if you should stumble, even if your choices lead you somewhere unexpected, do not mistake a detour for the end of your journey."

Bell's expression softened.

For someone who claimed to have existed before the gods, Uranus possessed a surprisingly human understanding of uncertainty.

"Grandfather," Bell said, "I cannot promise that I will always make the right decisions."

"I would be concerned if you did."

"I may make mistakes. I may misunderstand things. And there may come a time when I am forced to face something I cannot overcome alone."

"That is almost inevitable."

Bell gave a small, helpless laugh.

"You're not particularly reassuring."

"I am not here to reassure you with comforting lies."

Uranus stepped closer and placed a hand upon Bell's shoulder.

"I am here to remind you that you do not have to understand everything at once. When the time comes, think carefully. Observe what others overlook. Learn from your failures. And never allow fear to make your decisions for you."

Bell met his gaze.

"I will remember that."

"Good."

The ancient Being withdrew his hand.

"One last thing before you leave this place."

Bell waited.

"No matter how far you travel, remember that the sky above you is not merely an empty expanse. It is a reminder that the world is larger than whatever obstacle stands before you."

Uranus looked upward.

"And should you ever find yourself truly lost, look to the heavens. I may not always intervene directly, but I will be watching. If the time comes when you need my wisdom, I shall do what I can to guide you."

Bell lowered his head.

"Thank you, Grandfather. I will remember your words."

"See that you do."

Uranus's smile became faintly mischievous.

"After all, it would be rather embarrassing for a great-grandson of mine to forget his own family history."

Bell groaned.

"I knew you were going to ruin the moment."

"On the contrary. I believe I have improved it considerably."

For the first time since arriving in this strange place, Bell laughed without reservation.

The sound drifted across the endless heavens.

And then the world began to fade.

The stars blurred into streaks of silver. The ground beneath his feet dissolved into mist, and Uranus's figure gradually receded into the distance.

"Wait!" Bell called out.

The Being tilted his head.

"Something else?"

"Will I see you again?"

Uranus regarded him for a long moment.

"Perhaps sooner than you expect."

Before Bell could ask what he meant, the ancient Being raised his hand in farewell.

"Until then, live well, Bell Cranel."

The heavens disappeared.

And the young boy awoke.

II. An Echo from the Heavens

Bell's eyes opened.

For several moments, he lay motionless, staring at the unfamiliar ceiling above him. The lingering sensation of the dream clung to his mind with unusual clarity.

It had felt too real to dismiss.

The words, the stars, the presence of Uranus—all of it remained vivid in his memory.

He slowly sat up.

"That was... a strange dream."

Yet even as he spoke, he sensed something lingering at the back of his mind.

A faint vibration.

A voice.

Bell.

He froze.

The voice was unmistakable.

Do not look around. I am not standing beside your bed.

Bell slowly turned his head anyway.

There was no one there.

"...Grandfather?"

Good. You remember our conversation.

Bell stared at the empty room.

"How are you speaking to me?"

Through a remnant of my arcanum. Consider it an echo of my presence, anchored to you for the time being.

Bell rubbed his temple.

"An echo of your presence?"

Precisely.

"And this is not another dream?"

If it were, I would hope you had dreamed of something more entertaining than a conversation with an old Titan.

Bell sighed.

"You're enjoying this, aren't you?"

Immensely.

Bell leaned back against the wall.

For a few moments, he simply listened to the quiet room, attempting to reconcile the impossible situation with what he understood about the world.

Then he asked the most obvious question.

"How long will this last?"

Approximately one year.

Bell nearly choked.

"One year?!"

You needn't shout. I can hear you perfectly well.

"Grandfather, you just told me that an echo of your presence is going to remain inside my head for an entire year!"

An accurate summary, yes.

"And you don't think that's worth mentioning before it happens?"

I am mentioning it now.

Bell stared at the ceiling.

He had a feeling that this year was going to be considerably more exhausting than he had anticipated.

"Why a year?"

The humor faded slightly from Uranus's voice.

The arcanum I expended to establish this connection has not entirely dissipated. Rather than allow the remaining power to disperse without purpose, I have chosen to direct it toward something useful.

"Which is?"

Guiding you.

Bell was silent for a moment.

"You mean teaching me?"

Among other things. I can offer advice, help you examine problems from different perspectives, and explain certain matters that would otherwise take you years to discover on your own.

"Can you teach me magic?"

Depending on what you mean by magic, perhaps. But do not expect me to turn you into an omnipotent being merely because we share a family connection.

"I wasn't expecting that."

Good. Unrealistic expectations are the enemy of sound judgment.

Bell smiled faintly.

Then another thought occurred to him.

"If you possess such extraordinary knowledge, why choose me? Surely there are more experienced people you could guide."

Because you are my descendant.

"That is the sentimental answer."

And because you are interesting.

Bell's smile vanished.

"...Interesting?"

You ask questions. You examine your circumstances. You do not accept every answer simply because it comes from someone stronger than yourself. Those qualities are worth cultivating.

The voice paused.

Besides, I have spent an exceedingly long time observing the world. One might even say I have become rather accustomed to sitting around with nothing particularly interesting to do.

Bell blinked.

"You're telling me that a primordial Titan is accompanying me for a year because he's bored?"

When you phrase it like that, it sounds terribly undignified.

"Is it inaccurate?"

Not entirely.

Bell covered his face with one hand.

He had expected his newly discovered ancestor to be mysterious, solemn, perhaps even terrifying.

Instead, Uranus appeared to possess the temperament of someone who had lived long enough to stop taking himself seriously.

"Fine," Bell muttered. "Then I suppose I should establish some ground rules."

Ground rules?

"If you're going to remain in my head for a year, I would prefer to know when you're going to speak. I don't want you interrupting me during a conversation with someone else."

An understandable request.

"And please don't comment on every little thing I do."

I make no promises.

"Grandfather."

Very well. I shall exercise restraint.

Bell narrowed his eyes.

"That doesn't sound convincing."

You will learn to appreciate my company eventually.

"I doubt that."

An excellent opportunity for you to practice patience.

Bell could almost hear the smile in Uranus's voice.

Despite himself, he laughed.

It was absurd. Completely absurd.

Yet the presence of that ancient consciousness did not feel hostile. If anything, it was strangely reassuring to know that someone with such vast experience could offer guidance when he needed it.

Bell eventually grew serious again.

"Grandfather, there's something I want to understand."

Ask.

"You said you would guide me, but you also said that my choices belong to me. If you know so much about the world, will you tell me what I should do whenever I face a difficult decision?"

No.

Bell frowned.

"No?"

I shall tell you what I believe you need to consider. I may point out dangers you have overlooked, or question conclusions you have reached too quickly. But I will not make every decision on your behalf.

"Why not?"

Because a person who relies on another to think for him will eventually find himself helpless when that other person is absent.

Uranus's voice softened.

I am not interested in raising a puppet, Bell. I would rather help you become someone capable of standing on his own.

Bell remained quiet.

He understood the distinction.

Advice could strengthen a person, but dependence could weaken him. Even the most knowledgeable mentor could not live another person's life for them.

"Then I'll do my best to learn."

That is all I ask.

A comfortable silence settled between them.

Then Uranus spoke again.

Now, young man, you should rest. We have an entire year ahead of us.

Bell lay back down.

"One year," he murmured. "I still can't believe it."

Believe it or not, I shall be here.

Bell closed his eyes.

For the first time in a long while, he allowed himself to relax without feeling that he needed to anticipate every possible danger.

There were still countless questions waiting to be answered.

His origins. His future. The strange mysteries surrounding the world.

But he no longer felt compelled to solve them all at once.

As sleep began to claim him again, Uranus's voice drifted through his thoughts one final time.

Remember, Bell. The sky may be vast, but you need only take one step at a time.

And so began a year unlike any other in Bell Cranel's life.

A year of questions, lessons, arguments, and unexpected revelations.

A year in which the voice of an ancient Titan would accompany him through the trials ahead.

And a year that would prove far more important than either of them could yet imagine.

III. The Present — Answers Beneath the Heavens

The memory faded.

Bell Cranel stood before Uranus once more, no longer the young boy who had first encountered the primordial Being in the land of dreams.

Time had passed. Experience had sharpened his judgment, and the burdens he carried had taught him to measure his words carefully.

Yet the feeling of standing before his great-grandfather remained much the same.

There was something about Uranus's presence that made even the most imposing surroundings seem insignificant.

Bell inclined his head respectfully.

"It is an honor to meet you in person, Grandfather."

Uranus regarded him with a thoughtful smile.

"Come now, Bell. You needn't be so formal with me. We have already spoken at length, haven't we?"

"That is true. However, I believe meeting you face-to-face deserves a little more respect than speaking to an echo inside my head."

"An echo that offered you a year's worth of advice, if I recall correctly."

"And a year's worth of interruptions."

"Ah. So you do remember."

Bell allowed himself a small smile.

"Quite clearly."

Uranus laughed.

The exchange was brief, but it eased the tension between them. For all the differences between their existences, their relationship was no longer that of a stranger and an ancient power.

They were family.

Still, Bell had not come merely to exchange pleasantries.

His expression gradually grew serious.

"Grandfather, there is something I need to ask you about."

Uranus's smile diminished.

"I suspected as much. You did not come all this way simply to reminisce about our first meeting."

"No. I'm afraid the matter is considerably more urgent."

Bell met his gaze.

"I want to know what happened to the Artemis Familia."

For a moment, the chamber fell silent.

Uranus's expression changed. The lightheartedness disappeared from his eyes, replaced by the measured gravity of someone recalling an unfortunate decision.

"Their disappearance has troubled us as well," he said.

Bell waited.

"Tell me everything you know."

Uranus nodded.

"Their last recorded expedition took them to the Elsos Ruins, located in the far eastern reaches of the world. The site had recently attracted attention because of reports describing unusual monster activity."

"Unusual in what way?"

"Large numbers of scorpion-like creatures had been sighted throughout the ruins and their surrounding territory. Their movements suggested that the region had become a breeding ground for a particularly dangerous species."

Bell considered the information.

"Scorpion-like monsters are not unheard of. What made this particular infestation so concerning?"

"The scale of it, for one. More importantly, the creatures displayed behavior that suggested coordination rather than simple territorial aggression."

"Meaning someone—or something—was influencing them?"

"That was one of the possibilities we considered."

Uranus folded his hands behind his back.

"The Artemis Familia was assigned to investigate because of its expertise in hunting, reconnaissance, and the tracking of dangerous creatures. Their abilities made them a natural choice for an expedition of that nature."

Bell's eyes narrowed slightly.

"And yet they disappeared."

"Yes."

Uranus did not attempt to soften the answer.

"We believed the expedition could be completed with manageable risks. That assessment was wrong."

Bell remained silent for a moment.

He understood that even experienced investigators could misjudge a situation. The problem was not simply that the mission had failed.

It was that an entire Familia had vanished.

"Have you received any messages from them since the expedition began?"

"None that can be verified."

"No survivors? No reliable reports from nearby settlements?"

"Nothing conclusive."

Bell's expression hardened.

"Then we cannot assume they were killed."

"Nor can we assume that they remain alive."

The answer was unpleasant, but Bell appreciated its honesty.

He had no intention of building his next decisions upon comforting speculation.

"Was the expedition meant to exterminate the creatures, or were they simply tasked with investigating the ruins?"

"Initially, the objective was reconnaissance and the assessment of the infestation. If the threat proved manageable, they were authorized to eliminate the creatures they encountered. If the situation exceeded their capabilities, they were expected to withdraw and report their findings."

Bell looked directly at Uranus.

"Then something prevented them from withdrawing."

"That is the most troubling possibility."

Uranus turned his gaze toward the distant windows, beyond which the sky stretched endlessly.

"The reports concerning the Elsos Ruins were incomplete. We knew of the monsters, but we did not understand the nature of the threat they represented. The Artemis Familia entered the region expecting a dangerous expedition."

He paused.

"They may have encountered something far more dangerous than any of us anticipated."

Bell felt a familiar uneasiness settle in his chest.

"Something that could defeat an entire Familia?"

"Potentially, yes."

"Then what are we dealing with?"

Uranus turned back toward him.

"An ancient Beast known as Antares."

The name hung in the air.

Bell did not react immediately. He had learned that a name alone meant very little without understanding what stood behind it.

"Antares," he repeated. "What can you tell me about it?"

"Not as much as I would like."

That answer surprised him.

"You don't know?"

"I know of its existence. I know that it is an ancient creature of extraordinary danger. And I know that the accounts concerning its capabilities are sufficiently alarming that they cannot be dismissed."

Uranus's expression grew grave.

"Antares possesses the ability to absorb arcanum from deities."

Bell's eyes narrowed.

"Absorb arcanum?"

"Yes. The power that belongs to divine beings is not beyond its reach. Under the right circumstances, Antares can draw upon that power for itself."

Bell considered the implications.

"If that is true, then conventional divine intervention could make the situation worse."

"Precisely."

Uranus nodded approvingly.

"You understand the difficulty. A creature capable of absorbing arcanum cannot be approached as though it were an ordinary monster. The very power used to defeat it may become a resource for its survival."

"Then the more power a deity uses against it, the more dangerous it might become."

"That is a reasonable concern. We must not assume that its ability has no limits, but neither should we act as though those limits are already understood."

Bell's thoughts began to organize themselves.

The missing Familia. The strange infestation. The remote ruins. The ancient Beast.

Each detail suggested that the disappearance was not a simple matter of a hunting expedition encountering stronger-than-expected monsters.

There was a larger problem beneath the surface.

"Grandfather, does Antares command the scorpion-like creatures?"

"We do not have sufficient evidence to establish that. Their presence in the ruins may be connected to Antares, but the precise relationship remains uncertain."

"Then we need to distinguish what we know from what we merely suspect."

"An excellent principle."

Bell nodded.

"If we assume that everything in the ruins is under Antares's control, we may overlook other dangers. But if we treat the infestation as unrelated, we may miss the reason the Artemis Familia was unable to return."

Uranus watched him with quiet approval.

"That is why I wanted you to understand the situation before proceeding. Courage is valuable, Bell, but courage without an accurate understanding of the danger can become little more than recklessness."

"I agree."

Bell paused before continuing.

"But if the Artemis Familia is still alive, we cannot afford to waste time."

"Nor can we afford to rush into the same mistake that led to their disappearance."

The two regarded one another.

Neither was willing to abandon the possibility of a rescue. Neither was willing to pretend that hope alone could overcome an ancient Beast.

At last, Bell spoke.

"Do we know anything about Antares's weaknesses?"

"Very little that can be relied upon. Its ability to absorb arcanum is the most significant trait reported, but the circumstances under which it functions remain unclear. Until we know more, you should avoid assuming that any particular method will work."

"Then reconnaissance is our first priority."

"Yes. Learn what you can about the terrain, the creatures inhabiting the ruins, and the circumstances surrounding the Familia's disappearance. Do not commit yourself to a confrontation simply because you have reached the destination."

Bell inclined his head.

"I understand."

Uranus studied him for another moment.

"There is something else I must impress upon you."

Bell looked up.

"Even with the knowledge I can provide, I cannot guarantee your safety. I have existed for an age beyond your comprehension, but age does not make one omniscient. There are mysteries even I have yet to unravel."

Bell answered without hesitation.

"I wouldn't expect you to know everything."

"Good. Then you will understand why I am warning you now."

Uranus's voice became firmer.

"Antares is not an opponent you should underestimate. If the reports are accurate, the battle ahead may test not only your strength, but your ability to adapt when the methods you rely upon no longer work."

Bell's gaze remained steady.

"Then I will have to learn as much as I can before I face it."

"And remember that survival is not cowardice. If the situation becomes impossible, retreat and reconsider your approach. There is no virtue in dying simply to prove that you were willing to fight."

Bell fell silent.

He understood the meaning behind those words.

A successful expedition was not necessarily one in which every enemy was defeated. If the Artemis Familia had vanished because they had encountered something beyond their capabilities, repeating their mistakes would help no one.

"I'll keep that in mind, Grandfather."

"See that you do."

For a moment, the tension eased.

Bell bowed his head.

"Thank you for telling me the truth. I know that the information is incomplete, but at least we now have a clearer understanding of what we're facing."

Uranus inclined his head in return.

"Do not thank me yet. The truth has a habit of revealing more questions than answers."

"That has certainly been my experience."

"Then perhaps you are finally learning."

Bell gave a faint smile.

"I'll take that as a compliment."

"You should."

Their conversation continued for some time, covering the known details of the Elsos Ruins, the circumstances of the expedition, and the importance of distinguishing reliable information from speculation. Uranus offered what knowledge he possessed, while Bell asked careful questions, examining each answer for implications that might otherwise have been overlooked.

By the time their discussion came to an end, the mystery surrounding the Artemis Familia had not been solved.

But the shape of the danger had become clearer.

Antares was no ordinary monster. Its ability to absorb divine arcanum made it a threat that demanded preparation, patience, and a willingness to abandon conventional assumptions.

And somewhere in the far eastern reaches of the world, the Elsos Ruins waited.

Bell bowed once more.

"I will remember your advice, Grandfather. I won't treat this as a simple monster hunt."

"Good."

Uranus's expression softened.

"And Bell?"

"Yes?"

"Whatever awaits you in those ruins, do not forget what we discussed in the land of dreams. Your ancestry may explain your origins, but it does not decide your future."

Bell looked at him.

For a brief moment, he remembered the boundless heavens, the stars beneath his feet, and the ancient Being who had promised to guide him without choosing his path for him.

"I remember," Bell replied. "My decisions are still my own."

"Precisely."

Uranus smiled.

"Then go forward with your eyes open, my great-grandson."

Bell turned to leave.

He had arrived seeking answers about a missing Familia. He departed with a clearer understanding of the danger, a renewed sense of purpose, and a name that would remain at the forefront of his thoughts.

Antares.

An ancient Beast capable of consuming the power of the divine.

Bell did not yet know how he would defeat it, nor whether the missing members of the Artemis Familia could still be saved.

But he knew one thing.

He would not walk into the Elsos Ruins blindly.

And he would not allow the uncertainty surrounding their disappearance to become an excuse for abandoning those who might still be waiting for rescue.

As he stepped beyond the chamber, the light of the heavens fell across his path.

Somewhere within his thoughts, Uranus's voice stirred with quiet amusement.

Well, Bell. It seems your journey is about to become rather interesting.

Bell sighed inwardly.

Grandfather, please don't jinx it.

Uranus laughed.

And beneath the endless sky, Bell Cranel continued toward the truth.

Chapter Thirty-Nine: Tame

Arc 6: Point of Divergence

The decision had been made, but none of them mistook it for a victory.

They were merely choosing how to survive what came next.

Bell stood beneath the shadow of an old stone archway, his white hair stirred by the wind sweeping through Orario's streets. Artemis stood beside him, her fingers intertwined with his. Hermes, meanwhile, had abandoned his usual playful expression for something considerably more serious. For once, the messenger god appeared to understand that a careless joke could cost lives.

“We need more people,” Bell said. “As many capable fighters as we can gather without compromising the secrecy of our movements. If the enemy has the numbers, then we cannot afford to fight them on their terms.”

Artemis glanced at him. “You believe they'll have the advantage?”

“I believe that assuming they won't is a good way to die.”

His answer was immediate, almost clinical.

“Even if we possess superior individual strength, numbers can overwhelm us. They can surround us, divide our forces, exhaust our reserves, and force us to protect people who cannot

defend themselves. Worse, if the enemy understands our objective, they can choose the battlefield before we even arrive."

Hermes crossed his arms.

"An unpleasantly sensible assessment. I'd almost prefer it if you were being dramatic. At least then I could pretend the situation wasn't as dire as it sounds."

"Can you gather help?" Artemis asked.

Hermes tilted his head, allowing a familiar smile to return to his face.

"My dear Artemis, you wound me. Do you honestly believe I'd have allowed myself to become involved in such a troublesome affair without having a few useful acquaintances?"

"Useful acquaintances," Bell repeated.

"Friends, business partners, people who owe me favors, people who think they owe me favors, and people who would be delighted to see me suffer if I asked them for assistance. Orario is full of wonderful people."

"That last category doesn't sound particularly useful."

"Oh, you'd be surprised. Spite is a powerful motivator."

Artemis sighed.

"Hermes."

"Yes, yes. I'll be serious."

The god raised both hands in surrender. Then he lowered them, and his expression sharpened.

"I'll arrange additional support, secure transport, and make certain our departure doesn't attract unnecessary attention. However, there is one condition: none of you are to proceed toward the eastern frontier until we have established a reasonable margin of safety."

Bell's eyes narrowed slightly.

"And if you can't gather enough people?"

"Then we reconsider the plan. I'm a god, Bell, not a gambling addict. There's a difference between taking a calculated risk and throwing everyone's lives onto a table because the alternative is inconvenient."

For a moment, Bell studied him.

Then he nodded.

“Understood.”

Hermes smiled.

“Excellent. I do enjoy it when people appreciate my wisdom.”

“Don't ruin it,” Artemis muttered.

“Too late, I'm afraid.”

He turned toward the street, adjusted his hat, and began walking away. After several steps, he looked back over his shoulder.

“Oh, and Bell?”

“Yes?”

“Try not to cause any scandals while I'm gone. I have a reputation to maintain.”

Bell stared at him.

Artemis's fingers tightened around his hand.

“Go.”

Hermes laughed as he disappeared into the morning crowd.

The moment he was gone, the air seemed to grow quieter.

Bell looked down at the hand holding his own.

Artemis followed his gaze, but rather than release him, she lifted her chin and met his eyes with an expression that dared him to complain.

“Come,” Bell said. “There's someone I need to speak with.”

“Someone you need to speak with?”

“Hestia.”

Artemis's eyebrows rose.

“Your goddess?”

“Yes.”

She considered the answer for a moment before nodding.

“Then we shouldn't keep her waiting.”

Neither of them appeared to notice the storm they were about to walk into.

I. The Goddess and the Unwelcome Revelation

The abandoned church had never been particularly impressive.

Its roof bore the scars of age, several of its windows were cracked, and the wooden pews had begun to complain under even the slightest pressure. Yet, for Hestia, the little building had once been a home. It had been a place where she could escape the noise of the world, where she could worry about her children without other gods laughing at her circumstances.

And, most importantly, it was where Bell had come to see her.

That was why she had been waiting.

When the door opened, Hestia looked up with a smile already forming on her face.

“Bell! There you are! Do you have any idea how long I've—”

Her voice stopped.

Bell stood in the doorway.

And beside him stood Artemis.

Their hands were joined.

Hestia blinked.

Once.

Twice.

She stared at their hands, then at Bell's face, then at Artemis's face, and finally back at their hands as though the sight might become less absurd if she examined it from a different angle.

It did not.

“...Bell?”

“Yes, Hestia?”

“Why are you holding hands with Artemis?”

Artemis offered a polite smile.

“Hello, Hestia. It's been a while.”

Hestia's mouth opened.

Closed.

Opened again.

“That's not an answer!”

Bell sighed softly.

“Hestia, please. We have something important to discuss.”

“Something important?” Hestia repeated. “Something important? Bell, you walk into my church holding hands with my best friend, and you expect me to simply sit down and listen to whatever you have to say?”

“Preferably.”

“Preferably?!”

Artemis covered her mouth, but not quickly enough to hide the small laugh escaping her.

Hestia turned toward her.

“And you! You're supposed to be my friend! My best friend! You're supposed to help me when Bell does something stupid, not— not—”

“Hold his hand?” Artemis supplied.

“YES!”

Bell rubbed the bridge of his nose.

This was going to take longer than he had anticipated.

“Hestia,” he began carefully, “I understand that this looks strange.”

“Strange? Strange is when you find a monster living in your cupboard! This is—this is betrayal! Romantic betrayal! With extra betrayal!”

“I'm not betraying you,” Bell said.

“Then explain!”

He took a breath.

“Artemis and I have reached an understanding. Our relationship is something we decided between ourselves, and I don't intend to insult either of you by pretending otherwise. But that isn't why we're here. The situation involving the monster, Artemis Familia, and the people pursuing us has become too dangerous to handle carelessly.”

The humor gradually left Artemis's expression.

She turned toward Hestia.

“He's right. I know this is difficult to accept without warning, especially under these circumstances, but we need your help. There are things happening beyond Orario that may become much worse if we fail to act.”

Hestia looked from one to the other.

For all her indignation, she was not foolish. She had lived among gods for centuries, and she understood that the expression on Bell's face was not the expression of someone who had come to discuss his love life.

It was the expression of someone who had already begun preparing for a battle.

That frightened her far more than the sight of their joined hands.

“Bell,” she said quietly, “what exactly happened?”

He released a slow breath.

Then he began explaining.

He told her about the monster and the danger surrounding Artemis Familia. He explained why their current position left them vulnerable, why the enemy's numbers mattered, and why waiting for certainty could be more dangerous than moving with incomplete information. He described the arrangements he and Artemis had made with Hermes and the necessity of gathering additional allies before traveling east.

He did not pretend to know every answer.

When Hestia asked a question he could not answer, he told her so.

When she asked whether the situation could be avoided, he explained why they could no longer rely on that possibility.

And when she finally asked the question that had been troubling her most, Bell paused.

“Are you going to be in danger?”

“Yes.”

The answer was immediate.

Hestia's fingers curled into the fabric of her skirt.

“You could have lied.”

“I could have.”

“Then why didn't you?”

“Because you deserve to know what you're agreeing to. And because I don't want you making a decision based on a promise I might not be able to keep.”

For several seconds, the church was silent.

Hestia lowered her eyes.

She had known Bell long enough to recognize that stubbornness. He was gentle, often considerate to a fault, but once he had decided that a responsibility belonged to him, persuading him to abandon it was like asking the sun to stop rising.

She hated that part of him.

She was also, in a way she could never fully explain, proud of it.

“So,” she murmured, “you've already decided to go.”

Bell did not answer immediately.

“I've decided that we need to prepare. Whether we go forward depends on what we learn and what support we can gather.”

“That's a very careful answer.”

“It's the honest one.”

Hestia looked at Artemis again.

Her best friend stood close to Bell, not as a stranger who had wandered into his life by accident, but as someone who had chosen to stand beside him despite knowing what awaited them.

Hestia understood that part.

She understood it far too well.

She could love Bell. Artemis could love Bell. The world did not end simply because two people wanted the same impossible thing.

But understanding something did not mean she had to like it.

“You know,” Hestia said, forcing a smile that did not quite reach her eyes, “I was prepared for Bell to fall in love someday. I really was. I even imagined that I'd be the first person he'd tell.”

Bell looked faintly uncomfortable.

“Hestia—”

“No, let me finish.” She raised a hand. “I imagined some lovely girl who would make him happy. Someone kind, someone who would worry when he returned late, someone who would scold him when he forgot to eat. And I thought, well, perhaps I'd complain a little. Perhaps I'd make her work for my approval.”

Artemis's smile softened.

“But I never imagined that the girl would be you,” Hestia continued. “My best friend. Of all the people in the world, why did it have to be you?”

Artemis lowered her gaze.

“I can't give you an answer that will make this painless.”

“Good. Because if you tried, I might throw something at you.”

“That would be fair.”

“Hah! Don't agree with me!”

Despite herself, Hestia laughed. It was a small, wounded sound, but it was a laugh all the same.

Then she looked at Bell.

“You'd better take care of her.”

“I will.”

“And don't you dare think that means I'm giving you permission to make me your last priority.”

“I wouldn't.”

“Because I'm still your goddess, you little rabbit!”

Bell smiled faintly.

“Yes, Hestia.”

“And if you come back with even one unnecessary injury, I'll—”

She stopped.

Her smile faded.

For a moment, she seemed unable to find the words.

“Just come back,” she whispered.

Bell's expression softened.

“I'll do everything I can.”

It was not a promise of invulnerability.

It was not a guarantee that fate would be kind.

But Hestia accepted it, because she knew that a more certain promise would have been a lie.

She reached forward and pulled Bell into a tight embrace.

“You idiot,” she muttered against his chest. “You absolute, infuriating idiot.”

Bell returned the embrace.

“I know.”

“And stop making me worry!”

“I'll try.”

“Try harder!”

Artemis watched them quietly, a complicated expression passing across her face.

For all her own feelings, she could not begrudge Hestia this moment. Whatever had changed between them, the bond those two shared had been built through hunger, poverty, failure, and the stubborn decision to keep moving forward when the world offered them nothing.

It was not something that could be replaced.

Nor was it something Artemis intended to destroy.

Unfortunately, peace was a fragile thing.

And Hermes, as always, had terrible timing.

II. The Grand Entrance of Two Idiots

BANG!

The church doors flew open.

“GOOD NEWS, MY DEAR FRIENDS!”

Hestia nearly jumped out of her skin.

Bell instinctively shifted in front of the two goddesses, his hand already moving toward the equipment at his waist. Artemis turned sharply, her expression hardening.

Standing in the doorway, arms spread wide as though he expected an audience to applaud, was Hermes.

Behind him stood an enormous figure wearing a peculiar mask.

“I HAVE ARRIVED!” the newcomer declared, striking a pose so dramatic that it seemed physically impossible for him to remain standing afterward. “I AM GANESHA! THAT IS ALL YOU NEED TO KNOW!”

Silence.

Bell stared at him.

Artemis stared at him.

Hestia slowly turned toward Hermes.

“...Why?”

Hermes placed a hand over his heart.

“Why what?”

“Why is he here?”

“Because I invited him.”

“WHY?”

“Because he is Ganesha.”

Ganesha raised both arms.

“THAT IS CORRECT!”

Hestia closed her eyes.

For a moment, she appeared to be praying for the strength not to murder another god.

Bell, meanwhile, studied their unexpected visitor.

“Ganesha,” he said. “Your Familia specializes in monster taming, correct?”

“EXCELLENT! YOU KNOW MY GREATNESS!”

“I know your Familia's reputation.”

“EVEN BETTER!”

Hermes leaned against the doorframe.

“Ganesha's people have experience handling dangerous monsters, transporting large creatures, and keeping them under control. More importantly, they have the manpower to protect a traveling group without leaving us completely exposed.”

“Assuming the creatures cooperate,” Bell observed.

“Ah, yes. That little detail.”

Ganesha placed a hand on his chest with exaggerated dignity.

“MY FAMILIA HAS TAMELESSLY—”

“Tamed,” Hermes corrected.

“—TAMED MANY MONSTERS!”

Artemis raised an eyebrow.

“Are we supposed to trust them?”

“Not blindly,” Bell answered before Hermes could. “We'll need to establish how well the creatures respond to their handlers and whether they can carry us safely over long distances. If the journey takes us beyond familiar territory, we cannot afford transport that becomes a liability.”

Ganesha nodded with surprising seriousness.

“AN EXCELLENT QUESTION! OUR DRAGONS HAVE BEEN TRAINED FOR LONG-DISTANCE FLIGHT. THEY ARE USED TO RIDERS, AND THEY RESPOND TO COMMANDS FROM THEIR HANDLERS. THEY ARE NOT WAR MACHINES, HOWEVER. IF THEY ARE PROVOKED OR EXHAUSTED, THEY WILL NEED REST.”

Bell's eyes narrowed thoughtfully.

“Good. I'd rather know their limitations now than discover them in the middle of a crisis.”

“HA! YOU SPEAK LIKE A MAN WHO UNDERSTANDS THE IMPORTANCE OF PROPER PREPARATION!”

“I try.”

Hermes clapped his hands.

“Wonderful! Then we're all in agreement. Ganesha will provide transportation and a contingent of his Familia. I'll handle the remaining arrangements, and our dear Bell will presumably spend the next several hours finding ways to make my perfectly reasonable plan even more complicated.”

“I haven't agreed to the plan yet,” Bell said.

Hermes's smile froze.

“Pardon?”

“I said we need to verify the details.”

“Bell, my boy, I have gone to considerable trouble to arrange this.”

“And I appreciate that. But I won't accept an arrangement simply because you've put considerable effort into making it.”

For a moment, Hermes looked genuinely offended.

Then he laughed.

“Ha! Excellent! Absolutely excellent! A man who refuses to be persuaded by a good presentation. How troublesome.”

“I'm sure you'll survive.”

“Barely.”

Artemis covered a smile with her hand.

Hestia, however, had noticed something else.

“Wait. You said Ganesha is providing transportation?”

“Correct!” Ganesha announced.

“With dragons?”

“CORRECT!”

“Flying dragons?”

“OF COURSE!”

Hestia slowly looked toward the ceiling of the ruined church.

Then she looked at Bell.

“Bell, I would like to revise my earlier statement.”

“Which one?”

“The part where I said you were an idiot.”

“...Thank you?”

“You are a much bigger idiot than I thought.”

Hermes burst out laughing.

And just like that, the tension inside the church cracked—not entirely, but enough for everyone to breathe again.

They did not waste much more time.

There were supplies to gather, provisions to divide, and equipment that needed to be checked before departure. Bell insisted on reviewing their inventory personally, separating necessities from things that would only slow them down. Artemis helped organize the group's essentials, while Hestia made certain that Bell did not quietly remove half the food from his own pack to save room for someone else's belongings.

Hermes, naturally, supervised by offering advice nobody had requested.

Ganesha, meanwhile, loudly explained the virtues of his Familia's transportation arrangements to anyone willing to listen.

By the time the church had emptied of unnecessary belongings and the expedition's supplies had been assembled, the sun had climbed higher over Orario.

They were ready to leave.

Or so they believed.

Because while Bell and the others were preparing for the journey, Hermes had already made another arrangement.

One that involved a familiar elf, a considerable sum of money, and a young man who should not have existed.

III. The Rabbit Who Wasn't There

The Hostess of Fertility was busy.

The smell of freshly baked bread, simmering soup, and roasted meat filled the establishment. Adventurers occupied the tables, their voices rising and falling in the familiar rhythm of a tavern where people gathered to exchange stories, spend their earnings, and forget the dangers waiting beneath the city.

Hermes entered with his usual unhurried confidence.

He had barely crossed the threshold when something caught his eye.

At a table near the wall sat a young woman with white hair and red eyes.

She wore a simple dress, her hair arranged to frame a face that was unmistakably familiar.

Hermes stopped walking.

The young woman lifted a cup to her lips.

Hermes stared.

She lowered it.

Hermes continued staring.

Then, very slowly, he turned his head toward the door through which he had entered, as though expecting the real world to explain itself if he looked at it from the correct angle.

No.

He turned back.

Absolutely not.

The girl blinked at him.

“...Is something wrong?”

Hermes smiled automatically.

“Not at all, my dear. Not at all.”

He walked past her table, then paused.

He looked again.

White hair. Red eyes. A face that looked remarkably like Bell Cranel's, if Bell Cranel had been born a girl.

Hermes felt the first stirrings of a headache.

I just left Bell with Artemis. I watched them walk toward that miserable little church together. I am absolutely certain of this.

He glanced at the girl again.

So either I have finally worked myself to death, or someone has decided to make my life considerably more interesting.

He chose not to investigate immediately.

There were more pressing matters.

At the counter stood Mama Mia, polishing a glass with the expression of someone who had seen enough foolishness in her lifetime to recognize it before it opened its mouth.

Hermes approached her.

“Mama Mia, my dear! How lovely to see you.”

Mia did not look up.

“If you're here to drink, sit down. If you're here to cause trouble, take it outside.”

“Such a warm welcome.”

“I've known you too long.”

Hermes pressed a hand to his chest.

“And here I thought we had a beautiful friendship.”

“We have a business relationship. Don't confuse the two.”

“Then perhaps we can conduct a little business.”

Mia finally looked at him.

“What do you want?”

“I need to borrow Ryuu.”

Mia's expression became completely still.

“No.”

Hermes blinked.

“You haven't even heard the details.”

“I don't need the details. The last time someone said they needed Ryuu for something urgent, she returned looking like she'd spent three days fighting the Dungeon with a kitchen knife.”

“That sounds like an exaggeration.”

“It isn't.”

“Then you understand why I need someone competent.”

Mia put the glass down.

“Try again.”

Hermes sighed theatrically.

“Very well. I need an experienced adventurer for a time-sensitive expedition beyond Orario. The assignment requires someone who can operate independently, assess danger, protect a small group, and keep sensitive information confidential. Ryuu fits those requirements better than most people I know.”

Mia studied him.

“An expedition beyond Orario?”

“Yes.”

“How far?”

“Far enough that I cannot give you a precise return date.”

“Then the answer is still no.”

Hermes's smile faltered.

“Mia, please. This isn't an ordinary request.”

“Exactly. Ordinary requests are how people end up dead when someone else decides their time is more valuable than their lives.”

She leaned forward.

“Ryuu has responsibilities here. She works here, she protects people here, and I won't send her off on a mysterious journey because a god in a fancy hat says the situation is urgent.”

Hermes regarded her for a moment.

Then, with the solemnity of a man making a deeply regrettable sacrifice, he reached into his pocket.

“How much?”

Mia's eyes narrowed.

“Now we're talking.”

“Of course we are.”

“Compensation for the time she's away, the inconvenience to the establishment, and the possibility that she won't return when expected.”

Hermes winced.

“You're charging me for the possibility of something that hasn't happened?”

“Would you prefer to pay for it afterward?”

He stared at her.

Mia stared back.

At length, Hermes sighed and agreed to her terms.

The exchange was not especially dignified, but it was effective.

Once the arrangement had been settled, Mia gestured toward the back of the establishment.

“She's cleaning the storage room. If you're going to ask her, ask her yourself. And Hermes?”

“Yes?”

“If you bring her back injured because you couldn't be bothered to explain what she was getting into, I'll make certain your next visit to this establishment is considerably less comfortable.”

Hermes smiled.

“Your concern for your employees is truly touching.”

“Out.”

He went.

Ryuu was arranging a collection of supplies when Hermes found her.

She looked up at the sound of his footsteps, her expression immediately guarded.

“Lord Hermes.”

“Ryuu. Just the person I was hoping to find.”

“Then I recommend reconsidering your expectations. I am working.”

“Ah, but what if I told you that I had an opportunity for you to do something considerably more important than rearranging provisions?”

“I would ask why you came to me rather than a member of your own Familia.”

Hermes put a hand to his chin.

“A reasonable question. Unfortunately, my Familia's strengths are not particularly suited to this assignment. We have useful people, certainly, but I need someone with your particular combination of combat experience, judgment, and independence.”

Ryuu set the supplies aside.

“What assignment?”

“An expedition beyond Orario. The destination is far to the east, and the journey will likely take a considerable amount of time. We have reason to believe that the people involved may encounter hostile forces, and the information surrounding the mission is sensitive.”

“Then why not hire a larger force?”

“We are.”

Hermes held up a finger.

“But a large force has limitations. It is conspicuous, difficult to maneuver, and not always suitable for reconnaissance or emergency intervention. I need someone who can act as a frontline combatant while remaining capable of making independent decisions if the group becomes separated.”

Ryuu's expression changed slightly.

This was no longer an ordinary request from a god who had become bored and wanted an adventurer to entertain him.

“Who else is involved?”

“I cannot give you every detail here. Some of the information is classified for the protection of the people concerned, and I will not discuss it in a public establishment where half the room might be listening.”

“That is a convenient excuse.”

“Indeed. Which is why I am offering you a choice rather than demanding blind obedience.”

Hermes's tone became more measured.

“You may refuse. If you do, I will compensate you for your time and leave you to your work. If you accept, I will explain everything you need to know before we depart, including the risks, the destination, and the responsibilities expected of you.”

Ryuu regarded him silently.

“What makes you think I would accept?”

“Because you have a habit of walking toward trouble when someone else might be hurt.”

Her eyes narrowed.

“Do not presume to understand my motives.”

“I wouldn't dare.”

He smiled, but there was no mockery in it.

“I simply believe that, if I told you someone might need your help, you would at least want to hear the circumstances before deciding whether to walk away.”

Ryuu did not answer.

Hermes let the silence settle.

He knew better than to press her when she was thinking.

Then Ryuu's gaze drifted toward the dining area.

Toward the white-haired girl.

The girl had finished her drink and was now sitting quietly, her hands folded on the table. She seemed content to wait, apparently oblivious to the peculiar attention she had attracted.

Ryuu's expression softened.

“Bell...”

Hermes followed her gaze.

There it is.

The elf looked at the girl for several seconds, then turned back to Hermes.

“Why is he here?”

Hermes opened his mouth.

Closed it.

Then he smiled with the strained patience of a man attempting to explain an impossible situation without admitting that he had no explanation whatsoever.

“An excellent question.”

“Lord Hermes.”

“Unfortunately, I cannot provide you with an excellent answer.”

Ryuu's expression grew colder.

“Is he involved in this expedition?”

Hermes hesitated.

This was the problem with Ryuu.

She was intelligent enough to recognize a lie before most people had finished telling it.

And the longer she looked at the girl, the less likely she was to leave her behind.

Hermes decided to change tactics.

“Let me ask you something, Ryuu. If you were to accept this assignment, would you be willing to take responsibility for a civilian companion who might accompany the expedition?”

“A civilian?”

“Someone who is not equipped to participate in frontline combat.”

Ryuu glanced toward the girl again.

“Why would a civilian be traveling with an expedition of this nature?”

“Because circumstances are rarely as convenient as we would like. The person in question may possess information or circumstances that make it necessary for them to travel with us. Keeping them in Orario might expose them to a different kind of danger.”

“That still does not explain why you would bring them on an expedition where combat is expected.”

“Which is why I would prefer to have an experienced adventurer accompanying them.”

Ryuu folded her arms.

“You are asking me to protect an unknown civilian on a classified expedition, without telling me the full details, and you expect me to agree?”

“No. I am asking you to hear the full details in private before you decide.”

“That is a distinction without much difference.”

“Perhaps. But it is an important one.”

Hermes reached into his pocket again and produced a sealed document.

“This contains the preliminary terms, the destination, and the compensation. You may review it before we depart. If anything in it makes you uncomfortable, you can withdraw. I won't hold you to an agreement you haven't made.”

Ryuu accepted the document, but did not open it.

She was still looking at the girl.

For nearly two minutes, she remained silent.

Hermes waited.

He had learned that the best way to persuade someone like Ryuu was not to offer a grand speech. It was to give her enough information to recognize the problem herself.

At last, she spoke.

“If I accept, I will not tolerate being kept ignorant of dangers that directly affect the people under my protection.”

“Agreed.”

“And I will not abandon a civilian simply because the mission becomes inconvenient.”

“Nor would I expect you to.”

“Then I will hear the details in private. After that, I will make my decision.”

Hermes beamed.

“Splendid! I knew you would be reasonable.”

“I have not agreed to the expedition.”

“Of course not.”

“And I am still suspicious of you.”

“An excellent habit.”

Ryuu placed the sealed document into her bag.

Then she glanced at the girl once more.

“If he is going, I cannot simply leave him here without understanding why.”

Hermes tilted his head.

“Then perhaps the simplest solution is to bring him along.”

Ryuu stared at him.

“...What?”

“If you're worried about leaving him alone, bringing him with us solves that particular problem. You would be able to keep an eye on him, and he wouldn't be left in Orario while the rest of us travel east.”

“That is not a logical argument. It merely transfers the problem from one place to another.”

“Precisely! And sometimes, transferring a problem to a place where you have more resources is the beginning of a solution.”

“That is not how logic works.”

“Not always. But it is how logistics work.”

Ryuu looked as though she were considering whether the gods had somehow conspired to make her life more difficult.

Hermes continued before she could object.

“I am not asking you to agree to anything unreasonable. If the girl is to travel with us, she will have to understand that this is not a leisurely journey. She will need suitable clothing, supplies,

and protection. We will discuss all of that before we leave. You will also have the right to refuse the responsibility if the circumstances prove unacceptable.”

Ryuu glanced toward the table again.

The girl had noticed them now.

She raised a hand in a small, cheerful wave.

Ryuu's expression softened despite herself.

Bell, what on earth are you doing?

She still had questions. Far too many questions.

But she could not simply leave him alone in a city full of adventurers while embarking on an expedition whose details remained uncertain.

Not when he was looking at her with those familiar red eyes.

Not when some quiet, stubborn part of her insisted that whatever was happening, he might need someone watching over him.

Ryuu exhaled.

“Very well. I will accompany you to hear the details. And if I discover that you have manipulated me into accepting an unreasonable assignment, Lord Hermes, I will hold you personally responsible.”

Hermes placed a hand over his heart.

“Your faith in me is deeply moving.”

“It was not an expression of faith.”

“Even better.”

Ryuu walked toward the table.

Hermes followed, already wondering how he was going to explain this particular development to the real Bell.

For now, however, the problem had been contained.

More or less.

IV. The Northern Wall

The northern wall of Orario rose above the surrounding landscape like a final barrier between civilization and the unknown.

Beyond it lay roads that gradually thinned into wilderness, settlements that grew more distant with every passing mile, and territories where the protections of the great city could no longer be taken for granted.

The expedition gathered there beneath the morning sun.

Ganesha Familia had arrived in considerable numbers. Their members checked harnesses, inspected saddles, and exchanged instructions with the calm efficiency of people who had performed this work many times before.

And there, standing among them, were the dragons.

They were magnificent creatures.

Their scales caught the sunlight in shades of green, bronze, and deep blue. Their wings were folded neatly against their bodies, and their long tails rested upon the ground. Some blinked sleepily at the passing adventurers. Others lowered their heads to sniff at the supplies being loaded onto their saddles.

One dragon, in particular, had decided that a nearby handler's sleeve was worth investigating.

“Hey! Stop that!”

The dragon gently tugged at the fabric.

“Let go!”

It tugged again.

“I'm serious!”

The dragon released the sleeve, then immediately tried to chew on the handler's belt.

Bell watched the scene with quiet fascination.

“They're much calmer than I expected.”

Ganesha puffed out his chest.

“OF COURSE! A WELL-TRAINED DRAGON IS A COMPANION, NOT A BEAST TO BE FEARED!”

The dragon in question sneezed.

The handler stumbled backward.

Ganesha paused.

“...MOST OF THE TIME.”

Artemis laughed softly.

“I think I prefer them like this. It would be rather unpleasant to spend the journey trying to convince an angry dragon not to eat us.”

“An understandable preference,” Bell said.

Hestia stood beside him, staring at the enormous creatures with undisguised apprehension.

“Bell, how exactly are we supposed to ride those things?”

“Carefully?”

“That's not an answer!”

“It's the beginning of one.”

“Bell!”

He smiled.

“Don't worry. We'll follow the handlers' instructions.”

Hestia folded her arms.

“You say that now. I know you. You'll get curious about something, lean too far over the saddle, and nearly fall off.”

“I wouldn't do that.”

“You once tried to inspect a monster's teeth while it was still alive!”

“That was a different situation.”

“It was a monster, Bell!”

“A very interesting monster.”

Artemis laughed again, and for a moment the three of them seemed almost like an ordinary group preparing for an ordinary journey.

Then a familiar voice called from behind them.

“Ah! There you are!”

Hermes approached with his usual confident stride.

Beside him walked Ryuu, carrying her equipment and wearing the expression of someone who had already decided that this expedition was going to test her patience.

And beside Ryuu—

Bell stopped smiling.

The girl with white hair looked up at him.

Their eyes met.

For a brief, bewildering instant, the world seemed to pause.

Bell stared at the girl.

The girl stared at Bell.

Both possessed the same white hair, the same red eyes, and an almost identical face.

The only immediately obvious difference was the girl's clothing and the softer silhouette beneath it.

Artemis slowly turned toward Bell.

Hestia's mouth fell open.

Hermes, meanwhile, looked delighted.

“Everyone! I would like to introduce our additional companions!”

He gestured grandly.

“Ryuu Lion, a capable adventurer whose experience should prove invaluable to our expedition, and—”

The girl smiled.

“Hello!”

Hermes paused.

“—our other companion.”

Bell's expression remained perfectly still.

Then he looked at Hermes.

Then at the girl.

Then back at Hermes.

“...Explain.”

Hermes clasped his hands together.

“Ah, yes. I was hoping someone would ask.”

“Explain,” Bell repeated, his voice dangerously calm.

The girl tilted her head.

“Is something wrong?”

Bell stared at her.

That is my face.

He blinked.

That is quite literally my face.

He looked down at his own hands, then at hers.

No, I am not dreaming. I am not hallucinating. I am standing in broad daylight, surrounded by witnesses, and there is another me standing several feet away wearing a dress.

His thoughts raced through possibilities.

Magic.

Illusion.

Transformation.

A doppelgänger.

An elaborate joke.

A prank orchestrated by a god with too much free time.

His gaze returned to Hermes.

It's the last one, isn't it?

Hermes smiled.

“Bell, my dear boy, I can see that you have questions.”

“I have several.”

“Wonderful! I adore curiosity.”

“Start talking.”

“Unfortunately, we have a schedule to maintain.”

Bell's expression darkened.

Hermes immediately raised both hands.

“Later! I'll explain everything later. I promise.”

“That is not reassuring.”

“It wasn't meant to be.”

Artemis took a step closer to Bell, studying the girl with open astonishment.

“Who is she?”

The girl offered a polite little bow.

“I'm—”

Hermes cleared his throat.

“A companion. For now, let us leave the introductions at that. We have a long journey ahead of us, and I would rather not conduct a complicated discussion in the middle of a busy road.”

Hestia pointed at the girl.

“YOU CAN'T JUST SAY THAT AND EXPECT US TO ACCEPT IT!”

“I can, actually. Watch.”

“HERMES!”

Ryuu looked between them, increasingly suspicious.

“Lord Hermes, I believe you owe me an explanation.”

“I owe several people explanations today.”

“That is not helping your case.”

“I'm aware.”

The girl approached Bell, examining his face with unabashed interest.

“You really do look exactly like me.”

Bell looked at her.

“So do you.”

“Isn't that strange?”

“Extremely.”

She smiled.

“I think it's interesting.”

Bell had no answer to that.

For once, he found himself entirely unable to decide whether he was dealing with a threat, a mystery, or a catastrophe.

Possibly all three.

V. The Problem of Two Seats

The dragons had been prepared for departure.

The Ganesha Familia handlers had organized the riders according to their respective assignments. The main group would travel together, while a smaller advance party would move ahead to scout the route and identify potential dangers.

Ryuu and the girl were assigned to the advance party alongside several members of Hermes Familia.

Bell watched them prepare.

“Why are they going first?” he asked.

Hermes adjusted his gloves.

“Because we need to establish whether the route is safe. The advance party is smaller, more mobile, and better suited to reconnaissance. Ryuu can handle herself in a fight, and the girl will be traveling under her supervision.”

“You're sending someone who looks exactly like me into an unknown region, and you're still refusing to explain why?”

“Bell, I have not refused to explain. I have postponed the explanation until we are somewhere more suitable.”

“You've postponed it three times.”

“And each time, I have done so for a different reason.”

“That's not a defense.”

“No, but it is an accurate account of events.”

Bell stared at him.

Hermes smiled.

Then, before Bell could continue the interrogation, one of Ganesha's handlers approached.

“Everyone, we need to finalize the seating arrangements. Each dragon is carrying two riders. Please decide your partners now so we can check the weight distribution and secure the harnesses.”

The words fell upon the group like a divine curse.

Bell looked at the dragons.

Then at Artemis.

Then at Hestia.

Then at Hermes.

He counted silently.

Four people.

Two dragons.

Two seats per dragon.

The arithmetic was simple.

The consequences were not.

Hestia's expression changed first.

“Bell.”

He turned toward her.

“Yes?”

“We're riding together.”

Artemis immediately tightened her grip on his arm.

“No, we're not.”

Hestia stared at her.

“Excuse me?”

“I said Bell is riding with me.”

“You cannot simply decide that!”

“Why not?”

“Because I'm his goddess!”

“And I'm his partner.”

Hestia looked as though Artemis had just challenged her to a duel.

“YOUR PARTNER?!”

Artemis's chin rose.

“Yes.”

Bell closed his eyes.

Please, not here.

Hermes, naturally, looked as though someone had just handed him the finest entertainment in the world.

“Oh, this is marvelous.”

“Not a word,” Bell warned.

“I haven't said anything.”

“You're smiling.”

“Am I not allowed to smile?”

“Not like that.”

Hestia pointed at Hermes.

“And you! Stop encouraging her!”

Hermes placed a hand over his heart.

“I would never interfere in a private disagreement between friends.”

“You're enjoying this!”

“Immensely.”

Artemis turned toward Hestia.

“Listen, I understand that you have concerns. I understand that Bell is important to you, and I have no intention of taking that away from you. But I will not pretend that our relationship means nothing simply because acknowledging it is uncomfortable.”

Hestia's expression tightened.

“Do you think I'm pretending?”

“No. I think you're hurt.”

For a moment, Hestia said nothing.

Artemis continued, her voice gentler now.

“And I am sorry for that. But I will not apologize for loving him. I would rather be honest with you than hide behind excuses.”

Hestia looked away.

Bell felt the tension between them settle over his shoulders.

He could have intervened.

He could have tried to soften Artemis's words, or reminded Hestia that their relationship did not erase what they had shared.

But he knew both women well enough to understand that doing so might only make matters worse.

Instead, he spoke quietly.

“I'm not going anywhere without either of you.”

Hestia looked back at him.

“Bell...”

“I mean it. Whatever happens between us, you're still important to me. Both of you.”

Artemis's expression softened.

Hestia's eyes glistened, though she quickly looked away to conceal it.

Then Artemis moved.

Without another word, she took Bell by the hand and pulled him toward the nearest dragon.

“Artemis!”

“We're riding together.”

“You can't just—”

“I can, and I have.”

She turned toward the handler.

“Two riders here, please.”

The handler looked between Bell and Artemis.

Then, wisely, he nodded.

“Very well. Please wait while we secure the saddles.”

Bell looked over his shoulder.

Hestia stood frozen.

Beside her, Hermes slowly lifted one hand.

“Well, it appears that leaves us together.”

Hestia turned toward him with the expression of a woman who had just discovered that the universe possessed a cruel sense of humor.

“No.”

Hermes blinked.

“No?”

“I refuse.”

“I'm afraid the seating arrangements are rather limited.”

“Then I'll ride alone!”

“Each dragon has only two seats, and the handlers have already distributed the remaining riders.”

“THEN I'LL WALK!”

Hermes considered that for a moment.

“That would be an impressively stubborn decision, but I should warn you that the eastern frontier is quite far away.”

Hestia glared at him.

Hermes offered his arm.

“My dear goddess, I assure you that I shall be the most considerate traveling companion imaginable.”

“You're the least considerate god I know.”

“High praise, considering the competition.”

She stared at his offered arm as though it were a poisonous snake.

Then, with great reluctance, she accepted it.

“I'm holding you responsible for this.”

“Of course.”

“And if you make one inappropriate joke—”

“I shall make two.”

“HERMES!”

He laughed and helped her climb onto the second dragon.

The handlers checked the harnesses, adjusted the saddles, and gave the creatures their instructions. One by one, the dragons rose onto their hind legs and spread their wings.

The wind swept across the northern wall.

Loose dust and dry leaves spiraled through the air.

Bell settled into his seat behind Artemis, one hand gripping the saddle while the other rested lightly against her waist.

She glanced back at him.

“Are you comfortable?”

“Comfortable enough.”

“Good. Then hold on.”

“Artemis, wait—”

The dragon leaped.

Its wings unfurled with a thunderous beat, lifting them above the wall and into the open sky.

Bell's breath caught.

Below them, Orario spread across the landscape in a vast circle of stone and rooftops, the Tower of Babel rising from its center like a monument to the impossible ambitions of gods and mortals alike.

For a moment, he forgot the strange girl, the impending battle, and the mysteries waiting beyond the horizon.

There was only the wind.

The sky.

And the astonishing sensation of leaving the world he knew behind.

Artemis leaned back slightly.

“Beautiful, isn't it?”

Bell looked toward the distant horizon.

“Yes.”

Then his expression grew serious.

“But I wonder how much of it will still look the same when we return.”

Artemis did not answer immediately.

Instead, she reached back and took his hand.

“Whatever happens,” she said quietly, “we will face it together.”

Bell squeezed her fingers.

“Together.”

Behind them, the other dragon rose into the sky.

Hestia's voice carried across the wind.

“BELL! IF YOU FALL OFF THAT THING, I'M GOING TO KILL YOU MYSELF!”

Hermes's laughter followed.

“NOW, NOW, MY DEAR! TRY TO ENJOY THE SCENERY!”

“I WILL THROW YOU OFF THIS DRAGON!”

“THAT WOULD BE MOST INCONVENIENT!”

The advance party had already disappeared beyond the distant hills.

Ryuu sat beside the white-haired girl, watching the landscape unfold beneath their wings.

The girl leaned forward, her red eyes bright with curiosity.

“Ryuu?”

“Yes?”

“Have you ever traveled this far east before?”

“Not this far. There are territories beyond the reach of Orario where even experienced adventurers must exercise caution.”

“Are there many monsters?”

“Enough that you should remain close to me.”

The girl nodded obediently.

Then she smiled.

“Don't worry. I'll be good.”

Ryuu regarded her for a moment.

Something about that smile felt familiar.

Not merely because of the face she wore, but because of the quiet sincerity behind it. It reminded her of a certain white-haired boy who had once walked into danger without hesitation, convinced that he could somehow make the world a little kinder by refusing to abandon anyone.

Ryuu looked toward the eastern horizon.

Bell Cranel... what kind of trouble have you gotten yourself into this time?

Far ahead, the mountains rose like the broken teeth of some ancient giant. Beyond them lay lands absent from the maps most adventurers carried, and beyond those lands lay the destination Hermes had been so reluctant to discuss.

The Elsos Ruins.

A place where the remnants of an ancient civilization slept beneath centuries of dust.

A place whose secrets had remained undisturbed for longer than most kingdoms had existed.

And a place that, for reasons still unknown, had become the destination of four gods, two Bells, an elven adventurer, and a collection of tamed dragons.

The journey had begun.

Whether it would end in triumph or disaster remained to be seen.

But somewhere, beneath the distant eastern mountains, something ancient waited for them.

And it had already begun to stir.

Worked for 14s

DANMACHI: RETELLING OF THE LEGEND

Chapter Forty — The Camp

The sun was slowly descending beyond the distant hills when the expedition finally decided to establish camp.

After hours of traveling, the group had found a clearing that appeared suitable for an overnight stop. The ground was relatively flat, the surrounding trees offered some protection from the wind, and a small stream ran nearby. There were no obvious signs of monster activity, no suspicious tracks crossing the clearing, and no immediate reason to believe that their chosen campsite would become a problem.

At least, that was what it looked like.

“Let us stop here,” Ryuu announced. “We should have enough daylight to prepare the camp before nightfall. Establish the tents first, then organize the supplies. We will discuss the next day's route after dinner.”

The expedition members began unloading their equipment.

Bell placed his pack on the ground and stretched his shoulders.

“Finally. I was beginning to think we would be walking until midnight.”

His counterpart, who had been standing beside him, glanced at the horizon.

“We still have approximately two hours before complete darkness.”

Bell looked at him.

“Thank you for that deeply encouraging observation.”

“You're welcome.”

“That wasn't a compliment.”

“I know.”

Bell stared at his other self for a moment before letting out a weary sigh.

He sometimes wondered whether having another version of himself around was a blessing or a punishment devised by some particularly malicious deity.

The other Bell seemed to possess an extraordinary talent for making perfectly ordinary conversations exhausting.

And the worst part?

He knew exactly what he was doing.

“Anyway,” Bell continued, picking up a bundle of tent fabric, “we should get everything ready before Ryuu starts wondering why we're still standing here.”

“She's already wondering.”

Bell immediately looked toward the elf.

Ryuu was standing several paces away, examining the surrounding terrain with her usual vigilance. She had not looked in their direction, but Bell had learned that her apparent inattention was rarely genuine.

“...How do you know that?”

“She glanced at us three times.”

“Maybe she was looking at the trees behind us.”

“Of course.”

Bell narrowed his eyes.

His counterpart smiled.

“Come on. Let's get to work.”

Two Bells, One Tent

Setting up a campsite should have been a simple task.

Unfortunately, the expedition had two Bells.

And both were determined to be helpful.

The first problem occurred when they began assembling the largest tent.

Bell held one end of the canvas while his counterpart secured the opposite side. Everything proceeded smoothly until they reached the point where the supporting poles needed to be raised.

“On three,” the original Bell said.

“Understood.”

“One.”

They lifted the canvas.

“Two.”

They adjusted their grips.

“Three!”

Both pulled in opposite directions.

The tent fabric snapped taut.

Unfortunately, the pole between them slipped from its position, swung sideways, and struck Bell squarely on the forehead.

Tok.

“Ow!”

The original Bell stumbled backward, clutching his head.

His counterpart stood perfectly still.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then the other Bell tilted his head.

“Your coordination seems to have deteriorated.”

Bell stared at him in disbelief.

“MY coordination?”

“You were holding the wrong side.”

“You told me to hold this side!”

“I told you to hold the left side.”

“This was the left side!”

“Your left or mine?”

Bell's mouth opened.

He slowly closed it.

Then he pointed at the tent.

“Just hold the pole.”

“Of course.”

“And don't say anything.”

“I wasn't planning to.”

“Good.”

They resumed their work.

Several seconds passed.

“Your forehead is turning red.”

“I'm going to throw this tent at you.”

“That would be counterproductive.”

“I'm aware!”

Nearby, one of the expedition members paused while carrying a bundle of supplies.

The individual watched the exchange for several seconds before quietly walking away.

Apparently, some mysteries were better left unexplored.

Ryuu, however, had witnessed the entire incident.

She pressed two fingers against the bridge of her nose.

This is going to be a long expedition.

She had initially thought that the presence of two Bells might prove advantageous. They shared an extraordinary degree of familiarity with one another, and their combined abilities could potentially compensate for weaknesses in their respective fighting styles.

That assumption remained reasonable.

Unfortunately, she had not considered the possibility that they might also double the amount of nonsense occurring around her.

“Bell,” she called.

Both young men immediately turned.

“Yes?”

“Yes?”

Ryuu paused.

The two Bells looked at each other.

Then the original Bell slowly raised his hand.

“...Which one did you mean?”

Ryuu stared at him.

The other Bell helpfully added, “You could specify by describing our current positions.”

“I know where you are standing!”

“Then perhaps you could specify by describing our clothing.”

“We are wearing practically identical clothing!”

“Then I suggest a numerical designation.”

Bell slowly turned toward his counterpart.

“Please stop talking.”

Ryuu inhaled.

Exhaled.

Then spoke with the measured calmness of someone determined not to lose her temper over something so ridiculous.

“The Bell holding the tent pole. I need you to help secure the northern side.”

“Understood.”

The original Bell hurried over.

His counterpart watched him leave.

Then he glanced at Ryuu.

“Would you like me to assist with anything else?”

She looked at him for several seconds.

“No.”

“Very well.”

He walked away.

Ryuu watched him go.

I need to establish some rules.

Preferably before the two of them found a way to make an already dangerous expedition significantly more complicated.

The Smallest Difference

The tents were eventually assembled.

It took longer than necessary.

There had been several disagreements about the placement of the supporting poles, a brief argument over the distribution of sleeping arrangements, and one particularly confusing incident in which both Bells attempted to retrieve the same piece of equipment from the same bag.

They had somehow managed to pull the bag in opposite directions.

The contents spilled across the ground.

Neither had been particularly pleased.

By the time everything was organized, the sun had nearly reached the horizon.

Ryuu surveyed the campsite.

The tents stood in their assigned positions. The supplies had been arranged neatly, and the cooking area was ready for use. There was even enough space between the tents to allow everyone to move around without constantly bumping into one another.

It was, by every reasonable measure, a successful arrangement.

Yet Ryuu couldn't shake the feeling that something was missing.

Or perhaps something had been added.

She looked toward the original Bell.

He was crouching near the edge of the campsite, brushing some loose dirt away from the ground.

“What are you doing?”

Bell looked up.

“Checking the soil.”

“For what?”

“Nothing in particular. I just want to make sure the ground is stable.”

Ryuu regarded him for a moment.

“That is sensible.”

Bell smiled.

“Thank you.”

She continued toward the supplies.

Behind her, Bell pressed two fingers against the earth.

A faint ripple of magic passed beneath his hand.

It was subtle enough to escape ordinary notice, spreading through the ground without producing any obvious disturbance. The magical structure expanded outward, tracing the perimeter of the campsite before settling into place.

Bell withdrew his hand.

That should be sufficient for now.

He stood and brushed the dirt from his fingers.

Then he returned to the others as though nothing had happened.

A short distance away, his counterpart was arranging the firewood.

He glanced at Bell.

Bell glanced back.

Neither said anything.

They didn't need to.

The original Bell resumed helping with the supplies, while his counterpart finished arranging the wood beside the cooking area.

Ryuu noticed the exchange.

She frowned slightly.

What was that?

She looked toward the ground where Bell had been crouching.

Nothing appeared unusual.

The soil was undisturbed, and the grass had barely moved.

She considered asking him about it.

Then someone called for assistance with the remaining equipment, and she reluctantly postponed the question.

It would not be the last time that evening she regretted doing so.

Dinner and Other Disasters

By the time the tents were ready, the original Bell had already begun preparing dinner.

Cooking was one of the few things he could do without attracting unwanted attention from his counterpart.

At least, that had been his assumption.

He crouched beside the cooking area, arranging the ingredients he had brought along. Vegetables were sliced into manageable pieces, dried meat was prepared for the pot, and the necessary seasonings were placed within easy reach.

The other Bell approached carrying a bundle of firewood.

“Need any help?”

“No, thank you.”

“Are you certain?”

“Quite certain.”

“I could assist with the fire.”

Bell glanced at the wood.

Then at the fire.

Then back at his counterpart.

“You can do that without using magic, can't you?”

The other Bell looked mildly offended.

“Of course.”

“Good.”

He placed the firewood beside the cooking area.

Then raised one hand.

A small magic circle appeared beneath the wood.

A brief flash of light followed.

The firewood ignited instantly.

Bell slowly turned his head.

His counterpart smiled.

“What?”

“You used magic.”

“To start a fire.”

“I can see that!”

“Then why did you ask?”

Bell stared at him.

For a moment, he seriously considered using the wooden spoon in his hand as a weapon.

Instead, he returned to the cooking pot.

Calm down. He's doing this deliberately.

The other Bell settled beside the fire, looking entirely too pleased with himself.

Ryuu approached the cooking area and watched Bell stir the contents of the pot.

“The aroma is quite pleasant.”

Bell brightened.

“Thank you. It should be ready soon.”

She glanced at the other Bell.

“And you helped with the fire?”

“I did.”

“With magic?”

“Yes.”

Ryuu looked toward the firewood.

Then back at him.

“Was that necessary?”

“Not particularly.”

Bell stopped stirring.

His counterpart continued calmly.

“It was simply faster.”

Ryuu's expression became unreadable.

The original Bell closed his eyes.

He's doing it again.

He had no evidence that his counterpart was intentionally trying to embarrass him.

Unfortunately, he had years of experience being himself.

He knew perfectly well what that expression meant.

Ryuu looked between the two of them.

“I see.”

She didn't.

Not even remotely.

But she had learned that admitting confusion in front of the two Bells only encouraged them.

Dinner was eventually served.

The meal was simple but satisfying, and the exhaustion of the day's journey had left everyone particularly appreciative of the warm food. Conversation gradually returned to the campsite as the darkness deepened around them.

For a while, the evening was peaceful.

Then Ryuu made the mistake of asking a question.

“Bell, may I ask something?”

Both young men looked up.

She closed her eyes briefly.

“The original Bell.”

“Of course,” Bell answered.

Ryuu folded her hands in her lap.

“Do you always work together this efficiently?”

Bell considered the question.

“Most of the time.”

His counterpart nodded.

“Unless one of us becomes unreasonable.”

Bell immediately turned toward him.

“Excuse me?”

“I'm referring to your tendency to improvise without considering the consequences.”

“I consider the consequences!”

“You once created a solution to a problem that hadn't occurred yet, then caused the problem yourself while testing it.”

“That was an accident!”

“A predictable accident.”

Bell pointed his spoon at him.

“You're one to talk!”

Ryuu looked from one to the other.

“Could you provide an example?”

Both Bells fell silent.

Then the original Bell slowly lowered his spoon.

“No.”

His counterpart smiled.

“Certainly.”

Bell turned toward him in horror.

“DON'T YOU DARE!”

Ryuu leaned forward.

“Now I'm interested.”

Bell looked as though he had just suffered a devastating defeat.

His counterpart began explaining.

The story was not particularly long.

It was, however, extraordinarily embarrassing.

By the time the explanation concluded, Bell had buried his face in his hands, and Ryuu had turned away to conceal the small smile tugging at her lips.

“I see,” she said.

Bell groaned.

“Please forget everything you just heard.”

“I shall consider it.”

“That isn't reassuring.”

“It wasn't intended to be.”

For the first time that evening, Bell suspected that Ryuu was beginning to enjoy the situation.

That realization was considerably more frightening than he cared to admit.

The Question That Wouldn't Go Away

As dinner drew to a close, Ryuu found herself studying the two young men again.

The original Bell had begun cleaning the cooking utensils, while his counterpart remained near the fire, gazing at the night sky.

They possessed the same face.

The same voice.

Even their expressions were remarkably similar.

Yet their mannerisms differed in subtle ways.

The original Bell tended to react before fully concealing his thoughts. His embarrassment was easy to read, his concern for others came naturally, and his attention frequently wandered toward whatever task needed doing next.

His counterpart was more composed.

He seemed to observe everything, even while appearing to do nothing at all. His responses were measured, his movements economical, and his expression rarely revealed more than he intended.

Ryuu had fought alongside many adventurers.

She had encountered people who could coordinate through years of shared experience, companions who could anticipate one another's movements, and warriors who understood their allies through nothing more than a glance.

But this was different.

The two Bells didn't merely understand one another.

Sometimes, it seemed as though they were continuing conversations that nobody else could hear.

Ryuu finally decided to ask.

“How long have you two been able to cooperate like this?”

The original Bell looked up from the utensils.

“Like what?”

“You seem to understand one another without needing to speak.”

His counterpart turned away from the stars.

“It's convenient.”

“That isn't an explanation.”

“No,” he agreed. “It isn't.”

Bell sighed.

“We've had time to become familiar with each other.”

Ryuu studied him.

“Even your fighting styles seem connected.”

“They are,” the original Bell admitted.

“And your magic?”

“Somewhat.”

His counterpart raised an eyebrow.

“Somewhat?”

Bell immediately regretted answering.

“...More than somewhat.”

Ryuu leaned forward.

“Then how do you distinguish between your own capabilities and his?”

Both Bells looked at each other.

A long silence followed.

Finally, the original Bell answered.

“By remembering that we aren't the same person.”

Ryuu blinked.

The answer was simple.

Perhaps too simple.

She had expected some complicated explanation involving their magical abilities, their shared experiences, or the peculiar circumstances that had brought them together.

Instead, Bell had given her something that sounded almost obvious.

Yet there was a quiet conviction in his voice that made her hesitate.

His counterpart nodded.

“Besides, we have different strengths.”

Bell looked at him.

“Are you trying to be modest?”

“No.”

“Because that sounded suspiciously like modesty.”

“I was referring to your cooking.”

Bell stared at him.

Ryuu's shoulders trembled.

The original Bell lowered his head.

I cannot win.

Not against himself.

Not against Ryuu.

And certainly not against a world that had apparently decided to make his life as complicated as possible.

He finished cleaning the utensils and stood.

“I'm going to get some rest.”

His counterpart glanced at the sky.

“An excellent idea.”

Bell pointed at him.

“Don't.”

“I haven't said anything.”

“You're thinking it.”

“Am I?”

Bell walked away before the conversation could deteriorate further.

Ryuu watched him go.

Then she looked toward the remaining Bell.

“Does he always react like that?”

His counterpart considered the question.

“Only when he's embarrassed.”

“Which seems to happen rather frequently.”

“An unfortunate side effect of knowing exactly how to annoy yourself.”

Ryuu stared at him.

Then, despite herself, she laughed.

The other Bell smiled faintly.

For a brief moment, the campsite felt almost ordinary.

The fire crackled.

The night wind moved through the trees.

And the expedition seemed to have found a little peace.

It was a pity that peace was about to end.

The Earth Trembled

The first tremor was so subtle that nobody immediately recognized it.

A small stone shifted beside the fire.

The flames flickered.

Then everything became still again.

Inside his tent, Bell opened his eyes.

He remained motionless, listening.

A second tremor followed.

Stronger this time.

The ground beneath his bedding vibrated faintly, and a soft scraping sound came from somewhere beyond the campsite.

Bell sat up.

So they've finally decided to come out.

He rose, retrieved his equipment, and stepped outside.

His counterpart was already standing near the edge of the clearing.

Their eyes met.

“Everyone?” Bell asked quietly.

“Still asleep.”

Bell looked toward the tents.

“Then let's avoid waking them until we know—”

The earth exploded.

A tremendous crash shattered the silence as a gigantic creature burst from the ground near the eastern edge of the campsite.

Soil and stones scattered through the air.

A monstrous body emerged from the newly opened hole, its thick chitin glistening faintly beneath the moonlight. Numerous legs scraped against the earth, propelling the creature forward with alarming speed.

At the front of its body sat a single enormous eye.

Its curved tail rose above its back, ending in a wicked stinger.

A giant one-eyed scorpion.

It charged toward the campsite.

Then struck something invisible.

BOOM!

A translucent barrier flashed into existence.

The monster's body slammed against the magical surface, sending a ripple of light across its structure.

The barrier held.

Inside the tents, startled voices rang out.

Ryuu emerged almost immediately, weapon drawn.

“What happened?”

“Monster attack!” Bell shouted. “Stay inside the perimeter!”

She looked toward the scorpion.

Her eyes widened.

“That's enormous!”

Before she could say anything else, the ground erupted again.

Another scorpion emerged.

Then another.

Then several more.

The creatures clawed their way out of the earth from multiple directions, surrounding the clearing in a matter of moments.

Their massive bodies crowded against the barrier, and their stingers struck the magical surface with enough force to shake the surrounding trees.

BOOM! BOOM! BOOM!

Ryuu quickly assessed the situation.

The monsters had emerged from beneath the ground, surrounding them before they could properly organize themselves.

Had the attack occurred while they were still setting up camp, the consequences might have been disastrous.

She looked toward Bell.

“How did they get so close without us noticing?”

Bell glanced at the ground.

“Because they were underground.”

“That much is obvious!”

“I had hoped they would remain there until morning!”

Ryuu turned toward him.

“You knew they were there?”

Bell hesitated.

His counterpart answered for him.

“He suspected something was moving beneath the campsite. That's why the barrier was established before the tents were finished.”

Ryuu's eyes widened.

She looked toward the original Bell.

“You established this barrier earlier?”

Bell nodded reluctantly.

“When we arrived.”

“And you didn't tell me?”

“I didn't want to raise an alarm without knowing what was happening.”

Another impact struck the barrier.

The entire structure shimmered.

Ryuu gritted her teeth.

“We will discuss your judgment later.”

“Understood.”

“Much later.”

“Understood.”

A gigantic claw struck the barrier again.

This time, the magical surface briefly illuminated the entire clearing.

Ryuu looked at the growing number of monsters.

“Can the barrier withstand them?”

“For now,” Bell answered.

“For how long?”

He glanced toward his counterpart.

The other Bell was already moving.

“Long enough.”

Ryuu turned.

“Where are you going?”

“To solve the problem.”

He stopped just beyond the center of the campsite and looked toward the sky.

The original Bell's expression changed immediately.

“Oh, no.”

Ryuu looked at him.

“What?”

“Please tell me he's not planning to use that spell.”

His counterpart raised one hand.

The air began to tremble.

“Bell,” Ryuu said carefully. “What spell is he about to use?”

The original Bell covered his face.

“An improved version of one of mine.”

Ryuu stared at him.

“Improved?”

“Unfortunately.”

The other Bell began chanting.

Mille Sagittae Lucis

“Oh stars from the sky, heed my prayers,

fall upon the foes I'm facing,

descend the arrows of the heavens,

bring destruction upon these fools.

My vows are my own.

Mille Sagittae Lucis.”

The final words echoed across the clearing.

Then the heavens lit up.

One small magic circle appeared above the campsite.

Then another.

Then dozens.

Within seconds, a thousand luminous circles had formed across the night sky, each one glowing with pale, silvery light.

Their intricate symbols rotated in perfect synchronization.

Ryuu looked upward.

For a moment, she forgot about the monsters.

The spectacle was extraordinary.

The magic circles resembled a second constellation, their light spreading across the darkness and illuminating the surrounding hills. The scorpions continued pounding against the barrier, seemingly unaware that their fate had already been decided.

The other Bell lowered his hand.

Every circle turned toward the monsters.

Then the first arrow fell.

A streak of silver light pierced the darkness and struck a scorpion directly between two overlapping plates of chitin.

The creature convulsed.

Before it could recover, dozens of additional arrows descended upon it.

The next scorpion received the same treatment.

Then the next.

The sky became a storm of luminous projectiles.

The arrows moved with impossible precision, targeting the vulnerable joints between the monsters' armored plates. Some struck their legs, others pierced their bodies, and still others drove through the gaps beneath their raised tails.

The scorpions attempted to scatter.

They were too slow.

The magic circles tracked their movements, redirecting their arrows as the creatures scrambled across the clearing.

One by one, the monsters collapsed.

Their enormous bodies struck the earth with heavy thuds, their movements ceasing beneath the relentless assault.

The entire exchange lasted only moments.

Then the last arrow vanished.

Silence descended.

The barrier remained intact.

The tents were untouched.

Not a single member of the expedition had suffered so much as a scratch.

And the ground outside the campsite was covered with the bodies of dead scorpions.

Ryuu stared at the scene.

She had witnessed powerful magic before.

She had seen spells that could devastate entire groups of monsters, and she understood how difficult it was to maintain accuracy when attacking multiple targets simultaneously.

But this?

A thousand magic circles.

A thousand arrows.

One spellcaster.

And not a single wasted attack.

The other Bell lowered his hand and calmly examined the results.

“That's better.”

The original Bell made a sound somewhere between a groan and a strangled scream.

Ryuu slowly turned toward him.

“Better?”

Bell looked as though he wished to bury himself beneath the earth.

“Please don't ask.”

His counterpart glanced at him.

“What? The targeting was more stable than last time.”

“That's not the problem!”

“The distribution was also more efficient.”

“THAT IS DEFINITELY NOT THE PROBLEM!”

Ryuu stared at the two of them.

Then she looked back at the fallen scorpions.

Finally, she spoke.

“...You have an improved version of that spell?”

The original Bell closed his eyes.

“Yes.”

“And he has improved it further?”

“Yes.”

“And you appear to be embarrassed by that fact.”

Bell lowered his head.

“...Very much so.”

For several seconds, Ryuu simply looked at him.

Then she covered her mouth.

Her shoulders began to shake.

Bell stared at her.

“Ryuu?”

She turned away.

A quiet laugh escaped her.

Then another.

The original Bell's face burned.

His counterpart, meanwhile, appeared entirely satisfied with himself.

He had not merely defeated the monsters.

He had done so in front of an audience.

And he had made it look effortless.

The clone was, without question, farming aura.

The Original's Suffering

The expedition gradually emerged from its initial shock.

The immediate danger had passed, and the barrier was slowly dimming as Bell released the magical structure that had protected the campsite.

Ryuu approached the other Bell.

“That was an extraordinary display of magic.”

“Thank you.”

“How many targets can the spell accommodate?”

“It depends on the available magical energy, the targeting structure, and the complexity of the surrounding environment.”

“And the version you just used?”

“A thousand arrows.”

Ryuu's expression became thoughtful.

“Were all of them necessary?”

“No.”

“Then why use so many?”

The other Bell looked toward the fallen scorpions.

“Because I wanted to ensure that none of them escaped.”

The answer was simple.

Practical.

And completely reasonable.

Ryuu nodded slowly.

“I see.”

She turned toward the original Bell.

“Your magic is remarkable.”

Bell brightened slightly.

“Thank you.”

“However, I must admit that his execution was considerably more impressive.”

Bell's expression collapsed.

The other Bell inclined his head.

“That's a fair assessment.”

Bell stared at him.

“You could at least pretend to be modest!”

“I could.”

“And?”

“I see no reason to.”

Bell looked toward the sky.

Why?

He had spent an unreasonable amount of time developing the spell.

He had experimented with the magical structure, refined its targeting mechanism, and struggled to improve its efficiency without compromising its destructive power.

It had been a difficult process.

And now his counterpart had taken the same foundation and applied a more sophisticated theorem to it.

The result was a spell that could eliminate an entire group of powerful monsters with a single cast.

Bell folded his arms.

I need to improve my technique.

His counterpart glanced at him.

That's the spirit.

Bell's eye twitched.

Stop reading my thoughts!

I'm not reading them. You're making the same expression you always make when you're planning something.

That is somehow worse.

Ryuu watched the exchange with growing fascination.

The two Bells were not merely cooperating.

They were competing.

Quietly, constantly, and with a degree of familiarity that made the rivalry seem almost natural.

She wondered how many times they had faced one another in training.

How many techniques they had exchanged.

How many secrets they shared that the rest of the expedition could never hope to understand.

Most importantly, she wondered which of them was actually stronger.

The question was becoming increasingly difficult to answer.

Beneath the Camp

Once the immediate danger had passed, Ryuu insisted on examining the surrounding area.

The scorpions had emerged from beneath the ground, and their numbers were far too large to dismiss as a random encounter.

The original Bell accompanied her toward the eastern edge of the clearing.

His counterpart followed a short distance behind.

The ground was scarred by the creatures' emergence. Several holes had opened beneath the trees, their interiors descending into darkness.

Ryuu crouched beside one of them.

“These tunnels are enormous.”

Bell examined the loose soil.

“And there are more of them than I expected.”

His counterpart knelt beside another opening and pressed his hand against the earth.

A faint pulse of magic spread outward.

He remained still for several seconds.

Then his expression changed.

Ryuu noticed immediately.

“What is it?”

“Movement.”

“More monsters?”

“Yes.”

She tightened her grip on her weapon.

“How many?”

“I can't determine the exact number.”

The original Bell's expression grew serious.

“Are they approaching?”

“Some are moving deeper into the network. Others are traveling away from us.”

Ryuu looked toward the surrounding forest.

“Then this is not an isolated nest.”

“No,” the other Bell replied.

He withdrew his hand.

“The tunnels extend farther than this clearing. Much farther.”

The original Bell slowly stood.

He looked toward the distant hills.

The signs they had encountered earlier in the expedition began to fall into place.

The unusual tracks.

The disturbances in the soil.

The increasing frequency of monster sightings.

At first, the evidence had suggested that the local population was becoming unusually active.

Now, after witnessing an entire horde emerge from beneath their campsite, that explanation no longer seemed sufficient.

“This is spreading,” Bell said quietly.

Ryuu looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

“The monsters aren't simply gathering in one place. Their activity is spreading across the region.”

His counterpart nodded.

“And the tunnels make it possible for them to move without being noticed until they emerge.”

Ryuu's expression darkened.

“If this continues, the surrounding territory could become dangerous for anyone traveling through it.”

“More than dangerous,” Bell replied. “If the network reaches a populated area, the consequences could be disastrous.”

For a moment, nobody spoke.

The wilderness seemed vast and silent around them.

But beneath the earth, the movement continued.

Ryuu rose to her feet.

“We will need to investigate further tomorrow.”

“Agreed,” Bell said.

His counterpart looked toward the darkness beyond the clearing.

“Though I suspect we'll find more than we expect.”

Ryuu followed his gaze.

The horizon was almost completely black.

Somewhere in the distance, a faint rumble rolled through the earth.

It was too distant to identify.

Too faint to determine its source.

But all three of them heard it.

Bell's expression hardened.

The other Bell remained silent.

Ryuu slowly tightened her grip on her weapon.

The monsters had not merely appeared out of nowhere.

Something was happening in this region.

And whatever it was, it was spreading faster than they had anticipated.

The Night Before the Next Step

The expedition returned to the campsite and prepared to rest.

The remaining disturbances were monitored, the barrier was reinforced, and the sleeping arrangements were checked once more.

This time, nobody complained about the extra precautions.

Ryuu made certain that both Bells understood her expectations for the following day.

“No more withholding information about possible dangers,” she said firmly. “If either of you notices anything unusual, you will inform me immediately.”

“Understood,” the original Bell replied.

His counterpart nodded.

“Agreed.”

Ryuu studied them for a moment.

Then she sighed.

“And please try not to turn tomorrow's preparations into another competition.”

Both Bells looked at each other.

“What competition?” they asked simultaneously.

Ryuu closed her eyes.

“Good night.”

She walked away before either could respond.

The original Bell watched her retreating figure.

“She doesn't trust us anymore.”

“She trusts us to protect the expedition.”

“That's not the same thing.”

“No. It isn't.”

Bell sat beside the fire and looked toward the stars.

For a while, neither spoke.

Then he glanced at his counterpart.

“You really did improve the spell.”

“Yes.”

“How long did it take?”

“Long enough.”

Bell considered that answer.

Then he nodded.

“Show me how you structured the theorem tomorrow.”

His counterpart looked at him.

For the first time that evening, his expression softened.

“Of course.”

Bell smiled faintly.

The embarrassment was still there.

So was the frustration.

But beneath both was something more useful.

Curiosity.

If his counterpart had discovered a more efficient way to use the spell, then Bell wanted to understand it. He had no intention of allowing his pride to interfere with his progress.

After all, the goal had never been to prove that he was better than himself.

The goal was to become stronger.

And if the other Bell had found a way to improve their magic, then Bell would learn from him.

Even if it meant enduring another evening of relentless teasing.

He stood and brushed the dust from his clothes.

“I'm going to sleep.”

“Good idea.”

Bell paused.

Then looked back.

“And for the record, my cooking was better than your magic tonight.”

His counterpart smiled.

“Of course.”

Bell narrowed his eyes.

“You don't believe that.”

“Not even slightly.”

“Good night.”

“Good night.”

Bell entered his tent.

His counterpart remained beside the dying fire for a few moments longer, watching the darkness beyond the campsite.

The stars shone overhead.

The wind moved gently through the trees.

Everything appeared peaceful once again.

But the earth beneath them was no longer quiet.

Far beyond the clearing, the signs of monster activity continued to spread.

The expedition had survived the night.

Tomorrow, they would continue forward.

And with every passing hour, the evidence suggested that the danger ahead was growing far beyond anything they had originally anticipated.

End of Chapter Forty.